THE GILDED MYRTLE

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A NOVEL OF ROME

This is a work of fiction.

Set in EB Garamond.

Rome, in the twelfth year of Trajan.

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PART ONE

THE HOUSE

CHAPTER ONE

Antonia

Two hours before the banquet the cook discovered that the mice had got into the dormice.

They were kept in a clay jar in the back of the kitchen, in the dark, where a sensible animal would have stayed. Five of them, fat as thumbs, fed on walnuts and honey until they were worth forty sesterces apiece. By the time Calybe lifted the lid, four were dead in a corner and the fifth was sitting on the body of its brother with a look of profound and greasy satisfaction.

"Bring me the cat," said Antonia.

"The cat is also fat," Calybe said. She was a Bithynian with arms like a baker and a face that had never once asked permission. "The cat eats better than the kitchen boys. The cat will not trouble himself."

"Then bring me the kitchen boy."

The boy was brought. He was nine, and he had been told at the door that the mistress wanted him, which in that house could mean three or four things, and he had decided to cry on the way in the hope that it would help. Antonia looked at him for a moment.

"You will go to the market by the Circus," she said. "You will find the fat woman with the cages, the one who smells of nuts. You

will say: *four for the Myrtle, and she will pay on the Kalends as she always does.* You will not run, because if you fall the jar breaks and then you will be the one in it. Do you understand?"

He understood. He went out with the jar under his arm and came back in an hour with four live dormice, a bruised shin, and the calm of a boy who has learned that the worst thing that can happen to him in this house is to be sent out again.

The house was at the top of the Vicus Tuscus where it bent toward the Velabrum, in the shadow of the Palatine but not of its grandeur. It had been a fuller's shop and two flats when Antonia bought it. Now it was three storeys of brick faced with good stucco, a walled courtyard with a fountain that had a bronze myrtle tree in the middle of it and water coming out of the leaves, and a dining room that could seat nine men on three couches and twelve if they were friendly. On the street side there was nothing to see but a plain door and a lamp niche. The door had no name on it. The name was not required. Men found it anyway, the way water finds a crack.

By the ninth hour the whole house smelled of cumin, pine smoke and roasting birds, and Antonia went through it the way a general goes along a wall, looking for the place where it would fail.

In the courtyard, two boys were scrubbing the fountain with sand. She stopped them. "The fourth basin," she said. "From the left. There is a line in the marble."

"There is no line, domina."

She put her finger on it. There was a line. The boy looked at the line as though it had insulted his mother, and went to get the pumice.

In the corridor behind the kitchen, Prisca had the linens out on a bench, counting them, and Antonia stood at her shoulder and counted with her, without speaking, until Prisca said, "Nine sets, and the tenth for the general if he brings his own man."

"He will bring two. The second one will be a spy for the prefect's office and he will drink nothing but water. Put him at the end, by the door, and give him the cup with the chip in it, so that we know which one he is when he goes."

"The cup with the chip is the good cup."

"Then give him the good cup," Antonia said, "and we will know him by that instead."

She went into the dining room. It was the one room in the house that she had spent money on without counting it first. The walls were painted with a garden that did not exist: myrtles and oleander and a trellis of vines, and among the leaves, small and exact, the faces of birds done so finely that men who had drunk a great deal would sometimes stand up to look at them. The ceiling was coffered and gilded, not thickly, but well. The three couches were of citron wood with bronze feet. There was no mosaic on the floor, only polished black stone, because a floor that showed the dust was a floor that made the servants work.

The lamps came in at the ninth hour, carried by Felix.

He was twelve, and small for it, a Subura child with a face like a question. He had come to the house at seven with the lamp trade, the way some boys come with the water trade, and Antonia had bought him for eight hundred sesterces and had never regretted it except when he talked. He carried the first lamp to the altar in the corner, where the little painted figures of the household gods stood among the flowers, and set it down, and said the words he always said, which were not the right words, since nobody had taught him any.

"Say it properly," Antonia said.

"I do say it properly."

"You say *little gods, don't let the roof fall on me.*"

"It is the same thing," said Felix, with dignity, "only shorter."

She cuffed him, lightly, on the back of the head, and he grinned and went to set the second lamp, and she thought, as she thought perhaps once a month, that if the roof did fall it would be a pity.

Tiro came in from the street with the accounts under his arm and the smell of the river on him. He was fifty-two, and he had been a gladiator in the reign of Domitian, and before that he had been a boy in a slave barracks in Capua, and before that nobody knew. He had a scar that went from his left ear to the corner of his mouth, which made him look as though he were always about to smile at something unpleasant. In seventeen years he had never once called her anything but domina, and had never once meant it.

"The fish is late," he said.

"How late?"

"The man says the roads are full of building stone for the new forum and the carts have the right of way. He says the stone is coming from Liguria and there is a great deal of it."

"The stone is not coming from Liguria. The stone is coming from the quarries at Luna and the carts are coming from Ostia and the fish is coming from the market, and the fish is late because the fishmonger is a liar." She took the tablet from him and looked at the figures. "What is this, here?"

"The wine. The Falernian."

"Nine jars."

"Nine. He would not break the lot. It is a good year and he knows what he has."

"Then he will sell it to someone else, and we will drink the Caecuban, and in the morning I will send him a note saying that I am sorry to have troubled him and that I hope his wife's cough is better, and he will send the Falernian at the price of the Caecuban, because he will think that I know something."

"You do know something."

"I know that his wife does not have a cough," Antonia said. "Put the Falernian away. It will be better in three years and so will he."

She went out into the street for the air.

The Vicus Tuscus at that hour was a river of people going the other way. Porters with bales, a woman selling boiled eggs out of a basket lined with straw, two soldiers of the urban cohorts walking with the unhurried arrogance of men who are permitted to carry sticks in a city where nobody else is. A knife grinder. A boy with a performing goat. The shops were shutting their shutters, and the smell was the smell of the city at evening: bread, urine, pine, the mud of the river, and somewhere close a great deal of garlic.

Across the street a man was standing in the shadow of a doorway, not buying anything.

Antonia looked at him the way she looked at the fourth basin. He was well built, a little gone to fat, with the haircut of a man who had been a soldier and the shoes of a man who was paid by someone. He was not looking at her. He was looking at the door of her house, which was the same thing, only stupider.

She went back inside and found Tiro.

"There is a man across the street."

"I know."

"How long?"

"Three days. He comes at the ninth hour and leaves at the eleventh. He is not very good."

"Who is he?"

"His name is Verus. He was in the seventh cohort of the vigiles and he was put out for taking money from a baker. Now he takes money from anyone. He has a wife and three children and he is behind on his rent, which is why he is not very good, because a man who is behind on his rent will take any job and any job pays badly."

Antonia considered this. "Give him a job."

Tiro's scar moved. "A job."

"Ten sesterces a day to watch the door and tell us who else is watching it. He will say yes, because ten sesterces a day is more than he is being paid to be stupid, and then when the man who hired him asks him what he has seen, he will tell him the truth, and the truth will be what I want him to hear." She turned back toward the dining room. "And Tiro. The fish."

"The fish is coming."

"Of course it is coming. Everything is coming."

The guests came at the tenth hour, in litters, in pairs, some on foot with a lantern boy in front and a slave behind, and the street, which had been emptying, filled again with the particular noise of rich men arriving: the creak of the carrying poles, the murmured instructions to the bearers, the soft explosion of laughter at the door that means nothing has been said yet.

Antonia stood in the atrium to receive them, which was not the custom. Custom would have had her in the dining room, or in a corner of it, or not at all; the wife of a house received her husband's guests and then withdrew, and the women of a house like hers were supposed to be a decoration laid on at the third course. She had tried it that way in the beginning, and had found that men will say things in front of a decoration that they will not say in front of a woman who is looking at them. So she received them in the atrium, in a plain white stola with no jewellery but two pearls, and she looked at each of them for the length of time it takes to blink, and each of them felt it.

Tiberius Claudius Eutychus came first, because Eutychus always came first. He was fifty-five, an imperial freedman, the secretary of accounts, which meant that the money of the empire passed through his hands in the way that water passes through a mill. He was small and neat and grey, with a face like a scholarship, and he wore a plain equestrian ring and nothing else that might be remarked upon. He had the manners of a man who had spent forty years being underesti-

mated in a room and had long since stopped minding, because he won.

"Antonia Cassia." He took both her hands, which no senator would have done. "You are thinner."

"I am richer."

"That is not the same as being well."

"No," she said. "It is better."

He laughed, and went in, and put his hand on Felix's head as he passed, which Felix endured with the expression of a cat being blessed.

Decimus Terentius Blandus came next, a senator with a great name and a small fortune and a way of standing in doorways as though he were owed something. Behind him came Hostilius Rufus, a knight who had made his money in Spanish olive oil and had not yet learned to be quiet about it, and his son, and two men whose names Antonia knew but did not use, and Fannius, who was young and beautiful and entirely without money and had been invited because he made the room look better.

And last, with his own servant and his own cup, Gaius Vettius Proculus.

He was sixty-one and he looked older. He had been consul eleven years before, and there was a statue of him somewhere in the provinces with his name on it, and he had the thin, brittle dignity of a man who has been important for a long time and is beginning to suspect that he has stopped. His hair was white and cut close. His eyes were the colour of weak tea and they went around the atrium once, taking inventory, and stopped on Antonia.

"Domina," he said. "I have heard a great deal about you."

"From whom?"

"From everybody." He had a dry voice, like a knife on a whetstone. "It is the curse of my age that I hear a great deal about everybody and am acquainted with almost no one."

"Then you have come to the right house," Antonia said. "We are all acquaintable here."

He looked at her a moment longer than was polite. "I wonder," he said, and went in.

The dining room at the tenth hour, with nine men on three couches and the lamps lit and the first course coming in on a great silver tray: sea urchins, oysters from Baiae packed in snow from the mountains, eggs dressed with garum and pepper, thrushes in a paste of nuts and honey, and a dish that Calybe had invented and would not explain, which was made of something white and something green and tasted of the sea.

Antonia did not recline. She sat on a stool at the head of the middle couch, where the hostess sat if she was tolerated and the host sat if he was not, and she ate a little of everything and watched.

This was the work. Men thought the work of a house like hers was the wine and the women and the singing. The wine was a cost, the women were a cost, the singing was a cost. The work was the room. A senator who is worried about money will drink too much and talk about it. A senator who has just been passed over for a province will drink too much and talk about the man who was given it. A man who is being blackmailed does not talk at all, but he eats badly and looks at the door. A man who has done something he cannot undo will laugh at everything, a half-beat late.

By the second course she had learned that Blandus had borrowed sixty thousand sesterces from a man who was not a banker and could not pay the interest; that Hostilius had bought a villa at Tibur for a sum that had frightened even him; that Fannius had been offered a military tribunate and did not want to go; that Eutychus was pleased about something and would not say what; and that Vettius Proculus had not touched his wine.

He had a cup, his own cup, and his servant had filled it from his own jar, and he had lifted it twice to his lips and set it down both times without drinking.

"You do not like my wine," Antonia said.

"I do not like any wine."

"That is a misfortune."

"It is a discipline." He turned the cup slowly on the table. "I have a stomach that has declared war on me. My physician says I must choose between my digestion and my friends, and I have chosen my digestion, which is why I have so few friends left."

"Then why come out?"

"Because a man in a room learns things that a man at home does not," Vettius said, "and I am old enough to want to know things more than I want to be comfortable."

The second course: roast kid, a boar's head stuffed with larks, a turbot so large it came in on a board carried by two men, and with it the singing.

Leda sang after the fish, which was where she liked to be, because by then the room was warm and the men had stopped pretending to be interested in each other. She came in through the curtain at the far end with her lyre and stood in the pool of light by the fountain, and she wore green, and she did not look at any of them.

Antonia watched the room instead of the girl.

Nine men, and six of them had stopped chewing. Young Fannius had gone pink to the ears. Hostilius, who was fifty and had a wife and four children, was looking at Leda's hands with an expression that had nothing to do with music. Eutychus was watching Vettius. And Vettius was watching Leda as a man watches a door he thought had been locked.

She sang a song about a girl on a shore watching a ship go out, which was old and simple and had a tune that men remembered from their mothers, and she sang it in a voice that was not large but

was absolutely certain, and when she finished there was that little silence that is worth more than applause and that no one can buy.

Vettius set down his cup. It had a chip in the rim, Antonia noticed, on the far side. He had brought his own chipped cup into her house.

"Where is she from?" he asked.

"Who?"

"The singer."

"Puteoli," Antonia said.

"Puteoli." He said the word as though he were tasting it. "She has the accent of the south. Not the city. The bay."

"She has the accent of wherever she was taught to have it."

"And her name?"

"Leda."

"Leda is a name for a slave."

"Most names are," Antonia said.

He smiled, without warmth, and lifted the cup, and this time he drank.

The third course was a dish of quinces and honey and a wine that Antonia had chosen because it was good and not because it was expensive, and by then Blandus was telling a story about the emperor's bridge over the Danube that had every detail wrong, and Hostilius was asleep with his mouth open, and Fannius had gone out to the courtyard with one of the dancers and had not come back.

Antonia went out to the little garden behind the kitchen, where the myrtle grew in a stone box and the air was cooler, and stood for a moment with her hands on the rim of the box. Behind her the house made its noise: laughter, a dropped cup, the lyre starting again, someone singing flat.

Vettius came out.

He had a servant's way of moving for a man of his rank, and she had not heard him until he was three feet away.

"You are not a woman who forgets," he said.

"I forget a great deal."

"Not faces."

"Faces least of all." She turned. In the dark he was only a shape with a white head. "What do you want, Vettius?"

"Straight to it. I like that. I have spent forty years in the Senate listening to men take an hour to say nothing." He put his hand on the myrtle box, close to hers, not touching. "I want the girl."

"Which girl?"

"The singer. Leda." He said it carefully, the way a man says a word in a foreign language. "I will pay well. Twice what you paid. Five times. I am not a man who haggles."

"You have a reputation for it."

"I have a reputation for many things." He looked up at the black square of sky above the garden. "I am sixty-one years old, domina. I have a house on the Caelian with eleven rooms in it and I rattle around in it like a stone in a jar. My son does not speak to me except to ask for money. My wife is dead nine years. I have a great many acquaintances and no one to talk to at night." He said it without self--pity, which was somehow worse. "And six years ago, at Puteoli, I saw a child in a dealer's yard who looked at me as though she knew me. I did not buy her. I have thought about it since."

Antonia did not move.

"That is a strange thing to want," she said.

"I am a strange old man. It is the only luxury I have left."

"There is no girl here who will be sold."

"Everything in this city is sold."

"Then you will have to find the man who is selling," Antonia said, "and it will not be me."

He was quiet for a moment. Then he said, almost gently, "I have heard that before, from a woman I knew. She said it about herself."

"Did she sell?"

"She was sold," Vettius said. "That is not the same, and I have never known which of us it was worse for."

He went back inside. Antonia stood in the garden until her hands were cold.

When she came in, the room had changed its weather. The laughter was too loud. Blandus had his arm around the neck of the man beside him and was telling him something that had made him go grey. Eutychus had moved from his couch to the stool by the door and was eating almonds, one at a time, watching.

And Vettius was standing in the middle of the room with his cup in his hand, not drinking, looking at Leda as she tuned her lyre.

"Sing the one about the ship," he said.

"I have sung it," Leda said.

"Sing it again."

She looked at Antonia. Antonia gave her nothing, which was the answer, and Leda bent her head and began.

She got four lines in.

Vettius made a sound. It was not a large sound. It was the sound a man makes when he has been surprised by something inside his own chest, and he put his hand flat against his sternum and looked down at it as though it belonged to someone else. His cup went over. The wine went across the black floor in a sheet, and the room came to its feet all at once, all nine of them, in the shuffling clatter of men who have eaten too much and are suddenly sober.

"Physician," said Antonia. "Sarpedon. Now."

Sarpedon was in the kitchen, drunk, and came in with his bag and the expression of a man being woken for a fire. He got Vettius onto the floor, and put his ear to the old man's chest, and put his fingers on the throat, and then he sat back on his heels and looked up at Antonia with the particular stupidity of a man who has just remembered how much he has drunk.

"He is dead," he said.

The room was very quiet. Somewhere in it a man was breathing hard through his mouth.

"He was drinking his own wine," said Blandus, too loudly. "His own cup. His own man poured it."

"Be quiet," Antonia said.

She knelt by the body. Vettius's eyes were open and his face had gone the colour of a plum. There was a little foam at the corner of his mouth, and his fingers were curled so hard that the nails had cut the palm. She had seen a man die of a stopped heart before, in the Subura, when she was a child; he had gone grey and quiet and there had been nothing of this purple, thrashing ugliness.

She looked at the cup. It lay on its side with the chip in the rim showing.

"Nobody leaves," she said. "Tiro. The door."

Tiro was already there, with two of the bearers and the boy from the kitchen who was big for his age. The guests were standing in a crescent around the body, their faces in the lamplight, and every one of them was calculating. She could see them doing it. She had built a house in which men calculated, and now the calculation had come home.

Eutychus had not moved from his stool. He set down the almond he was holding and dusted his fingers on his napkin, and looked at Vettius, and then at her. His face was sad, and patient, and entirely without surprise.

"Antonia Cassia," he said. "This will cost you a great deal."

"Will it."

"A consular, in your house, at your table, dead in his own cup." He stood up and straightened his tunic, which did not need it. "The prefect will be told before dawn. He will be told by three men, and each of them will tell him a different story, and he will believe the one that is most useful to him." He walked to the door and stopped. "I could tell him a story that is useful to you."

"At what price?"

"Not tonight," Eutychus said. "A price named over a corpse is a bad price. I will come tomorrow, when you have had time to be frightened."

He went out. Tiro looked at her, and she shook her head, and the door closed.

They put Vettius on a couch in the small room by the atrium, and closed his eyes, and Antonia sent for his servant, who had gone out into the street to be sick and had come back grey and shaking and had to be held up by two of the bearers.

"What did he drink?" she asked.

"The same as always. Water and a little wine. He had a bad stomach. He never took anything else."

"Nobody gave him anything?"

"Nobody." The man was crying, which in a slave is either the truth or a performance and cannot be told from the outside. "He would not take anything from anyone. He was afraid of—"

He stopped.

"Afraid of what?"

"Nothing, domina."

"Afraid of what?"

The servant looked at the floor. "He said there were men who wanted him dead. He said it in the spring. He said if he died in his bed his son would have to explain it, but if he died in the street it would be an accident. He said he would not eat or drink in another man's house." He wiped his face with the back of his wrist. "He ate and drank in yours."

Antonia went out into the courtyard. The fountain was still running. The bronze myrtle leaves were black with wet. Felix had fallen asleep on the bench by the door with his lamp still burning beside him and his mouth open, and one of the kitchen girls had put a cloth over him.

She stood there and looked at the water for a while, and then she went to her own room and took the key from around her neck and opened the strongbox.

It was a plain box, iron-bound, olive wood, and inside were the papers of the house: the loan tablets, the deeds, the manumission records, the purchase documents of eleven women and three men and a boy. Under all of it, wrapped in a piece of old linen, was a second box, small, of myrtle wood.

She did not open it. She put her hand flat on the lid and left it there.

In the morning the prefect's men would come, and Eutychus would come, and the city would come, and every one of them would be thinking the same thing, which was that a woman like Antonia Cassia had finally made a mistake and would now be made to pay for it. She knew how the story would be told in the Forum by the second hour. She had heard that story told about other women, in other years, and had been careful, then, to be on the other side of the room.

She thought of Vettius in the garden with his hand on the myrtle box, saying *everything in this city is sold.* She thought of the chip in the cup. She thought, with the part of her mind that never stopped working, that a man who brings his own cup into a house is a man who expects to be poisoned, and that a man who expects to be poisoned does not die of a heart that stops like a fist closing.

Then she thought: *his son*.

And beneath that, in the place where she kept the things she did not look at, another thought turned over and settled: that in twenty-two years the world had not changed at all, that men still died at other men's tables and women were still blamed for it, and that the only difference between the girl who had been sold at fourteen and the woman who owned this house was the number of people she could make pay.

She put the small box back and locked the strongbox and hung the key around her neck.

Then she called for Tiro.

"Go to the Caelian," she said. "Before the light. Find the son. Tell him his father is dead in my house, and that I am sorry, and that I will pay for the funeral."

"And if he does not believe you?"

"He will believe me," Antonia said. "He will believe me because he will want the funeral paid for. And then he will ask me for something else, and when he asks, I want you to look at his face and tell me what he asks for first."

Tiro nodded slowly. In the lamplight his scar made it look as though he were enjoying himself.

"And Tiro. Send Felix to me."

The boy came in with his hair on end and his lamp in his hand, though it was not needed.

"You will run an errand," she said, "and you will not tell anyone. Not the cook. Not the girls. Not Tiro."

"Not Tiro?"

"Not Tiro."

Felix considered this, which was his great failing. "Is it a bad errand?"

"It is a small errand. You will go to the shop of the man who sells the voting tablets in the Argiletum, and you will ask him whether he has any tablets in the new wood, the cedar, and he will say no, and you will come home. That is all."

"That is not an errand. That is nothing."

"That is the point of it," Antonia said.

He went out, disappointed, and she stood in the empty room with her hand on the strongbox and listened to the house settle around her: the fountain, a woman crying somewhere above, the distant clatter of the vigiles going by on the street with their buckets, the

whole enormous animal of the city breathing in the dark outside her door.

I have been careful for twenty-two years, she thought. *And it has not been enough, and it never will be, because they do not require me to be guilty. They only require me to be convenient.*

She went to the window and opened the shutter.

Over the roof of the house opposite, above the black ridge of the Palatine, the sky was beginning to go the colour of a bruise.

CHAPTER TWO

Corvus

The first client arrived at the fourth hour of the night, which was an hour earlier than the law allowed and two hours earlier than was decent, and Gaius Claudius Corvus, who had not slept, heard him from the tablinum and knew at once that the day would be a bad one.

He was standing at the window with a cup of water in his hand. Below him the garden of the house of the Claudii Corvi lay in the grey light, a rectangle of clipped box and gravel with a fig tree in the corner and a small bronze Silenus, green with age, who had been falling over drunk for two hundred years. Beyond the garden wall the roof of the Temple of Apollo caught the first of the sun. The house had been in his family for four hundred and eleven years. He knew the number because his father had made him learn it, along with the names of every consul of the line, and the three who had been granted a triumph, and the one who had been condemned for extortion and had thrown himself on his sword in the latrine of a house in Ephesus, whose name was never to be spoken in the atrium.

Corvus had never thrown himself on his sword. He had done something worse, and he had done it quietly, and there had never been a day since when he did not know it.

He set the cup down and went to receive his clients.

They filled the atrium by the fifth hour, sixty-three of them, standing in their order: the equestrians first, then the men of the towns, then the freedmen, then the poor. Some were senators, and these did not stand in any order at all but moved about the room as though they had come by accident, which was the privilege of rank. The air smelled of their clothes. Corvus stood on the step of the tablinum and took each of them by the hand and said the same nine or ten things, in the same order, in the same tone, and each of them went away satisfied that he had been personally remembered, which was the only gift he had to give them and the only one they truly wanted.

Old Rufus, who had been a client of his father's, wanted a letter to the governor of Baetica about a lawsuit over an olive press. Corvus gave it.

A man named Caecilius wanted a place for his son in the vigiles. Corvus said he would see what could be done, which meant that he would not.

A woman wanted him to intercede for her brother, who had been condemned to the mines for a theft he had certainly committed. Corvus listened to her for as long as she spoke without weeping, and then said, "Come back in the Ides," which was not a promise but was better than nothing, and she kissed his hand, and he felt the wet of her mouth on his knuckles for a quarter of an hour afterward.

At the back of the atrium, by the door, a man with a purple stripe on his tunic was waiting with his hands folded, and had been waiting longest. Corvus came to him last, as he came to him every morning.

"Blandus."

"Corvus." Decimus Terentius Blandus smiled. He had a beautiful smile and no money, and Corvus had known him for thirty years. "I need a small thing."

"You need sixty thousand sesterces."

Blandus's smile did not move. "Have you been talking to my banker?"

"You have no banker. You have a Jew in the Transitberina who charges you four per cent a month, and you have a man in the Velabrum who is not a banker at all and charges you something else." Corvus walked him toward the door. "Sell the villa at Signia."

"The villa at Signia is the only thing my wife has left that she likes."

"Then sell her something else." Corvus put a hand on his shoulder, which was the Roman way of ending a conversation in a doorway. "I cannot help you, Decimus. I have not the money, and if I had it, it would not help you, because a man who cannot pay sixty thousand will need a hundred in a year. You have two sons and a name. Take the elder into the army. Sell the younger's betrothal to somebody's money. Do not come to me in the spring with the same face."

"You are hard," said Blandus, without rancour.

"I am accurate."

"You were not always accurate." Blandus looked at him a moment, and there was something in his eye that Corvus did not like. "You were a great deal more generous once. In the year of the German war. Do you remember? We were both young, and you had a—" he stopped himself, with the instinct of a man who has been in the Senate a long time and knows exactly how far a man may be pushed before he stops being useful. "Well. We were younger."

"Goodbye, Decimus."

"I am dining at the Gilded Myrtle tonight," Blandus said, from the doorway. "Do you know it? No. Of course you do not. I shall tell you about it tomorrow. It is a very interesting house."

He went out. Corvus stood for a moment in the empty atrium, and then went to find his steward.

Faustus was in the small room behind the kitchen that he called his office, with the household accounts on a board and a slave boy copying a letter at the other end of the table. He was a freedman of forty-five, thin, neat, with the soft hands of a man who had never carried anything heavier than a set of tablets, and he had been with the family twenty years. He rose when Corvus came in and stood until Corvus sat.

"The estate," Corvus said.

"It is not good."

"Tell me the number."

"Four hundred and ten thousand sesterces owing, at the Kalends of June. Of which eighty thousand is to the fiscus, on account of the loan your father took in the year of the Dacian war, and one hundred and twenty thousand to Volusius, and the rest to various." Faustus turned the board around. "There is the income from the farms at Tibur, which is eleven thousand this year and will be nine next, because the tenant is a fool. There is the rent from the shops in the Argiletum, four thousand. There is the house in Baiae, which costs us more than it brings. And there is the sum your mother brought, which is in trust to her and her heirs and cannot be touched."

"And what is the total?"

"Before the games, and the wedding, and the consular expenses—"

"Before the games, and the wedding, and the consular expenses."

"Perhaps sixty thousand in hand." Faustus folded his hands. "We are, in the technical sense, rich. In the practical sense, if you were to

die tomorrow your son would inherit a name, a house full of statues, and a debt that would eat both."

Corvus looked at the board for a while. His father had left it so. His father had been consul, and had built a portico, and had bought a team of Spanish horses, and had died in his own house at sixty-two in a manner that everyone had agreed to call an accident, and had left the family with a name that would open any door in Rome and not one sesterce to pay the doorkeeper.

"There is the Volusian marriage," Faustus said, carefully.

"There is not."

"The girl's dowry would be three hundred thousand. The father has made it plain. He wants a senatorial connection and he is willing to pay for it. The son is a decent enough young man. He has been in the army. He is not a fool."

"He is an equestrian," Corvus said. "His grandfather sold fish sauce."

"His grandfather sold fish sauce very well."

"My daughter is a Claudius."

"Your daughter," said Faustus, with the freedom of a man who had known him since he was a boy, "is a Claudius with no dowry, in a house with a leaking roof and a debt to the fiscus."

Corvus stood up. "I will think about it."

"Your mother has already thought about it."

"Then I will think about it after my mother."

He went through into the peristyle, where the sun had reached the top of the columns, and found his son.

Marcus Claudius Corvus was twenty years old and had come back from Dacia in the autumn with a scar on his forearm and a way of standing that was different from the way he had stood before he went. He had been a tribune of the seventh legion, which had meant a year of watching men die of dysentery and one afternoon of watching men die of other things. He was tall and brown and quiet, and he

had his mother's mouth. He was sitting on the edge of the fountain with his boots off and his feet in the water, eating bread.

"Get your feet out of the fountain."

Marcus got his feet out of the fountain.

"You are up early," Corvus said.

"I have not been to bed."

"Where were you?"

"With men," said Marcus. "You would not like them."

"I would not have liked the men I was with at your age either." Corvus sat down on the bench opposite him, and for a moment they were both quiet, and the water went on falling into the basin. "I have something to say to you. I have been waiting to say it for three days and I find that waiting does not improve it."

"Then say it."

"You will marry in the autumn."

Marcus chewed his bread and swallowed it. "Who?"

"The daughter of Vinicius Sabinus. The family is equestrian. They are rich. Her name is—" Corvus found that he did not know the girl's name. "It will be a good match."

"I see."

"You do not see. You will see. Her dowry will pay the fiscus and the roof and the games, and your sister will be married in the spring to a man with a name, and the family will go on, and in ten years nobody will remember where the money came from." He heard his own voice and hated it, mildly, the way a man hates weather. "You will be a consul. You will have a son. This is not a punishment, Marcus. It is a life."

"I know what it is." Marcus put the bread down. "It is what you had."

"It is what my father had, and his father. It is the only thing we have that the fish-sauce men do not." Corvus stood. "Do not marry her for love. Love is a thing that happens in a house after the mar-

riage, if it happens at all, and it is not the point of the house. Do you understand me?"

"Yes."

"Do you?"

"I understand you," said Marcus, and something in his voice made Corvus stop, but he could not tell what, and he did not have the time to find out, because at that moment Faustus came out into the peristyle with the news that the Senate had been summoned for the second hour, and that there was a rumour in the Forum that a consular had died in a house on the Vicus Tuscus in the night.

The Senate met in the Curia Julia, in the shadow of the building works, and the noise of the works came in through the open doors all through the debate: the chink of chisels, the creak of the cranes, the flat concussion of a great block of marble being set down, the shouts of the foremen in the accents of the Greek islands. The new forum of the divine Trajan was rising alongside the old one at a cost that no one had been able to calculate and no one had the courage to ask about. It had a basilica with columns of grey granite sixty feet high, and a temple, and a triumphal arch, and a column with a spiral of soldiers carved around it that would stand, men said, as long as the city stood. The dust of it lay over everything. It got into the wine and the lungs and the folds of a senator's toga, and men who complained about it were careful to complain quietly.

Corvus took his place on the benches of the praetorians, three rows back from the consulars, which was where a man sat when he had been praetor and was waiting for the consulship and did not wish to seem to be waiting for it. Around him the Senate of Rome settled itself like a flock of birds: six hundred men in white wool, the poor ones in togas that had been turned and re-turned, the rich ones in wool so fine that it hung like water. Two hundred of them were important. The rest were there because a man who does not attend the Senate is a man who is not missed.

The debate was on the corn supply.

It had begun with a report from the prefect of the annona: the fleet had come in from Egypt with a good cargo, and the granaries were full, and the price of grain in the city had fallen by a third of a denarius. This should have been the end of it. Instead a consular named Sura had risen to say that the fall in price was a bad sign, since it would discourage the merchants, and that the state should buy the surplus and hold it; whereupon another consular had risen to say that Sura's family owned the largest granaries in Ostia, and Sura had risen again to say that this was a slander, and the Senate had settled happily into the only sport it truly loved, which was the destruction of a colleague's reputation by men who had known him since he was a boy in a nursery.

Corvus listened. He had learned, in nineteen years, that a man's power in the Senate was not measured by how often he spoke but by how many men looked at him while someone else was speaking. He counted, this morning, and found eleven, which was respectable, and three of those were men who owed him money, which did not count.

Halfway through the third hour a clerk came up the aisle and put a folded tablet into the hand of the presiding consul. The consul read it, and his face changed, and he passed it to the man beside him.

"Fathers," he said. "I am told that Gaius Vettius Proculus died in the night."

The Senate made the sound a Senate makes. It was not grief. Vettius had been a difficult man with a cold manner and a talent for making enemies out of men who had been his friends; but he had been consul, and he had been of the old stock, and the death of an old stock is the death of a wall that everyone had assumed would stand.

"Where?" someone called.

The consul looked at the tablet again. "In a house on the Vicus Tuscus."

There was a pause, and then the laugh came. It started at the back and ran forward in a wave: the short, ugly, delighted laugh of men who have recognized a joke that they can tell in the baths for a month. Corvus did not laugh. He sat very still, and the noise of the chisels came in through the doors, and he felt something cold move in his chest, like a key turning in a lock he had thought was rusted shut.

"At the Myrtle," said the man next to him, to nobody in particular. "They say he was at the Myrtle. Well. He was a widower."

"He was a fool," said another. "A man of his age and his rank, in that house, with that woman."

"Which woman?"

"Antonia Cassia." The man said the name with a certain relish, the way a man says the name of a horse he is thinking of betting on. "The one who owns the place. They say she has half the Senate in her book, and the other half in her debt."

"They say," said Corvus, "a great deal."

He heard his own voice, and it was level, and he was proud of it, and he hated himself for being proud.

The debate resumed. He sat through the rest of it and did not hear a word. He was aware, in a distant way, of the shape of the argument, of the corn, of Sura, of the votes; and behind it, in the place where he kept the things that were not permitted, a room was opening: a room he had not entered in seventeen years, with a black floor and a painted wall and a bronze lamp, and a girl of twenty-three on her knees with her back striped open, and his father's hand in her hair.

He had been twenty-four years old. He had come in at the wrong moment. He had stood in the doorway for three heartbeats while his

father turned his head, and in the fourth heartbeat the girl had reached up and taken the stylus from the writing box.

The Senate voted. Corvus voted with the majority, because he had no idea what the question was and because the majority is always safe, and then he went out into the light.

Faustus was waiting for him at the foot of the steps, with two slaves and the litter.

"The prefect's office has sent a man," he said. "Pedo wishes to see you."

"About what?"

"About Vettius. He is forming a panel of inquiry. Three men. He wants a man of your rank on it."

"Why me?"

"Because you are known to be severe," Faustus said. "And because you have no connection to the house."

Corvus looked across the square at the works. A crane was swinging a block of marble through the air above the Basilica Ulpia, and the men below it were going about their business without looking up, which was either courage or habit.

"Tell him I am honoured," Corvus said, "and that I am unwell."

He got into the litter. Faustus walked beside it, and the bearers carried him up the hill, and the dust of the new forum settled on the roof of the old city behind them.

His mother was in the atrium when he came in, which meant that she had been waiting.

Claudia Junia was sixty-three years old and had been a widow for twenty-four years, and in that time she had run the house of the Claudii Corvi with the calm of a woman who had never once had to raise her voice. She was small and straight, with white hair in a knot and a face that had been beautiful and was now something more useful. She was seated on the bench by the shrine with her wool in her lap, spinning, which she did every afternoon and had done every af-

ternoon for forty years, and which she did not do because the family needed wool but because a woman who is spinning cannot be asked to do anything else.

"You are late," she said.

"The Senate was long."

"The Senate is always long. It is the one thing the Senate does well." She turned the spindle. "I have had a letter from Volusius. He is growing impatient. He wishes to know whether we are serious."

"We are not serious."

"Then we are fools." She did not look up. "Your father left you a name and a debt, and you have spent nineteen years polishing the name and paying the interest on the debt, and you have a son who is a soldier with no money and a daughter who is fifteen and will be married in a year or two to somebody, and if you do not take Volusius's money you will take somebody else's, and the somebody else will be worse. That is not a moral question. It is arithmetic."

"Volusius's son is a decent man."

"Then it is a better match than most." She looked up at last, and her eyes were the same weak-tea colour as Vettius's, which was a thing Corvus had never noticed before and would not be able to unnotice afterward. "What is the matter with you? You look as though you have seen a ghost."

"I have seen a name," Corvus said. "Antonia Cassia."

His mother's hands stopped.

For a moment she did not move at all. The spindle hung from her fingers, and the wool went on twisting slowly, and in the silence Corvus heard a slave sweeping in the next room and the pigeons on the roof.

"Where did you hear that name?" she asked.

"In the Senate. Vettius died in her house last night."

"Ah." She began to spin again, more slowly. "Then the gods are just, and late, and in a manner that no honest man would choose."

"You know her."

"I know of her. Everyone knows of her. She is a woman who keeps a house of whores on the Vicus Tuscus and has made herself rich enough that senators go to her for money. That is all I need to know of her, and it is more than I wish to." Her voice was perfectly steady, and perfectly cold. "Why does it trouble you?"

"It does not trouble me."

"Gaius." She had not called him by his name in a year. "You are a poor liar for a man in public life. You always have been. Your father was a better one." She set the spindle down. "There is a thing in this family that nobody speaks of. I have known it for seventeen years and I have never asked, and I will not ask now, because I have found that a woman who asks questions in this house receives answers she must then live with. But I will tell you this. Whatever she was to you, she is nothing now. She is a brothel-keeper with a fortune and a Greek steward and no name, and you are a Claudius, and this family has survived three emperors and two civil wars and one of its own consuls dying in a latrine in Ephesus, and it will survive her." She picked up the wool again. "Do not go to that house. Do not send to it. Do not let your son go near it. And when the prefect asks you to sit on his panel, sit on it, and be severe."

"He has already asked. I refused."

"Then send word that you have changed your mind."

"Mother—"

"Do it today," Claudia Junia said, "before some friend of hers tells him why you refused."

He found his daughter in the garden.

Caesia was fifteen, and she had the family's thinness and none of its calm. She was sitting on the rim of the fountain with a book roll on her knees and her sandals kicked off, and when she saw him she did not get up, which was a thing he had stopped correcting two years before.

"Mother's been in the atrium all morning," she said. "She sent the cook out for almonds and told her to take an hour about it."

"Your grandmother is a woman of strong opinions."

"Your grandmother," said Caesia, "is a woman who wants me to marry a man called Vinicius who has a nose like a shovel and a father who sells fish sauce, and she has told me so eight times since the Kalends, and each time she has told me that I must be sensible, and each time she has looked at me as though I were a horse she was thinking of selling."

"Would you rather a man with a better nose and less money?"

"I would rather," said Caesia, "that somebody asked me."

Corvus sat down on the bench opposite her. The fig tree had put out its first leaves, hard and small and green. Somewhere behind the wall a woman was calling a child.

"Very well," he said. "I am asking you."

Caesia looked up, and for a moment her face was entirely unguarded, and he saw how young she was, and how badly prepared for any of it.

"Does he beat his slaves?" she said.

"I don't know."

"Does he drink?"

"I don't know."

"Has he a mistress?"

"I don't know," Corvus said. "I know that his father is rich and that his mother is dead and that he has been two years in the army on the Danube and came back with his health. I know that the match would save this house. I know that if I refuse it we will sell the farm at Tibur in the spring and the house at Baiae in the summer, and by the time you are twenty there will be nothing left of us but the name and the statues." He said it flatly, because she was old enough for flatness. "What I do not know is what kind of man he is in a room at night.

Nobody knows that. Not his father, not his friends, and not his wife until the door is shut."

"Then how does anyone bear it?"

"They do not think about it until they must," he said. "And then they find that they can bear a great deal more than they thought."

Caesia was quiet for a while. She turned the book roll over in her hands. It was, he saw, a book of geography, with a map of the world drawn badly at the beginning: the Middle Sea in the middle, the lands around it like a stain, and at the edges the monsters.

"There was a girl," she said.

"What?"

"In this house. Before I was born." She did not look at him. "When I was small, before old Doris died, she used to tell me stories when she was doing my hair. She said there was a girl in this house who slept in the little room by the stairs, and that my grandfather was very fond of her, and that one night she killed him and ran away, and that everyone said it was a fit, and that my father—" she stopped.

"Go on."

"That my father sent her away," Caesia said, "and that he was never the same after."

The fountain went on falling into the basin. Corvus sat very still and heard, in the silence, the noise of the city beyond the wall: a cart, a dog, a man shouting a price.

"Old Doris," he said at last, "was a freedwoman of your grandmother's who drank, and who told you stories because children listen and because she had nothing else to do with her afternoons. She is dead. She cannot be corrected. That is the way with servants' stories." He stood up. "There was a slave in this house, and she was accused of a theft, and she was sold. That is all. If your grandmother heard you repeat what you have just said, she would be very angry, and I would be angry, and the girl would be—" he stopped himself. "Do not repeat it."

"No, Father."

"Caesia."

She looked up.

"Your grandfather," Corvus said, "was a hard man. He was a good consul and a hard man, and the two are not the same thing, and I have spent my life trying to be the first without being the second and I do not know whether I have succeeded." He put his hand on the top of her head for a moment, the way he had when she was small. "Marry the fish-sauce boy. He will be a senator before he is forty, and his nose will not get any worse, and if he beats his slaves you will find a way to make him stop."

"And if he beats me?"

The question was asked lightly, with a small smile, and it went into him like a splinter.

"Then you will come home," he said, "and I will do what must be done, and the family will survive it or it will not." He took his hand away. "But it will not come to that. We will be careful. Your grandmother will be careful. That is what we are for."

He went up the stairs.

He went up to the small room on the second floor that he used for his own, which had been his father's, and which he had never been able to make his own. There was a couch, a table, a cupboard of documents, a bust of Augustus with a chipped ear. There was a strongbox under the table, and in the strongbox, under a folded will and a bundle of letters from his brother in Baetica, there was a piece of soft leather, and in the leather a bronze stylus.

It was a common thing. A writing stylus of the sort that every schoolboy in Rome had in his satchel, four and a half inches long, with a flat end for smoothing the wax and a point for writing. The point had been cleaned. The rest of it had not; there was a dark stain in the groove behind the point, where the blood had gone in, and no amount of polishing had ever got it out.

He had taken it from the altar himself, before the slaves came in. He had wrapped it in his handkerchief and put it in his sleeve, and later, when the story had been told and the household had been told and the lie had been told, he had put it in this box, and he had never shown it to anyone, and he had never been able to throw it away.

He held it now, and turned it over, and the light from the window ran along the little bronze shaft.

She was on her knees, he thought. *And she was not crying.*

That was the thing he had never been able to explain to himself, in seventeen years: that she had not been crying. She had been flogged until the blood ran down her back and she had not cried then, and she had not cried when his father took her by the hair, and she had not cried when she killed him. She had looked up, and seen Corvus in the doorway, and her face had been the face of a woman doing sums.

He put the stylus back in the leather and the leather back in the box, and locked it.

Then he went to the door and called for Faustus.

"Two things," he said. "First, send to the prefect. Tell him I will sit on his panel."

Faustus inclined his head.

"Second." Corvus stood with his hand on the door frame and looked out at the corridor, at the painted panels of the old house, at the light falling on the floor where his father had walked. "Find out everything that is known about the woman who owns the Gilded Myrtle. Everything. Who her bankers are. Who her patrons are. What she owns and what she owes. And find out—" he stopped.

"Dominus?"

"Find out whether she has a girl in that house called Leda."

"Leda," said Faustus, writing it on his tablets. "May I ask why?"

"No," Corvus said. "You may not."

He closed the door and stood alone in his father's room, and outside in the city the hammers went on, and the cranes swung their blocks of marble through the air, and the new Rome rose stone by stone over the bones of the old.

CHAPTER THREE

Leda

The men from the prefect's office came at the third hour, when the house was still in the state a house is in after a night like that: the floors half swept, the cushions still carrying the shape of men who had lain on them, a smell of wine and cold roast and the sharp green of crushed myrtle where somebody had scrubbed the garden bench.

Leda watched them from the upper gallery.

There were four. Two were soldiers of the urban cohorts in scale armour with their sticks at their belts, and they stayed in the doorway with the look of men who have been in a great many doorways. The third was a small, neat, greying man in a plain tunic with a satchel and a stylus and an expression of mild and bottomless patience, and this was the one to watch. The fourth was a big man in a good cloak who did nothing at all except stand in the middle of the atrium with his hands behind his back and look at everything, and it was his looking that made Leda's stomach go cold, because he looked at the house the way a man looks at a woman he intends to buy.

Antonia received them in the atrium. She had been up all night and she had washed and dressed and put on her rings, and she stood

by the fountain with the bronze myrtle dripping behind her and did not invite them to sit.

"Telesinus," she said. "You have come early."

"Domina." The neat man inclined his head. "The prefect's duty is not to be early or late. It is to be thorough."

"You were thorough in the autumn, at the house of the widow Marcella, when her gardener died of a fall. You were thorough for nine days. Then her son made a gift to the prefect's building fund, and you became less thorough."

Telesinus wrote something on his tablets. "I shall note that you said so."

"Note whatever you like. You will note it in a room with a lamp and two clerks and it will go into a box, and in a year the box will be sold for waste."

The big man in the cloak laughed. It was a pleasant laugh, and it did not suit him.

"Antonia Cassia," he said. "I am Caius Vibius Maro, of the cohort of the watch. I am here to look at your people."

"You may look at them."

"I will do more than look. I will speak to each of them alone, and I will write down what they say, and if what they say does not agree with what the others say, I will tell the prefect so, and he will decide whether to ask the city's torturers to help them remember." He said it without heat. "That is the law. It is not my invention. A slave's word is worth nothing in a court unless it is given under torture, and so we begin with talk and end with the hook. You know this. You have lived in this city all your life."

"I have."

"Then we understand one another."

"I understand you," Antonia said. "You have not yet begun to understand me."

They took the dining room first.

Leda came down when she was called, and stood in the doorway, and saw the room in the morning light: the couches shoved back, the black floor scrubbed but not scrubbed well, a dark stain in the seam between two tiles that no one had got to. The dish of quinces was still on the side table with a fly on it. Vettius's cup was gone, and the place where it had fallen was marked with a scrap of wool.

"Your name," said Telesinus.

"Leda."

"Your owner?"

"Antonia Cassia."

"Your age?"

"Twenty-one."

"Your country?"

"I was born at Surrentum."

"Surrentum is not a country. It is a town on the bay." Telesinus wrote. "You are a singer."

"I play the lyre and I sing."

"You sang for the dead man."

"Yes."

"What did he say to you?"

Leda looked at her hands. She had a good face for this; she had learned, in six years, to keep her eyes down and her voice small, and to let men fill the silence with their own importance.

"Nothing," she said. "He asked me to sing the song about the ship. He had asked for it before."

"Did he speak to you alone, at any time in the evening?"

"No."

"Did he touch you?"

"No."

"Did you see him take anything?"

"No."

"Did you see anyone go near his cup?"

She thought of the passage behind the dining room, the narrow one that ran between the wine store and the kitchen, where the lamps were kept low because the smoke made the diners cough. She had gone out at the second course to retune, and she had stood in that passage for a moment with her back against the wall and her eyes shut, because her head ached from the smoke, and she had seen a man.

He had been ten feet away, going toward the dining room, and he had been carrying a cup.

He was not one of the house. He wore a dark tunic with a narrow stripe and his hair was cut short in the way of a man from a great household, and he moved like a man who knew where the passage went and did not want to be seen in it, and when he saw her he did not startle. He looked at her for a moment, and then he turned his shoulder and went on, and she heard the curtain move.

She had thought nothing of it. There were strangers in the house all evening. There were servants and bearers and cooks and the boys who carried the lamps and the men who came to tune the water organ, and there was wine, and there was a great deal of noise.

"Girl," said Telesinus. "Did you see anyone go near his cup?"

"No," Leda said.

The stylus went on moving. "You hesitated."

"I was thinking."

"About what?"

"About whether I had," said Leda. "There were a great many people. I was singing. When I sing I do not see the room."

"That is a pity," said Caius Vibius Maro from the doorway, "because the room sees you."

She was taken to the small room by the stairs and left there while they spoke to the others, and through the wall she could hear the voices going up and down like men in a race: Calybe's flat Bithynian

defiance, Prisca's careful nothing, Felix's high gabble, Tiro's silence, which was longer than all of them put together.

She sat on the bed with her hands in her lap and looked at the wall.

The room was the same room she had been given at fifteen, when she came to this house: white plaster, a bed, a chest, a stool, a bronze mirror on a nail, a window the size of a bread board that looked onto the wall of the house next door. She had thought, when she first saw it, that it was a cell. She had come from a cell, so she knew.

Surrentum, she thought, because the word had been said out loud and now it would not leave her.

She could remember the smell of it: the pine on the hill behind the town, the fish, the dust of the road, the barrels in her father's yard. She could remember the yard better than her father's face. It was a small yard with a wall of rough stone and a vine over the gate, and there were amphorae stacked in rows with the painted marks on their shoulders, and in the summer the whole place smelled of wine and wasps. Her mother had a song for the wasps. She could remember the tune and not the words, and it had come to her, over the years, that a day would come when she could not remember the tune either, and that on that day Surrentum would be gone.

She had been eleven when the ship came.

She did not remember the ship. She remembered the men. She had been on the beach with her brother, collecting (she thought) something to do with a net, and there had been a boat in the shallows and men in it who spoke to them in Greek and asked whether there was a well nearby. Her brother had run. She had not run, because she was eleven and a stranger had asked her a question and she had been taught to answer.

Then the boat, and the oars, and the sea going by very fast and very close, and her brother on the beach getting smaller, and a man's

hand over her mouth, and the smell of his hand, which was fish and salt and something sweet.

Four years in the yard at Puteoli. She did not think about them. She had a way of not thinking about them that was like carrying a stone in her pocket: you could forget it was there for an hour at a time, and then you put your hand in your pocket.

The dealer's name was Nymphodorus. He was a fat man with a kind voice, and he had bought her for nine hundred sesterces and fed her well and taught her nothing, and when she was fifteen he had put her on the block in his yard with forty others, on a spring morning, with a garland round her neck and her hair oiled, and the buyers had come.

There had been a fat man who smelled of cumin and wanted her for a kitchen. There had been a thin man who had asked her to open her mouth twice, which she had not understood, and then had understood later. And there had been an old man in a good cloak, standing at the back with two servants, who had looked at her for a long time with an expression she had not been able to read, and who had turned away and gone out into the street and got into his litter, and had not bid.

And there had been a woman.

She had come late, with one servant, and no litter, and she had walked along the front of the platform at a pace that made the dealer hurry to keep up with her. She had been thirty-three or so, dark, with a plain dress and good sandals and a face like a door being shut. She had looked at Leda for four heartbeats and said, "How much?"

"Twelve thousand," Nymphodorus had said.

"For a girl who has been four years in a yard? Eight."

"Twelve, domina. She sings."

"Everyone sings."

"She sings," said Nymphodorus, and had nodded at Leda, and Leda, who had understood nothing except that this was the moment,

had sung the first thing that came into her head, which was the wasp song, badly, with her voice shaking.

The woman had listened all the way through. Then she had said, "Eleven thousand, and you will throw in the girl's chest and the mirror."

"Done," said Nymphodorus, too quickly.

And the woman had come up the steps of the platform and stood in front of her and said, quietly, in a voice that the dealer could not hear: "My name is Antonia Cassia. You will call me domina in the street and in the market and in front of anyone who is not of my house. When we are alone you may call me nothing at all. Do you understand?"

"Yes, domina."

"Listen to me now, because I will not say it twice. In my house you will sing, and you will be taught to sing better than you do, because that voice is worth money and money is the only thing in this city that will keep you safe. You will not be given to men. Not for a price, not for a favour, not because a consul is drunk and has asked for you and it would be easier for everyone if you went. When the day comes that you wish to go to a man, you will tell me first, and if I think you are being a fool I will tell you so, and then you will do as you please, because you will be a woman and not a jar."

"And if a man takes me anyway?"

"Then he will have to take me first," Antonia said, "and men have tried, and I am still here."

That was six years ago. Leda had believed her. She had believed her for five years, and then, in the sixth year, she had begun to notice things.

She had noticed, for instance, that the promise covered a very small piece of ground. It did not cover the men who put their hands on her wrist as she went by with the lyre. It did not cover the dinner at which a praetor's wife had said, in her hearing, *and she is very well*

trained, in the tone of a woman discussing a dog. It did not cover the fact that she could not go out of the door alone, and that her contract, which Antonia had never shown her, was a piece of property that could be sold with the house, and that when Antonia died—and Antonia was thirty-nine and would die, as everyone died—Leda would be a line in an inventory, valued at whatever the executor thought fair.

It did not cover Marcus.

Nor did it cover the other women, whose arrangements were not hers and which she had spent six years failing to arrange into a single story.

Meroe, the dancer, had been bought at nineteen from a house in Alexandria that had trained her from childhood in the movements of the *kordax*, and she had a Greek contract with a fixed term and a sum named for her freedom, and she intended to buy herself out in four years and open a school for girls on the Piraeus road. She had shown Leda the contract once, proudly, and Leda had read it and seen that the term was twelve years and not eight, and had said nothing, because Meroe had been told eight by a man she trusted and it was not Leda's place to take that from her.

Prisca, who kept the linen and the keys, was forty and had been in the house since the beginning and was, in every way that mattered, the second person in it. She had a husband in Ostia, a freedman who ran a laundry, and she saw him four times a year, and she did not speak of him unless she was drunk, and when she was drunk she wept and said that he was a good man and that she had been a bad wife, though what she had done that was so bad Leda had never been able to discover.

Junilla, at the door, had been a soldier's woman on the Danube and had a knife in her sleeve and a laugh like a gate opening.

And two of the kitchen girls, and the girl who did the washing, and the girl who carried the water, none of whom had contracts and

all of whom had come from somewhere in the way that a coin comes into a house, by being lost and then found.

In the winter, when the house was closed for the Saturnalia and there were no guests for nine days, they all slept in the dining room around a brazier, and ate too much, and told stories, and Meroe danced, and Calybe sang songs in Bithynian that nobody understood, and it was the only time of the year when the house felt like a house and not like a business with a fountain in the middle of it.

Leda got up and went to the chest and took out the shell.

It was a small thing, a cowrie, pink and white, with a worn place where her thumb went. Her brother had given it to her on the beach the morning the ship came, and she had had it in her hand when the men took her, and she had kept it through the yard and the block and the six years, and no one had ever thought it worth taking. She held it in her fist and put her forehead against the cold plaster of the wall.

If I had run, she thought. *If I had run with him.*

The door opened. It was Antonia, alone, with the lamp light behind her.

"They are going," she said. "They will come back tomorrow, and the day after, and they will talk to the cooks and the bearers and the girl who does the washing. When they talk to you again, they will ask you the same questions in a different order, and they will try to make you say something you have not said. You will say nothing. You will be stupid. You are very good at being stupid when you choose."

"I told them nothing."

"I know." Antonia came in and sat on the stool, and for a moment she looked as tired as Leda had ever seen her. "Vettius was poisoned. Not by a stopped heart. Sarpedon says the colour of the face and the foam are the marks of a thing called aconite, or of white hellebore, or of something a man can buy in the Subura for four sesterces from a woman who sells love potions and rat poison out of the same jar. It was in his cup, and his cup was his own, and his man

poured it, and his man is now in the prefect's cells being asked to remember."

"Then it was his own man."

"Perhaps." Antonia looked at her for a moment. "Or perhaps somebody put it in the cup after it was poured, in a house full of strangers, in the dark, in the passage behind the dining room where the lamps are low."

Leda did not move.

"You were in that passage," Antonia said. "At the second course. With your back against the wall, with your eyes shut, because your head ached."

"I—"

"You are not the only person in this house who sees the room." Antonia's voice was quiet and entirely without accusation. "What did you see?"

Leda looked at the shell in her hand.

She thought of the man in the dark tunic, turning his shoulder. She thought of the prefect's men, and the hook, and the law that made a slave's word worth nothing until it was given in blood. She thought of Calybe, who had taught her to make the honey cakes. She thought: *if I say it, they will take me to the cells and hang me up by the wrists and ask me again, and then it will not matter what I say.*

And underneath all of it, in the place where she kept the things she did not look at, there was another thought, small and mean and hers: *if I tell her nothing, I am worth something to her. If I tell her, I am a witness, and witnesses are a liability, and I have seen what she does with liabilities.*

"There was a man," she said, "in the passage. I did not see his face. He had a cup."

Antonia was very still.

"Whose man?"

"I don't know. He was not of the house."

"Was he tall? Short? Old?"

"Young. Not a boy. His hair was short, cut close, like a soldier's or a great man's slave. He wore a dark tunic with a narrow stripe." She stopped. "That is all. I did not see his face."

Antonia sat back. In the lamplight her face had gone somewhere else, and Leda could see her thinking, the way you can see a cat thinking before it jumps.

"You will tell the prefect's man tomorrow," Antonia said. "Word for word as you have told me."

"You said I was to say nothing."

"I said you were to say nothing to them today. Tomorrow you will tell them about the man in the passage, and you will say that you did not see his face, and you will say it as though you were frightened, because you were frightened, and because a frightened girl is believed more readily than a cool one." Antonia stood. "And Leda. If they ask you whether you have ever seen that man before, in this house, on any night, you will say no."

"Have I?"

"Not to my knowledge," Antonia said. "But I want you to say no."

She went out.

Leda sat for a long time with the shell in her hand. Then she got up and put it back in the chest, and put on her mantle, and went down the back stairs to the yard, where the kitchen girls were washing the dishes from the night before and the water had gone cold in the basins, and where a boy from the baths was waiting at the gate with a folded tablet, as he did on Thursdays.

The tablet said: *The same place. The third hour after sunset. M.*

She read it twice, and then she put it into the brazier and watched it burn, and then she went back up the stairs and washed her face and sat down with her lyre and played the same twelve bars until her fin-

gers were sore, because it was the only thing in the world that she could do to make the time go by.

The place was the portico of the Temple of Portunus, on the river side, where the old cattle market had been and where at night the only people were the beggars sleeping under the arches and the rats and, sometimes, a watchman who did not care. She went out at the third hour by the kitchen door, with a shawl over her head, and Prisca saw her go and said nothing, because Prisca had been in the house eleven years and knew which things were not her business.

Marcus was standing in the shadow of the third column with his hood up.

He was twenty and he looked, in that light, like a boy playing at being a man: the good cloak, the good boots, the sword he had brought back from Dacia that he was not legally entitled to wear in the city. When he saw her he came forward quickly, and then stopped, as though he had forgotten what he had planned to say.

"You came," he said.

"You always say that."

"I am always afraid you won't."

She let him take her hand. His was warm and dry and there was a callus on the palm from a sword hilt, and it was, she had decided some weeks ago, the only honest thing about him.

"Your father is on the panel," she said.

He let go of her hand. "How do you know?"

"Everyone knows. The prefect's man told the steward, and the steward told the cook, and the cook told the whole house by the second hour. Your father is going to inquire into the death of Gaius Vettius, in the house of Antonia Cassia, on the night that I was there."

"My father has not spoken to me about it."

"He will not."

"No." Marcus turned and looked out at the river, at the black water and the lights of the boats. "He does not speak to me about anything that matters. He speaks to me about the roof and the marriage and the family. When I came back from Dacia I wanted to tell him what it was like, and he listened for the length of a cup of wine and then he said that the seventh legion had been lucky in its officers, and that I should be grateful, and then he asked me whether I had brought back any money."

"Did you?"

"Eleven denarii and a scar." He laughed, once, without pleasure. "And a girl in a house on the Vicus Tuscus who is going to be sold or killed or both before the year is out, and who is the only person I have ever met who does not want anything from me."

Leda looked at him.

"You want something from me," she said.

"I want you."

"That is something."

"It is not money. It is not a name. It is not—" he stopped, and rubbed his face with the flat of his hand. "I have been in a room with my father this morning and he told me that I am to marry a girl whose name he does not know, for three hundred thousand sesterces, and that I am to be a consul, and that this is not a punishment but a life. And I thought: I have been in the army. I have seen men die in a ditch for a pair of boots. And now I am to spend forty years in the Senate listening to men like my father talk about the corn supply, and at the end of it I will be a bust in a corridor and a name on a list, and no one will ever know that there was a night when I stood by a river with a girl and could have got on a boat."

"Could you have got on a boat?"

"Yes."

"Where would it go?"

"Anywhere. Ostia, and then a ship. Massilia. Tarraco. There are cities where a man with a strong back and a little money can be a nobody, and a woman can be—" he stopped again.

"Can be what?"

"Free," he said.

Leda looked at the river.

She had been on a boat once. She remembered the oars and the sea going by very fast and very close and a hand over her mouth. She thought of Massilia, of Tarraco, of a city where nobody knew her, and she found that she could not see it. She could see the boat, and the water, and the port, and then nothing: a blank, like a wall.

"Your father will find you," she said.

"He will not look."

"He will look. He is a man who does not lose things." She pulled her shawl closer. "And if he finds us, he will not kill me. He will do something worse. He will take me back to the prefect and say that I am a runaway, and the prefect will send me to the mines or to the mill, and he will put you in the army on the Wall, and it will be a story that he tells for the rest of his life about his son and the whore of the Vicus Tuscus."

"You are not—"

"I am what I am." She said it without bitterness; it was simply the truth, and she had learned to hold the truth the way you hold a hot dish, at the edges. "There is another way. Your father is on the panel. He will want witnesses. If I am a witness, I am worth something to him, and a man does not throw away a thing that is worth something. I tell him what I saw, and I ask him for one thing, and he gives it to me because it costs him nothing and because he is a man who pays his debts."

"What did you see?"

"A man in a passage with a cup."

Marcus stared at her.

"That is worth a great deal," he said slowly.

"It is worth my freedom, if I am clever, and if your father is the man I think he is." She turned to go. "Do not come to the house again. Do not send tablets. If I need you, I will send word by the boy from the baths, and you will come, and you will not ask why."

"Leda."

She stopped.

"When this is over," he said, "will you come with me?"

She looked back at him, at his young face in the dark, and she felt, for a moment, a tenderness so sharp that it was almost anger. He was a good boy. He was the best thing that had happened to her in six years and he did not know the first thing about her, or about the city, or about what men did when they were refused.

"Yes," she said.

She went back through the dark streets with her shawl over her head, past the closed shops and the drinking houses and the beggars under the arches, and she came in by the kitchen door and went up the back stairs, and in the passage at the top she met Tiro.

He was standing in the dark with his arms folded, and his scarred face was not smiling.

"The third hour after sunset," he said. "The Temple of Portunus. A young man with a good cloak."

Leda's heart turned over.

"You are to tell me his name," Tiro said, "or I am to tell the domina, and she will ask you herself, and you will find that she is not as patient as I am."

"His name is Marcus."

"Marcus who?"

"Marcus Claudius Corvus."

Tiro was silent for so long that she heard the water dripping in the courtyard below and a woman laughing in the street.

"The son of the man who is inquiring into this house," he said at last. "The son of the man who will decide whether the domina is ruined or not."

"He is not his father."

"No," said Tiro. "No man is. That is the trouble with sons." He unfolded his arms. "Go to bed. Say nothing to her tonight. She has enough."

He turned and went down the stairs, and Leda stood in the passage with her hand against the wall, and above her, in the dark, the house creaked and settled like a ship, and somewhere a long way off a watchman called the hour.

CHAPTER FOUR

Antonia

They burned Gaius Vettius Proculus on the fifth day, in the Campus Martius, in the family tomb by the Via Flaminia, and all of Rome came to watch.

Antonia did not go to the house of the dead. She was not welcome there and she had no wish to be. She stood instead at the top of the Argiletum, in the doorway of a bookseller's shop whose owner knew her and had gone pale at the sight of her, and she watched the procession come down out of the Caelian and turn into the Forum.

It took an hour to pass.

First the flute players, forty of them, playing the old harsh tune that is played at no other time. Then the hired mourners, the *praeficae*, women with their hair torn and their faces smeared with ash, who wailed in a rhythm that was older than the Republic and who were paid by the hour and would go on to another funeral in the afternoon. Then the wax masks of the Vettii: nine of them, in their little wooden cupboards, worn by men of the family or by hired men of the right height, each one the face of a consul or a praetor or a tribune dead two hundred years, and it was said that when a Vettius put on the mask of his ancestor he became, for a day, that man, and

spoke with his voice, and the family believed it, or pretended to, which is the same thing in Rome.

Then the bier.

It was a couch of ivory and bronze with a purple cover, and on it lay what was left of Vettius, and it was carried by eight men of his own household with their hair unbound. Behind it came his son.

Publius Vettius Proculus was thirty years old, and he walked alone, and he did not weep. He had a narrow face and a mouth that turned down at the corners and a way of looking at the crowd as though he were counting it. He wore a dark toga and the mask of his father was not on his face but carried before him, because a son who delivers the laudatio does not wear the mask. He looked, Antonia thought, like a man who had slept well.

Behind him came the Senate.

There were two hundred of them at least, in their white wool, and among them she picked out the ones she knew by the way they walked: old Sura, who had been consul twice and could no longer remember his own name after dark; Hostilius, still looking guilty about the villa at Tibur; Blandus, whose toga had been turned again since the Myrtle; and, at the edge of the group, in the second rank where he always placed himself, Gaius Claudius Corvus.

She had not seen him in seventeen years.

She had prepared for it. She had spent the morning preparing for it, in the way that she prepared for everything: she had thought about what she would feel and had decided that she would feel nothing, and she had been wrong, and she knew it in the instant she picked him out of the crowd, before she had even seen his face clearly. It was the way he stood. Nobody stands like that who has not been told since childhood that the ground was made for him.

He had grown heavier. His hair was grey at the temples and cut short, and there were lines from his nose to his mouth that had not been there at twenty-four, and he walked with his hands behind his

back and his head slightly forward, listening to a man beside him, and he was, she thought with a kind of cold astonishment, entirely ordinary. She had spent seventeen years being afraid of a man who looked like that.

Then he turned his head, as though someone had said her name.

Their eyes met across the width of the Argiletum, over the heads of the crowd, and he stopped walking.

It was only for a moment. The man beside him went on talking; the procession went on; the mourners wailed; and Corvus stood in the street with his face gone the colour of the plaster behind him, and then he turned away and walked on, and Antonia found that she had put her hand flat against the door frame of the bookshop and that the bookseller was asking her whether she was unwell.

"No," she said. "I am well. I am very well."

She went to the Forum.

The laudatio was delivered from the rostra, and Publius Vettius did it well. He spoke of his father's consulship, and of his father's service in Germany in the last years of the divine Domitian, and of his father's severity, and of his father's love of the old ways, and of the fact that he had died in the city he had served. He did not mention the manner of the death. He did not mention the house. He said, at the end, that his father had been a man who kept his own counsel, and that those who had known him best had known him least, and there was a murmur of approval from the Senate, and Antonia, standing at the back of the crowd with her shawl over her head like any shopkeeper's wife, thought: *He knows.*

She could not have said how she knew that he knew. It was in the way he held the tablet, and in the fact that he had not once looked at the place where the bier had stood, and in the speed with which he left the rostra when he had finished, as a man leaves a room he has robbed.

The crowd began to break up. The bier went on toward the Campus Martius with the family and the Senate behind it, and the rest of Rome went about its business, and Antonia went into the Basilica Julia.

It was the hour when the basilica was fullest. The great hall was full of the noise of the law: advocates declaiming in the corners, clerks shouting, a man weeping near the entrance where the money-changers had their tables. The air was thick with dust and the smell of wet wool. She walked along the north aisle with her head down and her heart going like a bird in a box, and she found him in the portico behind the temple of Castor, standing alone by a column with his hands behind his back, looking out at the Forum.

He did not turn.

"You should not have come," he said.

"You sent for me."

"I sent for no one."

"You stopped in the street."

"I stopped," he said, "because I thought I had seen a ghost." He turned then. In the daylight, close to, his face was harder than she remembered and his eyes were the same: pale, patient, the eyes of a man who has never once been obliged to explain himself. "You have done well for yourself."

"I have."

"I have heard the figures. They are not modest."

"They are accurate."

"Are they." He looked at her as though she were a column he was thinking of buying. "You have a house with a fountain and a Greek cook and eleven women, and you lend money to senators at rates that would make a Jew in the Transitberina blush, and you have dined with men who would not have you in their atrium. And you have kept out of my way for seventeen years, which was clever of you, and now you have put yourself in the middle of a murder inquiry and a

consular is dead in your dining room, and I am on the panel that will judge you." He said it all without emphasis, the way a man reads out a list of goods. "Why did you come?"

"Because I need to know what you will do."

"You know what I will do. I will do my duty."

"Your duty." She heard her own voice go thin. "You have never done your duty in your life. You have done what was convenient and called it duty, and you have done it so well for so long that you have forgotten the difference."

His face did not change. "You are a fool to say that to me here."

"I am a fool to say anything to you anywhere. I have been a fool since I was fourteen." She stepped closer. "Vettius was poisoned. Not by me, and not by anyone in my house. His son did it."

She had the satisfaction of seeing him blink.

"That is a very large thing to say with no proof."

"I have proof enough to say it to you. The old man came to my house with his own cup because he was afraid of being poisoned, and he drank from it, and he died. His son was told before dawn, by my steward, before the prefect knew, and the first thing he asked was not how his father had died. It was whether the cup had been taken away." She watched his face. "He asked whether the cup had been taken away, Corvus. A grieving son asks for the body. He asks for the will. He does not ask about the cup."

Corvus looked out at the Forum. A flock of pigeons went up from the steps of the temple and turned in the light.

"Suppose I believed you," he said. "Suppose I went to the prefect and said: the son of a consular, a man of the Vettian *gens*, poisoned his father at a dinner table because he could not wait for an inheritance. Suppose I said it on the word of a brothel-keeper. What do you think would happen?"

"You would be laughed at."

"I would be destroyed." He turned back. "And the girl would still be dead, and your house would still be closed, and the man who did it would be consul in five years. That is the world, Antonia. It is not the world I made. It is the world that was made before I was born and will be standing when we are both dust, and I have spent my life learning to work inside it, and you have spent yours learning to sell things inside it, and neither of us can get out."

"I do not want to get out. I want to keep what I have built."

"Then give me the girl."

The noise of the basilica went on behind them, the advocates and the clerks and the man weeping by the money-changers.

"What?"

"Leda." Corvus said the name carefully. "The singer. You bought her at Puteoli six years ago for eleven thousand sesterces from a dealer called Nymphodorus. She is not yours. She was free-born, of a family at Surrentum, taken by pirates in the year of the Dacian war. There is a woman in Surrentum, a *Vibia Prima*, who has been looking for a daughter for ten years and who has petitioned three governors, and the third petition is in the archive of the prefecture and has been read by my steward." He paused. "Give her to me. Not to the court. To me. I will produce her before the panel as a free woman recovered, and the panel will have its witness, and the house of Antonia Cassia will have been shown to have bought stolen goods in good faith and to have returned them at once, and the murder of Vettius will become a matter of his own household, and you will pay a fine and close for a season and open again in the spring."

Antonia could not speak.

"You knew," she said at last.

"I have known for nine days."

"Not that. You knew—" She stopped. "You knew about the girl before the banquet. Before Vettius died. That is why you asked Faus-

tus to find out about her. You have been looking for a way into my house since the day you heard my name in the Senate."

"I have been looking for a way to do my duty," Corvus said, "and I have found that the two are not always different."

"You will take her from me and put her in front of a panel, and she will say what you have taught her to say, and then you will have her, and I will have nothing."

"You will have your life and your house and your fortune."

"And my freedom?"

He looked at her.

The word lay between them on the stone floor of the portico, and the pigeons came down again onto the steps, and a long way off a man was selling hot sausages and calling out the price.

"You were manumitted by my hand," Corvus said. "In this city. In my father's house. Before two witnesses who are both dead. It is in the record, and the record says that you are the freedwoman of Gaius Claudius Corvus, and that when you die your property comes to me, and that if you are accused of a crime I may defend you or abandon you, and that if you are convicted I may claim the state's compensation as your patron." He said it quietly. "I have never claimed a sesterce. In seventeen years I have never once said your name in a public place. Do not tell me that I have not been generous."

"Generous." She heard the word come out of her mouth and it tasted like something spoiled. "You put me in the street with a purse and a lie and a letter telling me that if I spoke I would be dead, and you call it generosity."

"I gave you your life."

"You gave me a warning. There is a difference, and you have known it every night for seventeen years, or you would not have kept the stylus."

His face changed. It was very slight, a tightening around the eyes, and if she had not spent six years of her girlhood learning to read that face in the dark she would have missed it.

"What stylus?" he said.

"The one your father was writing with. The one I took off the altar. Do you think I did not see you take it, that night, before the slaves came in? Do you think I did not see the shape of it in your sleeve?" She smiled at him, and it was not a kind smile. "You have it still. I know you have it still. A man does not keep a thing like that for seventeen years unless he is afraid of it, and you are not afraid of me, Corvus, whatever you tell yourself. You are afraid that one morning you will wake up and find that you have become your father and that the only person who ever saw you choose not to be him is a whore on the Vicus Tuscus."

He hit her.

She had not expected it, which was strange, because she had spent six years of her life expecting it. It was not a hard blow; it was a backhanded slap with the flat of his hand, and it caught her across the mouth and knocked her against the column, and her lip split against her own teeth, and for a moment the world was white.

The portico had gone quiet. Two men by the door had turned. A clerk had stopped with his tablets in the air.

Corvus stood with his hand still raised, and his face was the face of a man who has just watched himself do something in a dream.

"Domina," he said. "I—"

"Do not." Antonia straightened. She put her fingers to her lip and looked at the blood on them, and then she looked at him, and she was surprised to find that she was not afraid. "There is the man I know."

"I am sorry."

"No, you are not. You are embarrassed, which is a smaller thing." She wiped her fingers on the edge of her shawl. "You may have the girl."

He stared at her.

"I beg your pardon?"

"You may have her. I will send her to the prefecture myself, with her purchase document and a statement, and I will say what I know about the man in the passage, and I will not ask you for anything in return." She turned to go, and then stopped, and looked back at him. "But I will tell you what I told Vettius in the garden, and what I have told every man who has ever come to my house believing that because he has a name he may take what he likes from a woman with none. Everything in this city is sold. That does not mean that everything is for sale to you."

She walked out of the portico with her lip bleeding and her heart going like a hammer, and the men by the door watched her go, and behind her she heard Corvus say her name once, quietly, in a voice she had not heard in seventeen years.

She did not turn.

She went out through the portico of Castor into the Forum, and she walked the length of it with her lip bleeding and her hands shaking and her heart going like a bird in a box, and every man she passed looked at her and then looked away.

She had thought, when she was twenty-three and had just killed a consul, that she had seen the worst thing the city could do to a woman. She had been wrong. The city had been saving it up for seventeen years, and it had turned out to be very simple: a man in a good toga, in a public place, with six hundred men within earshot, who was not afraid of her at all.

They burned him at the ninth hour, beyond the wall,He had been a difficult old man who had wanted to buy a girl because he was lonely, and somewhere in the smoke there was a boy of thirty who

had wanted his money more than he had wanted his father, and the world went on, and the fire went up, and the bakers' guild would have a new bench with his name on it.

where the tombs of the great families stood in rows along the road like houses in a street. Antonia went out through the Porta Flaminia with the crowd and stood on the grass verge with the beggars and the sellers of honey cakes, a long way off, where she could see the smoke and not the faces.

The pyre was built of pine and cypress in a square, taller than a man, with the couch set on top of it and the purple cover hanging down. The family stood at the front with their torches. The Senate stood behind them in a black mass. The hired women had stopped wailing by then, because the wailing is for the procession and not for the fire, and their throats were raw, and one of them was eating a piece of bread.

Publius Vettius put his torch to the wood.

It caught slowly, and then all at once, with a sound like a cloth being torn. The smoke went up in a column and bent sideways in the wind and came down over the crowd, and the smell of it was the smell of a city burning rubbish and something else underneath, sweeter, that made the people in front cover their faces with their mantles and the people behind push forward to see.

Antonia did not cover her face.

She stood in the smoke and watched the shape on the couch go black, and she thought about the old man in her garden with his hand on the myrtle box, saying *I have no one to talk to at night.* She had not liked him. She had not disliked him enough to want him dead. He had been a difficult old man who had wanted to buy a girl because he was lonely, and somewhere in the smoke there was a boy of thirty who had wanted his money more than he had wanted his father, and the world went on, and the fire went up, and the bakers' guild would have a new bench with his name on it.

When the crowd began to move away, she stayed.

"You came," said a voice behind her.

Publius Vettius Proculus stood with two of his father's freedmen at his shoulder and the torch still smoking in his hand. Up close his face was worse than it had been at a distance: there was a fine tremor in the muscle under his eye, and he smelled of wine, and he had been crying after all, or something like it.

"I came to pay my respects."

"To my father."

"To the dead," Antonia said. "I have no respects for your father. He was a hard man and he was rude to my cook. But he died at my table, and I do not take that lightly."

"Your table." Publius smiled. It was an unpleasant thing to watch. "You are very calm, domina, for a woman whose house is full of the prefect's men."

"I am calm because I have nothing to hide. I am also calm because I am rich, and rich women are allowed to be calm in this city for longer than poor ones."

"Not forever."

"No," she said. "Not forever."

He looked at the pyre, which had fallen in on itself and was beginning to be a heap of coals.

"My father was a fool," he said. "He had a house on the Caelian with eleven rooms and he went to the Vicus Tuscus to listen to a girl sing. He had a name that three emperors have respected and he died in a brothel, and now the whole city is telling the story and laughing, and I am the son who has to stand in the Forum and hear them." He turned the torch over in his hand. "So I will tell you what I told the prefect, and you may take it as a kindness, because it is the only one you will get from me. I do not care who killed him. I care that it was in your house. The law is the law, and a consular is dead in a whore's

dining room, and somebody will be made to pay for it, and it will not be a Vettius."

"It will be me."

"It will be you," said Publius Vettius, "unless you can find me a better answer."

He threw the torch into the coals and walked away toward the litters, and the freedmen went after him, and Antonia stood in the smoke until the smell of it was in her hair and her clothes and she could not get it out for three days.

She walked home through the Forum with her lip bleeding.

It was the ninth hour and the shops were shutting. A man selling water from a cart looked at her and then looked away. Two women in good cloaks stopped talking as she passed and then began again, more quietly, when she was three feet past them.

She had been in this city for forty years and she had never once been afraid of walking through the Forum.

That was the thing the blow had taken from her, and it was not the pain and it was not the humiliation; it was the fact that a man in a public place had put his hand on her and nothing had happened. No lictor had come. No magistrate had risen. The two clerks at the door of the portico had watched, and one of them had turned away, and the man with the sausages had gone on calling out the price.

That is what it is, she thought. *That is what it has always been. A woman like me is not a citizen in the street. She is a thing in a good dress, and the law is a wall that is on the other side of the street, and if a man with a name puts his hand on her the wall does not move.*

She went home.

The house was quiet when she got back. The women were in the courtyard, sitting in the last of the sun: Meroe with her hair down, combing it; Prisca mending; two of the kitchen girls playing at knucklebones on the warm stone. They stopped when they saw her face.

"Domina—"

"Get me cold water and a cloth, and then get out." Antonia sat down on the bench by the fountain. "All of you. Not you, Tiro."

He came and stood in front of her while the women went, and he looked at her lip and said nothing, which was one of the reasons she had kept him for seventeen years.

"The son asked about the cup," she said.

"He did."

"Before he asked about the body."

"Before he asked about anything. He was at the door of my lady's house before the fourth hour with his hair uncombed, and he said: *is my father's cup still there?* I said I did not know. He said: *find out.*" Tiro's scar moved. "Then he asked whether the will had been sealed."

"Has it?"

"The will was sealed at the house of the Vestals this morning. The estate goes to him, with a legacy to a freedwoman whose name nobody in the house could remember, and a sum to the guild of the bakers, and nothing to the city."

"Nothing to the city." Antonia laughed, and then winced. "A consular who leaves nothing to the city. He was afraid of being forgotten and he has left his name on a bakers' guild."

"Domina." Tiro crouched down so that his face was level with hers. "What happened at the basilica?"

She told him. All of it, in order, the way she would have told a partner in a business: the offer, the girl, the stylus, the blow.

When she had finished, Tiro was quiet for a while.

"You gave him the girl," he said.

"I gave him a witness who will say what I want her to say, in front of a panel he controls, and I did it before he could take her by force and make her say something else." Antonia pressed the wet cloth to her lip. "She is free-born, Tiro. Did you know?"

"I knew she was not born to it. There was a way she held herself."

"Her mother has been petitioning governors for ten years." She looked at the fountain. "I bought a stolen child at fifteen and taught her to sing and told myself that I had saved her, and I have been paying myself that compliment for six years."

"You did save her."

"I bought her. The saving was a thing that happened afterward, and it was cheaper than the price of the girl." She stood up. "Fetch Felix."

"Domina—"

"Fetch him."

The boy came at a run, and stopped when he saw her face, and his own face did something complicated.

"You are going to the house of Gaius Claudius Corvus on the Palatine," Antonia said. "You will not go to the door. You will find a slave of his household, one of the bearers, a man called—" she thought. "No. You will find the boy who carries the water. Every great house has a boy who carries the water. You will give him this." She held out a folded tablet. "And you will wait for an answer, and you will bring it to me, and you will not open it, and you will not tell anyone, not the cook, not the girls, not Tiro."

"Not Tiro," said Felix, delighted.

"Not Tiro." She put the tablet in his hand. "Go."

When he had gone, she went to her room and unlocked the strongbox and took out the small box of myrtle wood and set it on the table and looked at it for a long time without opening it.

She knew what was in it. A letter, in a hand she had once known better than her own, on paper that had gone brown at the folds. And a stylus, bronze, with a smoothed end and a point, which he had given her in the first year, when she was seventeen and could not write her own name, and had sat with her in the little room by the stairs and guided her hand through the alphabet, and had said, *there. Now*

you are a person who can write. She had kept it through everything. She had brought it to this house in her own hand.

Two styli. One to make her a person, one to make her a murderer. She had one and he had the other, and between them they made a kind of accounting, and she had spent her life in the belief that an accounting could be balanced.

She put the box back in the strongbox without opening it.

Then she went to the window and looked out at the street, where the lamps were being lit and a man was selling hot sausages and the whole vast animal of the city was settling down for the night, and she thought: *He will not keep his word. He has never kept his word, not to me, not to his father, not to himself. He will take the girl and he will close my house and he will do it kindly, because that is the worst way, and when it is done he will tell himself that he had no choice.*

So I will need something else.

She thought of the man in the passage, the dark tunic with the narrow stripe, the short hair. She thought of Publius Vettius asking about the cup before he asked about the body. She thought of Eutychus, who was coming in the morning with a price.

And she thought, for the first time in many years, of the house on the Palatine, and of the little room by the stairs, and of the noise the stylus had made going in.

PART TWO

THE PRICE

CHAPTER FIVE

Marcus

The baths of Trajan on the Oppian hill had been open three years and were already the largest thing of their kind in the world, and Marcus Claudius Corvus went there every morning that summer because it was the only place in Rome where nobody wanted anything from him.

He swam first, in the great cold pool under the glass roof, twenty lengths, until his arms ached. Then he sat in the warm room with the sweat running off him and let a slave scrape him with a strigil and listened to the talk.

The talk that morning was all of Vettius.

"He was poisoned," said a fat man on the bench opposite, with the confidence of a man who had been told a thing by a barber. "Aconite. They say his face went black and his tongue swelled out of his mouth."

"They say he was with a girl of seventeen."

"They say the woman did it herself."

"Why would she kill a paying customer?"

"Because he would not pay," said the fat man, and laughed, and the others laughed with him, and Marcus lay on the bench with his

eyes shut and his hands loose at his sides and thought about how easy it would be to kill a man like that with his own strigil.

They went to the hot room, and then to the cold again, and then out into the sun in the exercise yard, where the young men of the city threw a ball about and wrestled and showed off their shoulders. Marcus wrestled a cavalry officer from the Syrian legions and threw him twice, and the man took it well, and they sat afterward on the step with their chests heaving and their hair dripping and talked about horses.

"You are Corvus's son," the officer said.

"I am."

"I knew your father in the east. He was on the governor's staff in the year of the Parthian business." He wiped his face with a towel. "He was not liked."

"He is not liked here either."

"No." The officer grinned. "But he was trusted. There were four men in that province who could not be bought, and he was one of them, and it made him difficult company and it made the rest of us careful." He stood up. "Give him my regards. Tell him Quintus Drusus remembers the night at Zeugma."

Marcus went home by way of the Forum, and stopped on the steps of the Basilica Julia to watch the building works, because a man can watch a crane for a long time without thinking.

He had met her in the spring, at the house on the Vicus Tuscus, at a dinner given by a man called Blandus who owed money to everybody and had decided that the cheapest way to be important was to be seen in interesting company.

Marcus had not wanted to go. He had come back from Dacia in the autumn and had spent the winter in his father's house being asked questions about the war by men who had not been in it, and by the spring he had developed a manner that his grandmother called sullen and that his father called sensible. Blandus had sent a note, and

the note had said: *there will be nine men and no wives and the wine is good, and there is a singer who is worth the evening.*

He went because he had nothing else to do.

The house had surprised him. He had expected something gaudy and had found a plain door on a street of shops, and a courtyard with a fountain and a bronze myrtle tree, and a dining room painted with a garden, and a woman of forty in a white stola who had looked at him for the length of a blink and said, "You are Corvus's son."

"Yes."

"You have his mouth and none of his manners." She had turned away before he could answer. "Sit on the left, next to the poet. He is dull but he is not malicious, and the man on your right will try to sell you a share in a grain ship."

The singer came in after the fish.

She was in green, and she carried her lyre as though it were a part of her, and she stood in the light by the fountain and did not look at anyone, and when she began to sing the room went quiet in a way that Marcus had only ever heard in a temple.

He did not hear the song. That was the thing he was ashamed of afterward, when he tried to explain her to himself: that he had not heard the song at all. He had watched her hands.

Afterward, when the men were arguing about the corn supply and the poet had gone to sleep, he went out into the courtyard for the air, and she was there, sitting on the rim of the fountain with her feet in the water and her sandals beside her.

"You are not supposed to be here," she said.

"Nor are you."

"I live here." She looked up. "You are the son of the man on the Palatine."

"How does everyone know that?"

"Because you stand the way he stands." She kicked her feet in the water. "He came to a dinner here once, years ago, before I came. The

cook remembers. She says he did not eat anything and left before the third course and did not thank her."

"My father does not thank cooks."

"No," said Leda. "I did not think he did."

Marcus sat down on the rim of the fountain, a little way along from her.

"I am sorry," he said.

"For what?"

"I don't know. For the cook."

She laughed. It was a small, surprised, entirely genuine sound, and he would remember it for the rest of his life, and he did not know then that he was going to spend years trying to hear it again.

They sat by the fountain for an hour. She told him about the house and the women and the rules: that Meroe was buying her freedom in four years and had a contract she could not read properly; that Prisca had a husband in Ostia and wept about him when she was drunk; that the cook was a Bithynian and could put a man on the floor with a rolling pin. She told him about the summer when the house was closed and they all slept in the dining room around a brazier.

She did not tell him about the yard at Puteoli. He asked, once, and she looked at the water and said, "I do not talk about that," and he did not ask again, and he was proud of himself for it, and it did not occur to him for a long time that not asking is the easiest kind of kindness and the least useful.

"Tell me about Dacia," she said.

"There is nothing to tell."

"There is always something to tell. That is what men say when the thing is bad."

He looked at the water.

"It rained," he said. "It rained for four months. We built a road and the road washed out twice, and a man in my tent died of a fever

and we could not bury him for two days because the ground was water. And there was an afternoon in the autumn when a party of us went up a valley to look at a bridge and the woods were full of men, and we came back with eleven of us out of nineteen, and I have not told my father any of that because he asked me whether I had brought back any money."

Leda was quiet for a moment.

"Did you kill anyone?" she asked.

"Yes."

"Does it matter that I asked?"

"No." He looked at her. "It is a relief, actually. Everyone else asks me about the tactics."

She laughed again, and then the curtain moved and one of the women put her head out and said, "Leda. The domina wants the second song."

She got up and put on her sandals.

"Will you come again?" Marcus asked.

"To my own house?"

"To the dinners."

She looked down at him.

"You are a nice boy," she said, "and you are the son of a man who does not thank cooks, and you will be married in a year to somebody's daughter with a great deal of money." She picked up her lyre. "But yes. Come to the dinners."

He came to four dinners in the spring. He did not tell his father where he was going. He told himself that it was because his father would not approve of Blandus; he knew, by the third dinner, that it was because his father would.

In the afternoon his mother's cousin came, and there was a dinner.

It was at the house of Vinicius Sabinus on the Caelian, and it was not a dinner, it was an inspection. The house was new money and

did not pretend otherwise: the atrium was painted with scenes from the Aeneid in a style thirty years out of date, the mosaic in the dining room showed a chariot race in colours so bright that they hurt the eye, and there were four silver cups on the sideboard that had been bought on the same day from the same shop. But the silver was good and there was a great deal of it, and the cook was better than his father's cook, and the wine was Falernian and there was no water in it.

Vinicius Sabinus was a heavy, cheerful, sweating man of fifty-five who had made his money in shipping and in the fish sauce that Faustus had mentioned, and he had a senator's ambition without a senator's name, and he wanted, very badly, for his daughter to be a Claudius.

The daughter's name was Vinicia Sabina.

She was sixteen, and she was not what Marcus had expected. She was small and dark and extremely self-possessed, and she had a wit that she used the way a small dog uses its bark, which is to say constantly and without much damage. She sat beside him at dinner and asked him about Dacia.

"Was it cold?"

"In winter, very."

"Did you kill anyone?"

The table went quiet. Her father laughed too loudly.

"That is not a question for a young lady," he said.

"It is a question for a soldier," said Vinicia, without looking at her father. "I am to marry him. I should like to know what he is."

Marcus looked at her. She looked back at him with her chin up and her hands folded in her lap, and he understood, with a lurch, that she was frightened, and that this was how she was frightened: with questions.

"Yes," he said. "In the second year. A man in a wood, and another at a river, and I do not know how many with a bow, because you do not."

"And did you dream about it?"

"Sometimes."

"Then you are not a liar," said Vinicia Sabina, and turned to her fish.

Afterward, in the garden, when the men had gone to their cups and the women had been left with the almonds, her father took Marcus aside and put a heavy arm across his shoulders and said, "She is a good girl. She is headstrong. Her mother was headstrong. You will be patient with her and she will make you a very rich man," and Marcus said, "Yes," and felt the arm on his shoulder like a beam of wood.

He did not go home. He went to the Vicus Tuscus.

The house had a back door in the alley behind the kitchen, and he stood in the alley for a quarter of an hour in the dark before he knocked, because he was not a fool, and because a man who is watched will see who is watching.

He saw the door open at the ninth hour and a man come out.

He was thin and neat and moved quickly, and he had a tablet under his arm, and he stopped in the alley and looked up and down it, and Marcus pressed himself into the recess by the wall and did not breathe. The man went past him within three feet, and in the light from the kitchen door Marcus saw his face: a soft, pale, careful face, with the look of a man who has just done something he was told to do and is pleased with himself.

Marcus did not know him. But he knew the walk. It was the walk of a man who had spent his life in the antechambers of great houses, and when he turned the corner at the end of the alley, he turned it like a man going back to a place where he was important.

Marcus waited, and then he knocked.

Prisca let him in with a face like a locked chest, and took him through the kitchen and up the back stairs and left him in the passage, and Leda came out of her room with a lamp.

"You are a fool," she said.

"I know."

"I told you not to come."

"I know."

"There was a man here tonight. One of the prefect's men, and another one in a good cloak who stood in the atrium and looked at everything and said nothing, and they are coming back tomorrow, and the day after that, and this is the worst possible night in the world to be found in this house with me." She was whispering so fast that her breath caught. "And you came anyway."

"I came anyway."

She looked at him, and then she put the lamp down on the chest and put her hands over her face, and he stood there with his own hands at his sides, and after a moment she took them away and laughed, once, at herself.

"Come in," she said. "Sit on the floor and do not make a sound."

Her room was the same as it had been: white walls, a bed, a chest, a stool, a mirror, a window the size of a bread board. He sat on the floor with his back against the bed and she sat on the bed with her knees drawn up and the lamp between them.

"Who was the man in the alley?" he asked.

"What man?"

"Thin. Neat. A tablet under his arm. He came out of the kitchen door at the ninth hour and went off toward the Velabrum like a man who had done a good day's work."

Leda's face changed.

"That is Faustus," she said. "He is your father's steward."

The lamp flickered. Somewhere below them a woman laughed, and a door banged, and the whole house creaked.

Marcus felt the floor go out from under him, very slowly, like the deck of a boat.

"You are certain?"

"I have seen him four times. He comes at night and he talks to Tiro in the kitchen and then he goes away. The girls think he is a banker." She was watching his face. "Marcus. What does it mean?"

"It means my father knows where I go." He put his head back against the bed. "It means he has known for weeks, and he has not said anything, which is worse than if he had."

"What will he do?"

"He will not shout. He never shouts." Marcus closed his eyes. "He will make a plan. He has been making plans since he was fourteen years old, and the plan will have eleven parts to it and none of them will be wicked, and at the end of it I will be married to Vinicia Sabina and you will be on a boat to Surrentum, and he will believe, truly believe, that he has done the decent thing."

"Surrentum," Leda said.

"He knows who you are. He has known for nine days." Marcus opened his eyes. "He told me this afternoon, on the way back from the Vinicius house. He said there is a woman in Surrentum called Vibia Prima who has been petitioning governors for ten years, and that the petition is in the archive, and that when he produces you before the panel he will produce you as a free woman recovered, and the house will be shown to have bought stolen goods in good faith, and your mother will have you back, and everyone will be satisfied."

Leda did not move.

"My mother," she said.

"Her name is Vibia Prima. She lives at Surrentum, in a house by the wine quarter, and she has a son—"

"Her son is called Gaius," Leda said, in a voice that was not her own. "He is two years older than me. He has a mark on his chin from a fall off a wall. He cannot swim." She was staring at the lamp. "I had

forgotten his name. I have been trying to remember his name for six years and I could not, and I have been singing songs about a girl on a shore because I could not remember my brother's name."

Marcus reached out and took her hand.

"Then it is true," he said.

"It is true." She said it slowly, testing it. "I am not—" She stopped. "My father sold wine. He had a yard with a wall and a vine over the gate, and there were amphorae in rows, and in the summer it smelled of wasps, and my mother had a song for the wasps, and I could not remember the words." She looked at him. "I am somebody's daughter."

"Yes."

"And they are alive."

"Yes."

Leda put her other hand over her mouth and cried, and it was the first time he had seen her cry, and it was not like a woman crying in a play; it was ugly and wet and it went on for a long time. He sat on the floor and held her hand and did not say anything, because there was nothing to say, and because he had learned in Dacia that the thing a man does when someone is breaking in front of him is to stay.

When she had finished she wiped her face with the corner of the blanket and blew out her breath.

"All right," she said. "Then what do we do?"

"We go," said Marcus.

"To Surrentum?"

"To Surrentum." He was speaking quickly now, the way a man speaks when the plan is arriving in his head faster than he can examine it. "Not to the panel. Not to my father. To your mother. If we go to her ourselves, with the purchase document, and I stand before the duumvirs of the town and swear that you are free-born and that I mean to marry you—"

"Marry me."

"Yes."

"Your father will disinherit you."

"He will try. He cannot disinherit a son without cause and he will not air the cause in a court, because the cause is me running away with a singer, and a Claudius does not air anything in a court." Marcus was on his feet now. "I have eleven denarii and a horse. You have—"

"I have a shell and a lyre."

"Then we will sell the lyre." He laughed, and she laughed, and it was the laughter of two people who are very frightened and have decided to be brave. "There is a boat at Ostia on the Ides. A grain freighter that takes passengers, the *Providentia*, and the master is a man called Onasus who owes a debt to a friend of mine. It goes to Puteoli, and from Puteoli there are boats every day along the bay. It is three days. Four at the outside."

"And if your father sends after us?"

"He will send to the ports, and the ports will be watched by the time we get there, if he knows we have gone. That is why we go before he knows." He took her by the shoulders. "The day after tomorrow. At the fourth hour of the night. There is a door in the Servian wall by the Viminal gate that the watchmen use, and the man on it is called Petronius and he is drunk four nights out of seven and I have money for the other three. Bring nothing that will make a noise. Nothing that will weigh you down."

Leda looked at him.

"My mother is alive," she said, "and I am to run away from the only house that has kept me, with a boy I have known for four months, to a town I have not seen in ten years, on the word of a man who has never kept a promise to anyone."

"Yes."

"You are all I have," she said, "and that is a terrible thing to be."

"I know."

"You do not know. You are a Claudius. If this goes wrong you will be sent to the Wall and given a command and in ten years you will be a senator and this will be a story you tell at dinner. If it goes wrong for me I will be in a mill with a collar on, or in the Tiber." She stood up. "But I will be there. The day after tomorrow. At the fourth hour. And if you are not there, Marcus, I will not come looking for you, because I will be dead or gone, and either way there will be no point."

"I will be there."

"Say it as though you believe it."

"I will be there," said Marcus Claudius Corvus, and he believed it, and it was the last simple thing he believed for a long time.

He went out by the kitchen door at the eleventh hour and walked home through the streets with his hood up, past the closed shops and the watchmen and the dogs, and the city was quiet in the way that a city is quiet when it is full of people sleeping and a few people doing harm.

There was a light in his father's study.

He went up the stairs quietly and along the corridor, and the door was open a hand's breadth, and through it he saw his father sitting at the table with a lamp and a wax tablet and a cup of water, writing. He had taken off his shoes. It was the most human thing Marcus had ever seen him do, and it filled him with a sadness so large and so useless that he had to put his hand on the wall.

Then Corvus looked up and saw him through the gap in the door.

"Come in," he said.

Marcus came in.

"Sit down."

He sat. The room smelled of lamp oil and old paper. On the table beside the tablet there was a small box of dark wood with a bronze

lock, and Marcus had never seen it before in his life, and he noticed that his father's hand was resting on it.

"Where have you been?" Corvus asked.

"You know where I have been."

"Yes." Corvus set down the stylus. "I have known for a month. I had hoped that you would tell me, and I had hoped that you would stop, and you have done neither, and now I find that I must do the thing I have been putting off."

"Which is?"

"Which is to explain to you what you are doing." His father's voice was quiet and reasonable and it was worse than shouting. "You are twenty years old. You have no money, no office, no reputation to speak of, and a name that will open doors for you exactly once, when you are introduced in the Forum as the son of your father. In four months you will marry a girl with three hundred thousand sesterces and a good temper, and in six years you will be quaestor, and in fourteen you will be consul, and in thirty you will be an old man in a house full of statues who has done nothing dishonourable and nothing remarkable, and the family will still be standing. That is the whole of it. That is what a Claudius is for."

"And if I do not want it?"

"Then you will want it in ten years, and it will be too late." Corvus leaned back. "The girl is not the problem. I have known a hundred men who kept a girl. Blandus kept a girl for nine years and his wife used to send her presents at the Saturnalia. The problem is that you are in love with her, and a man in love is a man who can be led by the nose by anyone who has her, and you are the son of a man who is on a panel of inquiry into a murder in the house where she lives."

Marcus's hands were cold.

"You are going to destroy her," he said.

"I am going to do my duty, which will involve the house being closed and its women dispersed. The girl will be returned to her mother, which is a mercy, whether she knows it or not. The woman Cassia will be fined, or exiled, or—" he stopped. "That is not your concern."

"She is a witness. She saw a man in the passage with a cup. If you put her in front of your panel and then hand her to her mother, she will be gone, and the man who killed Vettius will be safe, and the whole thing will have been for nothing."

Corvus was silent for a moment.

"You have been talking to her," he said.

"Of course I have been talking to her."

"About the case."

"About everything. She is not a piece of evidence, Father. She is a girl who was stolen off a beach when she was eleven and has been sold twice, and she remembers her brother's face and not his name, and she is frightened of you and of the prefect and of the hook, and I have promised her—" he stopped himself.

"Promised her what?"

"Nothing."

"Marcus."

"Nothing that concerns you."

Corvus looked at him for a long moment. Then he did something that Marcus had never seen him do: he poured a second cup of water and pushed it across the table.

"Drink," he said. "You look like a man who has been walking in the heat."

Marcus did not touch the cup.

"When I was your age," Corvus said, "there was a girl in this house. She was a slave. She was clever and she was angry and she had been badly used before she came to us, and I was—" He stopped. He turned the cup around on the table. "I was not kind to her. I was not

cruel to her either. I was careless, which is what a young man is, and I have spent twenty years discovering that careless is a kind of cruelty and that the difference between the two is only who is keeping the accounts."

Marcus sat very still.

"What happened to her?"

"She was sold," Corvus said. "I sold her, and I gave her a purse, and I told myself that I had done a merciful thing." He picked up the stylus. "I have not seen her since. And I will tell you what I have learned, which is that a man may do a merciful thing and a wicked thing in the same hour and spend the rest of his life not knowing which one he did. That is not a reason to do nothing. It is a reason to do the thing that is required of you and to do it cleanly and without self-pity, and then to go on."

He looked up.

"The day after tomorrow," he said, "you will go to Ostia and you will meet the grain factor Manlius, who is a client of mine, and you will spend a month learning the shipping trade, which is a thing that every senator pretends to understand and none of them does. You will leave at dawn. You will not go to the Vicus Tuscus before you go, and you will not send a message there, and when you come back in the autumn you will marry Vinicia Sabina and you will never mention the singer again."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then I will have you watched, and you will be prevented, and the girl will go to the panel in chains instead of in a litter, and she will be asked questions under torture, because a slave's evidence is worth nothing otherwise, and I will not be able to stop it." Corvus said it without pleasure. "I am not threatening you. I am telling you the shape of the world. I have spent my life in it and I know the shape of it, and you do not, and one day you will thank me."

Marcus stood up.

"I will go to Ostia," he said.

"Good."

"At dawn."

"Good." Corvus looked down at his tablet. "Close the door."

Marcus went out and closed the door and stood in the dark corridor with his fists clenched and his heart going like a drum, and he thought: *the day after tomorrow, at the fourth hour, at the Viminal gate.* And then, because he was his father's son and had been raised in a house where nothing was ever said plainly, he thought: *he will have me watched. He said so. He said so because he wants me to know, and because a man who is watched will do something foolish to throw off the watchers, and he will be ready for that.*

So he would not go to the Viminal gate.

He would go over the roof.

In the morning his father beat a boy in the atrium for dropping a cup, and Marcus stood and watched, as he had watched since he was a child, and said nothing, and afterward he went to his room and packed a bag with a cloak, a knife, two loaves, and the eleven denarii, and he lay on his bed with his eyes open and listened to the house, and counted the hours.

CHAPTER SIX

Antonia

Eutychus came at the second hour, in a hired chair, with one slave and no escort, and he brought a basket of figs.

"From my place at Tusculum," he said, setting it on the table himself, before anyone could take it from him. "The first of the season. They are not as good as the ones from the coast, but they are earlier, and a man of my age has learned to prefer the early thing to the good thing, because he may not be alive for the good thing."

"You are fifty-five."

"I am fifty-five and I have a stomach like a bag of nails. Sit down, domina. You look as though you have been up all night."

"I have."

"Of course you have." He sat, uninvited, on the bench by the fountain. "I will not waste your time. You know what I am and what I can do and what I want, and I know what you are and what you can do and what you want. We are the two most practical people in this city and we may speak to one another without the usual noises."

Antonia sat down opposite him.

"Then speak."

"Three things." He held up one finger. "First: your house must close for a season. Not because I wish it. Because the prefect must be seen to do something, and the cheapest thing for him to do is to close a brothel. If your door is shut on the Ides, and there is a notice on it, and a fine is paid, then in the autumn you open again and the whole thing is a bad memory. If your door stays open, the prefect must do something larger, and larger things are harder to control."

"Second."

"Second: the girl." He held up another finger. "The singer. She is to be produced before the panel, and she is to say that she saw nothing in the passage. Nothing at all. Not a man, not a cup, not a shadow. The panel will accept it because the panel wants to accept it, and the death will be recorded as a seizure of the heart, which is what the physicians say when a great man dies inconveniently, and the whole affair will be finished by the Kalends."

Antonia looked at him.

"The girl saw a man," she said. "She has already told me so. She will tell the panel."

"Then the girl will be mistaken." Eutychus smiled, and it was a pleasant smile, and it did not reach his eyes. "A slave's memory is a fragile thing. It can be corrected. That is what the law is for."

"And the third thing?"

"The third thing is a list." He took a fig from the basket and turned it in his fingers. "I know what your house is. It is not a brothel; a brothel is a place where men go to be quick and ashamed. Your house is a place where men go to be slow and unwise. I know that senators have sat in that room and told you things they have not told their wives, their bankers or their gods, and I know that you have written some of it down, because you are a woman who has been poor, and a woman who has been poor writes things down."

"I have a good memory."

"You have a good memory and a locked box. I am not asking for the box. I am asking for a copy of the list of what you are owed. Names, sums, dates. The men who owe you money are the men who will vote as they are told, and I am in the business of knowing who votes as they are told." He put the fig in his mouth and chewed. "In return, I will make the prefect's inquiry a formality. I will find a man in Vettius's household who will confess to having brought the cup in, and the confession will be believed because he will be a slave and slaves confess, and the son will be grateful and the prefect will be satisfied and your house will reopen in the autumn with a new fountain."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then you will be tried for the murder of a consular, and the fact that you did not do it will not save you, because the trial is not about what you did. It is about what you are." He dusted the fig seeds from his fingers. "You are a freedwoman who keeps a house of women. You cannot give evidence in your own defence. You have no family to speak for you, no patron who will stand up in court and vouch for your character, and no name that anyone will remember in a year. The prefect will find what the prefect needs to find. You know this. You have watched it happen to other women."

"I have."

"And yet you sit there with your hands folded."

"I am thinking," Antonia said, "about which of us is more afraid."

Eutychus stopped chewing.

"You are a rich man," she went on. "You are a freedman who has made himself the second most powerful man in the accounts of the empire, and you have a house at Tusculum with a garden that people are invited to admire. And every sesterce of it depends on one thing, which is that the emperor continues to find you useful. You have no name, no ancestors, no soldiers, no land that has been in your family

for a thousand years. If Trajan dies tomorrow and Hadrian takes the purple, you will be a clever old man with a good garden and no friends, and the men who come to my house will not take your calls."

"There is a great deal in what you say," said Eutychus, "and none of it is new to me, and none of it will help you."

"I am not finished. You want the list because you want to know which senators are in debt, and you want to know it before the emperor comes back from the east, because the emperor is going to need money for the Parthian war and you are going to have to find it, and a man who can produce a list of indebted senators and their weaknesses is a man who can produce money out of a hat." She leaned forward. "You do not want to destroy me. You want to own me. And you have made a mistake, which is that you have come to me in the morning with a basket of figs and told me a lie about the girl, and the lie is the only thing in the whole of your proposal that tells me what you are afraid of."

Eutychus set the basket down.

"What lie?" he said.

"The man in the passage was not a slave of Vettius's household. He had short hair and a dark tunic with a narrow stripe, and he knew the passage, and he turned his shoulder when he saw the girl, which is what a man does when he is known in a house and does not wish to be. If he had been Vettius's man, she would have recognized him, because she had spent three hours in the same room as Vettius's people." She watched him. "He was your man. Or the son's man, hired through you. And you want the girl to say nothing because the girl's nothing is the only thing standing between you and a rope."

The fountain ran. Somewhere in the house a woman was singing at her work, badly, the way people sing when they think no one is listening.

"You have a great deal of imagination," Eutychus said at last, "and no proof at all."

"I have a witness."

"You have a slave. A slave who will be asked to repeat her story under the hooks, and who will not, because no one does." He stood up and picked up his basket, and looked at it, and set it down again. "Keep the figs. They will be a pleasant thing to have in the house while you are waiting."

"Eutychus."

He stopped at the door.

"If you are going to have me killed," Antonia said, "do it before the Ides. After the Ides I shall be at the baths every morning and it will be much more inconvenient."

He laughed, in spite of himself, and shook his head, and went out.

The counting room was at the back of the house, behind the kitchen, a small room with no window and a strong door and a table with a lamp and a set of abacus beads and a great many tablets stacked in racks along the wall. Antonia had it built in the second year, and she had built it before she built the dining room, which she had once said was the truest thing about her.

Zosimus was waiting in it. He was sixty, a Greek freedman of hers, bald, with the ink-stained fingers of a man who had done nothing else for forty years, and he had kept her accounts since the beginning, and he was the only person in the world who knew to the sesterce what she was worth.

"Tell me," she said, and sat.

"We have forty-one thousand sesterces in the chest, and eleven thousand in the hands of the money-changer by the Macellum, which is a convenience and not a risk. We are owed six hundred and twenty thousand, of which—" he ran his finger down a tablet—"four hundred and eleven thousand is out at interest, and two hundred and nine thousand is in the form of unpaid principal

that is not earning, which is to say it is owed by men who cannot pay and who are, nevertheless, our friends."

"Names."

"Blandus, sixty thousand, no interest and no prospect. Sura's son, ninety thousand, secured on a farm in Campania that is worth perhaps eighty and which he will not sell. The knight Hostilius, forty thousand, at six per cent, who pays on time and is afraid of his wife. A praetor whose name I will not write down, one hundred and ten thousand, in a house in the Subura that is worth nothing. The rest is in small sums to small men, and it will come in over the year or it will not."

"And the debts?"

"Nine thousand to the wine merchant. Four thousand to the dealer in lamps. Twelve thousand to the builders, who are patient. And—" he hesitated.

"And?"

"Two hundred thousand to the bank of Tiberius Claudius Eutychus, at four per cent, of which one hundred thousand falls due on the Kalends of July and is secured on this house."

Antonia sat back. The lamp flickered in the draught from under the door.

"When did we borrow that?"

"Three years ago, when we bought the two shops in the Argiletum. You said at the time that a woman who borrows from a man like Eutychus is a woman who has given him a key to her house."

"I remember what I said."

"You said it would be cheaper than borrowing from a senator, because a senator would want a favour and Eutychus would only want money."

"I was wrong," Antonia said. "He wants both."

She sat for a while with her hands flat on the table.

"Here is what we will do," she said. "Send to Blandus. Tell him to come tonight, by the kitchen door, and tell him that if he is seen coming he will be turned away. He will come. He is the sort of man who will always come if he thinks there is a chance of something." She stood. "And Zosimus. Take the small tablets, the ones with the personal notes on them, the ones that are not accounts. Not the loan tablets. The other ones. Put them in the strongbox in my room and burn everything else in this room that is not a ledger."

"Domina—"

"Burn it. I will not be tried for what I know. I will be tried for what I am." She stopped at the door. "And Zosimus. If I am dead before the Ides, take the strongbox to Tiro, and if Tiro is dead, take it to the Vestals and ask for the chief vestal, and tell her that Antonia Cassia asked for the old kindness, and she will know what it means."

"There is no old kindness."

"No," Antonia said. "But she will take the box and she will not open it, because she is a woman who has spent her life not opening things, and it will be safe, and that is more than I can say for the house of any man I know."

Vipsania Marcella lived on the Caelian, in a house that had belonged to her husband's family for two hundred years and had been added to by four generations of men who could not agree about anything, so that the atrium was old Republican and the peristyle was Augustan and the new bath wing was the sort of thing that a man builds when he has made a great deal of money in Africa and wants everyone to know.

Antonia had been in that house perhaps fifty times in eleven years. She had dined in the peristyle. She had sat with Vipsania in the winter garden while the older woman complained about her husband's digestion and her son's tutors and the price of silk. She had been useful to her: a discreet place for a woman of her rank to buy a thing she did not want her husband to know about, and a

source of gossip that was accurate and never cruel about anyone Vipsania liked.

She was kept waiting in the atrium for an hour.

That had never happened before. In eleven years she had never once been kept waiting in that house, and as she stood by the impluvium with the old Republican floor under her feet and the smell of the garden coming through the door, she understood that it was not an oversight.

Vipsania came at last.

She was forty-four, and handsome in the way that rich Roman women are handsome, with a great deal of hair and a great deal of gold and a way of holding her head that made her look as though she were listening to something a long way off. She came down the stairs with two of her women behind her and stopped at the bottom, and she did not come across the floor.

"Antonia."

"Vipsania."

"You should not have come."

"I know."

"I have been ill." The older woman's eyes went to the side, to the door, to the garden, to anywhere but her. "I have not been receiving. My husband has been—" she stopped. "You should not have come to this house. There are men who watch it. My husband has a position; he is on the board for the water; if it were known that I had received you—"

"Then receive me in the garden," Antonia said, "where the servants cannot hear, for five minutes, and then I will go, and I will not come again."

Vipsania looked at her.

Then she turned and walked into the garden, and Antonia followed her.

The winter garden was a green place with a pool and a hundred pots and a small bronze boy with a dolphin. Vipsania stood by the pool with her back to her, and her shoulders were shaking.

"I cannot," she said.

"You can. You are the wife of a consular. Your word is worth something in that basilica, and your husband's is worth more, and if you go to him tonight and tell him that he is to speak for me, he will do it, because he is afraid of you and because he has been afraid of you since the day you married him."

"Antonia—"

"Eleven years," Antonia said. "Eleven years, Vipsania. I have kept your secrets. I have kept the one about your son and the horse, and the one about the debt to the Jew in the Transitberina that your husband does not know about, and the one about the summer you spent at Baiae when your husband was in Africa. I have never asked you for anything. Not once. Not when the house was closed, not when the edict went up, not when a boy of twelve was carried out of a yard in the Via Tusculana." Her voice was quiet. "I am asking you now."

Vipsania turned around.

She was crying, and it was not the kind of crying that Antonia had seen in her own house, the useful kind; it was the ugly kind, with the mouth open.

"You do not understand," she said. "You have never understood. You are not like me. You have never had to be liked."

"I have spent my entire life having to be liked."

"No." Vipsania wiped her face with the back of her hand. "You have spent your life being necessary. It is not the same. A woman like me has no money of her own and no house of her own and no name of her own, and the only thing she has is the opinion that other people have of her, and she has to keep it the way a man keeps a wall. If I speak for you in that basilica, my husband will not divorce me; he is too afraid of my father's family. But every woman in Rome will

know by the evening, and every one of them will say: *she has been going to that house for eleven years. What do you think she was buying there?* And my son will hear it at the baths, and my daughter's betrothal will be—" She stopped.

Antonia looked at her.

"And a boy is dead," she said.

"Yes."

"And I am to be tried for my life."

"Yes." Vipsania's voice was small. "I am sorry. I am truly sorry. I have not slept since it happened, and I have prayed, and I have made an offering at the temple of Juno, and it has not helped. I am not a brave woman. I have never been a brave woman. I have been a woman who was liked, and it has been enough for forty-four years, and now I find that it is not enough, and I cannot make myself into something else at my age."

Antonia stood in the winter garden of the house on the Caelian and looked at the woman she had known for eleven years.

"You will think about this for the rest of your life," she said.

"I know."

"Not tonight. Not next month. In ten years, when you are fifty-four and your son is in the Senate and your daughter is married and everything is exactly as you wanted it, you will be sitting in this garden in the afternoon and it will come to you that there was a week in the summer when you could have stood up and did not." Antonia turned to go. "And you will find that you cannot tell anyone, because everyone you know will agree with what you did."

Vipsania put out her hand.

"Antonia—"

"Do not."

"I will send money."

"Keep your money," Antonia said. "I have never taken money from a friend and I am not going to start on the worst day of my life."

She went out through the peristyle and the old Republican atrium and past the two women at the door, and the doorkeeper, who had known her for eleven years and had always called her domina, looked at the floor as she passed him.

She walked home along the Caelian in the heat.

Halfway down, in the shadow of the wall of the Claudian aqueduct, she stopped and put her hand against the stone, and stood there for a while with her eyes shut.

Five, she thought. *Blandus, and Hostilius if I press him, and Sura's son if I frighten him, and the praetor, if the praetor is capable of anything, which he is not. Four. And Vipsania was the fifth, and Vipsania is a woman like me, and I have known for a year that she would not stand, and I asked her anyway, because a woman who is drowning will ask anyone.*

She went on down the hill.

The edict came on the fourth day, and it was nailed to the door by a public slave with a pot of paste and a brush, while a small crowd gathered to watch and the neighbours came out onto their balconies.

It said, in the flat language of the prefect's office, that whereas a death had occurred in the fourth region of the city in a house of public resort, and whereas the inquiry was not yet concluded, and whereas the peace of the region was to be preserved, no house of public entertainment in the fourth region was to be open for the sale of food, drink or company until the inquiry was concluded; and that the owner of the house concerned was to remain in the city and to present herself at the prefecture when called.

There was a space at the bottom for the seal, and the seal was there, a bull in a gate.

Junilla read it, because Junilla could read, and then she came in and stood in the middle of the atrium with the paste still on her hands.

"They have shut us," she said.

"I know."

"For how long?"

"Until the inquiry is concluded."

"And when is that?"

"When the prefect concludes it," Antonia said.

The women were all there by then, standing in the atrium and on the stairs, Meroe with her hair half braided, Prisca with the keys at her belt, the kitchen girls with their arms wet to the elbow, Leda in the doorway with her lyre in her hands. Nobody said anything. Outside, the crowd was still there, and somebody laughed, and somebody else said something that made the others laugh, and a boy threw a stone at the door and it made a flat, stupid sound and everyone in the house flinched.

"Listen to me," Antonia said.

They listened.

"This is not the end. It is a bad month, and there will be a worse one after it, and then it will be over. Nobody is to leave the house after dark. Nobody is to speak to the men at the door. If a man comes to the door and asks for me, he is to be told that I am at the baths, and if he asks when I will be back, he is to be told that I did not say." She looked at each of them in turn, the way she looked at the fourth basin. "Junilla, take the notice down and burn it. Prisca, we will need the winter stores brought up now; the price of oil will go up when the inquiry is in the streets and I will not pay it twice. Meroe, you will practise in the courtyard every morning where the neighbours can hear you, because a house with music in it is a house that is not afraid. Calybe, we will eat plainly for a month and nobody is to com-

plain, and on the Kalends we will have a dinner for the household, with the good wine, and we will invite nobody."

"And the girls who are not of the household?" Prisca said. "The ones who come in for the evenings?"

"Tell them to stay away until the autumn. Pay them for the month. In full."

"That is three thousand sesterces."

"It is cheaper than a girl who is frightened and talks to the watch." Antonia turned to Leda. "You. Come with me."

She took her into the counting room and shut the door.

"The panel sits in nine days," she said. "You will be called. My patron will be there—" she stopped, and corrected herself, because the word had come out of her mouth before she had thought about it. "Gaius Claudius Corvus will be there. He is the man who came to the basilica, the one whose son you have been meeting by the river, and he has known about you for some time. He will ask you questions. He will be courteous. He will be the most courteous man in the room, and he will try to make you say something you do not mean to say."

"I know," Leda said. "I have met his son."

"His son is not his father."

"No," said Leda. "That is what everyone keeps telling me."

Antonia looked at her for a moment. There was something in the girl's face that had not been there a month ago: a hardness, a thing shut like a door.

"You will tell them what you saw," Antonia said. "The man, the tunic, the cup, the passage. Nothing more. Not what you think, not what you guessed, not what I told you. What you saw."

"And what will happen to me afterward?"

"You will be given to your mother, if Corvus has his way. Or you will be kept as a witness, if the prefect has his. Or—" Antonia hesitated, and then said it, because the girl deserved at least one true thing.

"Or you will be sold, if I lose, because everything in this house is mine and a woman who loses a case in Rome loses everything, including the people who trusted her."

Leda nodded slowly.

"Then I will not lose," she said, and went out.

Antonia stood alone in the counting room for a while. Then she went out into the courtyard, where the fountain was running and the bronze myrtle was dripping, and she looked up at the strip of sky above the roof, and she thought about the man in the passage with his short hair and his dark tunic and his shoulder turned away, and she thought: *Somebody in this city is being paid to have me destroyed, and it is not Eutychus, because Eutychus would have done it more cheaply. Eutychus is being paid too. Somebody has bought us both.*

She called Felix.

He came at a run, as he always did, with his hair standing up and a smudge on his cheek from the lamp.

"You remember the man I told you about," she said. "The neat one, with the tablet, who comes out of the kitchen door at night."

"Faustus," said Felix. "The steward of the house on the Palatine."

"Yes." She crouched down so that her eyes were level with his. "I want you to follow him."

Felix's face lit up.

"Follow him where?"

"Wherever he goes. He will not see you if you are careful, and you are small and you are quick and you know this quarter better than he does. You will not speak to him. You will not let him see your face. You will watch where he goes and who he meets and how long he stays, and then you will come back and tell me." She put her hand on his shoulder. "And Felix. If anything happens that frightens you, you will run. You will not be brave. You will run, and you will come home, and I will not be angry."

"I am not afraid of him."

"You should be," Antonia said.

She watched him go out through the kitchen door with his shoulders back and his chin up, twelve years old and eight hundred sesterces and worth more to her than the whole of the house, and she stood in the courtyard for a long time afterward with her hand on the rim of the fountain, listening to the water.

That night Blandus came to the kitchen door.

He came with his toga pulled over his head and his shoes in his hand and the look of a man who had spent an hour working out how to be seen by nobody, and he stood in the kitchen with the smell of wine on him and his eyes going everywhere, and he said, "I heard. I heard about the edict. I came at once."

"You came because I sent for you."

"That too." He sat down heavily on the bench. "Antonia. I cannot pay the sixty thousand."

"I know."

"I have until the Kalends of August. If I do not pay, the man in the Velabrum will take the house at Signia, and my wife will—" he put his face in his hands. "I have made a mess of it. I have made a mess of everything. I had a career, you know, when I was young; I was quaestor at thirty-one, and I had a wife with a good name, and I have spent twenty years being charming to people who could have helped me and never asking them for anything, and now I am fifty and I have nothing to show for it but a beautiful wife who despises me and two sons who are ashamed."

Antonia sat down across from him.

"Look at me," she said.

He looked up.

"You owe me sixty thousand sesterces. I am going to give you the note."

He stared.

"What?"

"I am going to give you the note, and I am going to write on it that the debt is discharged, and you will take it to the man in the Velabrum and show it to him, and he will understand that Decimus Terentius Blandus has a patron who is owed by half the Senate and he will wait." She took a tablet from the shelf and broke the seal on the note and wrote across the wax while he watched. "In return, you will do one thing for me."

"Anything."

"Do not say anything," Antonia said. "Not yet. When the panel sits, and they ask whether anyone in Rome can speak for the character of Antonia Cassia, you will stand up."

Blandus's face did something complicated.

"The panel is the prefect's," he said. "To speak for you there is to be marked."

"Yes."

"I am a senator."

"Yes."

"I have a wife and two sons and a name that has been in this city for four hundred years."

"Yes," Antonia said, "and you have sixty thousand sesterces of my money in your hand."

He looked at the tablet. He looked at the wall. He looked, for a long moment, at nothing at all.

"I will stand up," he said.

"Thank you."

"I am not doing it for the money."

"No," said Antonia. "You are doing it because you are a man who has spent his life being liked and has just discovered what it costs to be needed. It is not the same thing, and it is worth more." She stood. "Go out by the kitchen. And Blandus—do not tell anyone you were here."

He went.

Antonia sat alone in the kitchen with the lamp and the cold oven and the sixty thousand sesterces she had just given away, and she thought: *One. That is one man who will stand up. I need nine.*

She counted them on her fingers in the dark, and she got to four.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Tiro

He had been in the house seventeen years and in that time he had learned the shape of the quarter the way a sailor learns the shape of a hull: every crack in it, every place where the water came in.

He went out at the second hour with a purse at his belt and a knife in his sleeve, and he went first to the barber.

The barber's shop was in the Via Tuscus under a striped awning, and it had three chairs and a boy who swept the hair into the street, and it was the best place in the fourth region to hear a thing before it was true. Tiro sat in the corner with his back to the wall and let the barber do his chin, which did not need it, and listened.

"—and the prefect has put Maro on it, and Maro is a hard man—"

"—hard men are the ones who take money, because soft men cannot get close enough—"

"—they say the old man's face went black as a boot—"

"—they say the woman did it herself, with her own hands, out of spite—"

"—they say she has a box of names that would bring down half the Senate—"

Tiro paid the barber and went out. The last one was the one that mattered, and it had been said loudly, by a man who had been drinking at the ninth hour of the morning, and it had been said in the tone of a thing that had been repeated before. Somebody was spreading the box. Somebody wanted the box to be talked about, so that when the prefect came to look for it, he would find it.

He went to the Emporium.

The great warehouses along the Tiber were already busy: the cranes swinging, the porters running with sacks on their shoulders, the clerks at their tables under the colonnade with the smell of the river coming up between the stones. Tiro walked along the wharf to the fourth shed, where the goods from Africa came in, and asked for a man called Niger, and waited while a boy went to find him.

Niger came out wiping his hands. He was a big Numidian with a broken nose and a freedman's cap, and he had been in the same barracks as Tiro in the year of the games, though they had never fought each other, which was the foundation of a friendship that had lasted twenty-six years.

"You look bad," Niger said.

"I look the same."

"You look worse than the same." Niger jerked his head toward the back of the shed, and they stood among the sacks where no one could hear. "The Myrtle."

"The Myrtle."

"Is it true?"

"Some of it." Tiro looked out at the river. "An old man died at the table. Not of a fit. Something in his cup. The prefect's men are all over the house and the door is shut and the women are frightened and the domina has a lip like a plum."

"And you want to know who did it."

"I want to know who sold the thing that did it."

Niger was quiet for a moment.

"There is a woman," he said. "In the Subura. Off the Argiletum, behind the dyer's, up the stairs where the lamp is. Her name is Canthara. She is old and she is half blind and she sells rat poison and love philtres and something for the gout, and she will sell anything to anyone because she cannot see well enough to be afraid of them." He wiped his hands again. "She has been there thirty years. She sold to my wife, for the rats. She is not a wicked woman. She is a shop."

"Will she talk?"

"She will talk if you pay her and she will talk more if you frighten her, and the frightening will cost you less." Niger put a hand on his arm. "Tiro. If it is a great house, leave it. Go to the domina and tell her to pay the fine and close the door for a year and sell the house and go to Baiae. She has money. She can live anywhere."

"She will not go."

"No," said Niger. "They never do." He let go. "If you need men, I have men."

"I know."

"That is not a no."

"It is not a yes." Tiro turned up his collar. "If I need men I will send the boy with a message that says the fish is off."

The Subura at the third hour smelled of tanning and smoke and the kind of cooking that is done with whatever is left. Tiro went up the stairs behind the dyer's with his hand on the wall, because the steps were worn and the light was bad, and knocked on the door at the top.

"Who is it?"

"An old customer."

"I have no old customers. They are all dead."

"Then a new one."

The door opened a hand's breadth. Behind it there was a room with a curtain, a table, a great many jars on shelves, a smell of dried things and honey and something underneath that was like a

butcher's yard in summer. The woman was very old and very small and her eyes were the colour of milk.

"Who sent you?"

"Niger, of the fourth shed."

"Ah." She opened the door. "Niger is a good man. He has a wife who beats him." She went back to her table and sat down. "What do you want? If it is for the rats, I have a paste that will kill a dog. If it is for a woman, I have a thing that will make her love you and a thing that will make her sorry, and the second is cheaper because it works quicker."

"It is not for a woman." Tiro sat down opposite her. "A man came to you nine days ago. Short hair, cut close. A dark tunic with a narrow stripe. He bought something."

The old woman's hands stopped moving among the jars.

"I do not remember," she said.

"You remember."

"I sell to a hundred men a month."

"You sell to women in this street and to the boys who work the docks, and once or twice a year a man in a good tunic comes up those stairs and you remember him for a year, because a man in a good tunic pays in silver and does not haggle and frightens you." He put a coin on the table. "I am not the prefect. I am not going to hang you. I want to know what he bought and what he said."

She looked at the coin without touching it.

"He bought white hellebore," she said. "Two drachms. And something else, which I will not name, because I did not sell it to him and he did not ask for it, and I am an old woman who has been in this street for thirty years and I know what a man is going to do with a thing before he does it."

"What did he say?"

"He said it was for his master's garden. For the moles." She laughed, and it turned into a cough. "Moles. In a garden in this city.

There are no moles in the gardens of this city; there are slaves who cut the grass and a man with a stick who kills the snakes. Moles." She wiped her mouth. "He was not a gardener. He had the hands of a man who carries a tray."

"Did he give a name?"

"He gave a name that was not his. They all do." She leaned forward. "But he had a mark. On the inside of the wrist, here. A burn, small, round, the size of a pea, and it had been done twice, so it made a figure of eight. I saw it when he counted out the silver." She sat back. "That is a slave's mark. A house mark. I have seen it before, on a man who came to buy a thing for his mistress's rival, twenty years ago, and I remember it because it was a curious thing, a burn in the shape of an eight."

"Whose house?"

"I do not know. I am a poisoner in the Subura, not a herald." She pushed the coin back across the table. "Take it. I do not want to be paid for this. I want to be left alone, and I want it understood that I told you nothing, because if it is a great house, and they hear that old Canthara talked, I will be found in the Tiber with my throat open and no one will inquire."

Tiro took the coin and stood up.

"One more thing," he said. "If a man comes to you in the next month and asks whether anyone has been asking about the man with the mark, you will tell him no."

"Why would I do that?"

"Because if you tell him yes, he will kill you," Tiro said, "and I would rather you were alive."

He went down the stairs and out into the light.

He knew where the mark was from. He had known before she said it; he had known the moment she said *a burn in the shape of an eight*, and he had stood in the small room off the kitchen of the house of Gaius Claudius Corvus three times in the last month and

seen the household slaves going about their business with their sleeves rolled up in the heat.

He walked for an hour without knowing where he was going, and found himself at the foot of the Aventine, at the shrine of the god who has no name, where the carters leave their garlands.

He had been a slave for the first thirty-five years of his life. He had been a gladiator for eleven of them. He had killed nine men in the arena, and the ninth had been a boy of nineteen with a net and a trident who had slipped on the sand, and Tiro had put his sword through the boy's throat because the crowd was screaming for it and because a gladiator who hesitates is a gladiator who is dead next season. He had been given his freedom at thirty-five by a magistrate who wanted to be seen to be merciful, and he had been given nothing else, and he had come to Rome with a knife and a scar and no name, and Antonia Cassia had found him in a doorway on the Vicus Tuscus in the rain and had said, *You look like a man who can keep a door*, and he had said, *I look like a man who can keep anything*, and she had laughed and taken him home.

Everything he had, he had because of her. That was the simple arithmetic of his life and he had never once needed to be reminded of it.

And he had a son.

The boy was fourteen. His name was Rufus, and he was in a smithy at Tibur, and he had been born to Tiro's wife, who had belonged to a Greek merchant and had died of a fever when the boy was six. The boy belonged to the smith, who had bought him as an apprentice with his mother, and the smith was a hard man but not a cruel one, and the boy was strong and had his mother's hands. Tiro had seen him four times in eight years, the last time in the spring, when he had walked to Tibur on his day off and stood in the street outside the smithy and watched his son work the bellows for an hour without going in, because he did not know what to say.

The papers would cost six hundred sesterces. He had two hundred and eleven in a jar under his bed.

He went back to the house at dusk.

She was in the counting room with the lamp lit and the tablets out, and she had been crying; he could tell by the way she held her face, which was the way a woman holds her face when she has been crying and has decided not to be seen doing it.

"Well?"

He stood in front of the table. "The woman in the Subura remembers a man. Short hair, a dark tunic with a narrow stripe, silver in his hand. He bought white hellebore and said it was for the moles." He paused. "She did not know his name. He had a mark on his wrist, a burn in the shape of an eight. That is a house mark, and there are forty households in Rome that use one, and she did not know which."

Antonia sat back.

"Forty households," she said.

"It is not a name."

"It is a start." She picked up the stylus. "I will send to Zosimus in the morning and have him inquire among the clerks at the prefecture; the clerks know the marks, they are always writing them down on runaway notices—"

"Domina."

She looked up.

"It will take a month to find a mark among forty households," Tiro said. "And when you find it, it will be the mark of a man who has already been paid and gone to ground, and the man who paid him will be a name in a great house that will swear the mark was stolen or the man was dismissed in the spring. I have been in this city thirty years. I know how these things go."

"Then what would you have me do?"

"I would have you take the fine and close the door and go to Baiae until the autumn."

"No."

"Domina—"

"No." She put the stylus down. "I have been in this city eighteen years, Tiro, and I have never once run, and I am not going to begin at forty because a man in a great house would find it convenient." She looked at him. "You have been with me seventeen years. You have never asked me for anything. Not a wage, not a favour, not a day. Why not?"

Tiro stood in the lamplight.

"I have everything I want," he said.

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one I have."

She looked at him for a moment and then, because she was tired and because it was that hour of the evening when people say things, she said, "Do you have a family?"

He should have said no. He had said no for seventeen years, to the cook, to Prisca, to the women, to a magistrate in the prefecture who had asked him once for the record. It was not a lie exactly. A man who has a son he has seen four times in eight years does not have a family; he has a debt.

But she had asked, and she had asked in the voice she used when she was not asking as a mistress.

"A son," he said.

Antonia put down the stylus.

"Where?"

"Tibur. In the smithy by the gate. He is fourteen." Tiro heard his own voice, flat and unsurprised, as though he were reading out a manifest. "His mother died when he was six. She belonged to a Greek merchant and the merchant sold her and the boy together to a smith

at Tibur, and the smith is not a cruel man, and the boy is strong and has the knack of the work, and he will be a good smith if he lives."

"And you see him."

"When I can."

"How often?"

"Four times in eight years."

She was quiet for a moment.

"Why so little?"

Tiro looked at the wall behind her, at the racks of tablets, at the lamp.

"Because the first time I went, he was six years old and he did not know me, and he held on to the smith's wife's skirt and would not come to me. And the second time he was eight and he knew me, and he stood in the yard and looked at me the way a dog looks at a man who has kicked it before. And the third time he was eleven and he asked me whether I was going to take him away, and I said not yet, and he said *that is what you said before.*" He stopped. "The fourth time was in the spring and I stood in the street and looked at him through the door of the shop for an hour and did not go in."

"Why?"

"Because I had nothing to say to him."

Antonia looked at him for a long moment.

"You could say: *I am sorry,*" she said.

"I have nothing to be sorry for. I have been a slave all my life and he is a slave, and I did not sell him and I did not leave him; the world did that."

"You could say it anyway."

Tiro looked at the floor.

"I could," he said.

She picked up the stylus again and turned it over.

"How much would it cost to buy him?"

"Six hundred. Gallio has said so. It will be twelve hundred by the time I have six hundred, because he is a man with a business and the boy is worth more every year."

"Then I will give you six hundred."

Tiro's head came up.

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because then he is your freedman and not mine," Tiro said, "and because you would give it to me and never mention it, and I would think about it every day for the rest of my life, and I am fifty-two years old and I do not want to spend the rest of my life being grateful." He heard how it sounded and did not take it back. "I will buy him myself. It will take four years. I have two hundred and eleven."

Antonia looked at him.

"You are a proud man for a man with a scar," she said.

"I am a proud man for a man with nothing. It is the only thing I have that nobody gave me."

She stood up and came around the table and did a thing she had not done in seventeen years: she put her hand flat on his chest, over the heart, the way a woman touches a member of her own family.

"Then go to Tibur on the next market day," she said, "and stand in the yard and say the thing you have nothing to be sorry for, and see what happens. And Tiro—" she took her hand away. "When this is over, whatever happens, if I have a house and you are in it, he will have a place. Not as a favour. As wages, for work. I will find him work."

Tiro looked at her.

"Yes, domina," he said.

He went out into the corridor and stood in the dark with his hand on the wall.

Then he went up through the house and out onto the roof and stood there for a while with his hands on the parapet.

From the roof of that house you could see the whole quarter: the roofs going down to the Velabrum and the river beyond it, and the Palatine up on the right with the temple of Apollo lit, and the great black mass of the amphitheatre away to the south-east with a light or two in it where the men were still working.

He had stood on that roof perhaps a hundred times in seventeen years. It was the only place in the city where he was above everybody.

He thought about the fact that a man may be a slave for thirty-five years and a freedman for seventeen and that the difference between the two is a piece of paper and a name, and that in the end the piece of paper is worth exactly what the man who can read it says it is worth.

Then he went down to his room and took the jar out from under the bed and counted the two hundred and eleven sesterces, and put them back.

He had told her about the mark. He had not told her whose he thought it was, and he had watched her face while he said it, and she had believed him.

He did not know, then, why he lied. He told himself it was because a name was not a proof, and because a steward's mark was not a confession, and because if he said the name out loud in that house, the domina would go to the prefect with it and the prefect would laugh at her, or worse, would go to Corvus, and Corvus would know that she had been told, and the boy in the smithy at Tibur would be the one who paid.

All of that was true. None of it was the reason.

The reason was that he had seen his son in the spring, and the boy had looked at him across the street with the flat, patient, unsurprised look of a slave who has learned that the people who are sup-

posed to come for him do not come, and Tiro had walked back to Rome with that look in his chest like a stone.

He went out again at the ninth hour, and this time he did not go to the Subura. He went to the Emporium.

The man with the mark came down to the river every second evening to meet a boat.

Tiro watched him for three nights from the colonnade, and on the third night he followed him. The man went along the wharf past the fourth shed and the fifth, and turned up the alley between the warehouses where the lamp-oil was stored, and there was nobody there, and it was dark, and the sound of the river was loud.

Tiro took him by the back of the neck and put him against the wall.

"Don't," he said. "Don't shout. If you shout I will break your neck and leave you in the water and nobody will find you for a week."

The man was young, twenty-five or so, thin, with a face that would have been handsome if it had not been so frightened. He had a purse at his belt and a knife he did not reach for.

"Who are you?"

"That does not matter. What matters is the eight on your wrist and the hellebore you bought nine days ago in the Subura."

The man's face went slack.

"I don't know what you—"

"You do." Tiro pressed him harder against the wall. "A consular died at the table of Antonia Cassia. You bought the poison. You carried it. Somebody paid you and I want to know who."

"I can't."

"You can."

"He'll kill me."

"He will kill you anyway," Tiro said. "He will kill you because you are the only thing between him and a rope, and he is a man who

does not leave things between himself and what he wants. You know this. You have known it for nine days and you have been sleeping badly."

The man began to cry. It was a horrible sound, quiet and hitching, and it went on for a while, and Tiro held him against the wall and waited, because he had learned in the arena that a man who is crying is a man who is about to talk.

"It was not for me," the man said. "I was told to put it in the cup. The old man's cup. Not the wine, because the wine was poured in front of everyone, but the cup itself, before the second course, in the passage, and then I was to go out by the kitchen and not come back."

"Who told you?"

"The steward."

"Which steward?"

The man looked at him. In the dark his eyes were two wet holes.

"I have a wife," he said. "She is in the house. If I am gone she will be sold."

"Which steward?"

"Faustus."

Tiro let go of him.

He did not decide to do it. That was the thing he would think about afterward, in the years that were left to him, which were fewer than he expected: that he did not decide, that his hand went to his sleeve and his body did the thing it had been trained to do thirty years before in a barracks in Capua, and that it was over in the time it takes to close a door.

The man made a small sound and sat down against the wall with his hands on his stomach, and looked at Tiro with an expression of enormous surprise.

"Run," Tiro said. "Run, you fool."

But the man did not run. He slid sideways into the dirt of the alley, and his hands came away from his stomach red, and Tiro stood

over him and watched him die, and it took less time than he would have believed.

Then he knelt down and went through the man's belt and found a purse with eleven denarii in it and a bronze token with a bull on one side and a name on the other: CALLISTVS. And under the token, folded small, a scrap of papyrus with three words on it in a bad hand, which he could not read, and which he put in his own belt because he could not read it and because a man who cannot read a thing should not leave it on a corpse.

He dragged the body to the water and rolled it in.

He stood on the wharf afterward and washed his hands in the river, and the river went by as it always went by, black and busy and indifferent, and the lights of the boats moved on it, and somewhere a long way off a woman was singing.

He walked back up the hill and let himself in by the kitchen door, and Prisca said, "You are late," and he said, "I was at the docks," and she said, "You smell like the docks," and he went up to his room and sat on the bed in the dark with his hands in his lap.

Faustus, he thought.

He knew what it meant. It meant that the steward of Gaius Claudius Corvus had bought the poison that killed Gaius Vettius Proculus, and that the man who was on the panel of inquiry into the death was the master of the man who had bought it, and that either Corvus had ordered it or Corvus's house had done it without his knowledge and Corvus would destroy anyone who said so. Either way, the road from that alley went to the Palatine, and the Palatine was the tallest hill in Rome.

And in his belt there was a scrap of papyrus with three words on it, and he could not read.

He was still sitting there when there was a knock at the door.

He opened it. Faustus was standing on the landing with a lamp in his hand and a smile on his face, and behind him, at the bottom of the stairs, there were two men.

"Tiro," he said. "May I come in? I think we have something to discuss."

"You have a great deal of nerve," Tiro said, "coming into this house."

"I have a great deal of nerve and a great deal to offer." Faustus stepped past him into the room and looked around it: the bed, the chest, the knife on the table. "You killed a man tonight. A slave of the house of Claudius Corvus, in an alley by the fourth shed. He was not a good man, and he was not important, and the world is better without him, and none of that matters. What matters is that I know, and that there are two men at the bottom of the stairs who will do what I tell them, and that in a little while I am going to have to decide whether to tell them to come up."

Tiro did not move.

"There is a boy," Faustus said. "At Tibur. In the smithy of a man called Gallio. Fourteen years old. Dark hair, like his mother. He is a slave of the estate, and I keep the estate's papers, and I have his manumission here—" he tapped his sleeve— "and a place for him in a household in Gaul, where a boy who can work iron can be a freedman in six years and a citizen in ten."

"That paper is not yours to give."

"Everything is mine to give," said Faustus, "because I am the man who holds it." He set the lamp down on the chest. "Give me the scrap of papyrus you took off the body. Give me the token. Tell me what the man said, and to whom you have said it, and then go back to your bed and be a steward, and in a month, when this is over, I will put your son's papers in your hand and you will never see me again."

Tiro looked at him.

He thought about Antonia Cassia in the rain, saying *you look like a man who can keep a door.* He thought about the boy at the bellows, and the flat look across the street, and the four times in eight years.

"No," he said.

Faustus's smile did not change.

"Think about it," he said. "I will come again on the Ides."

He took his lamp and went down the stairs, and the two men went with him, and Tiro stood in the doorway of his room for a long time with his hand on the frame.

Then he went to the chest and took out the jar with the two hundred and eleven sesterces in it, and counted them, and put them back, and sat on the bed with the scrap of papyrus in his hand, turning it over and over, and thought about the fact that he was fifty-two years old and could not read.

He thought about the shrine of the crossroads, and the lamp, and the paper in Faustus's sleeve.

He thought about the fact that a man who cannot read must trust whoever can, and that he had spent his life being proud of a thing that was, in the end, only a way of not knowing.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Corvus

The prefecture stood at the foot of the Palatine, in the old house that had belonged to a family no one remembered, and the room in which the panel sat had been a dining room once. You could still see the place on the wall where the painted frieze had been cut away, and the floor was a mosaic of a hunting scene with most of the animals missing, and there was a smell in it of wet stone and hot lamp oil and the particular smell of a room in which men wait.

There were three of them on the panel.

Lucius Pedo Vergilianus, the prefect of the city, was a heavy, tired, careful man of sixty who had been a consul and a governor and had asked for this post because it was the last one and because it kept him in Rome. He sat at the head of the table with his hands folded and his eyes half shut and said almost nothing.

Caius Vibius Maro, of the urban cohorts, sat at the end with a tablet and a stylus and the air of a man who has already decided and is waiting for the evidence to catch up. He had a scar on his neck and a way of looking at a witness as though he were measuring him for a collar.

And Corvus sat in the middle, in a plain toga, with his hands on the table.

The business of the first day was the cup.

It came in on a tray, carried by a slave, with a cloth over it, and Pedo lifted the cloth himself. It was a common cup of red Samian ware, with a chip in the rim and a dark stain inside that had not been washed out.

"The physician," said Maro. "Sarpedon of Athens, slave of Antonia Cassia."

Sarpedon came in. He had been sobered up by somebody and he was not enjoying it. He stood with his hands behind his back and gave his evidence in the flat voice of a man reciting a lesson.

"The deceased was sixty-one years of age and had the appearance of a man who had been unwell for some time. He had eaten oysters, eggs, thrush, kid, turbot and a dish of quinces, and had drunk, by his own servant's account, three cups of wine and water in the course of the evening, which is nothing. When I reached him he was on the floor, insensible, with the pulse gone from the wrist and the throat. The face was discoloured, the eyes prominent, the mouth foaming. There was no wound. There was no disease of the heart that I could detect, and I looked."

"You looked," said Maro.

"I looked."

"Are you often drunk when you look?"

Sarpedon's jaw tightened. "I had been drinking. It was a banquet. I was not so drunk that I could not find a man's heart."

"In your opinion, what killed him?"

"In my opinion he was poisoned."

"With what?"

"With something that acts quickly and produces convulsions and a discolouration of the face. Aconite would do it. White hellebore would do it. There are a dozen things that would do it, and half

of them can be bought in the Subura for the price of a dinner, and I could not tell you which it was without the stomach, and the stomach is—" he stopped.

"Where is the stomach?"

"Burned, with the body, on the fifth day, according to the custom."

Maro wrote something down. Pedo opened his eyes.

"Who washed the cup?" Corvus asked.

The room turned to him.

"The cup," he said. "It came from the table to this building in a locked box, and it is stained, and it has not been washed. Who decided that?"

"The steward of the house," said Maro, "at the instruction of the woman. She had it sealed and put in the strongbox before the body was cold. Which is either the act of an innocent woman preserving evidence, or the act of a guilty one preserving the appearance of it."

"Or the act of a woman who has been in business for twenty years," Corvus said, "and knows that in this city the man who holds the object decides what it means."

Pedo looked at him for a moment. There was something in the old man's face that Corvus did not like: not suspicion, exactly. Recognition.

"You have a theory, Corvus?"

"I have a question. The deceased brought his own cup. Why?"

"His servant says he was afraid of being poisoned."

"Then he was afraid of a particular person, or a particular house, and he went into that house anyway, and drank from his own cup, and died." Corvus turned his own cup around on the table, once, and stopped himself, because it was a habit of his father's. "I would like to know who he was afraid of."

"We have asked the servant," said Maro. "He says he does not know. He says his master did not confide in him."

"Then ask him again."

"We will ask him again," said Maro, "when we have him on the hook. He is a slave. His evidence is worth nothing until then."

Corvus looked at him.

"The man is a witness, not a suspect."

"Every slave is a suspect," said Maro, "until he has been examined."

Pedo cleared his throat. "We will come to the servants in due course. Today we will hear the woman."

They brought Antonia Cassia in at the third hour.

She came in through the door at the end of the room with her head up and her hands folded in front of her, in a plain white stola with no ornament but two pearls, and she was, Corvus thought, entirely composed. There was a scab on her lower lip, which he had put there, and which every man in the room had noticed, and which she had not attempted to hide with paint, and he understood, with a cold drop of something in his stomach, that she had left it showing on purpose.

"Antonia Cassia," said Pedo. "You are the owner of the house on the Vicus Tuscus known as the Gilded Myrtle."

"I am."

"You are a freedwoman."

"I am."

"Of what patron?"

"Of Gaius Claudius Corvus," Antonia said, "who is sitting at this table."

The room was very quiet.

Pedo's eyes went to Corvus. Maro's stylus stopped moving.

"Is this true?" Pedo asked.

"It is true," Corvus said. "I manumitted her seventeen years ago, in my father's house, before witnesses now dead. I have not seen her in the interval, and I did not know that she was the owner of the

house in question until nine days before Vettius's death, and I have declared the connection to the prefect in writing." He heard his own voice, level and cold, and he was impressed by it. "I have no interest in her fortune and no wish to defend her. I am here because I was asked to be here."

"You might have mentioned it sooner."

"I might have," Corvus said. "I did not think it was to the purpose."

"It is to the purpose now," said Maro, with a certain relish. "A patron sits on the panel that tries his own freedwoman."

"A patron," said Corvus, "sits on the panel that tries the woman accused of poisoning a consular at her own table, and whose house is a public nuisance, and who has been cited not for a crime against me but against the city. If I were to withdraw every time a man in this room had a connection to a woman—" he stopped himself. "I will withdraw if the prefect wishes it."

Pedo looked at him for a long moment.

"No," he said. "Sit. I would rather have you where I can see you."

Antonia smiled, very slightly, at nobody at all.

They examined her for two hours.

Maro asked the questions. Where was she when the cup was filled? What did she know of the deceased? Had she quarrelled with him? Had he offered her money? Had he been refused? How many times had he visited her house? Who were her bankers? Who were her patrons? Had she ever been accused of a crime? Had she ever been flogged? Had she ever been sold? By whom, to whom, for how much? Was it true that a woman of her condition could not give evidence in her own defence, and did she understand what that meant?

She answered all of it. She answered the questions about her girlhood in the same flat voice as the questions about the wine, and Corvus sat and listened, and once or twice he looked at the wall.

At the fourth hour Maro said, "The singer. The girl called Leda. She is yours?"

"She is of my household."

"She is a slave."

"She is of my household," Antonia said, "and I have reason to believe that she was free-born, and that her mother lives at Surrentum, and that a petition for her recovery is in the archive of this prefecture."

Maro's stylus paused.

"Who told you that?"

"Gaius Claudius Corvus told me," Antonia said, "in the portico of the temple of Castor, four days ago."

Corvus did not move.

Pedo turned his head, slowly, like a man who has heard a noise in an empty house.

"Is this true?" he asked.

"The girl's origin is a matter of record," Corvus said. "The dealer Nymphodorus of Puteoli sold her to the house six years ago, and the document of sale gives her origin as Massilia, which is false. I have made inquiries. Her mother's petition is in this building."

"And you did not think to bring it to the panel?"

"I am bringing it now," Corvus said, "with the girl."

"The girl is a witness," said Maro. "The girl's evidence is the only evidence that anyone saw a man in the passage. If she is free-born, her evidence is worth something without the hook, and the whole case changes shape." He looked at Corvus with a flat, unfriendly interest. "You have been sitting on this for four days."

"I have been verifying it for four days."

"Yes," said Maro. "You have."

Pedo closed his eyes for a moment.

"We will adjourn," he said. "The girl will be brought before us tomorrow. She will be examined as a witness, and if her manumission

or her free birth is established, she will be examined without the hook, and if it is not established she will be examined as the law provides." He stood up, heavily. "Corvus. A word."

The room emptied. Maro went last, with his tablets under his arm and his eyes going from one of them to the other, and the door closed.

Pedo stood at the window with his back to him.

"You are making this difficult," he said.

"I am trying to keep it from becoming a joke."

"It became a joke in the Forum nine days ago. You cannot keep a thing from becoming a joke; you can only decide whether you are inside the joke or outside it." Pedo turned. "I asked you onto this panel because you are severe and because you have no connection to the house. You told me that. You looked me in the eye and told me that."

"I did not know it was a lie when I said it."

"No," said Pedo. "That is what is interesting about you." He came back to the table. "I have known you twenty years. You are the most upright man in the Senate and the coldest, and I have never once seen you do a dishonourable thing, and I have often wondered why. Most men are upright because they are afraid of the gods. You are upright the way a man is upright who is carrying something heavy and has decided that the only way to carry it is not to put it down." He sat. "What is she to you?"

"Nothing."

"You struck her in the portico of Castor, in front of two clerks and a man selling sausages. That is not nothing; that is the opposite of nothing."

"I struck her," Corvus said, "because she said something true."

Pedo looked at him for a long moment. Then he laughed, without much humour, and rubbed his face with both hands.

"Get out," he said. "Bring me the girl tomorrow. Bring me a case that does not stink, or I will hand the whole thing to Maro and let

him hang whoever he likes, and he will like the woman, because she is rich and he is not and because she looked at him as if he were a doorkeeper."

He went to the Caelian that afternoon, on foot, with one slave, and he did not send word first.

The house of the Vettii was on the slope above the Colosseum, and it was a house of the old kind with a bronze lion on the door and cypresses in the garden, and it had the particular smell of a house in which somebody has died: wax, and lilies going over, and the closed air of rooms that are not being used.

The doorkeeper said that his master was not receiving.

"Tell him Corvus."

"Dominus, he is not—"

"Tell him Corvus, and tell him that I am on the panel of inquiry into his father's death, and that if he does not receive me now I will come back with a lictor."

Publius Vettius received him in the tablinum.

He was thirty years old and he looked forty. He had the thin, strained face of a man who has not slept, and there was a cup on the table at his elbow and a set of accounts pushed to one side, and the room smelled of wine and dust.

"Corvus," he said. "You might have written."

"I might have." Corvus sat down without being invited. "I have come about your father's will."

"The will is sealed."

"The will is sealed until the estate is administered, which will be in the autumn, and I have no interest in the will. I have an interest in the fact that on the morning after your father died you sent a man to the Vicus Tuscus to ask whether the cup had been taken away."

Publius's face did not change. That was the thing that Corvus noticed, and it was the thing he would remember: that the face did

not change at all, and that a man whose father has died is not usually so good at that.

"I sent a man to ask about the cup because my father was poisoned," Publius said. "It seemed to me the most important object in the city."

"It is a reasonable answer."

"It is the true one."

"Then answer another." Corvus leaned back. "Your father came to that house with his own cup and his own servant and his own wine, because he was afraid of being poisoned. A man who is afraid of being poisoned is afraid of a particular person. Who was your father afraid of?"

Publius picked up his cup and drank.

"He was afraid of everyone," he said. "He was sixty-one years old and he had spent forty years in the Senate and he had made an enemy of every man he had ever worked with. He thought the cooks were poisoning him. He thought the barber was poisoning him. In the spring he accused his own steward of selling his wine and putting the money in a box, and the steward was innocent, and my father never spoke to him again." He set the cup down. "He was my father and I will not speak ill of him in this house, but he was not a man who was easy to live with, and the last year was very bad."

"I am sorry."

"No, you are not." Publius looked at him. "You are on a panel. You are here to find out whether I killed him."

"I am here to find out who did."

"Then find out." Publius stood up and went to the window and looked out at the garden. "I will tell you what I know, and then you will go, and we will not have to do this again. My father had a freedwoman in this house, an old woman called Chloe, who had been his nurse when he was a child. She had a son, a man of thirty-five who works in the grain office. In the spring my father told me that he in-

tended to leave Chloe sixty thousand sesterces and the farm at Signia, and that the son was to have a place in the grain office, and that I was to have the house and the debts and the name." He turned. "I was angry. I said things to him in this room that I am ashamed of. If you are looking for a man with a reason to want him dead, you have found one, and he is standing in front of you, and he is not going to lie about it to a man who will find out anyway."

Corvus looked at him.

"Where were you on the night?"

"At the house of a friend. Manlius Sura, on the Aventine. There were nine of us and we played at dice until the fourth hour." Publius's mouth turned. "You may ask him. He will tell you. He will also tell you that I lost a great deal of money and that I was in a foul temper, and that when the news came in the morning I wept in front of everyone, and none of it will make you believe me." He came back to the table. "Do you know what is going to happen, Corvus? Nothing. Nothing is going to happen. There will be an inquiry and a report and a woman will be blamed, because there is always a woman, and in the autumn I will take my father's seat and my father's debts and my father's house, and I will sit in the Senate in his place and listen to men who despised him tell me what a loss he was."

"That is a very bitter speech for a grieving son."

"I am not grieving," said Publius Vettius. "That is the thing I cannot say to anyone else. I am not grieving. I have been trying to grieve for nine days and I cannot do it. He was a cold man and a hard father and he made my mother's life a misery and he never once in thirty years said a kind thing to me that was not about the family, and now he is dead and I am supposed to be broken, and what I actually feel is that a weight has come off my chest and I am ashamed of it." He picked up the cup again. "There. That is the truth. Put it in your report."

Corvus sat with his hands on his knees.

"There is a mark," he said. "A burn in the shape of an eight, on the wrist of the man who carried the cup."

Publius stopped with the cup halfway to his mouth.

"Is there."

"The girl saw it. The singer."

"The singer." Publius set the cup down very carefully. "And whose mark is it?"

"That is what I am trying to establish."

"Well." Publius looked at him. "You had better establish it quickly, had you not, before somebody decides that the mark belongs to a man in a great house and the whole thing becomes a scandal that nobody can control."

The room was quiet. In the garden a bird was making a great deal of noise about something.

"I know what you are doing," Publius said. "You are sitting there in your good toga with your hands on your knees, and you are thinking that I did it, and you are also thinking that if I did it, it would be very convenient for everybody, because a son who kills his father is a scandal that can be contained, and a consul-designate whose steward kills a consular is a scandal that cannot." He smiled. "You are welcome to think it. But I will tell you something for nothing, Corvus, because my father is dead and I find that I no longer care what I say to anyone. Whatever I am, I am not the worst man in this city. I have been in this house for nine days with the walls, and I have had time to think about the difference between a man who does a wicked thing and a man who arranges for it to be done by somebody else and then goes to the Senate in a clean toga. I have decided that I am the first kind, and that I can live with it, and that I do not envy the second."

Corvus stood up.

"Thank you for your time," he said.

"Corvus."

He stopped at the door.

"When you find out who it was," Publius said, "and you will find out, because you are a thorough man and because you cannot help yourself, come and tell me. Not for justice. I have no interest in justice. I want to know what my father was worth." He picked up the cup. "It turns out that everything in this city has a price. I should like to know his."

Corvus went out through the atrium past the lilies and the doorkeeper and into the street, and he stood on the Caelian in the sun for a moment with his heart going in a way that he did not like at all.

I do not envy the second, he thought.

He walked home.

He sat in the tablinum until the light went, and then he called for a lamp and a cup of water and sat for a while longer.

The house was quiet around him. Somewhere above, his mother's shuttle went back and forth; the sound came down through the floor, steady as a pulse, and it had been the sound of his whole childhood, and he understood suddenly that it would be the sound he remembered when he was dying.

She has been spinning for forty years, he thought. *She has spun through three emperors and a civil war and the death of her husband and the marriage of her son and the birth of her grandchildren, and she has never once stopped, and I have never once asked her why.*

He got up and went to the door and looked up the stairs at the light in her room, and then he came back and sat down, and the letter came.

The letter came that evening.

It came in the hands of a young man of the imperial bureau, who rode up to the house on the Palatine at the ninth hour and asked for Gaius Claudius Corvus and would not give the letter to a slave.

Corvus received him in the tablinum and broke the seal and read it twice.

"Dominus?" said Faustus, from the door.

Corvus looked up. The lamp was between them.

"The emperor," he said, "has been pleased to designate me consul for the coming year."

Faustus made a sound. It was a small, undignified, entirely genuine sound, and then he came forward and took Corvus by the hand and kissed it, which he had not done in twenty years, and said, "Dominus. Dominus, this is—the family—your father—"

"Yes," Corvus said.

He sat down slowly.

The letter was three sentences long and the second sentence said that the emperor had been pleased to hear of his diligence in the matter of the death of a consular, and that he trusted the affair would be concluded without scandal to the Senate.

"There is a condition," Corvus said.

Faustus's face went carefully blank. "A condition, dominus?"

"Not stated. Implied." Corvus folded the letter. "The emperor is at Antioch. He has been at Antioch for a year and he is preparing for a war in the east that will cost more than the Dacian wars put together, and he needs the Senate quiet and the provinces calm and the grain fleet on time. He has heard that a consular died in a brothel and that a woman is to be tried for it, and he does not care whether she did it. He cares that in six months' time, when he comes back to Rome, nobody is still talking about it."

"And so?"

"And so I am to make it go away," Corvus said.

"Then it will go away."

"It will not go away by itself. It will go away because somebody makes it go away, and the somebody is me, and the making of it will be the first act of my consulship." He looked at the letter in his hand. "My father would have known how to do it."

"Your father," said Faustus, carefully, "would have done it without hesitating."

"Yes."

"Dominus—"

"Send to my mother," Corvus said. "Tell her the news. Tell her that the wedding will be in the autumn and that the consulship will be in the spring, and that I will want her to receive the wives." He stood. "And Faustus. Where were you on the night of the banquet?"

Faustus did not move. In the lamplight his face was the face of a man in a portrait: smooth, careful, entirely still.

"At the house of the Vestals," he said, "with the will. You sent me yourself."

"The will was sealed at the sixth hour of the morning. The banquet was the night before."

There was a silence. Somewhere in the house a door closed, and a woman laughed, and a dog barked in the street.

"I was at the Myrtle," Faustus said. "You sent me to find out about the girl, and I went, and I spoke to the steward in the kitchen, and I came away. That is all."

"You did not tell me."

"You did not ask." Faustus folded his hands. "Dominus, I have served this house for twenty years. I have kept your father's secrets and yours, and I have done things in your service that I would not have done for any other man, and I have never once asked you for anything. I am asking you now to trust me, and to let this matter be finished in the way that it must be finished, and to think of the consulship and of your son and of the name of the Claudii Corvi, which is a thing that will outlast all of us, and which is worth more than a girl and a woman and an old man in a brothel."

Corvus looked at him.

"Faustus," he said. "Look at me."

Faustus looked at him.

"Did you kill Vettius?"

"No, dominus."

"Did you have him killed?"

"No."

"Do you know who did?"

Faustus was silent for three heartbeats.

"I know," he said, "that a man came to me in the spring with a great deal of money and a story about a father who had ruined his son, and that I listened to the story and took the money and did not ask what it was for. I know that I am a fool, and that a fool is a man who takes money and does not ask what it is for, and that I have been a fool in your service and not against it." His voice was perfectly steady. "And I know that if this comes out, the name of the Claudii Corvi will be dragged through the courts by a freedman and a whore, and your consulship will be a joke, and your son will not marry, and your daughter will not marry, and your mother will die of it. So I have taken steps."

"What steps?"

"To keep it from coming out."

Corvus stood up. He was aware, distantly, that his hands were shaking, and he put them behind his back.

"Who was the man with the money?"

"Publius Vettius."

The lamp guttered. Corvus looked at the letter in his hand: three sentences, and the second sentence, and the trust of an emperor who was a thousand miles away and did not care.

"Get out," he said.

"Dominus—"

"Get out of my sight," Corvus said, "and do not speak to me until I send for you, and if you take one step in the direction of the Vicus Tuscus without my order I will have you crucified in the yard of this house, and I will do it myself, and I will tell my mother that you died of a fever." He heard his voice rising and could not stop it. "Do you understand me?"

Faustus bowed his head.

"Yes, dominus."

He went out.

Corvus sat alone in the tablinum for a long time after the door closed.

He thought about the fact that he had known Faustus for twenty years and had never once asked him where he slept.

He thought about the fact that a man may keep a household of thirty people and know the name of every one of them and know nothing at all about any of them, and that this was, in the whole of Roman life, considered a virtue.

Corvus stood alone in the tablinum for a long time. Then he sat down and put the letter on the table and looked at it, and thought about his father in the shrine with the stylus in his throat, and about the girl in the little room by the stairs who had looked up at him with a face like a woman doing sums, and about the fact that in seventeen years he had never once been able to decide whether he had saved her or bought her.

I am to be consul, he thought.

And then, because he was his father's son, he began to make a list.

CHAPTER NINE

Felix

The thing about following a man was that you had to look as though you were not following him, and the second thing about following a man was that you had to be able to stop.

Felix had learned both from a boy called Scrofa in the Subura when he was seven, in the year before his mother sold him, and he had learned them well, and he had never had a chance to use them until now.

He went out at the second hour in his oldest tunic, with no lamp, and a crust in his belt, and he went up the hill by the Clivus Victoriae, which was the long way round, because the Palatine had two gates and the one on the Vicus Tuscus had a doorkeeper who knew him.

The house of the Claudii Corvi stood on the upper slope in the shadow of the temple of Apollo, and it was not what Felix had expected. He had expected something like the houses in the Greek novels his mistress kept in the chest in the tablinum: a portico with a hundred columns, gold on the ceiling, a fountain with a statue in it. What he found was a wall, a plain door, a lamp, and above the wall the top of a fig tree and the corner of a roof with a cracked tile. There

was a smell of cooking and a sound of somebody sweeping. It was, in fact, very like the house he had grown up in, except that the sweep was a slave with good sandals.

He waited in the doorway of a fuller's shop across the street for an hour and a half, and at the fourth hour Faustus came out.

He was easy to follow. That was the first thing that surprised Felix: a man who was important in his own house walked as though the street belonged to him, and a man who walks as though the street belongs to him does not look behind him. Faustus went down the hill, and along the Sacred Way, and into the Forum, and Felix went after him at the distance Scrofa had taught him, which was the distance at which a man looks like a man and not like a person who is following you.

In the Forum Faustus stopped at the stall of a bookseller and bought nothing, and spoke to a man in a green tunic for a short time, and then went on. He crossed the square in front of the Basilica Julia, and went down toward the river, and along the wharf to the fourth shed.

Felix had never been inside the Emporium. He stood at the corner of the shed and watched Faustus go in through the small door at the side, and he waited, and after a while Faustus came out with a man Felix did not know, a big dark man with a broken nose, and they stood in the doorway and spoke for a while, and the big man shook his head twice, and Faustus gave him something small that glinted, and the big man took it and put it in his belt, and went back inside.

Then Faustus went up the hill again, to the Caelian, and stopped at a house on the slope above the Colosseum.

This one was what Felix had expected. It had a proper door with a bronze knocker in the shape of a lion, and a slave outside it with a stool, and there were cypresses in the garden behind the wall and a smell of lilies, and Faustus went in without knocking.

He was inside for a long time. Felix sat on the kerb across the street with his crust and ate it slowly, in the way of a boy who has learned to make a thing last, and watched the door, and thought about what he would tell the domina.

He would say: *He went to the Emporium and spoke to a big man with a broken nose, and the big man shook his head, and Faustus gave him money. Then he went to a house on the Caelian with a lion on the door and he is in there now.*

He would say it in order, and he would not embellish, because the domina had told him once that a boy who embellishes is a boy who cannot be trusted with anything, and he had never forgotten it, and he had never embellished since.

He was thinking about this when the door of the house on the Caelian opened and Faustus came out with another man.

This one was younger, thirty or so, narrow-faced, with a mouth that turned down at the corners, and he was angry. Felix could see it from across the street: the way he walked, the way he put his hand on Faustus's arm and then took it away, the way he stood with his weight on one foot and then the other. They spoke for a while. Then the narrow man went back inside and the door shut, and Faustus stood on the step for a moment with his hand over his mouth, and then he turned and came down the street, and Felix got up and followed him.

He followed him all the way back to the Palatine, and then he went home, and it was the fifth hour, and he was hungry, and he was very pleased with himself.

The domina listened to him in the counting room with the door shut.

He told it in order, and he did not embellish, and when he had finished she sat back and looked at him for a long time.

"The house with the lion," she said. "On the Caelian, above the Colosseum. Are you certain?"

"Yes, domina."

"Was there a name on the door?"

"There was a tablet, but it was painted over. There was a man selling water by the fountain and I asked him whose house it was, and he said it was the house of the Vettii, and that the old man had died in the city and been burned in the Campus, and that the son was selling the furniture." Felix hesitated. "He said the son had been in a good mood for a week, and then he had not been in a good mood, and now he was in a good mood again."

Antonia did not laugh.

"Anything else?"

"Faustus gave money to the big man at the Emporium. The big man shook his head first, and then took it. And when Faustus came out of the house with the lion, the man with the narrow face was angry, and he took Faustus by the arm, and then he let go, and they talked, and then he went inside and shut the door."

"You did well," Antonia said.

Felix glowed.

"You did very well," she said, "and you are not to do it again."

"But—"

"I mean it. You are not to go near that house, or the Emporium, or the Palatine, or the man Faustus, ever again. Tomorrow you will stay in the house and help Calybe, and if I hear that you have been in the street I will have Tiro beat you." She said it quietly, and she was not angry, which was worse than if she had been. "Do you understand?"

"Yes, domina."

"Say it."

"I am not to go near the house or the Emporium or the Palatine or the man Faustus ever again."

"Good." She put her hand on his head, which she did not often do, and looked at him for a moment, and then said, "Go and eat."

He went out into the courtyard and Meroe was there, and she saw his face and laughed and said, "What have you done?", and he said, "Nothing," and she said, "You look like a cat that has been in the cream," and he said, "I am not a cat," and she said, "No, you are a boy, which is worse," and gave him half a honey cake.

He ate it sitting on the wall by the kitchen door, and the sun was coming over the roof, and he thought about the bakery.

This was a thing he had never told anyone. He wanted to own a bakery. Not to work in one; to own one. He had worked out the whole of it, in the way a boy works out a thing in the dark: a shop in the Subura near the old wall, with a stone oven and a boy to work the dough and a girl to sell at the counter, and in the morning the smell of it coming out into the street so that people would come from three streets away, and there would be a bench outside, and he would sit on the bench in the afternoon with his hands clean.

The price of it was about nine thousand sesterces. He had eleven, in a crack in the wall behind his bed, and he added to it whenever he could, and he had calculated, more than once, that at the rate he was going he would have the money in about eleven thousand years.

The domina had said once, in the winter, when the house was closed and they were all sitting around the brazier, that a person could buy themselves out of anything in Rome if they were patient and saved and did not have bad luck.

He had thought about that for a long time. He had thought: *she did it.* And then he had thought: *but she is the domina, and I am a lamp boy, and the difference between us is the difference between a lamp and the sun.* And then he had thought: *she was a slave once. She said so. She said it in front of all of us.*

He had never asked her how.

He finished the honey cake and licked his fingers and went to help Calybe with the bread.

Two days later he went out again.

He would think about it afterward, in the way that a person thinks about the last hour of a life, but he did not think about it at the time; he simply did it, the way a boy does a thing, because he had been praised and because he was bored and because there was a thing in the world that was not right and he had seen it with his own eyes and he was twelve years old and believed that he was the only person in the house who was not afraid.

He went out at the ninth hour, when the kitchen was busy and nobody counted the boys. He went up the hill. He was not going to the house on the Palatine; he was going to the fountain at the corner of the Clivus, where the water sellers stood, because the man there had been friendly and had told him about the Vettii, and a boy who is bored will go and talk to a man who was friendly.

He never got there.

He was in the Via Tusculana, in the narrow part where the tall houses lean over the street and the sun does not come in until noon, when a man stepped out of a doorway in front of him and said, "Boy."

Felix stopped.

The man was not Faustus. He was bigger and older, with a broken nose and a good cloak, and Felix knew him at once, and the knowing of it went through him like cold water.

"You are the boy from the Myrtle," the man said. "The lamp boy."

"No," said Felix.

"Yes." The man took a step toward him. "You were at the Emporium. You were at the fountain on the Caelian, asking about the house with the lion. You have been a busy little boy."

Felix ran.

He was fast. He had always been fast; it was the one thing about him that everyone remarked on, and he had used it a hundred times to get out of a hundred thrashings, and he used it now. He went un-

der the man's arm and down the street, and he heard the man's feet behind him, and he turned left into the alley by the dyer's, and left again, and he knew this quarter the way he knew his own hands.

But the man knew it too, and the man had been a soldier, and a soldier does not chase a boy down the street he runs to; a soldier goes around.

Felix came out of the alley into a little yard behind the bakery, meaning to go over the wall, and the man was standing in the yard with his arms folded.

"There you are," he said.

Felix backed against the wall.

The man came toward him, and he was not hurrying, and that was the worst thing: he was not hurrying at all, and he was breathing easily, and he looked at Felix the way a man looks at a job.

"Listen," Felix said. "I won't say anything. I won't say anything to anyone, I swear it on the gods, I swear it on my mother—"

"Your mother sold you," said the man. "I asked."

He took Felix by the throat.

It was not a quick thing. That was what the women said afterward, in the house, when they talked about it in the way that people talk about a thing they cannot bear: that it was not quick. It went on for a while. Felix kicked and clawed and got a hand into the man's face and tore something, and the man held him against the wall with one hand and pressed with the other and did not say anything at all.

At the end, Felix was thinking about bread.

That was the thing that Antonia Cassia would carry for the rest of her life, though she never knew it: that in the last of it the boy was not thinking about the gods, or his mother, or the domina, or the honey cake. He was thinking about the smell of the bakery in the morning, and about a bench outside a shop in the Subura where a man with clean hands might sit in the afternoon.

The man let go and Felix slid down the wall.

The man looked at him for a moment. Then he took the boy's purse, which had eleven sesterces in it, and he took the lamp from his belt, because a boy who has been sent on an errand carries a lamp, and he put the lamp on the ground beside the body, and he straightened his cloak, and he went out of the yard.

It was the lamp that made the story.

That was what the vigiles said, and what the prefect's clerk wrote down, and what the whole quarter believed by the second day: that the boy had been out at night with a lamp, and that he had been set upon by thieves, and that the city was full of such boys and such thieves, and that it was a wonder it did not happen more often.

The lamp was still burning when they found him.

It was Antonia who found him.

She had come out at dawn because he had not been in his bed, and she had gone up the hill with Tiro and two of the bearers, and they had asked at the fountain and at the bakery and at the fuller's, and a woman in the Via Tusculana had said that she had heard a boy shouting in the night, and had thought nothing of it, because in that street a boy shouting in the night was not a thing to think about.

They found him in the yard behind the bakery at the second hour.

He was lying on his side with his knees drawn up, and his face was swollen and dark, and there was a mark on his throat the size of a hand.

Antonia knelt down in the dirt and turned him over.

She did not scream. She had not screamed when she was fourteen and they took her out of the house of her guardian; she had not screamed in the yard at Puteoli; she had not screamed in the shrine on the Palatine with her back open. Somewhere along the way she had lost the thing that screamed, and in its place there was a cold, clear, enormously quiet place in which she could see everything.

She saw that his sandal was broken. She saw that his purse was gone. She saw that the lamp had burned itself out in the dirt and that there was a ring of black around it. She saw that his hand was curled, and in the palm of it there was a scrap of dark cloth with a thread of gold in it, torn from a cloak.

She put the scrap of cloth into her sleeve.

It was a piece of dark blue wool, good wool, with a gold thread running through the edge, and it had been torn from a cloak by the grip of a dying boy's hand.

She held it in her sleeve against her wrist all the way down the hill, and it was still there in the afternoon, and it was still there at night when she lay down on the bed in the small room by the stairs with her boots on and did not sleep.

She had bought him for eight hundred sesterces.

She had fed him for five years and taught him to say the household prayer properly and cuffed him on the back of the head perhaps a thousand times, and he had been worth, in the ledger of the city, eight hundred sesterces, and in the ledger of her own house he had been worth more than the fountain and the couches and the silver and the house itself, and there was no column in any book in Rome in which that could be written down.

Then she gathered him up, and he was lighter than she expected, and she carried him out of the yard.

Tiro took him from her at the corner of the street. She let him. They walked back down the hill through the waking city with the boy in Tiro's arms and Antonia walking in front with her head up, and the people in the street stood aside for them, and a woman selling eggs began to cry, and a man with a cart took off his hat.

At the door of the house the women were waiting.

Antonia stood on the step and looked at them.

"Nobody is to go out," she said. "Nobody is to speak to anyone. Junilla, bar the door. Prisca, bring me water and a cloth and a needle, and then bring me the boy's chest."

"Domina—"

"He will be washed and dressed and laid in the atrium tonight, and tomorrow he will be burned, and I will pay for the tomb, and there will be a stone with his name on it." Her voice did not shake. "His name was Felix. He was twelve years old. He was born in the Subura and sold at seven and he was the best of us."

She went inside.

In the afternoon she sat alone in the small room by the stairs with the boy's chest open on the floor: a wooden comb, two knucklebones, a broken strap, a stone with a hole in it, and a crack in the plaster behind the bed where eleven sesterces had been hidden in a rag.

She sat with the coins in her hand for a long time.

She went to the vigiles' station on the Aventine in the afternoon, and then to the prefecture, and then back to the vigiles' station, and it took her the whole of the day.

The station was a low building with a yard and a shed and a wall with hooks on it, and a man at a table who was writing in a ledger and did not look up when she came in.

"Antonia Cassia," she said. "Of the Vicus Tuscus. A boy of my household was killed last night in the Via Tusculana, in the yard behind the bakery."

The man turned a page.

"Name?"

"Felix. He was twelve. He was a slave of my household."

"Was he your property?"

"He was."

"Then it is a property matter." The man dipped his pen. "A slave killed by persons unknown. There were four of them last month and we found two. If we find the man who did it, he will be charged with

damage to property, and you will be compensated at the value of the slave. What was he worth?"

Antonia stood in front of the table.

"Eight hundred sesterces," she said. "I bought him for eight hundred sesterces when he was seven."

"Then eight hundred sesterces, if we find him, and if he can pay, and if the court awards it." The man wrote something down. "There will be a fee for the inquiry. Two sesterces."

She paid it.

"His name was Felix," she said.

The man looked up.

"Domina," he said, "I have eleven hundred slaves in this district on my books and I write down four of them a week. I do not have the room to write their names." He went back to his ledger. "If you have a witness, bring him. If you have the body, it has been taken to the potters' field. If you want the man found, find him yourself and bring him to me with two men who will swear to it, and I will charge him."

She went to the prefecture.

She was kept waiting four hours in a corridor with a stone bench and a smell of wet wool, and at the end of it she saw a clerk, not the prefect, a young man with a clean face and a tablet, who listened to her for the length of time it takes to write a line and then said, "This is a matter for the vigiles."

"The vigiles have told me it is a matter of property."

"Then it is a matter of property."

"A boy was strangled in a yard. I have the cloth from the cloak of the man who did it, and I have the name of the man I believe ordered it, and I have a household of eleven people who will swear that men have been watching my house for a month."

The clerk looked at her.

"Domina," he said, "you are the owner of a house of ill repute on the Vicus Tuscus, and there is an inquiry before the prefect into the death of a consular in that house, and you are the principal person of interest in it. If you come to this office with a story about a dead slave and a scrap of cloth, the prefect will ask me why I did not have you removed." He put his tablet down. "I am not a fool. I know that a boy is dead and I know that it is a bad business. But I have three hundred cases on this table and four clerks, and the case with a consular in it is the one that will be read in the Senate, and the case with a slave boy in it is the one that will not." He looked at her, and for a moment he looked tired and about twenty-five. "Go home, domina. Bury the boy. Do not go to the prefect with this today, because today he will use it against you."

She went out into the Forum.

It was the ninth hour and the light was going and the shops were shutting, and the whole city was doing the thing it did every evening, which was to go home. She stood at the foot of the steps of the prefecture with the dust blowing around her ankles and the noise of it all, and she thought: *Eight hundred sesterces. That is what he was worth in the record. That is what will be written down.*

She had bought him for eight hundred sesterces when he was seven, and he had carried a lamp for five years, and he had wanted to own a bakery, and the city had put him in a ledger between a runaway mule and a stolen cloak.

Then she called Tiro and showed him the scrap of dark cloth with the gold thread.

"Faustus wears a cloak of this colour," she said. "I saw it at the basilica. It is a dark blue, with a gold thread in the edge, and it is the cloak of a man who serves a great house and wants the street to know it."

Tiro looked at the cloth. His face did not change, but his hand closed around it.

"Domina," he said. "There is a thing I have not told you."

He told her about the Subura, and the poison-seller, and the man with the mark on his wrist, and the alley by the Emporium, and the body in the water.

He did not tell her about the papyrus, or about Faustus on the stairs, or about the boy at Tibur. He did not know why. Perhaps because the telling of it would have made the rest of it real.

Antonia listened without moving.

"Then we know," she said, when he had finished. "We know who carried the poison and who paid for it and who brought it into my house. And we know that the man who paid is the son of the dead man, and the man who brought it is the steward of the man who is to judge me, and the only thing we have is a scrap of cloth and the word of a dead child."

"We have the cup."

"The cup has been handled by a hundred hands and washed by none, and a clever man will say that anything could have been in it." She stood. "We have nothing, Tiro. We are a woman and a freedman and a dead boy, and they are the Senate and the prefecture and the name of the Claudii Corvi, and in this city the strong do not need to be right."

"Then what do we do?"

Antonia looked at the small room: the bed where Leda had slept when she was fifteen, the chest, the plaster with the crack in it.

"We make them pay," she said. "Not with the law. The law is theirs. We make them pay with the only thing they value, which is what people believe." She turned. "Go to the house of Gaius Claudius Corvus. Not to the door. Find the boy who carries the water, as Felix did, and give him this."

She wrote on a tablet, quickly, and folded it.

"What does it say?"

"It says: *Your steward bought the poison and his man carried it, and the man is dead in the Tiber and my lamp boy is dead in the Via Tusculana, and I have the cloth from your steward's cloak and the word of the woman in the Subura who sold the hellebore and can name the mark on the wrist of the man who bought it. Come to me alone, tonight, or I will take it to the prefect in the morning and let the city decide what a Claudius is.*"

Tiro took the tablet.

"He will not come."

"He will come," Antonia said. "He is a man who has spent his life believing that the world can be arranged, and a man like that will always come to look at the thing that cannot be arranged."

She went out into the courtyard. The fountain was running. The bronze myrtle was dripping, and the sun was going down behind the roof, and somewhere in the house a woman was crying.

Antonia stood by the water and looked at nothing at all.

She had built this house out of nothing, with her own hands and her own wit, on the principle that everything could be counted and everything could be paid for. And now she found that there was a thing in the world that could not be counted, and that she had spent it, and that the price of a boy's life was eleven sesterces in a rag behind a bed. At the ninth hour she went up to Leda's room.

The girl was sitting on the bed with her knees drawn up and the shell in her hand, and she had not eaten since the morning, and her face in the lamplight was the face of somebody keeping very still so as not to break.

"You knew him," Leda said.

"Yes."

"Was he your son?"

Antonia sat down on the stool.

"No," she said. "He was a boy from the Subura whose mother sold him for forty sesterces, and he came to this house with the lamp

trade when he was seven, and I bought him because he was small and quick and because I was tired of carrying my own lamp." She looked at her hands. "That is the whole of it. There is nothing else. He was not my son. He was not anybody's. He was a boy who wanted to own a bakery and I did not know it until he was dead."

Leda looked at the shell.

"He used to make up the household prayer," she said. "He could not remember the words. He used to say: *little gods, don't let the roof fall on me.*"

"I know."

"I heard him say it a hundred times and I never corrected him." She closed her hand on the shell. "I could have told him the words. It would have taken a minute."

Antonia sat with her in the little room for a while, and neither of them said anything, and below them the house creaked and the fountain ran and the women moved about the kitchen, and outside the door the men of the cohort stood in the street with their sticks and waited for the morning.

CHAPTER TEN

Antonia

They laid him in the atrium with a coin on his eyes and a wreath of myrtle on his head, and the whole household came to sit with him, and the neighbours came in from the street, and by the ninth hour there were forty people in the house and the door had to be left open.

This was the custom and Antonia did it properly. The women washed him and dressed him in a clean tunic that Prisca cut down from one of Tiro's, and Meroe combed his hair with her own comb, and Calybe put a honey cake in his hand because he had liked them, and nobody said anything about the fact that a honey cake in the hand of a dead boy was a waste of honey. The lamps were set at his head and his feet. The flutes came at the tenth hour, two of them, played by a pair of brothers from the Subura who did it for four sesterces and did it well.

The neighbours stood in the doorway and looked and said the things that people say. They said that he was a good boy and that he had been quick, and that it was the city now, and that in their fathers' time a man could walk from the Esquiline to the river at midnight with a purse in his hand.

One of them, a woman of sixty who kept a bread shop two doors down, came in and took Antonia's hands and said, "Who washed him?"

"I did."

"Did you put a coin on his eyes?"

"Two."

"Then you did it right," the woman said, "and there is nothing else anybody can do, and do not let the priest tell you otherwise."

She went out, and Antonia stood by the fountain with her hands still warm from the woman's hands, and thought that it was the first kind thing anyone had said to her in a month. *He was a good boy. He was quick. I remember him running errands for the baker. It is the city. It is the city now. In my father's time you could walk from the Esquiline to the river at midnight with a purse in your hand.*

Antonia stood by the fountain and received them and said thank you, and her face was calm, and by the eleventh hour she had said *thank you* so many times that the words had stopped having any meaning at all.

At the eleventh hour Corvus came.

He came alone, on foot, with a dark cloak over his tunic and no lictor and no slave, and he stopped in the doorway of the atrium and looked at the boy on the couch, and then at her, and his face was the face of a man who has walked into a wall in the dark.

"I did not know," he said.

"He was twelve."

"I did not know that he was dead."

"No," Antonia said. "You knew only that he was alive and inconvenient."

She led him through the house to the counting room and shut the door, and they stood on either side of the table with the lamp between them, and the flutes went on in the atrium, thin and reedy, playing the old tune that is played at no other time.

"Tell me," she said.

He told her.

He told her about Faustus, and the money, and the man with the mark, and the confession in the tablinum, and the letter from Antioch, and the consulship.

He told it in order, like a man giving evidence, and when he had finished he put his hands flat on the table.

"That is all of it," he said.

"It is not all of it."

"It is all of it that I know."

"Then you know less than my steward." Antonia took the scrap of dark cloth out of her sleeve and put it on the table between them. "This was in the boy's hand. It is from a cloak of dark blue wool with a gold thread in the edge, and I have seen that cloak on the shoulders of your steward in the portico of Castor, and there are three men in Rome who can afford a cloak like that and two of them are in the provinces."

Corvus looked at the cloth.

"Where is the boy who did it?"

"Dead in the Tiber, two days ago. My steward killed him." She watched his face. "You are shocked. Do not be. Tiro has killed nine men in an arena for the entertainment of the people of Rome, and he killed this one in an alley in the dark because the man had a hand in the death of a child, and I did not ask him to and I will not punish him for it. If you want him, you may have him, and you may try him for the murder of a slave, and the city will laugh at you for a month."

"What do you want?"

"I want your steward in the prefect's cells by tomorrow night."

"Faustus has served my family for twenty years."

"Faustus bought the poison that killed a consular at my table and set a man to watch my door and had my lamp boy strangled in a yard. He has served your family for twenty years and in that time he has

learned exactly what your family requires of him, and what it requires is that nothing is ever said out loud." She leaned forward. "You did not order this. I know you did not order this, because if you had ordered it you would have done it cleanly and you would have done it yourself, and you would not have left a cloak and a token and a woman in the Subura who remembers a burn on a wrist. Your steward did this to protect your name, and he did it in the way that servants do things for masters who never ask them what they are doing."

Corvus was silent for a long moment.

"If I put Faustus in the cells," he said, "he will talk."

"Yes."

"He will say that he took money from Publius Vettius to arrange the death of a consular, and that he did it without my knowledge, and that he used a slave of my household to carry the cup. And the panel will ask why a steward of the Claudii Corvi took money from a man to kill his father, and he will say that he did it for me, because that is what he believes, and because in twenty years I have never once told him not to." He pressed his hands flat against the table. "And I will be tried in the Senate for complicity in the murder of a consular, and my consulship will be gone, and my son will not marry, and my daughter will not marry, and my mother will die of it, and the name of the Claudii Corvi will be a joke in the Forum for a hundred years."

"Yes," Antonia said. "I know."

"You are asking me to destroy my family."

"I am asking you to be destroyed," she said, "instead of me."

The flutes stopped. In the silence they could hear the murmur of the neighbours in the atrium and somebody crying, and beyond that the noise of the street.

"How much?" Corvus said.

"What?"

"How much. For the boy's family, for the house, for the women, for the loss of the season. Name a sum. I will pay it out of my own purse and it will not be a small one, and we will call it compensation and it will be paid quietly and no one will ever know."

"He had no family. His mother sold him at seven for forty sesterces and went to Puteoli with a soldier, and I asked, because I am the kind of woman who asks." Antonia stood up. "You cannot pay for this. That is the thing you have never understood and the thing your father never understood and the thing every man in the Senate has never understood, and it is why the city is the way it is. You think that everything can be arranged. You think that there is always a sum, and if the sum is large enough, the thing is finished. And it is not finished. It goes on. It goes on in the woman who sold her son and in the man who carried the cup and in the boy in the yard, and it goes on in me, and it will go on in you, and no sum will ever make it stop."

Corvus looked at her.

"You have changed," he said.

"I have not changed at all. I have simply run out of the patience I used to spend on men like you." She sat down again. "What would you have me do?" Corvus said.

She looked at him.

"Go and look at him," she said.

"What?"

"Go out into the atrium and look at the boy on the couch. Not at me. Not at the papers on the table. Go and stand over him for a minute and look at what was done, and then come back in here and tell me what you would have me do."

Corvus stood in the door of the counting room.

"I have seen dead men," he said.

"Not this one."

He went out.

The atrium was full of the low sound of people being quiet together. The flutes had stopped; the two brothers had put them down and were eating bread by the door. The neighbours stood along the wall. The lamps at the boy's head and feet made a small yellow room in the middle of the larger dark, and there was a smell of myrtle and wet wool and, underneath it, the smell that Antonia had learned to recognize in the Subura when she was a child and had never got out of her nose.

Corvus stood at the foot of the couch and looked.

Felix had been washed and dressed. Somebody had combed his hair with water so that it lay flat, which it never had in life. He had a coin on each eye and a wreath of myrtle on his head that was too big for him and kept slipping sideways, and in his hand, because Calybe was not there to stop them, the women had put a honey cake.

His throat was the colour of a plum, in the shape of a hand.

Corvus looked at it for a long time.

He had seen dead men. He had seen them in Germany in the winter of the second year, when a party of his had been caught in a wood; he had seen a man with his jaw shot away and a man who had frozen sitting up against a tree with his eyes open. He had stood in the Forum and heard the death sentences read out and had voted for them. He had been in the room when his father's body was laid out, and had looked at the hole in the throat and had thought about the shape of the pen.

This was different, and it took him a moment to understand why.

It was the honey cake.

Somebody had put a honey cake in the hand of a dead boy because he had liked them, and it was, in the whole of that house, the most expensive thing anyone had done that day. It had cost four sesterces. It was going to be burned with him. It had no purpose at all, and no one would ever know about it except the women who had

done it and the man who was standing over him now, and it had been done anyway, out of a habit of love that the city had no line for in any inventory.

Corvus put his hand over his mouth.

He had been beaten by his father twice in his life: once at nine, for laughing at a slave who was being flogged, and once at fourteen, for a reason he had never understood. He had been made to stand and watch the flogging at nine, because his father said that a boy who was going to be a senator should know what discipline was, and he had stood in the yard and watched a man's back open and had been sick afterward in the stable, and his father had never mentioned it again.

He had thought, for years, that the lesson of that afternoon had been about the slaves.

It had not been. The lesson had been about his father: that a man may do a thing in front of his son and go in to dinner afterward and talk about the corn supply, and that the son will learn the thing that was done and not the thing that was said, and that he will carry it into rooms for the rest of his life without knowing where he got it.

He went back into the counting room.

"Well?" Antonia said.

"I do not know what to say."

"No," she said. "You do not. That is the first honest thing you have said in this house." She was standing by the window with her arms folded. "Here is what will happen. You will not give me Faustus, because you cannot, and I will not go to the prefect with a scrap of cloth and the word of a dead woman in the Subura, because he will laugh at me and give it to Maro and Maro will hang me. So we will do it the other way."

"What other way?"

"I am going to give a dinner," Antonia said.

He stared at her.

"A dinner."

"On the Kalends. In this house. With the door open and the lamps lit and the couches out and the best wine, and I will invite every man who has ever eaten at my table. Nine of them will come. Perhaps eleven. Blandus will come because he owes me sixty thousand and I have given him the note, and Hostilius will come because he is afraid of his wife and a dinner is an excuse, and Sura's son will come because he owes me ninety thousand and hopes I will forget it, and there are four more who will come because they are curious, and one or two who will come because they are brave." She smiled. "And you will come."

"I will not."

"You will come," Antonia said, "because if you do not come, every man in that room will know that the consul-designate is afraid of a woman, and by the morning it will be in the Forum, and by the Ides it will be in Antioch. And because—" she paused. "Because you want to know what I will say."

Corvus looked at her for a long time. In the lamplight his face was tired and not young, and there was a greyness around his mouth that had not been there in the basilica.

"If I come," he said, "you will say nothing about the boy."

"I will say nothing about the boy."

"You will say nothing about Faustus."

"I will say nothing about Faustus."

"And in return?"

"In return," said Antonia, "you will do the one thing that a man in your position can do, which is to be seen to eat at my table on the Kalends, three days after my house was closed by the prefect, and to be seen to enjoy it. And the men who come will see you there, and they will think: the inquiry is not what it seems. And the prefect will hear that you were there, and he will think: the case is not what it seems. And the case will become a thing that nobody wants to touch,

and it will die of being avoided, which is how most cases die in this city."

"That is not justice."

"No," Antonia said. "It is better. Justice would require the death of a consul's son and the ruin of a great house and the confession of a steward, and none of those things will happen, and a boy would still be dead. What I am offering you is survival, for both of us, and a dinner."

Corvus stood up. He walked to the door and put his hand on it, and then he stopped.

"How did you do it?" he asked.

"How did I do what?"

"All of this." He turned. "You came out of my father's house with a purse and a lie and nothing else. You were twenty-three years old. You had no family, no patron, no name, and a trade that the law despises and the Senate pretends not to use. And now you have a house with a fountain and a cook worth more than my steward, and half the Senate owes you money, and you have just invited a consul-designate to dinner and he is going to come." His voice was not friendly. It was not anything. "How?"

Antonia looked at him.

"Every morning," she said, "I got up before it was light. And I counted what I had, and I wrote down what I owed, and I made one friend and did one favour and asked for one thing, and I did not drink, and I did not trust a man who smiled at me, and I did not spend money on anything that could not be sold, and I did not let anyone see me cry, and I did that every day for seventeen years." She stood. "You have had a house and a name and a father's clients and an emperor's favour and you have spent your whole life being careful not to lose any of it. I have spent mine building something out of nothing. Those are not the same work, and the fact that you cannot tell the difference is why you are going to lose."

He opened the door.

"On the Kalends," he said.

"On the Kalends."

He went out through the atrium past the boy on the couch, and the neighbours made way for him, and old Rufus, who had been a client of his father's, said, "Dominus," and Corvus did not hear him.

They burned Felix at dawn on the Esquiline, outside the wall, in the potters' field where the poor are burned, and Antonia paid for a place at the front and for a stone.

The stone was small and grey, with four lines cut into it:

FELIX SLAVE OF ANTONIA CASSIA TWELVE YEARS HE WAS QUICK

The stonecutter had asked her what she wanted it to say and she had thought for a long time and then said, *He was quick.* The man had looked at her and said, *Is that all?* and she had said, *It is more than most men have said of them.*

Tiro stood at the back with his hands folded. Calybe wept. Meroe wept and was angry about it. Leda did not weep at all, and stood with her hands at her sides and her face white, and afterward she went back to the house alone.

Antonia stayed until the fire had fallen in.

The potters' field was a flat, dusty place with a wall around it and a smell that got into your clothes. There were other fires going that morning: an old woman, a man with a crooked leg, a baby. The smoke went up in three or four columns, and the men who tended the fires went about their work with the calm of men who have seen everything, and a dog sat at a distance and watched.

Antonia stood in the smoke and made a list.

She made it in her head, the way she made every list: the names, the sums, the weaknesses. Blandus, who owed her sixty thousand and had promised to stand up. Hostilius, who was afraid of his wife and had a villa he could not afford. Sura's son, who was a fool and could

be led. The praetor in the Subura, whose name she did not write down. Vipsania Marcella, who had been her friend for eleven years and had not called in nine days. Eutychus, who wanted the house and the list. Corvus, who would come to dinner. Publius Vettius, who had paid for the poison and was now walking about the city in a clean toga, waiting to inherit.

And Faustus.

When the fire had burned down she went back to the house and sat in the atrium and had the door opened, and the neighbours came in again, and she received them.

The inventory came on the day after the funeral.

There were three of them: a clerk of the prefecture with a tablet and a boy to carry the ink, and a man from the office of the city's property who had the flat, patient face of a man who has spent thirty years putting a value on other people's things.

They came at the second hour and Antonia received them in the atrium and said, "You will not go into the women's rooms."

"The law requires—"

"You will not go into the women's rooms," Antonia said, "and if you do, I will go to the prefect's house tonight and stand in his atrium and tell his wife what your clerk said to my doorkeeper, and I will do it loudly, and I will be arrested, and it will be in the Forum by the morning, and the prefect will have you flogged for making his life difficult in the fourth week of an inquiry." She stepped aside. "The rest of the house is yours."

They went through the rest of the house.

It took four hours. Antonia followed them. That was the worst of it: that she followed them, room by room, and watched a man with a flat face write down her life in a list.

Dining room: three couches, citron wood, bronze feet, valued at nine thousand sesterces. One table, marble, four feet, with a lion's head. Eleven lamps, bronze, of which two are better than the others.

One silver service, sixteen pieces, valued at twenty-two thousand. Curtains, six, of Egyptian linen.

Courtyard: one fountain, marble and bronze, with a myrtle tree, valued at four thousand. One bench, stone. Four pots, terracotta.

Kitchen: one oven, brick. One set of copper pans, eleven pieces. One mortar, one sieve, one set of knives.

Strongbox: one, oak, iron-bound, containing—

Here the clerk stopped and looked at her.

"The box is to be sealed," he said. "The prefect's office will take an inventory of the contents in the presence of two witnesses."

"The contents are loan tablets and deeds."

"Then they will be listed." He wrote: *contents, to be inventoried.* "You may keep the box until the trial, on your recognizance, because the prefect has said so, and because you are not charged with theft." He turned the page. "The household."

Antonia said nothing.

"Eleven slaves," the clerk said. "Names?"

"Prisca, housekeeper. Calybe, cook, taken by the prefect's men and not returned. Meroe, dancer. Junilla, doorkeeper. Tiro, steward, freedman. Felix—" she stopped. "Felix, lamp boy, deceased."

"Value of the deceased?"

"Eight hundred sesterces."

The clerk wrote it down.

"Continue."

"Two kitchen girls, one washerwoman, one girl who carries the water, one boy who carries the water." She gave the names. "They are not for sale."

"Everything in this house is under the recognizance of the court until the trial," the clerk said, and wrote: *eleven slaves, to be valued at the conclusion of the inquiry.* He looked up. "Domina. The prefect has instructed me to say a thing to you, and I will say it now and then we will finish, and you will not answer me, because I am a clerk and it

is not my business." He lowered his voice. "He says that a woman who keeps a house like this one should have had a friend in the Senate by now. He says that in nineteen years he has never seen a case in which a person of means had no one to speak for them, and that it is the strangest thing about the whole affair, and that it will be the thing that finishes you."

Antonia looked at him.

"Tell the prefect," she said, "that I have had a great many friends in the Senate, and that they were friends of the house and not of the woman, and that I have discovered this year that there is a difference, and that I am paying for it."

The clerk wrote something down that was not part of the inventory, and closed his tablet, and they went.

She walked through the house after they had gone.

The dining room with the garden painted on the walls and the birds among the leaves. The fountain with the bronze myrtle dripping into the basin. The little room by the stairs where a girl had slept for six years. The counting room with the tablets in their racks. The kitchen, where Calybe's rolling pin was still on the shelf.

She had built it out of nothing in seventeen years, and a man with a flat face had written it down in four hours, and the total had come to fifty-one thousand sesterces, which was less than she was owed and less than she had paid for it and nothing at all like what it was.

The women came to her that evening in the atrium, one by one and then all together, and asked whether they should go.

Meroe said it first, because Meroe was the bravest of them and had the least to lose, having a contract she could not read and four years of a plan. "Domina. If the house closes, we cannot stay in it. There is no money coming in and there is the rent on the shops and the wine merchant and the loan. If we stay, we eat the winter stores

and then we have nothing, and in the spring we open with no stock and no money and a debt to a man who owns the ground under us."

"You have been talking to Zosimus."

"I have been talking to Prisca, and Prisca has been talking to Zosimus, and between the three of us we can do sums." Meroe folded her arms. "We are not leaving because we are frightened. We are asking whether we should leave so that the house can be shut properly and opened in the spring with something in the chest."

Antonia looked at them: Meroe, Prisca, Junilla, the two girls, the washerwoman, the girl who carried the water. Seven. Calybe in a cell. Tiro in the kitchen with the accounts. Felix on the Esquiline.

"No," she said.

"Domina—"

"No one leaves, and no one is sold, and the house does not close." She stood up. "I have been poor and I have been careful and I have been sensible, and every sensible thing I have ever done has been a way of being afraid in an orderly manner. This is not a year for sensible." She looked at them. "On the Kalends I am giving a dinner. The best dinner this house has ever given. The Falernian, and the turbot, and the lamps along the whole front, and every man who has ever eaten at my table is going to be invited, and some of them are going to come, and when they come they will be seen coming, and the whole city will see that Antonia Cassia is not hiding."

There was a silence.

"That is either very brave or very stupid," said Prisca.

"Yes," Antonia said. "We will find out on the Kalends."

That night she wrote the invitations herself.

She had a good hand. She had been taught it at seventeen by a young man in a house on the Palatine who had sat with her in a little room by the stairs and guided her fingers through the alphabet, and she had kept the hand he taught her, and it was the only thing of his that she had ever allowed herself to use.

She wrote eleven.

To Decimus Terentius Blandus, senator, at his house on the Caelian: *Antonia Cassia greets her friend. On the Kalends of July there will be dinner at the Myrtle, at the tenth hour, and the door will be open, and there will be the Falernian you liked and the cook has been told to make the turbot. Come, and bring no one.*

To Hostilius Rufus, knight: the same, with the addition of a private word about the loan, which he would understand.

To the son of Sura.

To the praetor.

To Vipsania Marcella, whose husband was a consular and who had not called in nine days: the same, and at the bottom, in a smaller hand, *I know why you have not come. Come anyway. I have never asked you for anything.*

To Eutychus: the same, and at the bottom, *Bring the figs.*

To Gaius Claudius Corvus, consul-designate: the same, and at the bottom, *The fourth couch, on the left, where you sat when you were twenty-four. The cushion has been kept.*

And then she sat with the stylus in her hand for a long time, and the lamp burned down, and outside the city went on with its noise, and she thought about the fact that she had lied to Corvus twice in one night and had done it without any difficulty at all, and that the lies had been the truest thing she had said.

She had told him she would say nothing about the boy, and she would say nothing about the boy.

She had told him she would say nothing about Faustus.

That one she had not meant at all.

PART THREE

THE ELEVEN

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Leda

The day before the litter came, she went to the prefecture to give her statement, and they took her down into the cells to show her what would happen to her if she did not.

She did not know that was why they were doing it. Tiro knew, and Tiro said nothing, because a freedman who tells a girl that she is being frightened on purpose is a man who has just made her more frightened. He walked beside her with his hand under her elbow and his scarred face perfectly still, and they went down the steps from the portico into the lower part of the building, and the air changed.

It was not the dark that did it. There was light: a lamp at the end of the corridor and a grille high in the wall. It was the smell. It was wet stone and old urine and something else, sweet and thick, that she did not recognize and then did.

There were eleven cells along the corridor. Some of them had men in them and some did not. The man in the third cell was singing, very quietly, a song about a girl at a well, and he stopped when he heard them and said, "Domina? Domina, is that you?" and Tiro said, "No," and the man said, "All right," and began to sing again.

A door at the end of the corridor was open.

Inside, a man was being questioned.

She did not see him. There was a screen of boards between the doorway and the room, and the clerk stood in front of it, and she saw the clerk, and she saw the lamp on the wall, and she heard. That was all. She heard the man's voice going up and then stopping, and the sound of a rope, and a man's voice, quiet and reasonable, asking a question. Then the other voice again, which was not words.

She stood in the corridor and looked at the floor.

"Miss," the clerk said. "This way. The prefect's clerk is in the room at the top of the stairs."

Leda did not move.

"Miss."

"What is he being asked?" she said.

"That is not your business."

"What is he being asked?"

The clerk looked at her, and then at Tiro, and then he said, in the voice of a man who has been in that building a long time and has decided that the truth costs nothing, "He is being asked whether he stole a jar of oil. It is worth nine sesterces. He will say that he did before the fourth hour, because everybody does, and then he will be sold to the mines for nine sesterces, and in a month he will be dead, and nobody will remember that he was asked anything."

Leda went up the stairs.

She gave her statement in a small room at the front of the building, with a table and two stools and a window that looked out at a wall, and the prefect's clerk was a different man from the one in the cells: younger, with a good haircut and an ink stain on his thumb, and he had a stool for her and a cup of water and did not look at her the way the other one had.

"Your name."

"Leda. I have no other name that I can prove."

"You are the singer of the house on the Vicus Tuscus."

"I am."

"You were in the passage behind the dining room at the second course of the banquet at which Gaius Vettius Proculus died."

"I was."

"Tell me what you saw."

She told him. He wrote it down in a neat hand, and when she had finished he read it back to her, and she said yes, and he said, "You understand that if you say something different in the basilica, this paper will be read out and the prefect will be entitled to ask why," and she said, "I understand."

He put the pen down.

"Miss," he said. "I am going to say something that is not part of my duty. The man who examined the cook is not in this building today; he has gone to Ostia on another matter. If you are asked to go down to the cells again, do not go. If a man in a uniform comes to your house and says the prefect wants you, ask for the paper. If there is no paper, do not go."

Leda looked at him.

"Why are you telling me this?"

The clerk looked at the door.

"Because I have a sister," he said, "and because I have been in this office six years, and I have written down about four hundred statements, and I have learned to tell the difference between a witness and a person who is going to be made into a witness." He stood up. "That is all. You may go."

She stood up.

"Thank you," she said.

The clerk did not answer, and he did not look up, and he was already writing something else.

On the way out she was sick in the street. She was sick in the alley behind the prefecture, in the shadow of the wall, with her hand

against the stone, and the world went white and then came back, and she could hear a woman selling something two streets away and a dog and a cart, all of it going on exactly as it had before, which was somehow the worst part.

Tiro stood beside her with his hand on her shoulder until it was over, and then he gave her a cloth, and said, "That is the appropriate response. I have been in that building four times and I have been sick three."

"What happens to the fourth?"

"The fourth time I was too frightened to be sick."

She wiped her mouth.

"How does anyone bear it?" she said. "How does anyone live in a city where that is in a building at the foot of the hill, and men go past it in the morning on their way to the market, and the prefect has his dinner at the ninth hour?"

Tiro looked at her.

"Most people do not go down the steps," he said. "And the ones who do, do not go twice."

That was the day before the litter came.

The litter came for her at the second hour, with two bearers and a slave woman, and it was a good litter, cedar and leather, with a curtain that could be drawn.

"They are not to come in," said Antonia, at the door. "You will go out to them. You will not bring anything with you but your shawl and the document."

"The document."

"The purchase document. I have told you what it says. You are to have it in your hand when you arrive, and you are to give it to him if he asks for it, and you are not to let go of it until he does." Antonia put a fold of papyrus into her hand. "And you are to remember that you are not a slave going to a master. You are a witness going to a

panel, and the man you are going to see needs you, and a person who is needed may ask for things."

"What shall I ask for?"

"That is for you to decide," Antonia said. "You are twenty-one years old and you have been told what to do by other people since you were eleven. Today you will decide something yourself, and whatever you decide, I will stand by it."

Leda looked at her.

"Why are you being kind to me?" she said. "You have never been kind to me before. You have been just, which is different, and you have been careful with me the way you are careful with a good cup, and now you are kind, and it frightens me."

Antonia was silent for a moment.

"Because I have been sitting in a room with a dead boy," she said, "and it has occurred to me that I have spent seventeen years being careful with people, and that the people I was careful with are dead, and the people I was not careful with are also dead, and that the difference between them is not as large as I thought." She opened the door. "Go. And Leda—if they offer you a bath, take it. If they offer you wine, do not drink it. If they leave you alone in a room, count the doors."

The Claudii Corvi received her in the atrium, which was not what she had expected.

She had expected something like the house in the Greek novel: gold, purple, a hundred columns. What she found was an old Roman house with a black-and-white floor and a roof that had been mended in three places and a smell of wax and old wood, and a small shrine in the corner with the painted figures of the household gods, and a folded wool mantle on a bench where someone had been spinning and had put it down.

There were four people waiting for her.

The old woman sat in a chair by the shrine with her hands in her lap. She was small and straight in a dark stola, with white hair in a knot and a face like a closed door, and she looked at Leda for the length of a breath and then looked away, as though she had seen enough.

The girl was fifteen or so, and she was standing by the impluvium with her hands behind her back, and she was staring at Leda with open, unashamed curiosity.

The steward stood at the back with his hands folded. He was thin and neat and pale, and Leda knew him at once; she had seen him in the kitchen of the Myrtle four times, and she had been told that he was a banker.

And Corvus stood in the middle of the floor.

He was taller than his son, and greyer, and he had the same mouth. He was dressed plainly, in a white tunic with a narrow stripe, and he did not smile.

"Leda," he said. "You are welcome in this house."

"Thank you, dominus."

"You are not to call me that. Until the panel has determined your status, you will call me nothing at all, and I will call you by your name, and we will speak as two people in a room." He held out his hand. "May I see the document?"

She gave it to him.

He read it, standing, with the light from the impluvium on the papyrus.

"Massilia," he said. "Nymphodorus of Puteoli, dealer, to Antonia Cassia, for eleven thousand sesterces, warranted sound, no defects of body or character, origin Massilia, no known kin." He looked up. "You were not from Massilia."

"No."

"Where are you from?"

"Surrentum."

"Say the rest."

"My father's name was Vibius Rufus. He sold wine. Our yard was by the gate, with a wall and a vine over it, and there were amphorae in rows, and my mother's name is Vibia Prima, and my brother is called Gaius and he has a mark on his chin." Her voice was steady. "I was taken from the beach when I was eleven, by men in a boat who spoke Greek, and my brother ran, and I did not run, because I was eleven and a stranger had asked me a question."

The old woman by the shrine made a small sound.

Corvus folded the document.

"Thank you," he said. "That is what I needed to hear, and it is what you will say to the panel tomorrow, in those words, and they will believe you, because it is true and because truth has a sound that a lie does not." He handed the document back. "Now come with me."

He took her into a small room off the atrium, with a table and two chairs and a window that looked onto the garden. There was a bust of a man with a chipped ear on a shelf, and a set of wax tablets, and a box with a bronze lock.

"Sit down."

She sat.

"You saw a man in the passage on the night of the banquet," Corvus said.

"Yes."

"Tell me."

She told him. The dark tunic, the narrow stripe, the short hair, the shoulder turned away, the cup. She told it the way she had told Antonia and the prefect's clerk, in the same words, because she had decided in the litter that she would tell it always in the same words and never add anything to it, so that no one could catch her in a difference.

Corvus listened with his eyes shut.

When she had finished he was quiet for a moment.

"Now I will tell you what will happen," he said. "Tomorrow you will be brought before the panel. The prefect will ask you what you saw. You will tell him, as you have told me. And then Maro will ask you to describe the man's face, and you will say that you did not see it, and he will ask how it is that a girl who can describe the cut of a man's hair and the stripe on his tunic cannot describe his face, and you will say that the lamps were low and that he turned away."

"That is the truth."

"It is the truth, and it will not be enough. Maro will say that you are protecting the house, or that you have been instructed, and he will ask the prefect to have you examined under torture, because the law says that a slave's evidence is worth nothing until it is taken that way, and the prefect will agree, because he is a cautious man and because there is a consular dead and because a girl is a cheap thing to spend." He opened his eyes. "Unless you are free-born. If you are free-born, you cannot be examined except in the case of treason, and the whole thing changes."

"Then say that I am free-born."

"I intend to. But it is not enough for me to say it. I must prove it, and the proof is your mother's petition and the dealer's record and your own face and your own memory, and even then there will be a man on the panel who will say that the dealer's record is a forgery and that the girl has been coached." He leaned back. "So we will make it easy for him. You will say that you did not see the man's face, and that you cannot swear to the colour of the stripe, and that you were frightened and that the lamps were low, and that you have thought about it every night since and that you are no longer sure of anything except that there was a man and a cup."

Leda looked at him.

"You want me to say that I am not sure."

"I want you to say what a frightened girl would say."

"I am a frightened girl."

"Then say what you would say if you were frightened and alone and had no one to tell you what to say." His voice was quiet and patient. "Do you understand what I am offering you? If you do this, the panel will find that the evidence is insufficient, and the death will be recorded as a seizure, and you will be given to your mother, and you will go to Surrentum, and in a year you will be married to a man of your own class, and this will be a thing that happened to you once, in Rome, when you were young."

"And the man who carried the cup?"

"Will be dealt with."

"By whom?"

"By me."

Leda sat very still.

"You know who he is," she said.

"I know who paid him."

"And you will deal with him."

"I will deal with him," Corvus said, "in the way that such things are dealt with, which is quietly and completely and without a trial, because a trial would destroy the Senate and the city and my family, and because the man is the son of a consular and the courts of Rome do not convict the sons of consulars of anything." He said it without shame. "You are looking at me as though I were a monster. I am not. I am a man who has been given a great deal of power and a very small number of tools, and I am telling you what the tools can do."

"My lady's house is closed," Leda said. "Her door is shut and her women are frightened and her boy is dead on the Esquiline. If I say that I am not sure, then the panel will say that there was no man in the passage, and the prefect will say that the poison came from her kitchen, and the whole thing will be finished by the Kalends and it will be finished on her."

"Yes."

"And you will be consul."

"I will be consul," Corvus said, "and the city will be quiet, and the emperor will be pleased, and in ten years no one will remember any of it."

Leda stood up.

"I will not do it," she said.

Corvus did not move.

"Sit down."

"No."

"Sit down," he said, and something in his voice had changed, and she sat, because she was twenty-one and he was a consul-designate and because a room with a closed door is a room with a closed door.

"I am not asking you to lie," he said. "I am asking you to be uncertain, which you are, and to be frightened, which you are, and to let a panel of old men do what old men do, which is to find a way to be comfortable. That is not a betrayal of your lady. It is the only thing that will save her. If you go into that room and swear that you saw a man's face and name him, then Maro will say that you are a slave who has been coached, and he will put you on the hook, and you will say whatever he wants within an hour, and it will not be the truth, and the truth will be lost, and your lady will hang." He leaned forward. "Do you understand? The truth is not a sword. It is a heavy thing that you can only carry if you are strong enough, and you are not strong enough, and neither am I."

Leda looked at the floor.

"There is one more thing," Corvus said. "Your mother is alive, and she is poor, and she has spent ten years petitioning governors. If you go before that panel and make a spectacle of yourself, she will be told about it, and she will be told by men who will make it sound as though her daughter had become a whore in Rome and had lied to protect her whoremistress. That is the story that will reach Surren-

tum. Not the truth. The story." He stood up. "Think about what you want your mother to hear."

He went out.

Leda sat in the chair for a long time with the document in her hand.

Then the door opened and the girl came in.

She was fifteen, and she came in the way that young things come into rooms when they have been told not to, quickly and quietly and with her chin up, and she shut the door behind her and stood with her back against it.

"I am Caesia," she said. "You are the singer."

"Yes."

"You are the one my brother is in love with."

Leda said nothing.

"He does not say so. He does not say anything. He has been like a man with a stone in his shoe since he came back from Dacia." Caesia sat down in the other chair and folded her hands in her lap exactly as her grandmother had. "He is going to be married to a girl called Vinicia Sabina in the autumn, and he does not want to, and my grandmother says that what he wants does not matter, and my father says that in ten years he will be grateful. Will he?"

"I don't know."

"I think he will not," Caesia said. "I think he will be a consul and have a house full of statues and be very correct and very cold, and once a year he will drink too much at the Saturnalia and say something terrible to his wife." She looked at Leda. "Is it true that you were stolen?"

"Yes."

"From a beach?"

"Yes."

"With your brother on the beach?"

"Yes."

Caesia was quiet for a moment. Then she said, "I am sorry."

"Thank you."

"I do not mean it the way people mean it. I mean—" She stopped, and started again. "I have been in this house all my life and I have been told that we are the Claudii Corvi and that we are better than other people because we are older and because my great-great-grandfather was consul and because we do not make money in trade. And I have begun to think, this year, that it is all a story that we tell, and that the only reason it works is that nobody has ever made us stop telling it." She looked at Leda. "You are the first person I have ever met who did not believe it."

"I am not brave," Leda said. "I am frightened of your father and of the prefect and of the hook and of the dark. I have been frightened since I was eleven."

"Yes," said Caesia. "That is what I mean."

The door opened. The old woman stood in it, with the steward behind her.

"Caesia," she said. "Go to your room."

"Grandmother—"

"Go to your room, and do not speak to me of this, and do not speak to your brother of it either." The old woman's eyes came to Leda. They were pale and cold and entirely without malice, which was worse. "You will wait in the atrium. The litter will take you back."

Leda stood up.

"Domina," she said. "May I ask you something?"

"You may ask."

"Did you know? About me. Before all this."

Claudia Junia looked at her for a long moment.

"I knew that there was a girl in a house on the Vicus Tuscus," she said, "and that my son had been seen going into it, and that the woman who owned it had been in this house when she was a girl, and that

nothing good would come of any of it. I did not know your name or your story, and I would not have asked." She stepped aside. "That is the truth, and you may make of it what you like. It is more than most people in this city will give you."

Leda went out through the atrium, past the shrine with its painted gods and the folded wool on the bench, and she was halfway across the black-and-white floor when she saw Marcus on the stairs.

He was in a tunic and no shoes, and he had come down four steps and stopped, and there was a slave behind him with his hand out, and it was clear that he had been told not to come down and had come down anyway.

"Leda."

"Dominus."

"Do not—" He came down two more steps. "Do not call me that."

"The old woman is behind me," Leda said, "and there is a man at the door, and if you come down those stairs they will take you back up them and there will be a scene, and I have had a great many scenes this year and I would like to get into a litter and go." She said it quietly and clearly, and she did not move toward him. "I am well. They have been decent to me. I am to go to Surrentum the day after tomorrow."

"Surrentum."

"My mother's town."

Marcus stood on the stairs with his hand on the rail.

"I have a horse," he said. "There is a boat at Ostia. I have it arranged; I have had it arranged for a month—"

"I know."

"Then why did you not come?"

"Because I am tired," Leda said. "Because I have been running since I was eleven years old and I have found that I do not want to run any more; I want to arrive. Because if I go with you I will spend

the rest of my life being a woman who ran away with a senator's son, and if I go to Surrentum I will be a woman with a name." She looked at him. "And because your father would find us, and he would not kill me and he would not kill you, he would simply arrange things, and I have seen what happens to people when he arranges things."

Marcus came down the last step.

"Look at me," he said.

She looked at him.

He was twenty years old and he had a bruise on his cheek from a man in the street and his eyes were red, and he looked like a boy who has been told that the world is not what he thought.

"I love you," he said. "I have never said that to anyone. I am saying it now in my grandmother's atrium with a slave behind me and I do not care who hears it."

"I know," said Leda.

"Do you love me?"

"Yes." She said it without hesitating, which was the cruellest thing she did that day. "But I am not going to let it decide my life. I have had too many things decided for me by other people to give the last one away to a feeling."

The old woman's voice came from the door of the atrium.

"Marcus. Go upstairs."

He did not move.

"Go upstairs," Claudia Junia said, "or I will have Polio carry you."

Marcus looked at Leda.

"Surrentum," he said. "In the spring. I will come."

"Go upstairs," Leda said.

He went.

She watched him go up the stairs, and the slave went after him, and the old woman stood in the doorway with her hands folded and her face like a shut door.

"You are a sensible girl," Claudia Junia said.

"No," said Leda. "I am a girl who has been sold twice, and I have learned that a sensible girl is one who does what other people want and calls it her own idea." She picked up her shawl. "Your grandson will hate you for the rest of his life. I thought you should know that. He will be polite to you and he will come at the Saturnalia and he will hate you, and when you are dying he will sit by your bed and be correct, and he will not tell you anything true, and you will have nobody to blame but yourself."

She went out into the street where the litter was waiting, and she did not cry until the curtain was drawn.

She went back to the Myrtle and found Antonia in the courtyard with her sleeves rolled up, washing the fountain herself with a cloth and a bucket of water, which was a thing she did when she was thinking and could not sit still.

"Well?" she said.

Leda told her.

When she had finished, Antonia sat back on her heels.

"He is cleverer than I thought," she said. "He has found the one thing that will work, which is not a threat and not a bribe but a story. He has given you a story in which you are a frightened girl who is doing the best she can, and in that story you are not a coward, and he is not a villain, and the whole thing is very sad and nobody is to blame." She wrung out the cloth. "And it is a lie, because the man who paid for the poison is walking about the city, and the man who carried it is in the Tiber, and the boy who saw them is on the Esquiline, and somebody must be to blame, and it will be me, because I am the only one who cannot afford to be forgiven."

"What shall I do?"

"You will do what you decide," Antonia said. "I told you that this morning and I meant it."

"And if I decide to say what he asks?"

"Then I will lose," said Antonia, "and I will not blame you, and I will not speak to you again, because a woman who loses everything in Rome loses her friends first and her house second and her life last, and I will not have the strength to be gracious about it." She stood up and emptied the bucket into the basin. "But I do not think you will."

"Why not?"

"Because you are angry," Antonia said, "and anger is the only thing in this city that a poor woman can spend without a banker."

That night Leda sent a message to Marcus by the boy from the baths, and the message said: *The Nones. Before dawn. The roof, not the gate.*

And then she lay on her bed with the shell in her hand She had been in the house on the Palatine for a day, and she had seen the shrine with the scratched gods, and the wool on the bench where the old woman had put it down, and the wax masks in their cupboards in the hall.

She had stood in a basilica and told six hundred men what a man did to her in a passage. She had walked down a corridor past a room where a man was being questioned. She had been given a cup of water by a clerk with an ink stain on his thumb.

And tomorrow she was going to a house on the Palatine where a man would ask her to say that she was not sure. and looked at the ceiling, and thought about Surrentum, and about a beach, and about a boy on the beach getting smaller.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Antonia

On the Kalends of July, at the tenth hour, Antonia Cassia opened the door of the Gilded Myrtle and stood in it while Rome decided whether to come in.

The street was full. That was the first surprise. She had expected a few litters and a few curious neighbours and a decent number of men who had come to see a woman destroyed. What she got was a crowd: the bearers and the linkboys and the boys who sell flowers and the women from the laundry next door and a knot of young men from the Subura who had come to look at the house they had heard about, and, at the front, in a line of litters that stretched thirty feet up the Vicus Tuscus, eleven men who had been invited and perhaps twenty who had not.

She had put lamps along the whole front of the house. She had paid a man to hang garlands over the door. She had had the step scrubbed and the street swept and the fountain filled with rose petals, and she stood in the doorway in a white stola with the two pearls and a wreath of myrtle in her hair, and she smiled at every single person in that street, and she was, she thought afterward, more frightened than she had been in seventeen years.

Blandus came first, as he always did, and he came on foot, and he stopped in front of her and took both her hands.

"I said I would come," he said.

"You said you would stand up."

"That too." He looked at her, and his eyes were tired and kind and slightly drunken. "I am here, and I am not running, and if that is all I am, it is more than most."

Behind him Hostilius, sweating, with a story about his wife; Sura's son, fat and vague, with a wreath already on his head; the praetor, whose name she had never written down, in a good cloak with a bad clasp; Fannius, young and beautiful and completely penniless and delighted to be there; the knight from Spain; two men from the grain trade; a poet who had written a poem about her house that she had paid him not to publish, and who now pretended not to have written it.

Vipsania Marcella did not come. She sent a slave with a note that said she was unwell. Antonia read it on the step, in front of everyone, and folded it, and put it in her sleeve, and said, "Tell your mistress I hope she is better by the Ides," in a voice that carried.

Eutychus came at the eleventh hour, in a hired chair, with a basket.

"Figs," he said, presenting them. "The second crop. Better than the first."

"You said the first was better because it was early."

"I said that a man of my age prefers the early thing." He looked at her with his head on one side. "You have a great many people in your street, domina. There are men on the roof of the fuller's shop."

"I paid them."

"You paid them?"

"Four sesterces each, and a cup of wine. A crowd is a thing that can be bought like anything else, and a woman who is being investigated by the prefect cannot afford to be seen to be alone." She took

his arm. "Come in. You are on the left couch, next to the praetor, and I want you to talk to him about the corn supply, because he is dull and it will make him feel important."

"You are using me."

"I am using everyone," Antonia said. "It is a dinner."

The dining room was full by the twelfth hour: nine men on three couches, and the lamps lit, and the garden painted on the walls, and the ceiling gilded and glowing, and the birds among the leaves. The food came in and kept coming: oysters, urchins, eggs in garum, a whole turbot on a board carried by two men, kid roasted with cumin, a boar's head, a dish of mushrooms stewed in wine, honey cakes, figs, almonds, and the Falernian, which she had bought at last, at the price of the Caecuban, from a fishmonger who now believed she knew something.

There was a moment, in the middle of the second course, when Antonia looked down the table and understood that it was going to work.

It was the noise. A room in which men are afraid is a quiet room. A room in which men are calculating is quiet too, and this room had been quiet for the first half hour, and then the wine had gone round, and Hostilius had told a joke about a Spanish governor, and Fannius had laughed too loudly, and the praetor had begun a long boring story, and the whole thing had turned, the way a room turns, into a dinner.

Blandus caught her eye and raised his cup, very slightly.

And then Corvus came.

He came late, which was deliberate, and he came alone, without a lictor or a slave, in a white toga with the narrow purple stripe, and the room did not go silent when he entered, because a room full of senators does not go silent for a man; it does something more complicated, which is to rearrange itself. Two men moved up on a couch. The praetor's story stopped in the middle of a sentence and then

started again in a lower voice. Eutychus put down his cup and folded his hands.

Antonia went to meet him at the door.

"Consul-designate," she said. "You are welcome in my house."

"Domina." He took her hand. His was cold and dry, and it did not linger. "The fourth couch, on the left."

"The cushion has been kept."

She had not kept the cushion. She had bought a new one, and had it stuffed with wool, and had chosen the colour to match the wall, and she had spent an hour that afternoon deciding whether to tell him that, and had decided against it, and now she was glad, because he looked at the couch for a moment and then at her, and something went across his face that she could not read.

He took his place. He ate. He drank, a little. He talked to Hostilius about a villa at Tibur and to the praetor about a road in Campania, and he was courteous and dull and entirely at his ease, and Antonia, watching him from her stool at the head of the middle couch, thought: *He is better at this than I am. He has been doing it since he was a boy and he does it the way other men breathe.*

At the third course she had Leda sing.

It was a risk. She had thought about it for three days, and she had decided to take it, because a dinner without music is a dinner with an edge to it, and because she wanted to see what Corvus would do.

Leda came in through the curtain with her lyre and stood in the pool of light by the fountain, and she was wearing green, and she did not look at anyone.

She sang the song about the ship.

Corvus did not move at all. He sat with his cup in his hand and his eyes on the middle distance, and when it was over he applauded with the others, three times, politely, and set his cup down, and Antonia saw that his hand was not quite steady.

"Do you like music, consul-designate?" she asked.

"I know nothing about it."

"That is not what I asked."

"I like it well enough," Corvus said, "when it is not being used on me."

There was a small, delighted silence on the couch. Fannius laughed and then stopped.

"Everything in this house is being used on you," Antonia said. "That is what a dinner is. The wine is being used on you, and the fish is being used on you, and the ceiling is being used on you, and the girl is being used on you, and you know it, and you came anyway." She raised her cup. "That is either courage or appetite, and I have never been able to tell the difference in a man."

"Usually it is both," said Eutychus, "and the appetite is larger."

The room laughed. Corvus laughed too, a beat late, and lifted his cup, and the thing was done: he had been in her house for an hour and had eaten her food and laughed at her jokes and there were eleven men who would swear to it.

That was when Publius Vettius came in.

He had not been invited. He came through the curtain from the atrium with two of his father's freedmen behind him and a wreath on his head that he had plainly put on in the street, and he stopped at the end of the room and looked along the couches, and the room went quiet in the way it had not gone quiet for Corvus.

"Domina," he said. "I heard there was a dinner."

"There is always a dinner," Antonia said. "There is a couch at the end, if you have come to eat. If you have come to make a scene, there is the street."

"I have come to see the famous house." He walked along behind the couches, and men moved their feet out of his way. "My father saw it. He saw it once, and it killed him. I thought I should see it too, before it is pulled down."

"It will not be pulled down."

"Everything is pulled down eventually." He stopped at the middle couch, behind Corvus, and looked down at him. "Corvus. You are a long way from the Palatine."

"I am dining with friends."

"Are you." Publius looked around the room with his chin up, and then he did a thing that Antonia had not expected: he laughed. It was a real laugh, ugly and short. "Eleven of you. Eleven senators and knights and men of affairs, eating turbot in a whore's dining room, and not one of you will look at me." He spread his hands. "Look at me. Go on. I am the son of the man who died in this room. I am the heir. You were all at the funeral and you all said what a loss it was and now you are eating his last dinner with the woman who killed him."

"She did not kill him," said Blandus.

"Did she not?" Publius turned. "You are a brave man, Blandus. I did not know that about you. I thought you were a man who owed money to everyone in this room and had never in his life said a thing that cost him anything."

"That is enough," Corvus said.

"It is not enough. It is nowhere near enough." Publius came around the couch and stood in front of Antonia, close, and the smell of him was wine and something sour. "I know what you are doing. You are putting on a dinner so that the city will say the prefect's inquiry is a joke. I know. I have done the same thing myself, at the house of a man I wanted to ruin; you invite him to dinner and you sit him next to a consul and by the morning he is your friend and no one can touch him." He leaned closer. "It will not work with me. I have nothing to lose. My father is dead and my name is a joke and my inheritance is a house full of furniture that nobody wants, and I have been sitting in it for a month listening to the walls. Do you know what that does to a man? It makes him free."

Antonia looked up at him.

"Sit down," she said, "and have some wine."

"I do not want your wine."

"Then sit down and have some water, and stop making a fool of yourself in front of men who will remember it." She said it quietly, and something in her voice made him stop. "You are the son of a consular. You have a name that three emperors respected, and you are standing in a dining room at midnight with a wreath on your head, shouting at a woman. This is not the son your father raised. Sit down."

Publius stared at her. His mouth worked.

Then he sat down, at the end of the third couch, and somebody gave him a cup, and he drank it, and the room began, slowly and with a great deal of noise, to talk again.

It was an hour before Antonia got him alone.

She found him in the little garden behind the kitchen, standing by the myrtle box with his cup in his hand and his wreath slipping down over one ear.

"You should go home," she said.

"I am not a child."

"No. You are a man of thirty who has done a wicked thing and is discovering that it does not make him feel any better, and who has been drinking for a month because he cannot sleep." She stood in front of him. "I know what you did."

He looked at her.

"You do not."

"I know you paid a steward of the house of Corvus to have your father's cup prepared. I know the man who carried it is dead in the Tiber. I know the man who bought the poison is sitting in that room with a cup in his hand, and that he is going to be consul in the spring." She watched his face come apart. "And I know that you are going to be tried for it, unless you do something."

"Tried?" He laughed, and it cracked in the middle. "By whom? By the prefect? The prefect is Corvus's friend. The Senate will not

try the son of a consular for the murder of his own father; it would be a scandal, and there is nothing in this city that men fear more than a scandal, and I have known that since I was a boy." He drank. "Nobody will try me. That is the worst of it. I did it, and nobody will try me, and I will live in that house with the furniture and the walls until I die."

"You will be tried," Antonia said, "if I am tried first."

He stopped with the cup halfway to his mouth.

"Think," she said. "The panel meets. The girl gives her evidence. Maro wants a conviction and does not much care whose, and the prefect wants the whole thing finished. If I am convicted of killing your father, the case is closed, and the man who did it is never looked for. That is what Corvus wants and it is what Maro wants and it is what you want, and it is what will happen, unless—"

"Unless what?"

"Unless I am acquitted," Antonia said. "And then the panel must look for someone else. And the first thing they will find is a steward who took money, and the second is the man who paid him."

Publius put the cup down on the rim of the myrtle box.

"You are threatening me."

"I am telling you arithmetic. You are a man who has spent a month in a house with the walls, and you have not thought it through, because men like you never think it through; you think only as far as the thing you want and then you stop, and the world goes on without you." She stepped closer. "Here is what I will do. I will not name you. Not at the panel, not in the street, not anywhere. You will keep your name and your house and your furniture and your life, and you will go home tonight and you will never come to this house again, and in the autumn you will go to your estate in Campania and stay there for a year, and when you come back the whole thing will be a bad memory that people do not mention."

"And if I do not?"

"Then I will name you," Antonia said, "in front of the prefect, with the steward's name and the poison-seller's name and the mark on the wrist of the dead man, and I will not be believed, and I will be convicted, and I will be dead within the year. But before I am dead I will have said your name in a room full of men, and there is no trial in the world that survives a thing being said out loud. You will not be convicted. You will simply be the man who was named. And you will live in that house with the walls, and every man who comes to dinner will look at you and think it, and your sons will hear it in the street."

Publius Vettius looked at her for a long moment.

Then he picked up his cup and drank the rest of it, and set it down, and took off his wreath and dropped it on the ground.

"I will go to Campania," he said.

"Go in the morning."

"I will go in the morning." He stopped at the garden door. "Domina. When you are dead—and you will be dead, whatever happens at the panel, because they have decided it—will you tell me one thing? Did you kill my father?"

"No."

He looked at her, and nodded slowly, and went out through the kitchen and into the street, and Antonia stood in the garden with her hand on the myrtle box for a long time.

She went to the Palatine at the second hour of the night.

She did not plan it. She had gone up to her room to take off the pearls and had found that she could not sit down; she had walked the length of the corridor three times and stood at the window and looked at the black ridge of the hill above the roofs, and then she had put on a dark mantle and taken a lamp and gone out by the kitchen door.

The streets were quiet. The dinner was still going on behind her; she could hear the noise of it three streets away. She went up the Clivus Victoriae with her hood up, and the lamp made a small yellow

circle around her feet, and she passed the temple of Apollo and the house of Augustus and the great blank wall of the imperial palace, and she came to the house with the plain door and the fig tree.

The door was open a hand's breadth.

She stood outside it for a long time. The lamp guttered in the wind and she sheltered it with her hand, and she thought about turning around, and she did not turn around, and then she pushed the door and went in.

The atrium was dark, and it smelled the same.

That was the thing that undid her. It had been seventeen years and the house had been sold and resold and let out to tenants and used for storage and, at some point, for something worse; the floor was cracked and the paint was gone from the walls and there was rubbish in the impluvium and a smell of cats. But the shape of it was the same, and the smell was the same, which was wax and old wood and the ghost of the incense that had been burned at the shrine every morning for four hundred years.

She went through the atrium to the little room behind it.

The shrine was still there. The niche was black with soot, and the painted figures of the gods had been scratched out by somebody's knife, and the altar was broken at one corner, and there was dust on everything, but it was there.

She stood in front of it with the lamp in her hand and looked at the place on the floor where she had knelt.

"Seventeen years," said Corvus, from the doorway, "and I still cannot come into this room without expecting to see it."

She did not turn around.

"How did you know I was here?"

"I followed you. You are not difficult to follow; you walk as though the street belongs to you." He came in and stood beside her, and the two lamps made the shadows move. "I have been coming here for seventeen years. Not often. Twice a year, perhaps. The ten-

ants think I am the owner, and I am, in a way; I bought the lease through a freedman three years after my father died, and I have kept it empty since." He looked around the room. "I do not know why."

"Yes, you do."

"Do not."

"You keep the house empty and you keep the stylus in a box and you tell yourself it is penance, and it is not penance, it is a museum. You have made a little museum of the worst night of your life and you come here twice a year and look at it and feel something, and you call that guilt, and it is not guilt. Guilt is when you do something about it." She turned to face him. "Guilt is what I have been doing for seventeen years, and I did not do anything about it either, so I am not better than you. But I have not kept a museum."

Corvus looked at the altar.

"What happened?" he said.

"You were there."

"I was there for the end of it. I want to know what happened before."

She was silent for a long time.

"I was twenty-three," she said. "I had been in this house since I was seventeen. You bought me at Puteoli for nine thousand sesterces, and you gave me to your father's household as a waiting woman, and you taught me to write, and you were kind to me for a year, and then you were not kind to me, and then you were nothing to me at all, because you had begun to be a man in the Forum and a man in the Forum cannot be seen to be kind to a slave." She held the lamp steady. "Your father took me when I was nineteen. He did not ask. He was the master of the house and I was a thing in it, and he took me in the little room by the stairs, and after that he took me when he wanted me, which was not often, because he was old and because he did not like me. He liked to hurt me. He had a strap with a name on it, and he would have the boy bring it, and he would do it himself, and he

would talk while he did it, about the family, and about the Republic, and about how the world was going to the dogs."

Corvus's face in the lamplight was grey.

"I did not know," he said.

"You knew. You were in the house. There is no house in Rome where a thing like that is a secret; the slaves know, and the cook knows, and the boy who carries the water knows, and the son of the house knows, and he knows it the way a man knows there is a leak in the roof, which is to say that he knows and he has decided not to go up and look." She turned back to the shrine. "On the last night he had me brought here. To the shrine. He said it was fitting, because I had been a bad servant and the gods should see. He had the strap, and he used it until my back was open, and then he had me on the floor in front of the altar. And there was a writing box on the altar, with his pens in it, because he had been writing letters in the afternoon."

"I remember."

"You came in. You stood in the doorway. You were twenty-four years old and you had a cup in your hand and you did not move." She heard her own voice, very flat, very quiet. "I looked at you. I want you to know that. I looked at you and I thought: he will stop it. He is the son of the house and he is a man now and he will stop it. And you stood there for three heartbeats and you did nothing at all, and then your father turned his head, and I reached up and took the stylus, and I put it in his throat."

The lamp guttered. Somewhere in the empty house a shutter moved in the wind.

"I have never been sorry," Antonia said. "That is the thing I have never said to anyone. I have been sorry for a great many things in my life, and I have been afraid, and I have been ashamed, and I have never once been sorry that he died with his own pen in his throat."

Corvus put his hand over his eyes.

"I was a coward," he said.

"Yes."

"I have told myself for seventeen years that I came in at the end, that it was already done, that there was nothing I could have done." He took his hand away. "I could have stopped it. I could have said one word. He would have beaten me and he would have done it anyway, but I could have said the word, and I did not say it, and I have been not saying it ever since."

"Yes."

"And then I sent you away."

"You sent me away with a purse and a letter and a lie, and you told me that if I ever spoke of it you would see me dead, and I believed you, because I was twenty-three and I had just killed a consul and I did not know which way was up." She set the lamp down on the broken altar. "And then I built a house, and I made myself rich, and I have spent seventeen years being afraid of you in the back of my mind, and the amusing thing is that I have been afraid of the wrong thing. I thought you would come and kill me. You never came. You were not afraid of me at all. You were afraid that I would look at you the way I looked at you in this room."

Corvus was quiet for a long time.

"What do you want?" he asked at last.

"I want to live," Antonia said, "and I want my house, and I want the women in it to be safe, and I want the man who killed my boy to be punished. I have wanted those things for a month and I have got nowhere, because I have been fighting the way a woman fights, with dinners and lists and favours. I am finished with that." She picked up the lamp. "I am going to tell the truth."

"At the panel?"

"At the panel. All of it. The girl, the cup, the steward, the poison, the money, your son's messenger, the boy in the yard. And when they ask me how I know what a steward of the Claudii Corvi was do-

ing, I will tell them that I know because I was in this house for six years, and they will ask why, and I will tell them that too."

Corvus's head came up.

"You cannot."

"I can."

"It was seventeen years ago. There is no proof. My father died of a fit, the physicians said so, the family said so, the Senate said so—"

"There is the stylus," Antonia said.

He stared at her.

"You have it in a box in your study under the letters from your brother. You have had it for seventeen years. You took it off the altar before the slaves came in and you wrapped it in a handkerchief and put it in your sleeve, and you have never been able to throw it away." She smiled at him, and there was nothing kind in it. "Bring it to the panel, Corvus. Bring it and hold it up and say: *this is the pen my father was writing with when he died, and the woman who put it in his throat is standing in front of you.* Do it, and I will hang, and the city will have its scandal, and your consulship will be gone by the evening. Or do not do it, and I will tell my story without it, and half the city will believe me and the other half will say I am a liar and a whore, and your name will be in every mouth in Rome for the rest of your life."

"You would destroy yourself to destroy me."

"I would destroy myself to be free of you," Antonia said. "You have been in my head for seventeen years. I have been careful because of you. I have been quiet because of you. I have never married and never had a child and never once in seventeen years said out loud what happened in this room, and it has been like carrying a stone in my chest, and I am forty years old and I am tired." She went to the door. "Keep your stylus. Keep your museum. I am going to go and live in the world."

She was in the atrium when he spoke.

"Antonia."

She stopped.

"I did not know about the boy," he said. "I want you to believe that. Whatever else I have done, I did not know about the boy."

She stood with her back to him for a moment.

"I believe you," she said.

And then she went out through the plain door into the street, and the lamp went with her, and behind her the house of the Claudii Corvi stood in the dark with its broken altar and its scratched-out gods.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Corvus

The panel met on the fourth day after the Kalends, in the same room with the cut-away frieze and the hunting mosaic, and the girl was brought in at the third hour.

Corvus came early, and Pedo was in the corridor outside the room with a cup of water and a tablet, and he looked at Corvus the way a man looks at a bill he did not expect.

"You are early."

"I am early."

"Maro is already inside and he has been inside for an hour, and he has been reading his notes." Pedo drank the water. "He has a theory."

"What theory?"

"That you are protecting your own household and that the girl has been coached." Pedo put the cup down on the ledge. "He is not entirely wrong."

Corvus looked at him.

"I have told you the truth about everything that matters," he said.

"You have told me the truth about everything except the one thing that would end your career, and I have not asked you about it,

and I am not going to ask you about it today." Pedo turned to go in. "But I will tell you this, Corvus, because I am sixty years old and I have nothing to lose and because you are going to be consul in the spring and you should hear it from somebody. There is a thing in your family that has been sitting in that house for seventeen years, and everybody in Rome knows that there is a thing, and nobody knows what it is, and when a thing like that comes out it does not come out neatly. It comes out in a basilica in front of six hundred people, and it takes a good man and a bad one and a girl and a cook and a boy with a lamp and it puts them all in the same room and makes them say what they know." He opened the door. "I have seen it three times in my career. It is always the same. And the man who thinks he has arranged it is always the one who is most surprised."

He went in.

The girl was brought in at the third hour.

Corvus had not slept. He had sat up in his study until the sky went grey with the stylus in his hand—not the stylus; a stylus, an ordinary one, with which he had written three letters and burned all of them. His eyes were sore and his mouth tasted of ash, and he had discovered at some point in the night that the worst thing a man can do is to sit alone in a room and remember his own face at twenty-four.

The girl came in with her hands folded.

She was dressed plainly, in a grey stola, with her hair bound up like a respectable woman, and she was frightened; he could see it in the way she held her shoulders. But she walked to the mark on the floor and stood on it and looked at the prefect, and when Pedo said, "Your name," she said, "I am called Leda. My mother's name is Vibia Prima, of Surrentum, and my father was Vibius Rufus, a wine merchant of that town, and I was taken from the beach there when I was eleven years old by men in a boat, and sold at Puteoli to the dealer Nymphodorus, and by him to Antonia Cassia six years ago."

The room was quiet.

Pedo looked at the papers in front of him. "You understand that if you are free-born, you are not subject to examination, and that if you are not, your evidence is worth nothing without it. You understand what that means."

"I have been told, dominus."

"Then tell us what you saw on the night of the banquet."

She told it.

She told it well. She told it in the same words she had used in his study, and she did not embellish, and when Maro interrupted her to ask how she could describe a man's hair and the stripe on his tunic and not his face, she said, "Because the lamps in that passage are low and because he turned his shoulder, and because I was not looking at his face; I was looking at the cup," and Maro wrote something down and did not ask again.

When she had finished, Pedo sat back.

"Thank you," he said. "You will withdraw."

"Dominus." She did not move. "May I say one thing more?"

Pedo glanced at Corvus, and then at Maro, and then nodded.

"The man who carried the cup was not of our house," Leda said. "I have thought about it every night for a month, and I have thought about the way he moved, and I am certain of it. He was not of our house, and he was not a stranger to great houses. He was a man who knew a passage he had never been in, which is a thing you can tell from the way a person walks. He went as though he had been told where to go." She paused. "And there was a mark on his wrist. On the inside, here. A burn, in the shape of an eight. I saw it when he lifted his hand to the curtain."

Corvus did not move. Maro's stylus went still. Pedo raised his head slowly.

"You did not say this before," Maro said.

"I did not remember it before."

"You remembered it now."

"I have been thinking about it for a month," Leda said, "as I said."

There was a silence in which Corvus could hear the clerk's pen behind him and the noise of a cart in the street and his own blood.

"Withdraw," Pedo said.

She went out.

Maro was on his feet before the curtain had fallen. "A mark on the wrist," he said. "A burn in the shape of an eight. That is a house mark, and there are perhaps forty households in Rome that use one, and I can have a list of them by tomorrow, and then I can have every slave in those households looked at by the end of the week."

"That is a great many slaves," said Pedo.

"It is a city of slaves."

"You will not," said Corvus.

Both of them turned.

Corvus heard his own voice with a kind of distant surprise. He had not decided to speak. He had stood up, and his hands were flat on the table, and he was speaking.

"You will not," he said again, "because a house mark is not evidence. It is a thing that every household in this city uses to keep its property from being stolen, and if you begin hauling slaves out of the houses of senators and knights and having them strip to the elbow in the street, you will have forty households at your door by the evening and half the Senate in the morning, and the prefect will be explaining to the emperor why the city was in an uproar for a burn on a wrist. And the man who carried the cup is dead. He was found in the Tiber nine days ago, and the prefect's office has the body, and it has no name and no mark that anyone thought to write down before it was buried."

Maro looked at him with an expression of profound and unpleasant interest.

"How do you know he is dead?"

"Because I made inquiries," Corvus said, "as any man on this panel would. The body was taken from the river at the fourth hour of the morning and buried in the potters' field with four others, and the clerk who took it down wrote *male, adult, no name* and nothing else." He turned to Pedo. "There is a girl's memory and a dead man and a stain in a cup. That is the whole of it. If we make a case of this, we will make it on the woman, because she is the only one whose name we have, and the city will be satisfied, and the Senate will be satisfied, and nobody will ever look for the man with the mark, because the case will be closed."

Pedo looked at him for a long moment.

"That is a remarkable speech," he said, "from a man whose steward has a house mark."

The room went very still.

"It is on the door of the house," Corvus said. "It is on the door of every house in Rome."

"Yes," said Pedo. "I know."

He stood up, heavily.

"We will adjourn until the Ides," he said. "On the Ides we will hear the case against Antonia Cassia, and we will hear it in the basilica, in public, because the city will have it no other way. And on the Ides, Corvus, you will not sit on this panel. You will sit in the body of the court with the rest of the Senate, and you will say nothing, and if I hear one word out of you that is not an answer to a direct question, I will have you removed by a lictor, consul-designate or no." He gathered his papers. "And Maro, you will find me the man with the mark. Not forty households. One man. You will do it quietly and you will do it in nine days, and if you cannot do it in nine days you will tell me so and we will go to the Ides with what we have."

Maro bowed his head.

"Yes, dominus."

They went out. Corvus stood alone in the room with the hunting mosaic and the cut-away frieze, and after a moment he found that he was shaking.

He did not go home.

He walked instead, for an hour, up the Clivus Victoriae and along the ridge of the hill and down again through the narrow streets behind the temple of Apollo, and the city went on around him in its ordinary way, and he found that he was looking at it as a man looks at a room he is about to leave.

There was a woman selling bread at a stall, and two boys playing at knucklebones in the gutter, and a man mending a shutter, and a dog asleep in the middle of the street with its legs in the air. There was a beggar at the corner of the Clivus who had been there for eleven years and whose name Corvus did not know, and he stopped and gave him a coin, and the beggar looked at the coin and then at him and said, "Are you all right, sir?"

"Yes," Corvus said.

"You do not look all right."

"I have had a difficult month."

"Ah," said the beggar. "Well. It passes."

Corvus stood in the street and looked at him.

"Does it?"

"Not the difficult month," the beggar said. "That stays. But the being a man in a good toga in the middle of the street looking at a beggar, that passes." He put the coin in his mouth and bit it and put it in his belt. "Go home, sir. Whatever it is, go home and eat something and sleep, and in the morning it will be the same but you will be stronger."

He went home.

He found Marcus in the stable yard.

His son was standing by the stall of his horse with a currycomb in his hand, and the horse was saddled.

"Where are you going?"

"To Ostia," Marcus said. "You sent me."

"That was a month ago. You went, and you came back in four days, and you have been in this city ever since, and I have known it, and I have said nothing." Corvus stood in the yard with his hands behind his back. "Put the comb down."

Marcus put the comb down.

"Faustus tells me that you have been buying things," Corvus said. "A cloak. Boots. Two knives. A purse of silver changed into gold at a moneylender in the Transitberina, which is a thing a man does when he does not want a transaction to be traced. And a passage on a boat at Ostia, in the name of a man called Verus, who does not exist."

Marcus said nothing.

"You are going to take her," Corvus said. "You are going to take the singer out of that house and put her on a boat, and you are going to go with her, and you are going to be a nobody in Massilia or Tarraco, and you think it is a story out of a poem and that it will end with the two of you on a beach."

"I think it will end with me being free," Marcus said.

"You will be a deserter from the legions, which is a thing that can be punished with death, and a fugitive from your own family, and a man with no money and a woman with no papers, in a town where you know nobody and where the first magistrate who asks who you are will be answered by a man who wants a reward." Corvus's voice was rising. "You will be back in this city within a year, and you will be back with a child, and then you will come to me, and I will have to decide whether to take you in, and I will take you in, because you are my son, and I will hate it, and I will hate you, and you will know it."

"Then do not take me in."

"Marcus."

"Do not take me in." Marcus's face was white. "You have spent your whole life arranging things. You arranged my education and my commission and my marriage and my sister's marriage and the roof of this house, and you have never once asked me what I wanted, and when I told you, you said that what I wanted would not matter in ten years." He took a step forward. "I have been in a country where men died in ditches for a pair of boots. I have seen a man's leg come off at the knee and heard him ask for his mother. I came back here and you told me that the seventh legion had been lucky in its officers, and then you asked me whether I had brought back any money."

"I did not know what to say to you."

"You could have said anything. You could have said: that must have been hard. I would have taken that. I would have taken a single word." Marcus's voice cracked. "I am not doing this because of a girl. I am doing it because I have spent twenty years in this house and I have never once been asked what I think about anything, and because the only person who has ever asked me a question and waited for the answer is a slave in a brothel, and because when I am with her I am not the son of Gaius Claudius Corvus, I am just a man, and I have found that I like him better."

Corvus struck him.

It was not a slap. It was a closed fist, and it caught Marcus on the cheekbone, and he went back against the stall and his head hit the wood, and the horse shied and stamped, and for a moment neither of them moved.

Corvus looked at his own hand.

"I am sorry," he said.

"No, you are not," Marcus said, and there was blood at the corner of his mouth. "You are embarrassed. That is a smaller thing."

The words went into him like a knife, because they were not his son's words. They were the words Antonia Cassia had said to him in the portico of Castor, and Marcus had never heard them, and could

not have heard them, and yet they came out of his mouth in the same cadence and with the same contempt, and Corvus understood, in that moment, that he had spent twenty years teaching his son everything he knew about how to be a man, and that the lesson had been learned exactly and applied to himself.

"Take the horse," he said.

Marcus stared at him.

"Take it and go," Corvus said. "Not to Ostia. Not with her. Go to my farm at Tibur and stay there until the Ides, and do not come to Rome, and do not write to her, and do not send a message by any boy or any slave or any man in this city. If you do that, I will not have you followed, and I will not tell your grandmother, and when this is over we will find a way to live."

"And after the Ides?"

"After the Ides," Corvus said, "I do not know."

Marcus looked at him for a long moment. Then he wiped the blood from his mouth with the back of his hand, and took the horse's bridle, and led it out of the stall, and Corvus stood in the yard and watched him go.

His daughter was in the garden.

Caesia was sitting on the rim of the fountain with a book in her lap and her feet in the water, and she did not get up when he came out, and he saw that she had been crying and had stopped.

"Where is your brother?"

"Gone to Tibur. He took the horse." She turned a page without looking at it. "He came to say goodbye to me first. He stood in the door of my room and he said: *if she is harmed, I will never forgive any of you, and if I am sent away, I will not come back.*" She looked up. "Is he right? Is she going to be harmed?"

"She is being taken to a house in the country for her own protection."

"That is what grandmother says. Grandmother says a great many things in the voice she uses for the accounts." Caesia put the book down. "Father. I am fifteen years old and I am to be married in the spring to a man I have met twice, and I have been told all my life that I am not to ask questions, and this year I have found that I cannot stop asking them." She swung her feet out of the water. "Where is she?"

"At Ficulea. In a villa with a maid and two men."

"Against her will?"

"She is a witness in a capital case and the prefect's office has an interest in her." Corvus heard his own voice and was disgusted by it. "That is the legal position."

"That is not what I asked."

He looked at his daughter.

There was a thing in her face that he recognized: it was the look of a person who has discovered that the people around her are not what she thought, and who is deciding, minute by minute, what she is going to do about it. He had seen it in his own mirror at nineteen, in the year he had learned what his father was, and he had done nothing about it for twenty-two years, and he found that he could not bear to watch his daughter begin the same long silence.

"No," he said. "Not against her will exactly. She is being kept there because if she is free to go she will go, and if she goes I lose the only witness who can say that a man came into that house with a cup, and the case becomes a case about a whore who poisoned a consul, and the city has its scandal and my family has its ruin."

Caesia stared at him.

"Thank you," she said.

"For what?"

"For telling me the truth. Nobody in this house has ever told me the truth." She stood up and put her sandals on. "I am going to say something now and you are going to be angry, and I do not care. I

have been in this house for fifteen years and I have watched grandmother run it, and I have watched you do what she says and call it duty, and I have watched my brother come back from the war and be asked whether he brought any money." She straightened her stola. "The girl is a free woman. The panel has said so. She has a mother in Surrentum who has been petitioning governors for ten years, and she is being kept in a villa in the country so that you can put her in front of a panel and make her say what you want. That is not the law. That is kidnapping, and it is being done with a seal and a clerk and a litter, which makes it worse."

"Caesia—"

"I am not finished. Marcus is the best man in this family and he is being sent to Syria because he fell in love with a singer, and I am to be married to a fish-sauce man's son because we need three hundred thousand sesterces, and you are going to be consul in the spring and the whole city will say what a fine upright man you are." She picked up her book. "I have decided that I am not going to be like grandmother. I am telling you now, so that you know. I am going to marry the fish-sauce man's son, because I have no money and no choice and I am not a fool, and then I am going to run my own house, and in my house nobody will be kept in a villa in the country and nobody will be told to stop asking questions."

She went into the house.

Corvus stood in the garden with the fountain running behind him.

She will be a better woman than any of us, he thought, and then, because he was his father's son and because he had spent forty-one years learning to put a thing down rather than examine it, he thought: *and she will be married in the spring, and by then this will be over, and she will never know how close she came to being right about everything.*

His mother was waiting in the atrium.

She was not spinning. She was standing by the impluvium with her hands folded, and she had the look of a woman who has been standing there for some time, and on the bench behind her there was a small wooden box that Corvus had not seen in twenty years.

"Your son is gone," she said.

"He has gone to Tibur."

"He has gone to the girl."

"No," said Corvus. "He has gone to Tibur. He gave me his word."

"His word." Claudia Junia's mouth turned. "You gave me your word, once, that there was nothing in this house that I needed to know. That was the night after your father died and I have kept it for seventeen years, and I have been a fool, but I have been a loyal fool, and I have kept this house standing while you have been in the Forum being upright." She put her hand on the box. "Do you know what is in this?"

Corvus did not answer.

"His papers. His letters. The physician's report, which says that he died of a stoppage of the heart, and which I dictated to the physician myself at the fourth hour of the morning, because I found him in the shrine with a hole in his throat and I knew what would happen to this family if it came out." Her voice was perfectly steady. "He was a hard man and a bad husband and a worse father, and he was my husband, and I have spent seventeen years making sure that his death was an accident. Do you understand what that has cost me? I have lied to my son and my daughter and my priest and my own sister, and I have done it every day, and I have never once complained, because that is what the women of this family do while the men are being upright in the Forum."

"Mother—"

"Be quiet." She opened the box. "There is a letter in here. It is from the woman. It came to me eleven years ago, when she bought

the house on the Vicus Tuscus, and it says: *I have not spoken and I will not speak, and I do not want anything from you, and I am writing because I want you to know that I am alive.* I have kept it, because I did not know what else to do with it, and I have read it perhaps once a year, and I have hated her every time I have read it, and I have never been able to decide whether she was threatening me or whether she was being kind."

She held it out. Corvus did not take it.

"She is going to tell the truth at the trial," he said.

"Yes."

"She will say that my father was killed in this house, by her, in the shrine, and that I was there, and that I sent her away."

"She will say it," said his mother, "if she is alive to say it."

The words hung in the air of the atrium, among the painted gods and the cracked impluvium and the smell of wax and old wood.

"Mother."

"I am not asking you to kill her," Claudia Junia said. "I am telling you what is required. A witness can be discredited, and a woman of her condition can be discredited more easily than most, but a woman who stands up in a basilica and tells a story that is true, with details that only she could know, in front of six hundred men—" she stopped. "You have three days until the Nones and nine until the Ides. Use them."

"To do what?"

"To make sure that she is not believed." The old woman closed the box. "There is a girl in that house. The singer. The one who is your son's ruin and the only witness to the cup. Take her out of the house. Not by force, in the street, where there will be a crowd; take her quietly, as a witness, into the custody of the prefecture, on the ground that her life is in danger and that she is a material witness in a capital case. Put her in a house outside the city, with a guard and a

maid, and let the woman spend the nine days before her trial looking for her."

"That is not lawful."

"It is entirely lawful," said Claudia Junia. "It is done every month. And it is the only thing you have left that is not murder." She turned and walked toward the stairs, and then stopped, with her hand on the rail. "Gaius. When your father died I sat in this room for two days and I did not weep, and on the third day I went to the shrine and cleaned the floor myself, because I did not trust the slaves to do it, and I scrubbed it with my own hands until there was no mark on the stone. I have never told anyone that. I am telling you now so that you understand that I know exactly what this family is, and exactly what it costs, and that I am not asking you to do anything I have not done myself."

She went up the stairs.

Corvus stood alone in the atrium for a long time.

Then he went to the tablinum and sent for Faustus.

"I want the girl taken out of the house," he said, "tonight, quietly, and put in the villa at Ficulea with two men and a woman, and I want her treated well, and I want her alive, and if she is harmed I will have your hands. Do you understand?"

"Yes, dominus."

"And Faustus." Corvus looked up at him. "When this is finished, you will go to my estate in Baetica and you will not come back to Rome, and you will not see me again, and the money you took from Publius Vettius will be taken out of your peculium and given to the guild of the bakers in the name of a boy called Felix, who was twelve years old, and if you tell me that you cannot afford it I will sell you."

Faustus's face did not change.

"Yes, dominus."

He went out.

Corvus sat down at his father's table and put his hands flat on it, and outside the window the light was going, and the city was beginning to make its evening noise, and somewhere a long way off a woman was singing at her work.

He thought about the girl in the green dress standing in the pool of light with her lyre, and about the mark in the shape of an eight, and about the fact that he had just ordered a witness taken out of her house so that his mother's seventeen-year silence would hold.

He thought: *I have become my father.*

The villa at Ficulea had four rooms and a wall and a gate and a woman who came in to cook. It had a well and a fig tree and a view of the hills. It was, in every particular, a decent place to keep a witness, and he had chosen it himself in one afternoon from a list of three, and had thought at the time that he was being careful and humane.

And then, because he was a man who had been taught since childhood that a thought like that is a thing to be put down and not to be examined, he took out a tablet and began to write out the arrangements for the villa at Ficulea, in the clear, careful, upright hand of the consul-designate of the year to come.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Tiro

He went to Tibur on the day after the panel, on foot, at dawn, with a purse at his belt and a lie in his mouth.

"To see a man about a dog," he told Prisca, and she looked at him and said, "You have never owned a dog," and he said, "I am thinking of starting," and she said, "You are a terrible liar, Tiro," and he said, "I know," and went out.

The road to Tibur went up through the olive country and the stone quarries, and it took four hours at a good pace. He had walked it four times in eight years. He knew every milestone and the place where the stream came down under the road and the shrine of the fountain with the worn face, and he walked it now with his mind going round and round like a wheel with a broken spoke.

The smithy was at the bottom of the town, by the gate, where the carts came in.

It was a good smithy as smithies went: a stone shed with a wide door and a thatched roof and a yard with a well and a heap of charcoal and a goat tied to a post. There were two men working and a boy working the bellows, and the boy was fourteen and had his mother's hands, and he was taller than Tiro remembered and thinner, and

there was a burn on his forearm from the sparks, and he did not look up when Tiro came into the yard.

Gallio the smith came out wiping his hands.

"You," he said.

"Me." Tiro put the purse on the bench. "I want to talk about the boy."

"The boy is not for sale."

"Everything is for sale."

"Not this boy. He is worth more to me in the shop than he is in silver. He has the knack. He can shoe a horse and he can temper a blade and he is not a fool, which is more than I can say for the last three I bought." Gallio looked at the purse, and then at Tiro. "You are his father."

"I am."

"You have been his father four times in eight years, and each time you have stood in that street and looked at him and gone away again. He told me. He said: *my father came and looked at me and went away.* He said it the way a man says the weather."

Tiro's face did not move.

"How much?"

"Twelve hundred."

"Last year it was six."

"Last year he was twelve and could not do anything but sweep. Now he can temper a blade." Gallio picked up the purse and weighed it in his hand. "You have two hundred here."

"I have two hundred and eleven."

"Then you have two hundred and eleven and the price is twelve hundred, and I am not a hard man, and I will take it in instalments, and it will take you five years, and in five years he will be nineteen and worth two thousand and I will raise the price again." He put the purse down. "That is the way of it. I am sorry. I am not a monster. I am a man with a business."

Tiro stood in the yard and looked at his son.

The boy had stopped working the bellows. He was standing with his hands hanging and his face carefully blank, and he was looking at Tiro the way a dog looks at a man who has kicked it before and might kick it again.

"Rufus," Tiro said.

"Sir."

The word went into him.

"Come here."

The boy came, and stood, and Tiro put his hand on the back of his neck, which was the only thing he could think of to do, and the boy endured it.

"I am going to buy your freedom," Tiro said. "I have been saying it for eight years and I have not done it, and I am going to do it this year. Do you hear me? This year."

"Yes, sir."

"Do you believe me?"

The boy looked at him.

"No," he said.

Tiro took his hand away.

"Then I will have to do it and not talk about it," he said, and the boy nodded, and went back to the bellows, and Tiro stood in the yard for a while and then took up his purse and walked back to Rome.

He was on the road by the third hour, and he was halfway home, at the place where the road bends and you can see the whole plain and the city lying in it like a stain, when a litter came down the road toward him with four bearers and a man walking beside it.

The man was Faustus.

The litter stopped. Faustus said something to the bearers and came forward on foot, and he was dusty and he had been riding, and

he looked, for the first time in all the years Tiro had known him, like a man who was not entirely in control of things.

"Tiro," he said. "I have been to the house. They told me you had gone to Tibur. I have come after you."

"Then you have wasted a morning."

"I have come to make you an offer." Faustus fell into step beside him. "You went to the smithy. I know what he asked. I know what the boy is worth and I know that you will never have it, not in five years, not in ten, because a steward's peculium is a slow thing and because the domina pays you what she pays you." He took a folded paper from his sleeve. "This is the boy's manumission. It is signed by Gallio and sealed by the duumvirs of Tibur and it is dated the day before yesterday. It cost eleven hundred sesterces of my own money and it is in my hand, and the boy is free from the Kalends of August."

Tiro stopped in the road.

"You are a liar," he said.

"I am a great many things." Faustus held the paper up. "Look at it. You cannot read it, but you can look at the seal, and you know the seal of the duumvirs, and you know that I would not forge a public seal for a boy in a smithy." He put it back in his sleeve. "He is free. He does not know it. He will not know it until somebody tells him, and the somebody will be me, or you, or nobody at all."

"What do you want?"

"The box," Faustus said.

Tiro did not move.

"You know the one," Faustus said. "The small one, of myrtle wood, in the strongbox in her room. There is a letter in it, in the hand of my master, written seventeen years ago, and a stylus. I want the letter."

"You want me to rob her."

"I want you to save her." Faustus's voice was quiet and reasonable. "Think, Tiro. On the Ides she is to be tried. If she is convicted,

the court will seize the house and everything in it, and the strongbox will be opened by the prefect's clerks, and the letter will be read out in the basilica. And what does the letter say? It says that a woman in this city took money to keep silence about a death in the house of the Claudii Corvi. And then the panel will ask: what death? And the answer will be the death of a consul, seventeen years ago, in his own shrine, with a pen in his throat. And she will be tried for that instead, and she will be executed, and every woman in that house will be sold, and your boy will be free and you will be dead." He paused. "Whereas if the letter is not in the box on the Ides, the clerks will find loan tablets and deeds and a purchase document and nothing else, and she will be tried for the death of Vettius, which she did not do, and she may even be acquitted."

Tiro looked at the road ahead, at the city lying in the plain.

"You are doing this to protect your master," he said.

"I am doing this to protect my master and myself and the house I have served for twenty years, and I am also telling you the truth, which is that the letter will destroy her." Faustus spread his hands. "You may believe both. A man may do a thing for a bad reason and it may still be the right thing to do. You have been in the world long enough to know that."

"And the boy?"

"The boy is free either way," Faustus said. "I have already paid. I am not a man who takes back a payment. Give me the letter and the paper is in your hand tonight; refuse me and the paper is still in my hand, and I will keep it, and when I go to Baetica in the autumn I will take it with me, and he will be free in law and a slave in fact, which is the worst of both."

They walked on in silence for a while.

"Why?" Tiro said. "Why do you care so much? You did not kill the old man. You took money from the son. You could go to the pre-

fect yourself and tell him everything and be a witness and take your chances."

Faustus laughed. It was a small, dry, entirely mirthless sound.

"Because I am a freedman," he said, "and a freedman who informs on his patron is a dead man, and because in twenty years I have never had a thing of my own, and because—" he stopped.

"Because what?"

"Because when I was eleven years old," Faustus said, "I was sold into that house, and the old consul used to have me stand at the foot of his couch while he ate, and he would throw the bones on the floor for me to pick up, and he would laugh, and the lady of the house would look at the wall. And when he died I was twenty-four years old and I stood in the atrium with the others and I felt nothing at all, and then I went out into the garden and I found that I was crying, and I did not know why, and I have never known why." He looked at Tiro. "I did not kill him. But I have thought about him every day for twenty years, and when the son came to me with money I took it, and I have told myself ever since that I took it for the family, and it is a lie. I took it because I wanted him dead and I could not do it myself."

The road went down toward the city. A cart passed them, going the other way, and the driver called out a greeting, and neither of them answered.

"Tonight," Faustus said. "At the second hour of the night. Bring it to the shrine of the crossroads at the foot of the Palatine, and the paper will be in my hand, and I will take the letter and burn it in front of you, and you will never see me again."

He turned and walked back toward the litter.

Tiro stood in the road for a long time.

Then he went on into the city, and he came to the house at dusk, and he ate his dinner in the kitchen with the women, and he listened to them talk about the dinner and about the prefect's men and about

the girl, and at the second hour of the night, when the house was quiet, he went up the back stairs to the domina's room.

The door was not locked. She had never locked it. She had said once that a woman who locks her door in her own house is a woman who has already decided that her household is her enemy, and she had looked at him when she said it.

He stood in the dark room and listened to her breathe.

She was asleep, on her side, with her hand under her cheek, and in the light from the window she looked younger and smaller and entirely without defences, and he had known her for seventeen years and she had never once let him see her asleep.

The key was on the table by the bed, on a cord.

He took it. He went to the strongbox and opened it, and the lock made a sound that seemed to fill the room, and he stood still with his heart going, and she did not wake.

The box of myrtle wood was at the bottom under the deeds.

He lifted it out. It was lighter than he expected. He stood in the dark holding it, and he thought about the letter inside it, in a hand he could not read, and about the fact that he was fifty-two years old and had never stolen anything in his life, and that the first thing he had ever stolen was the only thing his mistress had never told him about.

He put the box inside his tunic and closed the strongbox and put the key back on the table by the bed, and then he stood over her for a moment.

"Domina," he said, very quietly, and she did not wake.

He went out.

He did not go straight to the shrine.

He went up to his room first and took the box out of his tunic and put it on the bed and looked at it. It was small and dark and beautifully made, with a bronze lock and a lid that fitted so well that you could not see the seam, and it had been in her strongbox for seventeen years and she had put her hand on it in the dark, and he had

watched her do it and had said nothing, because a good steward does not remark on what his mistress keeps.

He opened it.

The letter was folded twice, with the seal broken, and the paper had gone brown at the folds. There was a stylus beside it, bronze, worn smooth at the end, the sort of thing a schoolboy would have.

He could not read the letter.

He sat on the bed with it in his hands and turned it over and over, and the not being able to read it was, for the first time in his life, a physical thing, a wall he could put his hand on.

She taught herself to read, he thought. *She told me once. She said a man in a house taught her when she was seventeen and she learned in a fortnight and it was the thing that made her.*

He put the letter back in the box and closed it and put it inside his tunic, against his chest.

The shrine of the crossroads was at the foot of the hill, a little square building with a worn step and a niche with three figures in it and a lamp that somebody kept filled. Faustus was waiting with two men and a lantern.

"You have it."

"I have it."

"Give it to me."

"The paper first."

Faustus took the folded paper from his sleeve and gave it to him. Tiro unfolded it and looked at it, and could not read a word of it, and looked at the seal, and it was the seal of the duumvirs of Tibur, and he folded it again and put it inside his tunic.

Then he took out the box.

"I want to see it burned," he said.

"You will see it burned."

Tiro opened the box. There was the letter, folded twice, with the seal broken, and a stylus of bronze, worn smooth at the end, the sort of thing a boy would have in his satchel at school.

He looked at the stylus for a moment. Then he took out the letter and held it over the lamp.

And Faustus took it out of his hand.

"Thank you," he said, and put it in his sleeve, and nodded to the two men, and they came forward and took Tiro by the arms.

"What is this?"

"I told you I would burn it," Faustus said. "I did not tell you when."

"Give it to me."

"No." Faustus picked up the empty box and turned it over in his hands, and then put it on the step of the shrine. "You are going to go home and go to bed and say nothing. If you say anything to her, I will have the boy's paper revoked on the ground that it was obtained by fraud, and I will have him sold to a man I know in Puteoli who buys boys for the galleys." He turned to go, and then stopped. "Tiro. You did the right thing. You will not believe it tonight, and perhaps you never will, but you did. The letter would have hanged her."

He went away up the hill with his two men, and the lantern went with him.

Tiro stood in front of the shrine with the empty box in his hands.

Then he walked home, and let himself in by the kitchen door, and went up to his room, and sat on the bed, and took out the paper and looked at it for a long time in the dark.

He could not read it.

He could not read a single line of it. He could read four words: his own name, her name, and *the old man first*, which he had copied out on a tablet from the papyrus, letter by letter, in the dark. He had been a slave until he was thirty-five and nobody had ever taught him,

and he had never minded, because a man who cannot read is a man who cannot be caught in a lie, and because a steward who cannot read the accounts is a steward who is trusted with other things. He had never minded in his life.

He minded now.

He sat on the bed with the paper in his hands and his hands shaking, and he thought: *I have given away the only thing she kept, and I do not even know what it said.*

He went down to the kitchen at the third hour because he could not sit still, and Prisca was there.

She was always there at that hour. She came down before the girls to light the oven and put the water on, and she had a shawl over her nightdress and her hair in a plait and she was not pleased to see him.

"You are up early."

"I could not sleep."

"No." She looked at him. "You look like a man who has been up all night doing something he should not have been doing."

Tiro sat down on the bench by the oven.

Prisca put the kettle on the hook and swung it over the fire and stood with her back to him, and the kitchen was quiet except for the sound of the fire taking hold.

"Prisca."

"What?"

"I want you to read something for me."

She turned around.

"You want me to read something."

"Yes."

"You have never asked me to read anything in eleven years." She wiped her hands on her apron. "You have never asked anyone to read anything. You told me once that a man who cannot read is a man who cannot be caught in a lie, and I said that a man who cannot read

is a man who has to trust whoever can, and you said that you had never met anyone worth trusting."

"I remember."

"So what is it?"

He took the paper out of his tunic and put it on the table.

Prisca looked at it. Then she looked at him, for a long moment, and then she came and sat down on the bench opposite and picked it up and unfolded it and held it close to the fire.

"Where did you get this?"

"That does not matter. Read it."

"Tiro—"

"Read it."

She read it.

She read it slowly, moving her finger under the words, and it took her a long time, because it was a clerk's hand and the light was bad and because she had learned to read from an old woman in a laundry in Ostia and had never had much practice.

Then she put it down on the table.

"It is a manumission," she said.

"Read it out."

"*Gallio, smith, of Tibur, with the consent of the duumvirs, manumits Rufus, his slave, aged fourteen years, from the Kalends of August next, in consideration of the sum of eleven hundred sesterces paid by Faustus, freedman of Gaius Claudius Corvus.*" She looked up. "It is sealed by the duumvirs. It is a proper paper. He is free."

Tiro sat very still.

He had known. He had known since the shrine, since he had looked at the seal and had not been able to read a word of it. But there is a difference between knowing a thing and hearing a woman read it out in a kitchen at the third hour of the morning, and the difference went through him like a knife.

He put his hand over his face.

"Tiro."

"He is free."

"He is free from the Kalends of August." Prisca put the paper down. "What did you give him?"

He did not answer.

"Tiro. What did you give him?"

"A letter."

"What letter?"

"A letter out of the box in her room." He said it flatly, with his hand still over his face. "A letter from a man, seventeen years old. He said it would hang her if the court found it. He said that if I gave it to him he would burn it and she would be safe and the boy would be free, and I believed the first part and I wanted the second part, and I have been sitting upstairs for four hours trying to work out which of them I believed more."

Prisca was silent.

"You went into her room," she said.

"Yes."

"While she was asleep."

"Yes."

"And you took the one thing in this house she has never spoken about, and you gave it to the steward of the man who is trying to destroy her, and you did it for a paper." Prisca's voice was not raised. That was the thing about Prisca: she had run a household for eleven years and she had learned that the quiet voice does the work. "Tiro. She gave you a place when you had nothing. She gave you a name and a room and a seat at her table and she never once asked you what you had done before. I have been in this house eleven years and I have never seen her trust anyone the way she trusts you."

"I know."

"And you did it for a paper."

"For my son."

"Your son." Prisca stood up. "Your son has been four times in eight years, Tiro. I know, because you told me when you were drunk at the Saturnalia, and I have never told anyone, and I have thought about it every time you went to Tibur and came back and sat in the kitchen and did not eat." She put the kettle on the table. "You did not do it for your son. You did it because you could not bear to be a man who had done nothing for his son. There is a difference, and it is the difference between a father and a coward, and I am not sure which one you are this morning."

Tiro looked at the table.

"Neither am I," he said.

Prisca sat down again.

She was quiet for a while. The fire took hold of the wood and the kitchen began to be warm, and somewhere above them the house creaked, and in an hour the girls would come down and the day would begin.

"Are you going to tell her?" she said.

"Yes."

"When?"

"Before the trial."

"She will turn you out."

"I know."

"She will turn you out and you will have nowhere to go, and you are fifty-two years old with a scar on your face, and no one in this city will take a steward who has been turned out of the Myrtle for stealing from the mistress." Prisca looked at him. "I could read it to you again, if you like. The paper."

"No."

"Why not?"

Tiro looked up at her.

"Because I have heard it once," he said, "and I have waited eight years to hear it, and I thought that it would be the best morning of

my life." He picked the paper up and folded it and put it inside his tunic. "And it is the worst. And I would like to sit in this kitchen for an hour before the girls come down and not think about anything at all."

Prisca got up and cut him a piece of bread and put it in front of him, and then she went back to the oven, and neither of them said anything for a long time.

At the fourth hour of the morning he heard the house wake: the kitchen girls, the water, the door, the fountain. He heard Antonia come down and speak to Prisca in the atrium, and he heard her laugh at something, and the sound of it went through him like a blade.

He went down.

She was in the atrium with a tablet in her hand, and she looked up when she saw him, and her face changed.

"Tiro. What is it?"

"Domina." He stood in front of her. "I have done a thing."

She looked at him for a long moment. Then she turned and walked to her room without a word, and he followed her up the stairs, and she opened the strongbox and knelt down and went through it, and came up with her hand empty.

She sat back on her heels.

"Where is it?"

"I gave it to Faustus."

She did not move. The morning light came in through the shutters and lay on the floor between them.

"Say it again."

"I gave it to Faustus. Last night, at the shrine of the crossroads. He gave me the manumission of my son, and I gave him the letter." His voice was steady, and he was ashamed of how steady it was. "He told me it would hang you. He told me that if the court seized the house the clerks would find it and read it out in the basilica and you

would be tried for the death of the old consul. I believed him. I still believe him. And I wanted the paper for my boy."

Antonia looked at him.

"Seventeen years," she said.

"Domina—"

"Seventeen years, and I have told you everything. Not everything; I have not told you that. I have not told anyone that." She stood up, slowly. "I gave you a house and a name and a place at my table, and I have never once asked you what you did before I found you, and I have never once looked at you the way the men in the Forum look at a man with a scar. I trusted you with my life. I trusted you with the lives of every woman in this house." Her voice was quiet. "And you sold me for eleven hundred sesterces and a piece of paper you cannot read."

"I did it to save you."

"You did it for your son. Do not dress it up. I would have done the same for a child, and I would have hated myself, and I would have told you afterward, and I would not have stood in the atrium in the morning and said *I did it to save you*." She turned away. "Get out."

"Domina—"

"Get out of my sight, Tiro." She said it without raising her voice. "Go down to the kitchen and sit there and do not speak to me and do not leave the house. I will decide what to do with you when I have decided what to do with everything else."

He went.

At the door he stopped.

"There is a thing I have not told you," he said. "The papyrus. The one I took off the man in the alley. I could not read it, so I kept it. It has three words on it, in a bad hand, and I do not know what they are."

Antonia turned.

"Where is it?"

"In my room. Under the mattress."

"Bring it to me."

He brought it. She took it and unfolded it and read it, standing in the middle of her own room with the strongbox open at her feet, and her face did not change at all.

"What does it say?" Tiro asked.

"It says: *the old man first.*" She folded it. "It is a note from Faustus to his man, telling him the order of the deaths. Your master first, and then whoever was in the way." She looked at him. "You have brought me the one piece of paper in this city that could hang him, and you did it by accident, and you gave away the only thing I ever asked anyone to keep."

She put the papyrus in her sleeve.

"Go and sit in the kitchen," she said. "And Tiro—if you leave this house tonight, do not come back."

He went down the stairs and sat in the kitchen with the women, and Calybe gave him bread and he did not eat it, and the morning went on around him, and at the ninth hour a man came to the door with a message from the prefecture, and at the tenth hour the women began to scream.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Antonia

They took Calybe at the tenth hour, in the kitchen, with her hands in the flour.

There were six of them: four of the urban cohorts and a clerk and Maro himself, who stood in the doorway with his hands behind his back and watched while they put the irons on her wrists. Calybe did not scream. She looked at Antonia, who had come running at the noise, and she said, "Domina, the bread," and Antonia said, "I will take the bread out," and Calybe nodded, and they took her away.

The bread burned.

Antonia stood in the kitchen and watched it burn, because she had said she would take it out and she had forgotten, and the smell of it filled the house and got into the curtains and stayed there for a week.

She went to the prefecture at the second hour and was kept waiting until the sixth.

The room was the same room with the cut-away frieze, and Pedo received her alone, without a clerk, which was a courtesy and also a warning.

"You have come about the cook," he said.

"I have come about the cook."

"She is being examined. It is lawful. She is a slave and she is the person who had charge of the food and wine in the house on the night in question, and the law requires that her evidence be taken under examination, because a slave's word is worth nothing otherwise. You know this. You have known it since you were a child."

"I know it." Antonia stood in front of the table with her hands at her sides. "I know that a woman who has been on the hook for an hour will say anything that the man with the hook wants her to say, and that what she says will be written down and read out in the basilica and believed by six hundred men who have never seen a woman on a hook. I know that this is not justice. I know that it is the law. I am not here to argue the law."

"Then why are you here?"

"To ask you what you want."

Pedo looked at her for a long moment.

"I want the case finished," he said. "I want the emperor to come back from the east in the spring and find the city quiet. I want the Senate to stop talking about a dead consular in a brothel. I want to retire in four years to a house in Campania with a garden and a library, and I want to die in my bed, and I want no one to say at my funeral that I was the prefect who let the city be made a fool of." He sat down. "That is what I want. It is not a noble list. I am sixty years old and I have stopped pretending."

"Then take the case away from Maro."

"I cannot."

"You can. You are the prefect."

"Maro has the ear of the emperor's secretary," Pedo said. "He has had it for nine years. He is a hard man and a stupid one and he believes what he says, which is the most dangerous kind, and if I take the case away from him he will write a letter to Antioch, and the letter will say that the prefect of the city is protecting a brothel-keeper,

and I will spend the last four years of my life explaining myself to a man who is a thousand miles away and does not read carefully." He folded his hands. "I am sorry. I am not your enemy. I am a man in a bad position, and I am telling you the truth because you are the only person in this city who has ever told it to me."

Antonia stood very still.

"Then I will ask you for one thing," she said. "The girl. Leda."

"She is a witness."

"She is a witness and she is in danger. The man who paid for the poison is the son of the dead man and he is at liberty, and the man who carried it is dead, and the only living witness to either is a girl of twenty-one who has already told her story to your clerk." She stepped closer. "Put her in the custody of the prefecture. Not in a cell; in a house, with a guard, under your seal. If she is in your custody, no one can touch her, and she will be produced at the trial and she will say what she saw, and the case will be decided on the evidence instead of on the hook."

Pedo looked at her with something that might have been respect.

"You are a remarkable woman," he said.

"I am a woman who has run out of options."

"I will consider it."

"Consider it today."

"I will consider it today," he said. "Now go home, and do not come here again until the Ides, and if you send me another letter like the one you sent me on the Kalends I will have you arrested for insolence." He stood. "And domina—I read the letter. Twice. I have kept it. If the case goes the way Maro wants it to go, it will not help you, and if it goes the other way it will not help you either. But I have kept it, and I do not keep many letters."

She went out through the prefecture and down the steps into the Forum, and the sun was hot and the dust was thick and the city went on around her.

She did not sleep that night either.

She lay on the bed in the little room above the fuller's and listened to the city and thought about the ledger.

It had always been the ledger. That was the thing she understood at three o'clock in the morning in a rented room with no house: that she had spent twenty-six years keeping accounts, and that she had believed, in a way she had never said out loud, that if the accounts were kept properly the world would be fair. A woman borrows and repays. A woman buys a girl and teaches her to sing and does not sell her to men. A woman pays her debts and her people and her taxes, and in the end the accounts balance, and the woman is safe.

The accounts had never balanced. They had simply been kept by her, in her hand, in her own favour, and the world had gone on doing exactly what it liked.

Very well, she thought. *Then I will not keep accounts any more. I will do the thing that is in front of me and I will do it as well as I can.*

The confession was read to her three days later by a clerk in the portico of the basilica, because she was entitled to know the evidence against her, and because Maro wanted her to know it.

It was four lines long.

Calybe, slave of Antonia Cassia, cook, questioned by the hook, says: that her mistress gave her a packet of white powder on the morning of the banquet and told her to put it in the cup of the consular Vettius, and that she did not wish to, and that her mistress said that a slave who refuses her master's orders is a slave who is sold to the mines. She says that she put the powder in the cup in the passage behind the dining room before the second course, and that a man of the house saw her and said nothing. She says that she is sorry, and that she did it out of fear, and that her mistress is a hard woman and a bad one.

Antonia read it twice.

"Where is she now?"

"In the cells," said the clerk.

"Is she alive?"

The clerk looked at his tablets. "She was alive this morning."

Antonia folded the paper and gave it back to him.

"Tell Maro," she said, "that a confession obtained on the hook is worth precisely what the hook is worth, and that in the reign of Tiberius a man confessed under torture to having killed his own father, and then, when he was released and tried to go home, his father came to meet him at the gate." She turned away. "And tell him that I will see him on the Ides."

She went to see Calybe.

It cost her thirty sesterces and a promise to the gaoler's clerk, and it took two days to arrange, and in the end they let her in at the second hour of the night through a door at the back of the building, with a lamp, and up a flight of steps and along a corridor that smelled of the same thing the corridors had smelled of when Leda came down them.

Calybe was in a cell at the end.

She was sitting on a stone bench against the wall with a blanket over her shoulders and her hands in her lap, and her hands were wrapped in cloth. She looked up when the lamp came in, and for a moment her face was the face of the cook in the kitchen at the fourth hour of the morning, and then it was not.

"Domina."

"Calybe."

"You should not be here."

"I know."

"They will say you came to silence me." Calybe's voice was slow and careful, the way a person speaks who is choosing each word. "They will say you brought money. They will say—" she stopped. "I have said so many things in this room. I do not know any more which of them were true when I said them."

Antonia sat down on the bench beside her.

"Tell me what they did."

Calybe looked at the wall.

"They put me on the hook," she said. "Not the first day. The first day they asked me questions and I said I did not know and they wrote it down. The second day they asked the same questions and I said I did not know. The third day they put me on the hook and asked them again." She was quiet for a moment. "It is not like being hurt. I thought it would be like being hurt. It is like being in a place where there is nothing except the question. There is no floor and no ceiling and no yesterday. There is only the question and the man's voice asking it, and after a while you find that you will say anything that makes the voice stop, and the voice knows that, and it does not stop, and so you say more, and more, and in the end you say the thing that makes it stop."

Antonia sat with her hands in her lap.

"What did you say?"

"I said that you gave me a packet." Calybe's face worked. "I said it because he wanted it. And then he wrote it down and read it back to me and I said it was true, and it was not true, domina, it was not true, you never gave me anything, you never gave me anything in eleven years but a kitchen and a bad temper and a place to sleep—" Her voice broke. "And then I said it was not true and he wrote that down as well, and then he asked me again, and I said it was true."

"I know."

"They will read out the first one in the basilica."

"They will read out both," Antonia said, "and Maro will say that the second one proves you are unreliable, and the panel will believe whichever one is convenient. I know how it works. I have been on the other side of it for seventeen years." She took Calybe's wrapped hands. "You will not be tried. A slave cannot be tried for a crime committed at the order of her mistress. You will be held as a witness and then you will be returned to the household or sold with it."

"I know what sold with it means."

"You will not be sold. I have made an arrangement with a man who will keep the women, and there is a paper, and it is sealed, and you will be free." Antonia said it quietly. "I have given away the house for it. It is done. You will be free, and you will have wages, and there will be a kitchen, and it will not be my kitchen."

Calybe stared at her.

"You gave away the house."

"Yes."

"For me?"

"For all of you. There are eleven of you. Tiro counted this morning."

Calybe began to cry. She cried the way a big woman cries, without any grace, with her whole body, and Antonia sat on the stone bench beside her in the dark and held her hand through the cloth and did not say anything.

After a while Calybe stopped and wiped her face with the corner of the blanket.

"Domina," she said. "There is a thing I have to tell you and I have been sick about it for four days."

"What?"

"The morning of the banquet. I went out into the passage at the second hour to get the garum, and there was a man there." She stopped. "Not in the passage. In the little room where the cups are kept. He had his back to me and he was doing something at the shelf, and when he heard me he turned round and smiled and said, 'The wine is over there, mother,' and I said, 'I know where the wine is,' and I took the garum and I went back into the kitchen."

Antonia was very still.

"What did he look like?"

"Young. Thirty perhaps. Thin face. He had a cup in his hand." Calybe's hands were shaking. "He had a mark on his wrist, on the in-

side. A burn, in the shape of an eight. I saw it when he put his hand on the shelf."

The lamp guttered.

"That is the man," Antonia said.

"I know it is the man. I have known it for four days. I have been sitting in this room knowing it, and they came in and asked me whether my mistress gave me a packet, and I said no, and they put me on the hook, and it never once occurred to me to say: *there was a man in the little room with a cup and a mark on his wrist.*" Calybe began to cry again. "Why did they not ask me that? Why did they ask me the one question I could not answer and not the one I could?"

Antonia sat in the dark with the smell of the corridor in her nose.

"Because they did not want that answer," she said.

She stood up.

"Domina—"

"Listen to me." Antonia crouched down in front of her. "When they bring you into the basilica, and they read out the first confession, you will say: *that is not true, I said it on the hook, and I have told the domina what I saw.* And then you will say what you have just told me, and you will say it loudly, and you will describe the man and the mark and the little room and the cup, and you will not stop for Maro and you will not stop for the prefect and you will not stop for the lictors." She gripped her hands. "Can you do that?"

Calybe looked at her.

"I can try," she said.

"Then that is all," Antonia said. "That is all anyone can do."

She went out through the corridor and down the steps and into the street, and the gaoler's clerk took his thirty sesterces and shut the door, and she stood in the dark alley behind the prefecture with her hand against the wall.

Two, she thought. *The girl, and the cook.*

She went to the baths.

The baths of Trajan at the fourth hour were the busiest place in Rome, and Antonia had not been in them in eleven years, because a woman of her condition did not go to the public baths; she had a bath in her own house, with a slave to pour the water and a bronze basin and a door that locked. She went now in a plain stola with her hair covered and a slave woman behind her and her eyes on the ground, and she went into the women's side and sat in the warm room among the wives of shopkeepers and the daughters of clerks, and she waited.

Eutychus came at the fifth hour, into the colonnade outside the cold pool, where the men walked after their exercise.

He was in a towel and sandals, and he was grey and thin and he looked, without his tunic, like an old soldier who had been left out in the rain. He sat down on the bench beside her with a grunt.

"You came," he said.

"You said you would come if I sent word."

"I said I would come if you sent word and if it was not a trap. I have had two men watching the door since the fourth hour." He looked at her. "You are in the women's colonnade."

"I am aware."

"There will be talk."

"There has been talk about me for seventeen years," Antonia said. "I have found that it is not the talk that kills you; it is the silence afterward."

Eutychus nodded slowly.

"The cook has confessed," he said.

"Yes."

"Under the hook."

"Yes."

"Then you are finished," Eutychus said, "unless the panel decides that the confession is worthless, which it may, because Pedo is cautious and because a confession from a cook is a cheap thing and every

man on that panel has owned slaves and knows what a slave will say on a hook. That is your only hope. It is a thin one."

"I did not come to talk about hope."

"Then what did you come to talk about?"

Antonia took the papyrus out of her sleeve and put it on the bench between them.

Eutychus looked at it. He did not touch it.

"What is it?"

"A note from the steward of the house of the Claudii Corvi to a slave of that household, telling him the order of the deaths. The slave is dead. He was killed by my steward in an alley by the Emporium, and the note was on the body, and it says: *the old man first.*"

Eutychus picked it up.

He read it twice, and then he turned it over and looked at the back, and then he put it down on his knee and looked out at the pool, where two young men were racing each other from end to end, and the water was going everywhere, and a slave was shouting at them.

"Where is the steward now?"

"At the house on the Palatine, serving his master, who is to be consul in the spring."

"And what do you want me to do with this?"

"I want you to put it in front of the panel."

Eutychus laughed. It was a short, unhappy sound.

"You want me to destroy a consul-designate of Rome," he said, "in the third month before he takes office, on the word of a brothel-keeper and a scrap of papyrus. Do you know what happened to the last man who did a thing like that? He was a friend of mine. He was a secretary of the grain account, and he made an accusation against a man with a great name, and the man with the great name was acquitted, and my friend was found in his bath three months later with his wrists open and a note beside him saying that he could not live with

the shame." He turned the papyrus over. "That note was in my friend's own hand. I saw it. It was a very good forgery."

"Then you will not do it."

"I did not say that." Eutychus was quiet for a moment. "I said that it is dangerous. But I am fifty-five years old, and I am the second most powerful man in the accounts of the empire, and I have spent my life being useful to men who despise me, and there is a particular pleasure, at my age, in doing a thing that is dangerous to somebody who deserves it." He folded the papyrus and put it in his towel. "I will put it in front of the panel. Not in my own hand; I have a man in the prefect's clerks, and the papyrus will be found in the file on the morning of the trial, having been sent in anonymously by a citizen who wishes to remain unnamed. Maro will not be able to ignore it, because it will be in the file, and Pedo will not be able to ignore it, because Maro will read it out." He looked at her. "And what do I get?"

"What do you want?"

"The house," Eutychus said.

Antonia had known. She had known since the figs.

"The house and the ground under it," he said, "and the loan discharged, and the two shops in the Argiletum, and the furniture, and the fountain. The women are yours; I do not want the women, and I would not know what to do with them. I want the building. I have a plan for it."

"What plan?"

"A bath," Eutychus said. "A small one. For the clerks of the annona and their wives. There is no decent bath between the Velabrum and the river and the men who work for me have to walk to the Esquiline." He said it without embarrassment. "I am a practical man. I have been practical all my life, and it has made me rich, and it has not made me happy, and I have found that the two are not as connected as I was led to believe."

Antonia looked at the pool. The two young men had finished their race and were hanging on the edge, laughing, and one of them had a cut on his forehead from the tiles.

"Draw up the papers," she said.

"You agree?"

"I agree."

"You are giving up everything you have built."

"I am giving up a building," Antonia said. "I have been in this city long enough to know the difference. A house is a thing that can be bought; a woman who has been hanged cannot be bought back." She stood up. "But I want one thing in return, and it is not in the papers."

"Name it."

"When this is over, whether I am acquitted or convicted or exiled, you will not touch the women. Not one of them. Not Meroe, not Prisca, not Junilla, not the girls in the kitchen. Their contracts are to be given to them, free, every one, and if any of them wishes to stay in the building and work in your bath, she stays as a free woman with wages." Antonia looked down at him. "Put it in the papers. In your own hand, sealed, with witnesses."

Eutychus looked up at her.

"You are a strange woman," he said.

"I am a woman who has been a slave," Antonia said. "It is not the same as being strange."

She went home.

Leda was in the courtyard with her lyre on her knees and her hands not moving, and she looked up when Antonia came in, and her face was the face of a girl who has been waiting three days to be told something.

"Sit down," Antonia said.

Leda sat.

"The trial is on the Ides. The cook has confessed under torture and the confession will be read out and believed by some of them." Antonia sat down on the bench opposite her. "I am going to tell you what will happen, and then I am going to ask you to do something, and you will decide, and I will not overrule you."

"All right."

"On the Ides I will be tried for the murder of a consular. The panel will hear the cook, and the physician, and the prefect's men, and then it will hear you. You are the only witness who saw a man in the passage. If you tell the truth, there is a chance, a small one, that the case will collapse and that the mark on the wrist and the papyrus will lead to the steward and to the son. If you are not there, the case will not collapse, and I will be convicted, and I will be executed or exiled, and the house will be seized, and every woman in it will be sold." She paused. "And if you are there, you will be in the room with the man who has already taken you to his house and offered you a bargain, and who has a son who loves you, and who has spent seventeen years learning how to make people do what he wants without ever raising his voice."

Leda's hands were still on the lyre.

"You want me to go," she said.

"I want you to decide." Antonia leaned forward. "There is a boat at Ostia. There is a boy who loves you and a road out of this city and a mother in Surrentum who has been looking for you for ten years. If you go tonight, you will be gone before the Ides, and I will lose, and I will not blame you, and I will not send anyone after you."

"And if I stay?"

"If you stay, you will be in a basilica in front of six hundred men, and you will have to say out loud what was done to you when you were eleven and what was done to you when you were fifteen, and there will be men in that room who will enjoy it." Antonia's voice was quiet. "I have done that. I have stood in a room and said out loud

what was done to me, and I know what it costs, and I will not ask it of you."

Leda looked at her for a long time.

"You bought me," she said.

"I bought you."

"And you told me that no man would touch me until I chose."

"I did."

"And then men touched me anyway, in the street, at the door, at the dinners, and you did not stop them, because you could not stop them without losing the dinner." Leda's voice was steady. "And you told me that I was not a slave and that I would be free one day, and you kept my contract in a box, and you never once showed it to me. And I have spent six years loving you and being afraid of you and wanting you to look at me the way you looked at the fountain when it was clean."

"I know."

"Why did you buy me?"

Antonia was silent for a moment.

"Because you sang badly," she said, "and you were frightened, and you looked at me as though I were a door that might open. And because I had been sold at fourteen and nobody had opened a door for me." She looked at her hands. "And because I am a woman who has spent her life buying things, and I saw a thing that was worth more than eleven thousand sesterces, and I bought it, and I have been paying for it ever since."

Leda set the lyre down.

"I will stay," she said.

"Leda—"

"I will stay and I will tell them what I saw, and I will not be a frightened girl who is not sure, and I will not let him make me into a story." She stood up. "But not for you. I am not doing it for you. I am doing it because there was a boy in this house who was twelve

years old and who was kind to me, and because I have a mother in Surrentum who has been petitioning governors for ten years, and because if I run away tonight I will spend the rest of my life being a woman who ran." She picked up the lyre. "And because I want to see his face when I say the mark."

Antonia looked at her.

"Then I will tell you one thing," she said, "and then we will not speak of it again. If the case goes against me, you will leave this city. Not with the boy; he is a Claudius and he will be married in the autumn and he will not defy his father in the end, whatever he says in the dark by a river. You will leave with the paper I give you, and you will go to Surrentum, and you will not look back."

"Antonia—"

"Say it."

"I will go to Surrentum," Leda said, "if it goes against you."

"Good."

They sat in the courtyard until the light went. The fountain ran. The bronze myrtle dripped, and above the roof the sky turned from white to gold to the colour of a bruise, and the noise of the city came over the wall as it always did, and neither of them said anything at all.

At the second hour of the night Leda went up to her room and took out the shell and the paper and put them in a bag, and then she sat on the bed with the bag in her lap.

She did not go to the Nones.

She had promised, and she did not go, and she sat on the bed all night listening to the house, and at the fourth hour she heard the sound of a horse in the street and then nothing, and at the fifth hour the sky began to lighten.

Three streets away, at the foot of the Viminal, a young man stood in a doorway with his hood up and waited for a girl who did not come.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Marcus

He had made the plan for the Nones the way a young man makes a plan: thoroughly, and without any understanding of what could go wrong.

There was a horse at a stable behind the Temple of Vesta, hired for three days with money he had got by selling a signet ring that had belonged to his mother. There was a cloak and a pair of boots and a purse with forty denarii in it, and a knife, and a letter to the master of a boat at Ostia that had cost him two denarii and a great deal of charm. There was a route: out through the Viminal gate, north along the salt road to the crossing at Fidenae, then west to the river and down the Tiber to Ostia, four days, three if the roads were dry.

And there was the roof.

He had gone over it twice in the dark to be sure of it: out of his window onto the ridge, along the ridge to the corner above the fig tree, down onto the wall, and into the street. The drop from the wall was twelve feet and there was a water trough in the street below, and he had put a sack over the edge of the trough so that he would not make a noise.

He did all of it. He went out of the window at the second hour with his boots in his hand and his cloak over his arm, and he went along the ridge and down over the wall and into the street, and the two men at the gate never saw him, and he walked north through the sleeping city with his heart going like a drum.

He was at the Viminal gate by the third hour.

She was not there.

He waited in the shadow of a tomb on the other side of the road, which is what a man does when he is early and does not want to be seen, and the gate stood open with the watchman's fire burning in the niche, and the watchman was a fat man with a stick who sat on a stool and did not look at anything.

At the fourth hour a cart came through, and then two men with a lantern, and then nothing.

At the fifth hour the sky began to lighten.

He told himself that she had been delayed. He told himself that Prisca had caught her, or that the domina had kept her up, or that she had gone out by the kitchen door and had had to wait for a watchman. He told himself eleven different things, and each of them was reasonable, and underneath all of them was a thing he would not look at, which was that she had told him, in as many words, that she might not come.

I will be there, she had said. *And if you are not there, I will not come looking for you.*

He had said that he would be there, and he was, and she was not, and he stood in the shadow of a tomb on the Viminal road while the sky went from black to grey to the colour of a fish's belly, and the city woke up around him: a baker's cart, a woman with a bucket, a boy driving goats, a man selling hot wine out of a pot.

A watchman came past and looked at him.

"You waiting for someone?"

"Yes."

"They are not coming," the watchman said, with the cheerfulness of a man who has seen everything twice. "They never come. I have been on this gate nine years. I have seen eleven men waiting in the dark for someone who was going to come, and two of them came. The other nine stood there until the sun was up and then went home." He spat in the road. "Go home, sir. Whatever it was, it was not worth standing in the cold for."

Marcus went to the house.

He went the long way, by the Velabrum and up the Vicus Tuscus, because a man who is going to be seen standing in the street should not come by the alley. The street was empty except for a baker's boy and a woman washing the step of a shop, and the door of the Myrtle was shut, and there was no lamp in the niche.

He stood in the doorway of the fuller's shop opposite and watched the house for an hour.

At the fifth hour the kitchen door opened and a girl came out with a bucket and went to the fountain at the corner, and came back, and the door shut. At the sixth hour a man came up the street with a cart and stopped at the house next door and unloaded jars. At the seventh hour the door of the Myrtle opened and Prisca came out with a basket and went toward the market, and Marcus stepped out of the doorway and said, "Prisca."

She stopped as though she had been struck.

"You," she said.

"Is she awake?"

"Go away."

"Prisca—"

"Go away," Prisca said, and her face was white. "You are not to be here. She is not to see you. There is a thing happening in that house this morning and you are the last person in Rome who should be standing in this street." She took him by the arm and pulled him into the doorway, and her hand was shaking. "They have taken the

cook. Maro took her three days ago and she has confessed and the confession will hang your—" she stopped herself. "And now there are two men in the alley behind the house who have been there since before dawn, and a litter at the corner, and the domina has been up all night, and the girl has been crying."

"What girl?"

"Leda." Prisca looked at him. "You do not know."

"Know what?"

"Go home," she said. "Go home, Marcus, go home, go home—"

The door of the Myrtle opened.

Two men came out with Leda between them.

She was not struggling. That was the thing he would remember: that she was not struggling, and that she was walking, and that her hands were folded in front of her, and that she had her shawl around her shoulders as though she were going to the market. One of the men had her by the elbow. The other walked behind with his hand near his belt.

There was a third man at the door, and it was Faustus.

Marcus started forward and Prisca caught at his sleeve and he pulled free, and he was across the street before anyone had time to think about it.

"Take your hands off her."

The man holding her elbow turned. He was a big man, forty or so, with the flat face of a man who has been in the army and has not enjoyed it, and he looked at Marcus the way a man looks at a dog in the road.

"Stand aside," he said.

"That is my—" Marcus stopped. "That is a free woman. She has been claimed free before the prefect. You have no right to take her."

"She is a witness in a capital case," said Faustus, from the door, "and she is being removed for her own protection, by order of the prefect's office, and here is the order with the seal on it, and if you lay

a hand on my men I will have you arrested in the street." He was pale and he was sweating and his voice was not quite steady. "Marcus. Go home."

Leda looked at Marcus.

Her face was calm. That was the second thing he would remember, and he would think about it for years: that her face was calm, and that she looked at him the way you look at a person on the other side of a river.

"Go home," she said.

"Leda—"

"Go home." She said it clearly, and then she said, more quietly, "I am all right. They are taking me to a house in the country. There will be a maid and two men and I will be brought back for the trial." She paused. "Do not do anything stupid. That is the only thing I have ever asked you."

The man with the flat face moved her toward the litter.

Marcus took a step.

He did not decide to. It was the same thing that had happened in the stable yard with his father: his body did the thing before his mind had agreed to it, and he got a hand on the big man's shoulder and turned him, and the man let go of Leda's elbow and hit him in the stomach, once, with a fist like a mallet.

Marcus went down on the stones.

He heard Leda say his name. He heard Faustus say, "Get her in, get her in." He got a hand under himself and pushed up, and the big man hit him again, on the side of the head this time, and the street went away and came back, and when it came back the litter was moving up the hill.

He got up.

Prisca was there, and Tiro was there, and Tiro had him by the arm and was walking him into the alley behind the house, and Mar-

cus was saying, "Let go of me, let go of me," and Tiro was saying nothing at all.

They got him into the kitchen and sat him on the bench, and Calybe's place at the oven was empty, and the fire was out, and there was a smell of burnt bread in the room that would not go away for a week.

Tiro put a cup of water in his hand.

"Drink."

"Get out of my way."

"Drink it," Tiro said, "and then I will tell you where they have taken her."

Marcus drank it.

"Ficulea," Tiro said. "A villa on the road, four hours north, with a wall and a gate. The domina has a man in the prefecture's clerks and he was told this morning. There are two guards and a woman, and the villa belongs to a freedman of the house of Corvus, and the order came from your father's steward and not from the prefect." He sat down on the bench opposite. "So now you know. And now I will tell you the other thing, which is that if you go out that door and up that road, you will be doing exactly what your father expects you to do."

Marcus looked at him.

"You know my father."

"I have been in this house seventeen years," Tiro said. "I know everyone."

"What does he expect me to do?"

"He expects you to go to Ficulea and make a scene at the gate, and be brought back, and be locked in your room until the Ides, and then married in the autumn." Tiro's scarred face was entirely without humour. "He is a man who arranges things. He has arranged this. He has put her somewhere he can produce her at the trial and somewhere you cannot get at her, and he has put a man on the road who

will bring you home, and he is sitting in his study at this moment thinking that he has been clever."

"Then what should I do?"

"Nothing," Tiro said. "For three days. And on the Ides you should be in the basilica, in the crowd, where six hundred men can see the son of the consul-designate standing behind the woman his father is trying to destroy."

Marcus stared at him.

"That is not—"

"It is not a poem," Tiro said. "It is not a boy and a girl on a boat. It is a trial in a basilica and a city that loves a scandal, and the only weapon either of you has is that there will be people watching." He stood up. "You are a Claudius. You have a name that opens doors and a face that men recognize and a father who cannot afford to be seen to be cruel to his own son in public. Use it. Stand in the crowd on the Ides and let them see you, and when the girl is brought in to give her evidence, look at her, and let every man in that room see that the son of the house believes her."

"And that will save her?"

"No," said Tiro. "It might save her. It will not save the domina, because nothing will save the domina, and she knows it. But it might save the girl, because a witness who is believed is worth more than a witness who is not, and a girl who has a Claudius standing behind her is a girl who will be believed by men who are afraid of your father." He picked up the cup. "That is what I would do. I am a freedman and a murderer and a thief, and I have made a mess of my own life, and you should not take my advice about anything. But that is what I would do."

Marcus sat in the kitchen for a long time after Tiro went out.

Then he went home.

His father was in the tablinum with the door open, writing, and he did not look up when Marcus came in.

"You have been to the Vicus Tuscus," he said.

"Yes."

"You were knocked down in the street by a man of my household."

"Yes."

"Sit down."

"I will stand."

Corvus put down the stylus.

"She is at Ficulea," he said. "She is well. There is a maid with her and two men at the gate and a physician in the village who has been told to attend her if she is ill. She will be brought to the basilica on the Ides, and she will give her evidence, and she will be treated with every courtesy, and after the trial she will go to her mother at Surrentum with a purse from me." He folded his hands. "I have not harmed her, and I will not harm her, and whatever you think of me, I would like you to know that."

"I think you are a coward," Marcus said.

"Perhaps."

"You have taken a girl out of her house in the morning with two men and a litter, in front of the whole street, and you have put her in a villa in the country, and you are telling me it is for her protection."

"It is for her protection."

"From whom?"

Corvus looked at him for a long moment.

"From me," he said. "From my mother. From the man who paid for the poison and the men who would like to see the whole thing finished before the emperor comes home. From Maro, who would put her on the hook if he thought he could get away with it. And from you, Marcus, and your boat at Ostia, and your two knives and your purse of gold, because if you had taken her out of that house on the Nones she would have been a runaway slave in the provinces with a price on her head, and the first magistrate who stopped you

would have been the end of it." He stood up. "I have done a great many things in my life that I am ashamed of. This is not one of them. This is the first thing I have done in a month that I can defend."

"Then let me see her."

"No."

"Let me send her a letter."

"No."

"Then I will go to Ficulea."

"You will not," Corvus said, "because I have given orders that you are not to leave this house until the Ides, and because there are two men at the gate, and because if you go over the wall they will bring you back, and it will be in the street, and it will be a scandal, and the scandal will be about you and not about her." He came around the table. "Three days, Marcus. That is all. Three days, and then the trial, and you may stand in the crowd and look at her as much as you like, and I will not stop you. After the trial she will be free and you will be married in the autumn and in ten years you will understand that I did the only thing that could be done."

Marcus looked at his father.

"I will never understand it," he said. "And I will never forgive you. And when you are consul, and when you are old, and when you are dying in that room upstairs, you will send for me and I will come, because I am your son and because I was raised to do my duty, and I will stand by your bed and I will not say the thing you want me to say."

He went out.

He went to his sister's room before the light went.

Caesia was sitting on the bed with her knees drawn up and a book open beside her, and she looked at him and said, "You are going to do something stupid."

"Yes."

"To Ficulea."

"Yes."

"Tonight."

"Yes."

She was quiet for a moment.

"Take me with you," she said.

"Caesia—"

"I mean it. I can ride. I can keep my mouth shut. I have four hundred sesterces of my own that grandmother gave me at the Saturnalia and a cloak and a good pair of boots, and if you go alone they will catch you at the gate before the second hour, and if there are two of us one of us can go round the back and make a noise and the other—"

"Caesia."

"I am fifteen years old," she said, "and in the spring I am going to be married to a man called Vinicius who has a nose like a shovel, and I have been in this house all my life and I have never done one thing that mattered." Her voice was shaking. "You are the only person in this family who has ever done a thing that mattered. Let me come."

Marcus sat down on the edge of the bed.

"If we go," he said, "and they catch us, they will not punish you, they will punish me, and they will do it by marrying you to somebody worse than Vinicius in a month. And if we are not caught, we will be in a fishing town in the provinces with no money and no name, and you will be the sister of a man who ran away with a singer, and no man will marry you at all." He took her hand. "I am not being noble. I am doing the sums. I have had a month in a room to do the sums."

Caesia looked at him.

"Is she worth it?" she said.

"I do not know what that means."

"Is she worth losing everything?"

Marcus sat with his sister's hand in his.

"I do not think it is a question of worth," he said. "I think a man is given a few moments in his life when he can be the person he actually is, and the rest of the time he is the person his family needs him to be. This is one of the moments. If I stay in this house and marry Vinicia Sabina and be a senator, I will be a good man and a correct one and I will think about this for the rest of my life." He let go of her hand. "I would rather be a fool in a fishing town."

Caesia wiped her face with the back of her wrist.

"You are a fool," she said.

"Yes."

"You are a better fool than anyone in this house." She got up and opened the chest and took out a purse and put it in his hand. "Four hundred sesterces. Take it."

"Caesia—"

"Take it, or I will throw it out of the window." She closed his fingers on it. "And when you are in the fishing town, send me word. Not to the house; to the wife of the bookseller in the Argiletum, her name is Vibia and she is a client of grandmother's and she is the only person in this city who can keep her mouth shut."

Marcus put the purse in his tunic.

"Thank you," he said.

"Go," said Caesia. "Go now, before I decide to be sensible."

He spent the afternoon in his room. He ate nothing. At the ninth hour he heard the house settle for the night: the slaves banking the fires, the doors being barred, his grandmother's step on the stairs, his father's voice in the tablinum.

At the second hour of the night he went out of the window onto the roof.

It was easy. He had done it as a boy, and he knew every tile. He went along the ridge and down over the wall by the fig tree and dropped into the street, and the two men at the gate did not see him because they were watching the gate.

He walked north.

He walked all night, along the Via Nomentana, past the tombs and the villas and the dark fields, and the moon went down and the road was black and the only sound was his own feet. He was twenty years old and he had been in the army and he had walked further than this in worse country, and he did not stop.

At dawn he came to Ficulea.

The villa was a low white building with a wall around it and a cypress at the gate and a boy sitting on the wall with a stick. Marcus stood in the road and looked at it, and the road was beginning to fill with carts, and a woman went by with a basket of eggs, and the sun came up over the hill behind the house.

There was a window on the second floor with a shutter open.

She was standing at it.

She saw him. He saw her see him. She did not wave; she put her hand flat on the shutter, and he put his hand flat on the air, and they stood like that for perhaps ten heartbeats.

Then a man came around the corner of the wall and saw him and shouted.

There were three of them by the time he reached the gate, and they were not gentle, and he did not fight back, because there was no point, and because he had seen her, and because in the whole of that night and that morning the only thing that had been in his head was the shape of her hand on the shutter.

They took him inside the wall.

The villa belonged to a freedman called Primus, who had been the steward of the house of the Claudii Corvi before Faustus and had retired to Ficulea with his savings and a garden and a wife who did not like him. He was sixty years old and he did not want to be in the middle of a scandal, and he stood in the yard with his hands folded and said, "Dominus, I am sorry, I did not know who it was," four times, while the two men held Marcus by the arms.

"Let me see her," Marcus said.

"I have my orders."

"Let me see her for one minute and I will go quietly and I will tell my father that you were civil."

Primus looked at the ground.

"There is a girl in the house who is to be sent to her mother," he said. "That is what I was told. That is all I was told. I have a wife and a garden and I have not been in Rome in four years." He looked up, and he was not an unkind man, and his eyes were unhappy. "Dominus, if I let you in, they will say I let you in, and I will lose the villa, and I am sixty years old."

Marcus stopped struggling.

"All right," he said.

They let go of him.

He stood in the yard and looked up at the house, and the shutter on the second floor was open, and Leda was standing at it with her hands on the sill.

She had been crying. He could see it from the yard. She had a shawl around her shoulders and her hair was down her back and she looked, in the morning light, like a girl in a painting of something very sad.

She said something that he could not hear.

"What?" he called.

She said it again, and he still could not hear it, and then the maid came and put her hand on her arm and drew her back from the window, and the shutter closed.

Primus's wife brought him water.

She was a thin woman with a hard mouth, and she brought it in a cup and stood over him while he drank it, and she said, "She is a nice girl. She has been no trouble. She cried all night and she would not eat, and this morning she asked me to send for a priest." She took the cup. "If you are the reason she has been crying, you should be

ashamed of yourself, and if you are not, you should go home and leave her alone, because there is nothing you can do for her in a yard."

"I love her," Marcus said.

The woman looked at him.

"I loved a man once," she said. "He was a porter. He died of a fever in the winter and I married Primus in the spring, and I have been warm and fed for thirty years, and I still think about the porter." She turned away. "That is what love is worth in this world, dominus. It is worth a warm memory in a good marriage. Do not make it into a boat."

They put him on a horse and took him back to Rome.

One of the men was called Severus and he had been in the fleet and he talked the whole way, because a man who is riding four hours with a prisoner talks or he thinks.

"You are the son," he said.

"I am."

"Your father is a hard man."

"Yes."

"I was in the house at Ostia for a year, on the door, and I saw him twice." Severus shifted in the saddle. "He came down about a cargo and the steward had made a mistake in the manifest and your father had him up against the wall in the yard, not with his hands, with his voice, and the man was crying by the end of it. And then your father went out and got into the litter and I heard him say to the man beside him: *see that he has a good dinner.*" He spat over the horse's neck. "That is the thing about the great houses. They will break a man in the morning and feed him in the evening and think no more about it, and the man thinks about it for the rest of his life."

Marcus did not answer.

"Your girl," Severus said. "The singer."

"Yes."

"She is all right. I have seen her twice and she has a maid and the maid is a decent woman and the food is good." He looked at Marcus. "I am not supposed to tell you that. I am supposed to keep my mouth shut and take my pay. But I have a daughter of my own in Ostia and if a man was holding her in a villa in the country I would want to know that the food was good."

They rode on.

The sun came up over the hills and the road filled with carts and the dust came up, and Marcus rode with his hands tied to the saddle and his eye closing and the taste of blood in his mouth, and he thought about a boat, and about a warm memory in a good marriage, and about the fact that he had done everything a man could do and it had not been enough, and that this was the first time in his life that he had discovered that there were things a man could not do.

They came into Rome at the sixth hour.

His father was waiting in the atrium.

Marcus came in with his lip split and his eye closing and dust on his cloak, and Corvus stood by the impluvium with his hands behind his back and looked at him for a long moment.

"Did you see her?" he asked.

"Yes."

"Was she well?"

"Yes."

Corvus nodded slowly.

"Go to your room," he said. "You will be let out on the Ides."

Marcus went up the stairs.

At the top he stopped and looked down at his father standing in the atrium of the house of the Claudii Corvi, in the light from the impluvium, with the painted gods in the corner and the four hundred years of ancestors in their cupboards on the wall.

"You should have let me go," he said. "You should have let me take her and go, and you should have told my grandmother that I

was dead, and you should have been consul and had your statues and your name on a bench in the Forum. It would have been a better life for everyone."

Marcus stopped with his hand on the door.

"There is a thing I want to say to you," he said, "and I am going to say it now, because in the autumn I will be on a ship and you will be consul and we will never say anything to each other again."

"Say it."

"You were a better man than your father," Marcus said. "That is the whole of it. You were a better man than him and you have spent your whole life afraid that you were not, and it has made you cruel in a way that he never was, because he did not care and you do." He opened the door. "I would rather have had a father who did not care."

"It would not," said Corvus. "But you are young, and you will not know that for twenty years, and by then it will not matter."

Marcus went into his room and shut the door.

PART FOUR

THE BASILICA

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Antonia

She woke in the dark in a room above a fuller's shop in the Subura, with the smell of the vats coming up through the floor.

The room had one window and a bed and a chest and a lamp, and she had been in it for nine days. It belonged to a woman called Marcella who had been a laundress and was now too old to work and who had taken in Antonia and the women for nothing, because, she said, a woman who has been in the Subura does not forget the Subura.

Prisca was already awake. She had laid out the white stola the night before and had sponged the hem and hung it to dry, and there was a bowl of water on the chest and a comb and the two pearls.

"Domina."

"I am awake."

"You are not. You have not opened your eyes."

Antonia opened her eyes.

"Nine days," she said.

"Nine days."

"It feels like a year."

"It feels like nine days," said Prisca, "and you have eaten almost nothing and you have not slept more than three hours in any of them, and today you are going to stand in a basilica in front of six hundred men who have come to watch you hang." She put the bowl down. "So you are going to eat a piece of bread, and you are going to let me do your hair, and you are going to put on the pearls, and you are not going to say anything clever to the prefect, because men like the prefect hate a clever woman in a courtroom."

"I have nothing clever left to say."

"Good."

Antonia sat up.

The room was grey and cold and the window showed the top of the wall opposite and a slice of sky. Below, in the street, a man was shouting at a donkey.

"The girl is at Ficulea," Prisca said.

"I know."

"He will bring her this morning."

"I know."

"And the cook—"

"I know."

Prisca combed her hair and bound it up the way a matron's is bound, and put the two pearls in her ears, and stood back and looked at her.

"You look like a woman who is going to a trial," she said.

"I am going to a trial."

"You look like my aunt," said Prisca. "She was a hard woman and she buried three children and she never once cried in front of anybody."

Antonia stood up.

They went out at the second hour.

The street was full. The whole of the Subura knew by then, and the shopkeepers had come out to their doorways and the women

were on the balconies, and when she came out of the door of the fuller's shop with Prisca and Meroe and Junilla behind her there was a noise that went up the street like a wind through a field.

She walked.

They came down the Argiletum and along the Sacred Way, and by the time they reached the Forum there were people in front of them and behind them and along the steps of the basilicas, and a man on the roof of the portico of Gaius and Lucius was calling out the odds to a crowd below him, four to one against an acquittal, seven to one against her leaving the city alive.

Antonia walked through them with her head up.

She heard the words. She heard all of them: *whore, poisoner, that is her, that is the one, she does not look like much, my cousin says she has a box of names, my cousin says she bought the cook's silence with a house, look at her hands, look at her hands, she has never done a day's work in her life—*

She had done nothing but work for twenty-six years. She had got up before light every morning since she was fourteen years old. She had counted and saved and carried and smiled and remembered and been afraid, and there had not been a single day in twenty-six years when she had not been working, and the man on the roof of the portico had never worked at anything in his life except finding out which way a crowd was going.

She stopped at the foot of the steps of the Basilica Julia.

"Domina," said Prisca. "You are shaking."

"I know."

"Look at me." Prisca turned her around by the shoulders. "You are Antonia Cassia. You built a house out of nothing in a city that eats women, and you have fed and housed eleven people for seventeen years, and you are the only woman in Rome who has ever made a senator pay interest." She gripped her arms. "When you go in there, do not look at the gallery and do not look at the prefect and do not

look at the man on the Palatine. Look at the back wall, above their heads, and say what you have to say to the wall."

Antonia looked at her.

"When did you become the brave one?" she said.

"About nine days ago," said Prisca. "It was either that or weep, and there was nobody else to do it."

Antonia went up the steps.

They tried her in the Basilica Julia, in the great central hall, because the prefect's court could not hold the crowd.

The basilica was a hundred and eighty feet long and a hundred and seventy wide and had four aisles and a gallery, and on the morning of the Ides it was full by the second hour. Men had begun arriving before dawn. The advocates had their places on the steps; the clerks had their tables at the side; the money-changers had been moved out into the portico and were doing a fine trade in bets. In the gallery the women of good family sat with their slaves and their fans, and there was a great deal of noise and a smell of hot wool and garlic and the dust that rose off the floor when six hundred people shuffled their feet.

Pedo sat on a raised platform at the eastern end with the panel on either side of him. Maro sat at his right with his tablets. On his left there was an empty chair where Corvus had sat, and Corvus was in the body of the court, in the third row of the senatorial benches, with his hands on his knees.

Antonia came in at the third hour.

She came on foot, from the Vicus Tuscus, with Tiro on one side and Prisca on the other and Meroe and Junilla behind her, and the crowd in the street outside the basilica parted for them and then closed behind them and came in after them. She wore a plain white stola, no jewellery but the two pearls, and her hair bound up like a matron's, and she walked up the central aisle with her head up and

her eyes on the platform, and she did not look at the people on either side.

She heard them. That was the thing nobody tells you: that you hear them. *That is her. That is the one. She does not look like a murderer. She looks like my aunt. Look at her hands. They say she has a box of names. They say the consul-designate—*

She stopped at the mark on the floor.

"Antonia Cassia," said Pedo. "You are charged with the murder of Gaius Vettius Proculus, consular, by poison, in your house on the Vicus Tuscus, on the sixth day before the Kalends of June; and with keeping a house of ill repute contrary to the peace of the city; and with the corruption of the morals of the young. How do you plead?"

"I plead not guilty to the murder," Antonia said. "I plead guilty to the house, because it is mine, and I have kept it for seventeen years, and I have paid the tax on it, and I have never made a secret of it to anyone who asked."

There was a ripple of laughter in the gallery.

"The plea is noted," said Pedo. "Maro. Begin."

Maro began.

He was a good speaker, which Antonia had not expected. He was not clever and he was not subtle, but he had a way of laying out a thing in order that made the order itself seem like proof, and he had a voice that carried to the back of the hall without effort.

He began with the dead man.

He described Vettius: consul, senator, soldier, a man of the old school, a widower, a father, a man of sixty-one who had gone to a house on the Vicus Tuscus to be entertained and had died there among strangers. He described the banquet in detail: the nine guests, the wine, the singing. He described the cup.

"The cup," he said, "was the dead man's own. He brought it with him. He had a stomach that had made war on him and he did not drink from the cups of other men. Think about that, fathers.

Think about a man who has come to the end of his life and has learned to be careful, who brings his own cup to a dinner because he is afraid of being poisoned." He turned slowly. "And think about a house in which a man may be poisoned in his own cup, at the table of the woman who owns it, with nine witnesses and not one of them able to say who did it."

He called Sarpedon.

The physician was sober this time, and frightened, and he gave his evidence in a low voice and Maro made him repeat it twice. The discolouration. The foam. The absence of any disease of the heart. The impossibility of examining the stomach, because the body had been burned on the fifth day, according to the custom.

"Who ordered the body burned?" Maro asked.

"The family," said Sarpedon.

"Did the panel order it?"

"The family took the body. It is the custom."

"It is the custom," Maro said, "and it is also a very convenient custom for a woman who wishes the evidence to be in a jar on the Via Flaminia."

He called the clerk who had taken the cup.

He called the man who had carried the bier.

He called, at the fifth hour, the clerk of the cells, who read out the confession of Calybe.

The hall went quiet for that.

The clerk read it in the flat voice of a man reading a list of goods, and when he came to the end of it there was a sound from the gallery that was not quite a sigh and not quite a groan.

"The cook will be produced," said Maro.

They brought her in.

Antonia had prepared herself for it. She had lain awake for three nights preparing herself for it, and she had told herself that Calybe

would be alive and would be broken and that it would be a terrible thing and that she must not weep. She was not prepared at all.

Calybe came in between two guards with her arms held and her feet dragging, and she was a different woman. She was grey. Her face had a slackness in it, and one of her eyes did not track, and her hands were bound in cloth, and she walked the way very old women walk, in little steps, and she was forty-four years old.

She did not look at Antonia.

"Calybe," said Pedo. "You are the slave of Antonia Cassia, a cook. You have confessed to putting poison in the cup of Gaius Vettius Proculus at your mistress's order. Is that confession true?"

Calybe stood in the middle of the floor and said nothing.

"Answer the prefect," said Maro.

"It is true," said Calybe.

"Say it in your own words."

"My mistress gave me a packet." Her voice was slow and there were gaps in it. "White powder. She said to put it in the cup. The old man's cup. I said I did not want to. She said—" she stopped, and her mouth worked. "She said a slave who will not do as she is told is a slave who is sold to the mines."

"Did you put it in the cup?"

"I put it in the cup."

"Where?"

"In the passage. Behind the dining room. Before the second course."

"Did anyone see you?"

"A man of the house saw me."

"Who?"

"I do not know his name."

"Was it the singer? The girl called Leda?"

Calybe's head came up, and for the first time she looked at Antonia, and Antonia saw in her face something that was almost a smile.

"No," she said. "It was not the girl."

Maro's stylus stopped.

"You said in your confession that a man of the house saw you and said nothing."

"I said a man of the house. It was not the girl. It was a man." Calybe's voice was firmer now. "It was not the girl and it was not the steward and it was not the boy. It was a man I did not know. I do not know his name. I do not know whose man he was." She turned her head, slowly, and looked at the crowd, and her voice went up. "It was not her. She never gave me anything. She never gave me anything in her life but a good kitchen and a bad temper and a place to sleep—"

The guards took her by the arms.

"Withdraw the witness," said Maro.

"The witness has not finished," said Pedo.

"The witness is raving. She was examined under the hook four days ago and she has been raving since. She has said three different things in three days. I have the clerk's record here—"

"Sit down, Maro," said Pedo.

There was a silence. Maro sat down.

Pedo looked at Calybe for a long moment.

"You have said that you put the powder in the cup at your mistress's order," he said. "And now you say that she never gave you anything. Which is true?"

Calybe stood in the middle of the floor with the guards holding her arms.

"I do not know," she said. "I do not know what is true any more. I have been in a room for four days and there was a man with a hook and he asked me the same question over and over and after a while I could not tell what I remembered and what he wanted me to remember, and I said what he wanted, and he wrote it down." She began to cry. "I have been a cook in that house for eleven years and I have never put anything in a cup but wine."

They took her out.

The hall was very quiet.

Antonia stood at the mark on the floor and her hands were shaking, and she put them behind her back.

"The court will adjourn for an hour," said Pedo.

In the recess they put her in a small room off the portico with a guard at the door and Tiro and Prisca inside, and Antonia sat on a bench and drank water and could not stop shaking.

"She did not do it," Prisca said. "She did not do it, domina, she has never—"

"I know."

"Then why did she say it?"

"Because a man put a hook in her and asked her the same question for four days." Antonia put the cup down. "And because for the first three days she said nothing, and on the fourth day she would have said anything to make him stop, and then they wrote it down and read it out in a basilica and six hundred people heard it."

"What will happen?"

"I do not know." Antonia looked at the wall. "Maro will say that she is raving because the hook has addled her, and the panel will believe him, because it is convenient, and because a confession that is withdrawn is worse than no confession at all. Or he will say that her second statement proves she is unreliable and her first statement is the true one, and the panel will believe that instead, because it is also convenient." She stood up. "Either way the room has heard a woman say that I put poison in a cup."

She went out into the portico. The crowd in the Forum was enormous; the trial had emptied the shops and the workshops, and there were people standing on the steps of the temple of Castor and on the roof of the portico opposite. She could hear them, a low continuous roar, like the sea.

Blandus was waiting for her by the column.

"You did well," he said.

"I did nothing."

"You stood there." He was pale and he had been drinking. "I have been in the Senate nineteen years and I have never seen a woman stand there."

"You said you would stand up."

"I will." He looked at the crowd. "When?"

"When they ask if anyone in Rome can speak for my character."

Blandus nodded slowly.

"Antonia," he said. "My wife has left the city. She has gone to her sister at Tusculum and she has taken the boys. She told me this morning that if I stand up in that basilica and speak for a brothelkeeper I am not to come home." He looked at her. "I am going to stand up."

"Blandus—"

"I am fifty years old," he said, "and I have done nothing in my life but be charming and in debt. And you gave me back sixty thousand sesterces because I asked you at a kitchen door, and you did not make me crawl for it, and you did not tell anyone." He straightened his toga. "I am going to stand up, and my wife will go to Tusculum, and in ten years I will be a man who was ruined by his principles, which is a better thing to be than a man who was never ruined by anything."

In the recess they gave her bread and she could not eat it.

She sat in the small room off the portico with the guard at the door and the noise of the Forum coming through the wall, and she thought about Calybe in the middle of the floor with her hands wrapped in cloth, and about the fact that the confession had been read out and six hundred people had heard it, and that in the whole of that hall there had been perhaps nine men who understood that a confession taken on a hook is not a confession but a sound.

Marcus was in the hall. She had seen him at the back, by the door, with his hood down; the son of the man who was trying her, standing at the back of the crowd like a client.

She had looked at him for a moment and he had looked back and neither of them had moved.

That was the thing she would remember about the first day, more than Maro or the cook or the crowd: a boy of twenty standing at the back of a basilica with his hands at his sides.

The court resumed at the eighth hour.

Maro rose and said that he had finished with the witnesses of fact, and that the panel would hear the evidence of the household, and that he would call, first, the singer.

There was a stir in the hall.

"The singer is not in the city," said Pedo. "She is in the custody of the prefecture at Ficulea and will be produced tomorrow morning."

"Then I will call the steward of the house," said Maro.

Tiro stood up.

He was fifty-two years old and had a scar from his ear to his mouth and had killed nine men in an arena, and he walked to the mark on the floor and stood on it with his hands at his sides.

"Your name."

"Tiro. Freedman of Antonia Cassia."

"Your trade."

"Steward."

"You found the body of the man Callistus in the Tiber."

"I did not."

"You reported it to your mistress."

"I reported a man dead in an alley."

"You killed him."

Tiro did not move.

"I did," he said.

The hall made a noise.

"You admit it."

"I killed him. He had a hand in the death of a boy of twelve in my house. I found him in an alley by the fourth shed and I put a knife in him." Tiro's voice was flat. "I am not sorry and I will not pretend to be. If the panel wishes to try me for it, I will stand here and be tried for it. But I will tell you what I found on him first."

Pedo leaned forward.

"What did you find on him?"

"A token with a name on it, and a note in a bad hand."

"What did the note say?"

"I cannot read," said Tiro. "I gave it to my mistress."

Every head in the basilica turned to Antonia.

Pedo sat back.

"Domina," he said. "Do you have this note?"

"Yes."

"Will you produce it?"

Antonia looked at Maro, and at Pedo, and at the crowd in the gallery, and at Corvus in the third row of the senatorial benches, who was sitting very still with his hands on his knees.

"Not yet," she said.

There was a murmur.

"Domina," said Pedo. "You are on trial for your life. If you have a document that bears on this case, you will produce it now."

"I will produce it when the man whose household it names is in this room and can answer for it." Antonia's voice carried. "The note is in the hand of a steward. It says: *the old man first.* I will produce it, and I will name the steward, when the panel is ready to hear the name, and not before."

"You do not get to decide when the panel is ready," said Maro.

"No," Antonia said. "But I have been in this city for forty years, and I have learned that a thing said at the wrong moment is a thing

that can be denied, and a thing said at the right moment is a thing that cannot."

Pedo looked at her for a long time.

"The court will adjourn," he said, "until the second hour tomorrow. The witness from Ficulea will be produced. The domina will bring the note. And I will have order in this basilica, and if there is one more outbreak I will clear it and try the case in a closed room, and the city may say what it likes." He stood up. "Take her to the cells."

They took her to the cells.

It was a room under the basilica, with a stone floor and a barred window at the height of a man's chest, and a bench, and a bucket, and a lamp that was not lit. There was a smell of damp and of the river, and through the wall she could hear men talking and a man singing, very badly and very far away.

Antonia sat on the bench in the dark.

She thought about Calybe in the middle of the floor with her hands bound in cloth, and about the fact that a woman she had known for eleven years had been broken in a room with a hook, and that the breaking had been done lawfully, by men with a warrant, in the name of the city.

She thought about the trial. She had thought, in the months before it, that she would be frightened. She was not frightened. She was angry, in a way that was so large and so cold that it had stopped being a feeling and become a place she could live in.

She thought about Tiro, who had sold her and had stood up in a basilica and confessed to a murder to put the panel off its stride, and who had done it, she understood, as a man pays a debt.

She thought about the boy on the Esquiline.

At some hour of the night she heard the bolt go back.

The guard came in with a lamp and set it on the bench and went out, and a man came in and stood in the doorway with his hands behind his back.

It was Corvus.

"You should not be here," Antonia said.

"I know."

"If Maro hears of it he will say that the panel is corrupt."

"Maro is asleep," Corvus said, "and the guard has been paid by my steward, which is a thing I have never done before and will not do again." He came into the room. "I have come to tell you that the girl will be produced tomorrow, and that she will give her evidence, and that she has been treated well."

"I know. You told me."

"I have come to tell you the other thing." He stood in front of her. "My steward is going to be named tomorrow. You will produce the note, and Maro will read it out, and the panel will send for Faustus, and Faustus will be arrested, and he will be examined. He is a freedman and he can be examined, and he will be examined, because a freedman who is accused of murdering a consular is not protected by anything at all."

"Yes."

"And when he is examined," Corvus said, "he will say that he did it for me."

Antonia looked up at him.

"Will he be lying?"

"Yes." Corvus's voice was quiet. "He will be lying, and he will believe it, and there is nothing I can do about it, because in twenty years I never once told him not to." He sat down on the bench, at the other end, with his hands on his knees. "I have spent the whole evening thinking about what I will do tomorrow, and I have found that there is only one thing that will save my family, and it is a thing that will

destroy you, and I have come here to tell you to your face that I am going to do it."

"What is it?"

"The letter," Corvus said.

Antonia did not move.

"The letter I wrote you seventeen years ago, which Faustus took from your steward at the shrine of the crossroads. It is in my study. It says: *take the purse and go, say nothing, and you will never see my face again; say one word and I will see you dead.*" He looked at her. "Tomorrow, when you produce your note, I will produce my letter. I will read it out in the basilica, and I will say that it was written to a slave who had stolen from my father's house and who was sent away with a purse for the sake of the family's name, and that she has been silent for seventeen years because she was paid to be silent. And every man in that room will believe it, because it is in my hand and because I am the consul-designate and because you are a brothel-keeper, and the note about the steward will become a thing that a guilty woman produced to save herself."

Antonia looked at him for a long time.

"You will destroy the only evidence that might have saved you," she said, "to destroy me."

"Yes."

"And your steward will still be arrested."

"Faustus will be arrested and he will be convicted and he will be sent to the mines or crucified, and the city will be satisfied that the poisoner has been found, and the woman who kept the house will be acquitted of the murder and convicted of the rest, and the case will be closed." Corvus's voice was very flat. "And I will be consul in the spring, and my son will marry, and my daughter will marry, and my mother will die in her bed, and the name of the Claudii Corvi will survive. That is what I have decided. I have spent the whole night de-

ciding it and I have not slept, and I am not proud of it, and I am going to do it."

Antonia stood up.

"Then I will tell you what I am going to do," she said. "Tomorrow, when you read out your letter, I will tell them what happened in the shrine."

"You have no proof."

"I have the stylus," Antonia said.

Corvus's head came up.

"You have no stylus. You never had it; I took it from the altar."

"I have a stylus," Antonia said. "It is bronze, and it is worn smooth at the end, and it is the one you gave me when I was seventeen, in the little room by the stairs, when you taught me to write my name. It is in a box in my strongbox, and tomorrow, when you have finished reading your letter, I will hold it up in that basilica and I will say: *this is the pen that killed your father, consul-designate, and you have the other one in a box in your study.*" She smiled at him. "It is not proof. It is a thing. And a thing held up in a basilica in front of six hundred men is worth more than proof, and you know it, because you have spent your whole life in rooms where things were held up."

Corvus stared at her.

"It will destroy us both," he said.

"Yes," said Antonia. "I told you that in the shrine. You did not believe me."

He stood up. He went to the door and stood with his hand on it, and the lamplight was on the side of his face, and he looked, for a moment, like the boy she had known in the little room by the stairs.

"I did not want any of this," he said.

"I know."

"I wanted to be a good man."

"You wanted to be thought a good man," Antonia said. "It is not the same, and the difference is the whole of your life."

He went out.

The bolt went home. The lamp burned on the bench, and Antonia sat in the cell under the basilica and listened to the man singing through the wall, and after a while she found that she was crying, and she did not know whether it was for herself or for the boy in the little room by the stairs or for the girl who had been sold at fourteen and had believed, for a little while, that a man with a kind face would open a door.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Corvus

◆

He woke before light, and for a moment he did not know where he was.

The house was quiet in a way that it had never been quiet. There were no slaves in the corridor and no smell of bread from the kitchen; the cook had gone nine days before and the boy who had taken her place made a fire at the sixth hour and burned the porridge. The atrium, when he went down, was full of grey light and dust, and the impluvium had a skin on it, and there was a dead moth floating in the middle of the skin.

The boy who carried the water was asleep on the bench by the door with a blanket over his head.

Corvus stood over him for a moment.

He was eleven years old and he had been left behind when the others went, because nobody had told him to go, and he had been sleeping on that bench for nine days and eating whatever the boy in the kitchen gave him.

"Boy."

The boy woke up and scrambled to his feet.

"Dominus."

"Go to the kitchen and get something to eat and then go home to your mother."

"I have no mother, dominus."

"Then go to whoever you have."

The boy looked at him.

"I have a sister," he said. "In the Subura. She is married to a cooper."

"Then go to her, and tell her that you have been discharged from this house with your peculium, and that you are to say nothing about anything you have seen in it." Corvus took a coin from his purse and gave it to him. "And take this and do not tell her where it came from."

The boy took the coin and looked at it and then at him, and his face was the face of a child who has been in a great house long enough to know that a gift from a master is not always a gift.

"Dominus," he said. "Is the house going to be sold?"

"Yes."

"Will the new man want a water boy?"

"I don't know."

"Because I am good at it," the boy said. "I get up early and I do not spill."

Corvus looked at him.

"I will write you a letter," he said.

He went into the tablinum and wrote the boy a letter of recommendation, in his best hand, on the good paper, and sealed it, and gave it to him, and the boy went out through the door with the letter in his hand and did not look back.

It was the last official act of his life as a man of affairs, and it was for a water boy whose name he did not know.

His mother was in the atrium when he came back out.

She was dressed for the Forum, in a dark stola with her hair bound, and she had the box in her hands.

"You are going," she said.

"I am going."

"You will sit in the body of the court and say nothing."

"I will sit in the body of the court and I will say nothing unless I am asked."

"Gaius." She came toward him. "It is not too late. The letter is in your sleeve. Burn it in the brazier and go to the prefect this morning and tell him that you have nothing to add and that the panel should finish the case. The girl will give her evidence, and the cook has confessed, and the woman will be convicted, and it will be over by the Ides. You will not be consul, but you will not be—" she stopped.

"I will not be what?"

"You will not be the man who stood up in a basilica and destroyed a woman to save himself."

Corvus looked at her.

"That is exactly what I will be," he said, "whether I stand up or not. The only difference is whether the city knows it."

He went out.

The walk down the Palatine to the Forum took a quarter of an hour and he did it on foot with no lictor and no slave, and the streets were full of people going the same way. Nobody spoke to him. A man selling water from a cart looked at him and then looked at the ground.

He came into the Forum at the second hour and stood at the foot of the steps of the Basilica Julia.

The crowd was already there: the whole square, the steps of the temple of Castor, the roof of the portico of Gaius and Lucius, the windows of the shops along the Argiletum. A man was calling out the odds. Somewhere a woman was selling pies out of a basket, and her voice went up over the noise, flat and cheerful, *hot, hot, two for an as,* and it was the most obscene thing he had ever heard.

He went up the steps.

At the door he stopped and took the letter out of his sleeve.

It was folded twice and sealed with his own seal, and it had been written seventeen years before in the room at the top of the house, at his father's table, with a pen that was not his father's. He had read it perhaps six times in seventeen years. He knew it by heart.

Take the purse and go. Say nothing, and you will never see my face again. Say one word, and I will see you dead.

He turned it over in his hands.

There was a brazier by the door, for the clerks, and it was burning.

He stood in front of it for a long moment with the letter in his hand, and the crowd went on shouting behind him, and a lictor pushed past him and said, "Dominus, you cannot stand in the doorway."

Corvus put the letter back in his sleeve.

The hall filled in front of him.

They came in by the doors at the west end and stood in the aisles and along the walls and in the galleries, and by the second hour there were more people in the Basilica Julia than Corvus had ever seen under one roof, and he had been in the Circus Maximus on the day of the games.

He picked out faces. Blandus, in the second row of the senatorial benches, with his toga crooked and his eyes red. Hostilius, at the back, sweating. Eutychus, standing in the aisle with two of his clerks and a tablet, looking like a man at an auction. Vipsania Marcella in the women's gallery with a fan, and her husband beside her, and neither of them looking at anything.

And at the very back, by the door, in a plain tunic with his hood down and his arms folded, Marcus.

Corvus looked at his son for a long moment.

He came, he thought. *He came, and he is standing at the back where they can see him, and when the girl comes in he will look at her, and six hundred men will see a Claudius stand behind a singer.*

He turned his head and looked at the platform, at Pedo's empty chair, at the cut-away frieze, at the mosaic of the hunting scene with most of the animals missing.

The letter was against his ribs, and it weighed nothing at all, and he had never in his life carried anything so heavy.

He thought about the fact that in an hour he would either read it out or he would not, and that whichever he did, there would be no third thing.

He thought about his father, who had made every decision of his life in a room with a door, and had never once been in a basilica in his life without knowing exactly what he was going to say.

He went in and sat in the third row of the senatorial benches with the letter against his ribs, and he waited for the second hour.

The basilica was fuller than it had been the day before. There were men standing in the aisles and along the walls and in the galleries, and the women in the upper gallery had brought cushions and food, and there was a holiday air in the hall that turned his stomach. A man behind him was eating nuts. Somewhere on the far side a child was crying, and a woman was telling it to be quiet, and the child would not be quiet.

He had not slept.

He had lain on his bed in the room at the top of the house with the letter on the table beside him, and had listened to the city, and at some hour before light he had got up and gone to the window and looked out at the black shape of the Palatine and the temple of Apollo and the lights of the city below, and had thought about the fact that in nineteen years he had never once been unable to decide a thing by the morning.

At dawn his mother came to the door with a cup of water and did not speak, and he took it and drank it and gave it back, and she went away.

Marcus was in the atrium when he came down.

He had been let out of his room that morning, because there was no longer any point in keeping him in it, and he was standing by the impluvium in a clean tunic with his hands at his sides, and he was thin and there was a fading bruise on his cheekbone, and he looked at his father the way a man looks at a stranger across a room.

"I am coming to the basilica," he said.

"No."

"I am coming to the basilica," Marcus said, "and I am going to stand in the crowd where six hundred men can see me, and when the girl is brought in to give her evidence I am going to look at her, and I am going to let every man in that room see that the son of the house believes her." He did not raise his voice. "Tiro told me to do it. He said it was the only thing I could do that would help and the only thing you could not prevent."

Corvus looked at his son.

"Tiro is a murderer and a thief," he said.

"Yes," said Marcus. "He is also the only man in this house who has ever told me the truth."

They walked down the hill together, in silence, with two of the household behind them and no lictor, and the crowd in the Forum made way for them, and Corvus heard the whispering start and go along the front of the basilica like wind through wheat.

At the door Marcus stopped.

"I will sit at the back," he said.

"Marcus."

His son turned.

"Whatever happens today," Corvus said, "I want you to know that I have loved you since the hour you were born, and that I have

never been able to say it, and that I am saying it now because there may not be another time."

Marcus looked at him.

"That is the first true thing you have said to me in twenty years," he said, "and it is too late, and I am sorry for both of us."

He went in.

At the second hour they brought in the girl.

She came up the aisle between two clerks, and she had been washed and dressed in a good grey stola and her hair was bound up, and she walked like a woman going to a wedding she did not want. She did not look at Corvus. She did not look at anyone. She stood on the mark and put her hands in front of her.

"The witness Leda," said Pedo. "The panel has before it the petition of Vibia Prima of Surrentum, the record of the dealer Nymphodorus of Puteoli, and the testimony of the household. The panel finds that the witness is free-born and that she is not subject to examination. She will give her evidence as a free woman."

There was a stir in the hall, and then a silence, and Corvus found that he had been holding his breath.

"Tell us what you saw," said Pedo.

She told it.

She told it in the same words she had used in the study and before the panel, and she told it slowly, so that every man in the hall could hear it, and when she came to the end she stopped and stood with her hands in front of her.

Maro rose.

"You say you saw a man in the passage with a cup. You did not see his face."

"I did not."

"You did not see his face, and you did not see the powder, and you did not see him put anything into the cup, and you cannot say that the cup he carried was the cup that the dead man drank from."

"No."

"Then what did you see?"

"I saw a man in a passage with a cup," Leda said, "and the next morning the old man was dead, and I have thought about it every night since."

"That is not evidence. That is a girl's nightmare."

"It is what I saw."

Maro turned to the panel with his hands spread. "Fathers, this is the whole of the case for the woman's innocence. A girl who cannot describe a face, a man who may have been a servant carrying a cup to a guest, and a mark on a wrist that she remembered a month after the event and only when she had been in the house of the consul-designate for a day."

Corvus's hands closed on his knees.

"There was a mark," Leda said.

"There was a mark which you did not mention to the prefect's clerk, or to the panel, or to anyone, until you had spent a day in the house of Gaius Claudius Corvus, who is sitting in the third row and whose steward has a house mark in the shape of an eight on the door of his house." Maro's voice was loud and reasonable. "Fathers, I do not say that the girl is lying. I say that she has been in a great house, and that she has been told a story, and that she has come to believe it. It is a thing that happens to witnesses. It is the reason the law does not accept a slave's evidence without examination, and it is the reason I asked that this girl be examined, and the prefect in his mercy has declined."

"I was not told a story," Leda said. "I saw the mark."

"Where?"

"On his wrist. On the inside, when he lifted his hand to the curtain."

"Which wrist?"

"The left."

"Which hand held the cup?"

The girl was silent.

"Which hand held the cup?" Maro said again, and his voice was almost gentle. "You have thought about it every night for a month. You have seen it in your sleep. Which hand held the cup?"

"The right," Leda said.

"Then he lifted the cup with his right hand and he pushed the curtain with his left, and the mark was on the inside of the left wrist." Maro turned to the panel. "It is possible. It is entirely possible. But it is also possible that a girl who has been coached has been coached a little too well, and has been given a story with a mark in it, and has not been given the whole of the story, and I would ask the panel to consider which is more likely."

Pedo looked at him for a moment.

"Does the panel have any other evidence of the mark?"

"I have," said Antonia.

She was standing at the mark on the floor with her hands at her sides, and she had not been invited to speak, and the whole hall turned.

"Domina," said Pedo. "You will speak when you are asked."

"I will speak when I am asked," said Antonia, "and I will ask the panel to ask me now, because I have a note in my sleeve which names the man with the mark, and because if it is not read out in this hall today it will be read out in a closed room in a month and the city will say that the panel had something to hide."

Pedo sat back.

"Produce the note."

Antonia produced it.

The clerk took it and carried it up to the platform, and Pedo read it, and his face did not change, and then he handed it to the man beside him, and then he said, "Read it out."

The clerk read it in the flat voice of a man reading a list of goods.

The old man first.

The hall was silent.

Six hundred people and not one of them moved. Somewhere a woman in the gallery dropped her fan, and the sound of it on the stone went through the whole building like a shot.

"Where did you get this?" Pedo asked.

"My steward took it from the body of a man called Callistus, who was a slave of the household of Gaius Claudius Corvus, and who carried the cup in my house, and who was killed in an alley by the Emporium nine days after the banquet." Antonia's voice carried to the back of the hall. "The man who wrote it is the steward of that household. His name is Faustus. He is in this basilica today, standing at the back, and he has been in this basilica every day, and he has a burn in the shape of an eight on the inside of his left wrist, and if the panel sends for him now he will not be able to hide it."

There was a moment of absolute quiet.

Then the hall erupted.

It took four lictors to clear a space, and it took Pedo standing up and shouting, and it took Maro hammering on the table with his fist. Corvus sat in the third row and watched his own steward being brought up the aisle between two guards.

Faustus was very pale. He walked with his head up, and when he came to the mark on the floor he stopped and stood, and he did not look at Corvus at all.

"Your name," said Pedo.

"Faustus. Freedman of Gaius Claudius Corvus."

"Hold out your arms."

Faustus held out his arms, and a guard pushed back the sleeve of his tunic, and there on the inside of the left wrist was a burn in the shape of an eight, old and white and unmistakable.

The hall made a sound like a wave breaking.

"Faustus," said Pedo. "You are accused of the murder of Gaius Vettius Proculus. You are a freedman and you may be examined. Will you answer the panel, or will you be examined?"

Faustus looked at the panel. Then he looked at Corvus, and his face did something that Corvus would see for the rest of his life: it was not hatred, and it was not fear, and it was not reproach. It was the face of a man who has been waiting for a thing for twenty years and has finally been allowed to stop waiting.

"I will answer," he said.

"Did you write this note?"

"I did."

"Did you buy poison from a woman in the Subura?"

"I did."

"Did you give it to the man Callistus?"

"I did."

"Did you tell him to put it in the cup of Gaius Vettius?"

"I did."

"Why?"

Faustus was silent for a moment.

"Because I was paid," he said.

"By whom?"

"By Publius Vettius Proculus, the son of the dead man."

The noise in the basilica was enormous.

Corvus sat very still. He was aware of men turning to look at him; he was aware of the third row of the senatorial benches, and of the faces on either side, and of the fact that his hands were flat on his knees and that he had not moved.

"Publius Vettius is in this building," said Pedo. "Bring him."

They found him in the portico, trying to leave.

He came up the aisle between four guards with his cloak torn and his hair in his eyes, and he did not fight. He looked, Corvus

thought, relieved. He looked like a man who had been carrying something heavy for a year and had finally been allowed to put it down.

"Publius Vettius Proculus," said Pedo. "You are accused of the murder of your father."

"I did it," said Publius.

The hall went mad.

It took a long time to restore order. Men were standing on the benches. The women in the gallery were leaning over the rail. Somewhere at the back a man was shouting a name over and over, and it was not clear whose. Pedo stood up and shouted and the lictors pushed into the crowd, and by the time the noise had died down Publius Vettius was standing at the mark on the floor with his hands hanging at his sides and his face wet.

"Why?" Pedo asked.

"He was going to change the will," Publius said. "He had a freedwoman at the house, a woman who had been his nurse when he was a boy, and she had a son, and he was going to leave her sixty thousand sesterces and the farm at Signia, and I was going to have the house and the debts." He wiped his face with his sleeve. "I did not want him dead. I wanted him to stop. I went to him in the spring and I asked him for the money and he said no, and he said that he had been thinking about the will, and he said that a man of his age should put his affairs in order, and I knew what that meant." He looked at the panel. "I did not want him dead. I wanted him to stop."

"You had him killed."

"Yes."

"You hired a steward of the house of the Claudii Corvi to put poison in his cup at a dinner table."

"Yes."

"Did Gaius Claudius Corvus know?"

The hall went quiet.

Corvus stood up.

He did not decide to. He had not intended to. He stood up in the third row of the senatorial benches with the letter against his ribs and his hands at his sides, and every face in the basilica turned to him.

"Publius Vettius," he said. "Look at me."

Publius looked at him.

"Did I know?"

"No."

"Say it so that the court hears it."

"He did not know," Publius said, loudly. "He knew nothing. It was Faustus. Faustus came to me and said that his master would not be told and that the family would be protected, and I paid him, and I never spoke to Corvus about it, and he did not know."

"Why did your steward do it?" Pedo asked.

Corvus looked at Faustus.

"Because he was a fool," Faustus said, "and because I have served that house for twenty years and I have watched it go down and down into debt and disgrace, and because I thought that if the old man's son was finished the family would be saved, and because I wanted him dead for my own reasons, which are twenty years old and have nothing to do with any of you." He turned his head and looked at Corvus for the first time. "Dominus. I did it for the house. I have done everything for the house. I have been your father's servant and your servant and I have never once been thanked, and I do not want to be thanked now. I want to be believed. I did it for the house and you did not know, and that is the truth, and when they have finished with me I will go to the mines and I will die there and the house will go on."

The hall was silent.

Pedo sat down slowly.

"The court will adjourn," he said. "The accused Publius Vettius will be held. The accused Faustus will be held. The panel will consid-

er the case against Antonia Cassia, and will hear the evidence of character, and will give its verdict at the ninth hour."

Corvus did not sit down.

He stood in the third row with the letter against his ribs and his heart going like a hammer, and he thought: *it is over. They have their murderer. The case is closed. She will be acquitted of the murder and convicted of the rest, and the house will be closed, and my family will survive.*

And then he thought: *she will tell them about the shrine.*

He looked across the hall at Antonia Cassia, standing at the mark on the floor with her hands at her sides, and she was looking at him.

She had not produced the stylus. It was in her sleeve; he could see the shape of it against the white wool. She was waiting.

Blandus rose at the ninth hour.

"The panel has asked whether any man in Rome will speak for the character of Antonia Cassia," he said. "I will."

He was drunk. He was fifty years old and his toga was crooked and his wife had left him that morning, and he stood in the middle of the basilica and spoke for a quarter of an hour about a woman who had given him back sixty thousand sesterces at a kitchen door and had not told anyone.

It did not save her and it was not meant to; it was meant to be said, and it was said, and when he sat down half the hall was quiet and the other half was ashamed.

Then Pedo asked the question that Corvus had been waiting for.

"Domina. Have you anything to say before the panel gives its verdict?"

Antonia looked at the panel.

"Yes," she said. "I have one thing to say, and I will say it once, and then I will not speak of it again as long as I live."

She took the stylus out of her sleeve and held it up.

"This is the pen that killed Lucius Claudius Corvus, consul, in the shrine of his own house on the Palatine, seventeen years ago," she said. "It went into his throat in my hand. I was twenty-three years old. I had been his son's slave since I was seventeen, and his since I was nineteen, and on the night he died he had me brought to the shrine and had me flogged until my back was open, and then he had me on the floor in front of the altar. His son came in and stood in the doorway and did not stop it. I reached up and took the pen from the writing box and I put it in his throat, and I have never been sorry."

The hall did not erupt. That was the terrible thing: it went absolutely still, six hundred people in a basilica holding their breath, and in the silence Corvus could hear a pigeon on the roof and the small dry sound of the stylus in her hand.

"The consul-designate has the other pen," Antonia said. "He took it from the altar before the slaves came in. He has kept it in a box in his study for seventeen years. He wrote me a letter that night, which I have kept, in which he told me to take a purse and go and to say nothing, and to say one word would be to die." She lowered the stylus. "I have kept it for seventeen years. I have kept it because I was afraid, and because I was twenty-three, and because I had killed a consul and did not know which way was up. And I am telling it now, in this basilica, because the man who is to be consul in the spring was prepared to destroy me today to keep it quiet, and because I have decided that I would rather be destroyed out loud."

She sat down.

Corvus stood in the third row of the senatorial benches with the letter in his sleeve, and the letter was a piece of paper that weighed nothing at all, and he found that he could not move.

Pedo's voice came from a long way off.

"The court is adjourned," he said. "The panel will sit again in the morning. The accused will be held in the cells. The prefect's office will take possession of the house on the Vicus Tuscus pending the

verdict, and the household will remain in it and will not be sold, and if any man in this hall speaks to a magistrate or a clerk or a man of the cohorts before the morning, I will have him arrested for contempt of the court." He stood up. "And Gaius Claudius Corvus will attend me in my office at the second hour. Not in the morning. Now."

The lictors came for her.

Corvus watched them take her down the aisle, and she walked with her head up and the stylus in her hand, and as she passed the third row she turned her head and looked at him.

She did not smile. She did not look triumphant. She looked at him the way she had looked at him in the shrine seventeen years ago, across a room with a body on the floor: with the face of a woman doing sums.

And then she was gone, and the crowd was surging toward the doors, and the whole city was pouring out into the Forum with the story in its mouth.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Antonia

They put her in the same cell, and the lamp was lit this time, and there was a stool and a jug of water, which she understood to be a courtesy offered by a man who expected her to be dead by the morning and did not want to be remembered for meanness.

She sat on the bench with the stylus in her hand.

She turned the stylus over in her fingers.

It was bronze, four and a half inches long, with a flat end for smoothing the wax and a point for writing, and it had cost perhaps two sesterces in a shop in the Argiletum seventeen years before, and a man had bought it for a girl of seventeen who could not write her own name.

She remembered the room. It was the little room by the stairs, with a bed and a chest and a stool and a window the size of a bread board, and he had sat on the stool with his knees almost touching hers and had put the tablet on her lap, and had said, *this is an A. It is the first letter of your name. No, do not hold it like a knife; hold it like a spoon.*

She had learned to write in a fortnight. She had been quick; he had said so; he had said, *you are quicker than my brother, and my brother had a tutor from Rhodes.*

And then she had learned to read, and had read everything in the house, and had found the accounts, and had understood for the first time that the money in the strongbox was not a hoard but a set of agreements, and that each agreement was a person who owed and a person who was owed, and that she was, in the accounts, a line.

She had never told him that. She had never told anyone that the first thing she read in her life was the page on which she was written down as property.

Her father had been a grain factor in the Subura, and he had hanged himself in his shop when she was eleven because he had been ruined in a lawsuit and could not face the men he owed. She remembered the shop. She remembered the smell of it, which was dust and grain and mouse, and she remembered the men who came the day after and took the sacks out one by one and wrote them down in a book.

She had been sold at fourteen by her guardian, who was a cousin, and who had taken the money and gone to Africa.

Everything in this city is a line in a book, she thought. *My father was a line that went to nothing and hanged himself. I was a line that was sold. The boy was eight hundred sesterces. The girl was eleven thousand. The house was fifty-one thousand, and the silver was nineteen, and the mirror was ninety.*

And tomorrow I am going to stand up in a basilica and tell them that the lines are all wrong.

The noise from the Forum came through the barred window in a way that was worse than noise: it was a sound with no shape to it, a roar that rose and fell and rose again, and every so often there would be a shout that was almost a word, and then the roar would take it back. She had heard that sound twice in her life. Once when she was

nine, at a fire in the Subura, and once at the games, when a man had refused to die.

At the second hour of the night the bolt went back.

She thought it would be Corvus. It was not Corvus. It was a small old woman in a dark stola with a slave behind her and a guard who would not meet Antonia's eyes, and she came into the cell and stood in the middle of the floor and looked around it as though she were pricing the furniture.

"Claudia Junia," Antonia said.

"You know me."

"I have seen you once, in the atrium of your house, when I was seventeen and you looked at me the way a woman looks at a dog that has got into the kitchen." Antonia did not stand. "What do you want?"

"I want to talk to you about my son."

"He is forty-one years old."

"He is my son," Claudia Junia said, "and he has been a fool since he was a boy, and he has been a good fool, which is the worst kind, and today he stood up in a basilica and told six hundred men that a girl had been sent away from his father's house with a purse, and by tomorrow morning the whole city will have the rest of it." She sat down on the stool, which put her below Antonia, and Antonia understood that this was deliberate. "They will come for him. The prefect will report to the emperor, and the Senate will be asked to consider whether a man who was in the room when his father was killed, and who concealed it for seventeen years, is fit to be consul. He will not be consul. He may be expelled from the Senate. He may be tried."

"Yes."

"You do not care."

"I care," Antonia said. "I have cared about your son for twenty-two years, and it has cost me everything I have, and I am finished caring. That is not the same as not caring. It is worse."

The old woman looked at her.

"I wrote to you," Antonia said. "Eleven years ago, when I bought the house. I wrote to you and I said that I had not spoken and would not speak and that I wanted nothing from you, and I said it because I had a house and a name of my own and I wanted you to know that I had not come to beg." She turned the stylus over in her fingers. "You never answered."

"No."

"Did you keep the letter?"

Claudia Junia was silent for a moment.

"Yes," she said. "I kept it. I have read it perhaps once a year. I have never been able to decide whether it was a kindness or a threat."

"It was both," Antonia said. "I was thirty years old and I had just bought a house with money I had made from men, and I wanted to be forgiven by a woman who had never spoken to me, and I wanted her to be afraid of me. That is what a person is at thirty."

The old woman almost smiled.

"I have come to make you an offer," she said.

"Of course you have."

"Tomorrow the panel will give its verdict. You will be acquitted of the murder, because the murderer has confessed in open court and because the city has a new story to tell. You will be convicted of the rest, because a woman in your position is always convicted of the rest, and the prefect will fine you and close the house and perhaps send you out of Italy for a few years, because he will want the city quiet." She folded her hands. "That is what will happen if nothing is done. It will ruin you, and it will ruin my son, and it will be in the mouths of every man in Rome for a year, and in ten years it will be a joke that children tell in the street."

"And if something is done?"

"If you stand up tomorrow and say that you lied today," Claudia Junia said, "and that the story of the shrine was a story told to you by a slave who wished to injure the family, and that you have never been in the house on the Palatine in your life—" she paused— "then the prefect will be able to record that the woman's evidence was the raving of a hysteric, and there will be no report to the emperor, and my son will be consul in the spring, and I will pay you four hundred thousand sesterces and a house at Baiae, and you will leave Italy for five years and come back a rich woman with a new name."

Antonia looked at her.

"That is a great deal of money," she said.

"It is everything I have."

"And you would give it to me."

"I would give it to a woman I have hated for seventeen years," Claudia Junia said, "because it is the only thing I have that will buy my son's life, and because I am sixty-three years old and I have spent my whole life keeping this family standing, and I am not going to stop now because the price has gone up."

Antonia stood up.

She walked to the barred window and looked out at the dark, at the wall of the building opposite and the small square of sky above it, and the noise of the city came in, and there was something in the noise now that was not a roar but a rhythm.

"No," she said.

"You are a fool."

"Perhaps." Antonia turned. "I have been offered a great many things in my life by people who wanted me to be quiet, and I have taken most of them, and I have told myself each time that I was being practical. I took a purse from your son when I was twenty-three. I have taken money from senators and favours from men and I have smiled at people I despised, and I have built a house on it, and I have

told myself that it was the only way a woman like me could live in a city like this." She put the stylus down on the bench. "And then a boy of twelve was strangled in a yard because he had seen something, and I found that there was a thing I would not sell. It came as a surprise to me. I am forty years old and I did not know it until this year."

"You will destroy him."

"He destroyed himself," Antonia said. "He has been destroying himself for seventeen years, in a room in a house on the Palatine, twice a year, with a pen in a box. I am only the thing he did it to."

Claudia Junia stood up.

"You will be alone," she said. "Do you understand that? Tomorrow you will be convicted, and the house will be sold, and the women will be sold or scattered, and the men who ate at your table will cross the street to avoid you, and there will be no one. A woman of your condition has no family, no patron, no name, and no friends who will stand by her when she is finished. I have been alone in a house for twenty-four years and I know what it is. You will not last five years at Baiae. You will be dead in three."

"Then I will be dead in three," Antonia said, "and I will have been myself for the whole of it."

The old woman looked at her for a long moment.

Then she turned and went out, and the guard shut the door, and the bolt went home.

It was perhaps an hour later that the light changed.

Antonia was sitting on the bench with her back against the wall and her eyes shut, and she noticed it first as a warmth on her face, and then as a flicker behind her eyelids, and she opened her eyes and the cell was full of a faint orange light that came and went.

She went to the window.

The wall of the building opposite was lit from above, and the small square of sky was the colour of a coal, and there was smoke in

it, and the noise of the city had changed: it was no longer a roar but a crowd, with voices in it, and somebody was screaming.

She could not see the fire. The window looked north, and the Vicus Tuscus was to the south, and she could see only the light of it on the wall and the smoke going up over the roofs.

She stood at the bars and watched the light.

The vigiles will be there, she thought. *They will have the buckets. It is a stone house with a fountain in the middle of it. It will not burn.*

And then she thought: *the contracts*.

They were in the strongbox in her room: the purchase documents of eleven women and three men, the manumission records, the loan tablets, the deeds. Everything she owned was in that box and everything those women were was in that box, and if the house burned the box would burn, and a slave whose papers are burned is not free; she is a person with no evidence, which in Rome is worse.

She stood at the window until the light went down.

She watched the light on the wall until it went.

There was a small window high up, and the wall opposite was white plaster, and the light from the fire came over the roofs and moved on the plaster and then faded, and the cell got cold.

She thought about the house burning. She thought about the papers in the strongbox, and the deeds, and the purchase documents, and the manumission records, and the loan tablets with the names of senators on them, and she thought: *if the box burns, then every woman in that house is a slave again with no evidence, and every debt is unprovable, and seventeen years of accounts go up in smoke.*

And then she thought: *and if the box survives, I will have a house and no money and eleven women, and no way to feed them.*

She laughed, once, in the dark.

That was the thing she had not expected about the worst night of her life: that somewhere in the middle of it she would find something funny. She had spent seventeen years building a thing that could be

written down, and a crowd from the Forum had come up the street with a torch and settled the question of what a written thing is worth.

Nothing, she thought. *It is worth nothing at all. A man may be owed sixty thousand sesterces on a tablet and be turned out of his house by a man in the Velabrum, and a woman may own eleven people on a tablet and be sold herself by a prefect who is tired.*

And yet.

And yet Tiro went back in for it.

She sat in the dark and thought about that for a long time.

In the morning they came for her at the second hour and took her up into the basilica, and the hall was half empty, and the men in it were quiet, and there was a smell of smoke in the air that had got into the building from the street.

Pedo read the verdict in a flat voice.

On the charge of the murder of Gaius Vettius Proculus: not guilty. The panel found that the poison had been procured by Faustus, freedman of Gaius Claudius Corvus, at the instigation of Publius Vettius Proculus, and that the woman Antonia Cassia had no part in it.

On the charge of keeping a house of ill repute: guilty. The house on the Vicus Tuscus was confiscated to the city. She was fined one hundred thousand sesterces.

On the charge of the corruption of morals: guilty. She was relegated from Rome and Italy for five years, and forbidden to come within a hundred miles of the city.

The hall made no sound at all.

"Do you wish to say anything?" Pedo asked.

"No," Antonia said.

"Then the court is dismissed." He gathered his papers, and then he looked up. "Domina. A word."

They took her into the small room behind the platform, and Pedo stood with his back to her and his hands behind his back, and for a moment he did not speak.

"The fire," he said.

"Whose house?"

"Yours." He turned. "It began in the doorway at the third hour of the night. There was a crowd in the street. The vigiles were at the granaries; there had been a fire there the week before and half the cohort was on the river. By the time they came, the roof had gone." He paused. "The women got out. All of them. The steward took them out through the kitchen and into the alley, and then he went back in."

Antonia stood very still.

"For the strongbox," she said.

"For the strongbox. He came out with it. He was on the step when the floor went, and the beam came down on him, and they brought him out into the street and he was alive for a little while." Pedo's voice was quiet. "I am told he asked for you."

"Where is he?"

"In the yard of the vigiles' station on the Aventine. They have laid him in the shed with the others. There are four of them; the fire took a woman in the house next door and her child, and a man in the street." He came around the table. "I have signed the order for your release. You will be out of the city by nightfall. That is not a thing I can change; the verdict is the verdict, and if I let you stay until the funeral I will have half the Senate asking why." He stopped in front of her. "I am sorry."

"You are not."

"I am," said Pedo, "and it is the only thing I have said today that I did not have to say. Take it or leave it."

She went out of the basilica into the Forum.

The crowd was there, but it was a different crowd now: the holiday crowd had gone home, and the people in the square were the people who always come after a thing is finished, the scavengers and the curious and the men who want to see a famous woman walk out of a court in the morning. They did not shout at her. A few of them looked at her, and one woman said something that Antonia did not hear, and a man spat on the ground as she passed, not at her, at the ground in front of her, which is what a man does when he wants to be seen doing something and does not want to be arrested for it.

She went to the Vicus Tuscus first.

The street was open. That was the first thing: that the street was open, and you could see from the corner of the Velabrum all the way to the top, because the house that had stood on the corner for seventeen years was not standing any more.

The walls were still there. That was the strange thing about a fire in a stone house: the walls stand. The west wall and the north wall were black and cracked and the roof had fallen in behind them, and through the gap where the door had been you could see the sky, and the whole of the inside was a heap of black timber and ash and broken tile.

There was a smell of wet charcoal and burnt wool and something else, sweet and foul, that she did not want to identify.

The vigiles had put a rope across the front and a notice on a stick. Two men of the cohort were sitting on the step of the fuller's shop opposite with their sticks across their knees, and one of them was eating something out of a cloth.

Antonia stood at the rope and looked in.

She could see the fountain. It was still there, in the middle of what had been the courtyard: the basin was full of ash and broken tile and the bronze myrtle tree was bent and black and the leaves were gone, but it was standing.

She had bought that fountain in the second year, from a man in the Argiletum who had taken it from a house that was being sold for debt. It had cost her four thousand sesterces, which had been a great deal of money then, and she had stood in the courtyard while they installed it and had said, *the leaves should be myrtle, because the house will be called the Myrtle*, and Tiro had said, *why not call it something without leaves*, and she had said, *because a house with a name is a house that people remember.*

"What happened?" she said.

The guard looked up.

"Fire," he said.

"I know it was a fire. Who started it?"

The guard chewed.

"A crowd came up from the Forum after the basilica yesterday," he said. "They had been at the trial. There was a man with a torch. We were on the river; there was a fire at the granaries the week before and half the cohort was down there." He wiped his mouth. "By the time we got here the roof was gone. There was nothing to do but keep it off the neighbours."

"How many dead?"

"Four. A woman in the next house and her child, and a man in the street, and a slave from this house who went back in for a box." The guard looked at the ruin. "He came out with it. He was on the step when the floor went."

Antonia stood at the rope for a long time.

"Domina," the guard said. "You cannot stand here."

"I am not standing here," she said. "I am leaving."

She walked up the street to the corner and turned and looked back once at the two black walls and the sky through them and the bent myrtle in the ash.

Seventeen years, she thought. *Fifty-one thousand sesterces, and eleven women, and a boy of twelve, and a cook's rolling pin, and a*

fountain with bronze leaves, and a box of paper, and a man on the Palatine who kept a pen.

And a crowd from the Forum with a torch, who did not know my name, and who went home to supper.

She walked to the Aventine.

The vigiles' station was a low building with a yard and a shed, and the shed was open, and there were four bodies in it on boards, covered with cloth. The man at the door knew who she was; the whole city knew by then. He stood aside.

Tiro was on the third board.

They had washed him. His face was grey and there was a burn along the side of his neck and his hands were folded on his chest by somebody who had taken trouble over it. He looked fifty-two years old, which he had never looked in life.

Antonia knelt down beside him.

"You fool," she said.

The strongbox was on the floor by the door, blackened and warped, with the lock broken open. Somebody had gone through it and taken the money, and left the tablets: the deeds, the loan records, the purchase documents, the manumission papers of eleven women and three men.

She picked up the papers and held them against her chest.

"He asked for you," said the man at the door. "He said: *tell her the box is out.* And then he said something else, and I did not understand it, and he said it twice." The man rubbed his jaw. "He said: *the boy at Tibur.*"

Antonia closed her eyes.

"He has a son," she said. "At Tibur. In a smithy by the gate. He is fourteen and he is free, or he thinks he is free, and his father is on a board in a shed on the Aventine."

The man looked at the floor.

"Do you want us to send word?"

"No," Antonia said. "I will go."

She went out of the shed into the yard, and the sun was high, and the city went on beyond the wall, and somewhere a woman was selling figs.

Prisca was waiting in the street with Meroe and Junilla and the two kitchen girls and the washerwoman and the girl who carried the water. They had come up from the fire with nothing but what they stood in, and they stood in a huddle in the street with their hair down and their faces smudged, and when they saw her they did not speak.

Antonia stood in front of them.

"The house is gone," she said. "The court has taken the ground and the walls and everything that was in them. I have been fined a hundred thousand sesterces and sent out of Italy for five years, and I will be out of the city by nightfall." She looked at each of them. "But I have these."

She held up the papers.

"Your contracts. All of them. Every one of you is free from this morning, and no one in this city can sell you, and if a man tries, you will show him these, and if he does not believe you, you will go to the prefect's office and ask for the clerk who wrote the verdict and he will remember." She looked down at the papers in her hands. "Tiro went back into the house for these. He is dead. He was a thief and a murderer and a fool and he was the best man I have ever known, and he died for a box of paper."

Meroe began to cry. Then the kitchen girls. Then Prisca, who never cried, sat down on the kerb in the street and put her face in her hands.

"What will we do?" Junilla said.

"You will do what free women do," Antonia said. "You will find work, or you will come with me, and I will not lie to you: I have nothing. The fine will take the money in the chest and the house is

gone and I have four hundred sesterces in my purse. But I am going to Surrentum, and there is a woman there who sells wine, and there is a town on a bay where a woman might start again, and there is a boat at Ostia that will take us for nothing if we work the passage." She put the papers in her sleeve. "I am not asking. I am telling you what I am doing, and any of you who wishes to come is welcome, and any of you who wishes to stay in Rome is free to stay, and I will give you what I have to give and I will not hold it against you."

There was a silence.

"I will come," said Prisca, from the kerb.

"And I," said Meroe.

"And I," said Junilla.

The kitchen girls said nothing, and looked at the ground, and Antonia understood that they had families in the Subura and were fifteen years old and did not want to go to the end of Italy with a ruined woman, and she said, "That is right. That is the right thing. Go home, both of you, and take the papers, and if there is trouble, send for me at Surrentum."

They went.

That afternoon Antonia went to Tibur.

She walked. There was no money for a horse and no time to find one. She walked the four hours up the Via Nomentana in the clothes she had worn in the basilica, with the papers in her sleeve and the dust on her hem, and she came to the smithy at the bottom of the town by the gate in the late afternoon, and the boy was working the bellows.

She stood in the yard until he looked up.

"You are the domina," he said. "My father's mistress."

"Yes."

"Is he coming?"

Antonia looked at him: fourteen years old, with his mother's hands, and a burn on his forearm from the sparks, and his whole life in front of him.

"No," she said. "He is not coming."

She stayed the night in Tibur. She told the boy the whole of it, sitting on the wall by the well with the goat looking at them, and she did not soften it, and at the end she gave him the paper that Faustus had given Tiro and which Tiro had put inside his tunic and which had been found on him and brought to her with his knife and his purse.

"You are free," she said. "You have been free since the Kalends of August. Your father bought it for you, and he could not read the paper, and he was afraid that it was a lie, and he gave away something he should not have given to get it. That is who he was."

The boy looked at the paper in the failing light, and turned it over, and turned it over again.

"I cannot read it," he said.

"Then I will read it to you," Antonia said. "And then I will teach you to read it yourself, if you want, and if your master will let you go, and if you will come with me to a town on a bay where there is a woman who sells wine and a great deal of work to be done."

The boy looked at her.

"Was he a good man?" he asked.

Antonia thought about it.

"He was a man who did one good thing at the end," she said, "and a great many bad ones before it, and he was sorry for the bad ones, and he did not know how to say so. That is more than most men manage."

The boy nodded slowly.

"I will come," he said.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Tiro

After the basilica, the house belonged to the city, and the city sent a man to sit in the atrium and write down what was in it.

He came in the afternoon with a clerk and a lamp and a stool, and he sat in the atrium for four hours writing, and the women stood in the kitchen and listened to him turn the pages.

Tiro stood in the doorway and watched him.

"Two couches, citron wood," the man said to his clerk. "One table. Eleven lamps. Six curtains, Egyptian, of which two are—" he held one up— "of which two are good."

"They are all good," said Meroe, from the kitchen door.

The man looked at her and wrote something down.

"Eleven slaves," he said. "Names."

"Not today," Tiro said.

"Tomorrow, then. The prefect wants the list before the trial resumes."

"You have the house," Tiro said. "You will have the list when the trial is over and not before, and if you write down one name today I will take that stool and put it through the window."

The man looked at him for a moment, and then at the scar, and then he wrote: *slaves, to be listed.*

He went away at dusk.

The women cooked a meal in the kitchen and nobody ate it. Prisca put the plates out and Meroe sat down and then got up again, and the two kitchen girls sat at the end of the table and whispered, and Junilla went up onto the roof to look at the street and came down and said, "There are men at the corner."

"How many?"

"Six. Maybe eight. They are not doing anything. They are standing."

Tiro went out to the step and looked.

There were eight of them at the corner of the Velabrum, and they were the sort of men who stand at corners in every city: men with nothing to do and a grievance they could not name. One of them had a stick. One of them, Tiro noticed, was the man who had sold fish at the corner for eleven years and had always been civil.

He went back inside.

"Prisca," he said. "Get the money out of the strongbox and put it in your apron. All of it."

"Tiro—"

"All of it. And the papers. And then go upstairs and put on two tunics and your oldest shoes and take the chest with the boy's things down to the kitchen." He looked at the women in the kitchen. "This is what we are going to do. At the second hour of the night, or sooner if they come, we are going out by the kitchen door and up the alley and into the Clivus and then to the house of the fuller's widow in the Subura, which is nine streets away and which none of them will think of. You will walk. You will not run. You will carry one thing each and no more. If a man speaks to you, you will not answer. If a man puts a hand on you, you will scream as loud as you can and keep walking."

"And you?" said Prisca.

"I will be behind you."

"Tiro—"

"Prisca. Get the money."

They came down with their bundles and their boxes and their arguments.

Meroe would not leave her contract. It was in a wooden case with a lock and she had carried it from Alexandria to Rome and she was not going to leave it in a house that was going to be sold by the court. Prisca would not leave the household accounts. The two kitchen girls would not leave a jar of pickled fish that they had made themselves in the spring. The washerwoman had a bronze mirror that had belonged to her mother, and the girl who carried the water had a bird in a cage.

"Leave the bird," Tiro said.

"He will die."

"Then he will die. Take him out of the cage and let him go in the kitchen."

"He will come back."

"Then he will come back to a burned house and he will learn something." Tiro took the cage out of her hands and opened the door and shook it, and the bird flew up into the dark of the kitchen and sat on a beam and looked at them all with enormous offence. "There. Now he is free and he is your problem no longer. Take the mirror. Leave the fish."

They left the fish.

He got them out through the kitchen door half an hour before midnight, one at a time, into the alley, and the alley was empty, and Niger's cart was at the end of it with the tarpaulin up and one of the men sitting on the tail with a club across his knees.

Meroe went first, with her case. Then the girls. Then the washerwoman, who was sixty and could not walk fast, and whom Tiro took

by the arm and half carried to the end of the alley. Then Junilla, who refused to go until the others were in, and who stood at the corner with her knife in her sleeve and her eyes on the street.

Prisca was last.

"You are coming," she said.

"I am coming."

"You are not coming."

"Prisca." He took her by the shoulders. "There is a box in her room with the papers in it. If it burns, eleven women are slaves again, and everything she has done for seventeen years is nothing. I am going to get it, and then I am going out through the kitchen and up the alley, and I will be at the fuller's widow's house before the fourth hour."

"Then I will wait for you at the corner."

"No. You will get on the cart."

"Tiro—"

"You will get on the cart," he said, "because if you do not, I will have to carry you, and I am fifty-two years old and I have a bad back, and I will drop you, and it will be undignified for both of us."

She looked at him.

"You are a terrible liar," she said.

"I know."

She kissed him on the cheek, which she had never done in eleven years, and got on the cart, and Niger's man put the tarpaulin down over her, and the cart went up the alley and turned into the Clivus and was gone.

He stood in the kitchen doorway for a moment with his hand on the frame.

Then he shut the door and put the bar across it and went to the stairs.

He stood in the kitchen and looked at the women: Meroe with her hair half braided, Junilla with her knife in her sleeve, the two

girls, the washerwoman, the girl who carried the water. Six of them. Seven with Prisca. And the boy's chest, and the money, and eleven sets of papers.

He thought, quite clearly, in the way a man thinks when he has been in a burning building before: *I cannot carry all of this.*

He went upstairs and got the boy's chest.

Niger came at the ninth hour with two men and a cart.

He came to the kitchen door and knocked twice and once, which was the signal they had used in the barracks twenty-six years before, and Tiro let him in and shut the door behind him.

"I heard," Niger said.

"Who told you?"

"Everybody. It was in the Emporium by the fourth hour. They are saying the prefect is going to let her go and the crowd is going to do the job for him." He looked around the kitchen. "You have women here."

"Six."

"How many can walk?"

"All of them. None of them will want to."

Niger nodded.

"I have the cart at the end of the alley with a tarpaulin on it. Two men on it. We can take four under the tarpaulin as far as the Esquiline and then they can walk to the Subura." He put his hand on Tiro's shoulder. "You come too."

"I will come when they are out."

"Tiro."

"I will come when they are out."

Niger looked at him for a moment and then took his hand away.

"You were always like this," he said. "In the barracks. When there was a thing to be done you were the last one out of the door." He went to the back door and looked out into the alley. "If it goes bad, get onto the roof of the fuller's shop and go along the ridge to the

corner. There is a builder's ladder there, and I will leave a man at the bottom of it until the fourth hour."

"Thank you."

"Do not thank me. I am doing it because you are the only man in Rome who ever gave me half his bread." Niger opened the door. "And because a woman who keeps a house of women and pays them and does not sell them is a better Christian than half the people I know, and I am not even a Christian."

He went out.

Prisca came down with the money in her apron and the papers in a cloth, and Tiro took the papers and put them inside his tunic, and then he did the thing that he would think about afterward, in the street, with the beam on him: he took the money out of her apron and put it in a bag and put the bag in her hands.

"Take it."

"You take it."

"No." He closed her fingers on it. "If they stop you, they will search you for money and they will find it and they will let you go, because a crowd wants money more than it wants a woman. If they find papers on you they will burn them, because papers are a thing a crowd does not understand and therefore hates. So you carry the money and I carry the papers, and if one of us gets out, the women are free."

Prisca looked at him.

"You are not going to get out," she said.

"I am going to get out."

"Tiro."

"Prisca." He took her by the shoulders. "I have done a bad thing this year and I have not told her and I am not going to tell her, and I am going to get every woman in this house out of it if I have to carry them one at a time, and then I am going to walk out of that door and up the alley and I am going to be at the fuller's widow's house by the

fourth hour, and she will shout at me for being late, and I will sit down and eat something." He let go. "Now go and tell the women."

She went.

The crowd began to gather at the eleventh hour of the night, and by the second hour of the morning there were four hundred of them in the Vicus Tuscus.

They came from the Subura and the Velabrum and the river, and they were not a mob in the way that a mob is imagined; they were a great many people who had heard a story in a wine shop and had come to look at the house where it had happened. There were porters and water carriers and a woman with a basket of oranges and a dozen boys and a man with a performing dog. There were men who had lost money at the granaries and men who had been turned away from the door of some great house that morning. There were two men with a jar of wine and a good deal of opinions.

By the second hour they had begun to shout.

It was not about Vettius. That was the thing that Tiro understood at once, standing on the step with Junilla and two of the bearers, and it was the thing that frightened him. The shouting was not about a dead consul. It was about the woman who had killed a consul and been paid to keep quiet, and the family on the Palatine that had covered it up, and the fact that in this city a man could be murdered in his own shrine and the whole of the Senate could agree to call it a fit, and nothing would happen, and nobody would hang, and the only person who had been punished was a cook and a boy in a yard.

"They will burn us," Junilla said.

"They will not."

"Look at them."

He looked. There was a man at the front with a torch, and he was not a young man and he was not drunk, and he was holding the torch the way a man holds a tool.

"Get the women out," Tiro said.

"What?"

"Get them out. Now. The kitchen door and the alley, and up the Clivus toward the Velabrum, and do not run and do not stop for anything and do not come back." He took her by the shoulder. "Junilla. Listen to me. Prisca first; she will argue. Then Meroe. Then the girls. Count them at the top of the hill and count them again at the fountain. Do you hear me?"

"Yes."

"Go."

She went.

At the second hour, Tiro opened the door and went out onto the step.

Junilla caught at his arm. He shook her off.

There were four hundred people in the street, and the ones at the front were the ones who had been there longest, and the ones at the back were the ones who had come to see. Somebody had brought a torch. Somebody had brought a jar. There was a man with a performing dog on his shoulder, and the dog was barking, and the man was laughing.

Tiro stood on the step with his hands at his sides.

"I know some of you," he said.

The noise went down a little. He had a voice that carried; he had spent eleven years making himself heard over a crowd in an arena.

"I know you, Caius, you sell fish at the corner, and you have sold it to this house for eleven years and been paid on the day every time. I know you, mother, with the oranges, you have stood on that corner since I came to this street. I know the two of you at the back, you work the boats. I do not know the rest of you and I do not care." He took a step down. "There is nobody in this house but women. There is no money in it worth having and there is nothing in it that any of you need. The woman who owns it is not here. She is in a cell under

the basilica and she will be tried in the morning, and whatever you think of her, the law will do what the law does, and it will do it whether you burn the house or not."

Somebody at the back shouted something.

"I did not hear that," Tiro said.

"He said the consul," somebody called. "He said she killed a consul and the Senate covered it up and the whole lot of you ought to be burned."

"The consul died seventeen years ago," Tiro said, "and if you want to be angry about it, go up the hill and be angry at the man who is to be consul in the spring, and see how far you get. He has a lictor. I have a door."

There was a movement in the crowd, the way there is a movement in a crowd when the front rank has decided and the back rank has not.

The fish seller looked at the ground.

"I am sorry, Tiro," he said.

"I know."

"Rent went up in the summer and there is no work on the river."

"I know."

"I am not going to be the one to do it."

"Then do not be here when it is done," Tiro said.

The fish seller went away, down the street, with his hands in his pockets. Two others went with him. The rest stayed.

Tiro stood on the step and looked at them for a moment, and then he went back inside and put the bar across and stood with his hand on it.

"That was brave," Junilla said.

"That was useless," said Tiro. "But it bought us ten minutes and eight people, and ten minutes is ten minutes."

The door went in at the third hour.

It was not a ram; it was eight men with a beam from the builder's yard at the corner, and they swung it four times, and the fourth time the bolt came out of the wood and the door fell inward and the crowd came in like water.

Tiro was standing in the atrium with a knife in his hand.

He was fifty-two years old, and he had been a gladiator for eleven years, and he had killed nine men in an arena, and he knew exactly what a crowd is. A crowd is not a man. You cannot frighten a crowd and you cannot reason with it and you cannot fight it; you can only be somewhere else.

He went up the stairs.

They were in the dining room by then, and he heard them: the crash of the couches going over, the smash of the silver, a woman's voice screaming with delight, a man shouting about the ceiling. Somebody had climbed onto the table and was hacking at the gilded coffers with a knife, and the gold was coming down in flakes.

The women were in the alley.

He could hear them through the kitchen door, and he stood at the top of the stairs and counted the voices, and he got to nine and then to eleven, and then he heard Prisca say, "Where is the boy? Where is Felix's chest?" and he remembered that the chest was still in the little room by the stairs, and the boy's knife was in it, and the stone with the hole in it, and the two knucklebones, and the rag with eleven sesterces in it that had been found in the plaster.

He went into the little room and got the chest.

He came out into the corridor with it under his arm and the smoke was already in the passage, and he went down the back stairs and out through the kitchen, and he put the chest in Prisca's arms in the alley and said, "Go. Go now."

"Tiro—"

"Go."

She went.

He stood in the alley and looked back at the house, and the smoke was coming out of the upper windows in two thick columns, and the light of the fire was on the wall of the house opposite, and the crowd was shouting inside his house.

The strongbox was in her room.

He stood there for perhaps five heartbeats and thought about it. He thought about the fire, and about the fact that a stone house with a fountain in it will not burn down in five minutes, and about the fact that the strongbox was on the second floor at the front and the fire was in the dining room at the back, and about the fact that a man who goes into a burning house for a box of paper is a fool.

And then he thought: *she will have nothing*.

Not the money. He did not care about the money. The money was in the chest and the chest was in Prisca's arms.

The papers were in the strongbox: the purchase documents of eleven women and three men, the manumission records, the loan tablets, the deeds of the two shops. He had watched her write them out over seventeen years, at that table, with that lamp. He had watched her buy women out of houses where they were beaten and put the papers in the box and say, *that is one more who cannot be sold.*

He went in.

He met a man on the stairs.

He was coming down with his arms full: two silver cups and a lamp and a folded curtain, and his face was black with soot and he was grinning like a boy. He saw Tiro and stopped.

"There is a fire," he said.

"I know."

"You should get out."

"I know." Tiro looked at the silver in his arms. "That is my mistress's."

The man looked down at the cups.

"She is not going to need it," he said.

"No," said Tiro. "She is not."

He stepped aside and let him go. He would think about that afterward; not the man, who was nothing, but the fact that he had stepped aside, that he had been in a burning house with a knife in his sleeve and a lifetime of violence in his hands and he had let a man walk past him with two silver cups because the cups did not matter and the box did.

The heat came up the stairwell in a wave.

The kitchen was full of smoke and he went through it on his hands and knees with his tunic over his mouth. The back stairs were clear. The corridor at the top was not: the fire had come through the ceiling of the dining room and into the passage, and there was a line of flame running along the top of the wall, and the smoke was rolling along the ceiling in a way that told him the roof was going.

He went under the smoke with his face a hand's breadth from the floor. It was like crawling through a wall. The smoke had no top and no bottom; it was hot and it had a taste, and the taste was wood and pitch and the wool of the curtains and, underneath, something that he did not want to think about.

He kept his hand on the wall because the wall was the only thing that was where it had always been.

Her door was open. The room was full of a red light and there was smoke in it but the fire was not in it yet, and he got up and went to the strongbox and dragged it out from under the table.

It was heavy. It was iron-bound oak and it weighed as much as a man, and he got his arms around it and lifted it and it came off the floor by a hand's breadth and he dropped it.

He could not carry it. He was a strong man. He had been stronger. He had carried a man out of the arena at Capua when he was twenty-two years old, and he had carried a beam at Ostia when he was forty, and it had taken two of them to lift a jar of wine off a

cart in the summer, and he had done it alone because the carter was a boy.

He could not carry it now.

He stood in the middle of the room with the smoke stinging his eyes and his lungs full of it, and he thought, quite clearly, in the way that a man thinks when he is frightened: *the box or the papers.*

He took the key from the table and opened the box.

The lid came up and the smell of it came out: leather and wax and the dry dust of documents, and under that something else, which was the smell of her: the oil she used on her hair, and the cedar of the tablets, and a faint sourness that was the room.

He stood in the middle of her room with the box open in his hands and the fire coming along the corridor outside.

The money was on the top, in bags: eleven thousand sesterces in silver and gold. He left it. He lifted out the tablets and the rolls and the folded documents, and he stuffed them inside his tunic, against his skin, and there were a great many of them and they would not all fit, and he took the rest in his arms.

The ceiling of the corridor came down as he reached the door.

He went through it into a wall of heat and he could not see and he could not breathe, and he went down the back stairs on his back, sliding, with the papers against his chest and his elbows banging on the steps, and he came out into the kitchen and the kitchen was on fire.

The door was ten feet away.

He got up and ran.

He was on the step when the floor went.

It was not the beam that killed him. That was what he would have said if anyone had asked, and nobody asked. It was the beam that broke his back, and it came down across the doorway, and the whole of the front of the house came down with it, and he was thrown out into the street and the papers went everywhere.

He lay on his back in the Vicus Tuscus with the fire above him.

Somebody was pulling at him. There were faces over him, and hands, and a woman was saying something that he could not hear. The crowd had stopped shouting. The crowd had turned, the way a crowd turns, and the men who had been breaking the ceiling were coming out of the house with their arms over their heads, and somebody was shouting for water, and somewhere a long way off a bell was ringing.

Tiro looked up at the sky.

There was a great deal of smoke between him and it, and the smoke was orange at the edges, and beyond the smoke the sky was beginning to go grey.

He thought about the arena.

He thought about the boy with the net and the trident, who had slipped on the sand, and about the sound the crowd had made when he put his sword in.

He thought about his son at the bellows.

He had stood in the street outside the smithy four times in eight years and looked at the boy and gone away, and he had told himself each time that it was because he had nothing to say, and it had not been that. It had been because the boy looked at him with a face that said *you will go away again*, and because it was easier to go away than to stand there and be looked at.

He had bought the boy's freedom with a letter that was not his to give. He had stolen from the only person who had ever trusted him. He had killed a man in an alley and he had felt nothing, and then he had gone home and sat on his bed and shaken for an hour.

He was fifty-two years old. He had been a slave for thirty-five years and a free man for seventeen, and in seventeen years he had learned to read four words: his own name, her name, and *the old man first*, which he had copied out on a tablet from the papyrus, let-

ter by letter, in the dark, so that he would know what he had given away.

He turned his head.

The strongbox was in the doorway, blackened and warped, with the lock broken. Somebody had gone through it. The bags of money were gone. The tablets were in the street, in the ash, and a woman was picking them up and putting them in a heap, and a man was standing on one of them.

"Don't," Tiro said.

The man did not hear him.

"Don't. Those are—" He could not get enough breath. "Those are people's—"

The woman looked at him. She had a broad red face and a scarf round her hair, and she was the woman who sold oranges, and she had been in the crowd an hour before, shouting.

"What?" she said.

Tiro looked at her.

"Tell her," he said. "Tell Antonia Cassia. The box is out."

"Who?"

"The box is out. Tell her—"

He stopped. The words were not coming. He lay in the street with the fire above him and the sky going grey, and he thought about the boy at the bellows, and about the fact that the paper said he was free, and that the boy could not read it, and that there was nobody now who would read it to him.

He said, "The boy at Tibur."

"What?"

"The boy at Tibur."

He said it twice. The woman with the oranges heard it and remembered it, because it was the only thing in the whole of that night that she could make any sense of, and in the morning she told the man from the vigiles, and the man from the vigiles told the prefect's

clerk, and the clerk wrote it down in the margin of a report about a fire in the fourth region in which four persons died.

Then Tiro stopped saying anything at all.

He was not thinking about the arena, or the boy, or the woman with the oranges, or the papers in the street.

He was thinking about a doorway on the Vicus Tuscus in the rain, seventeen years before, and a woman in a dark cloak who had stopped and looked at him and said: *you look like a man who can keep a door.*

And he had said: *I look like a man who can keep anything.*

And she had laughed.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Leda

They took her back to the house on the Palatine after the trial, because there was nowhere else to take her.

The panel had found that she was free-born and that her mother was Vibia Prima of Surrentum, and Pedo had said that she would be sent to her mother at the expense of the court; and then a clerk had said that the arrangements would take some days, and Corvus had said that she could not be left in the cells, and Claudia Junia had said that the family would undertake to keep her until the ship sailed, and so it was decided, in the way that such things are decided, by men who were tired and wanted to go home.

They gave her a room on the upper floor with a window that looked over the garden.

It was the best room she had ever had. There was a bed with a carved footboard and a coverlet of good wool, and a chest with a lock on it, and a bronze mirror on a stand, and a small table with a jug and a basin, and a slave woman called Doris, who was old and deaf and kind and brought her food three times a day.

On the first morning she sat on the bed and did not touch anything.

She had been in the house a day and a night, and she had not seen Marcus. She had seen Caesia twice, who had come to the door and said, "Are you well?" and had stood in the doorway with her hands behind her back and had not known what else to say, and had gone away. She had seen Claudia Junia once, in the atrium, who had looked at her and said, "You will eat, and you will sleep, and you will not go out of this house," and had gone on up the stairs.

She had not seen Corvus at all.

The city was outside the window. She could hear it: the carts, the shouts, the hammers from the building works below the hill, the dogs, the children. It went on and on and it had nothing to do with her, and she sat on the bed with her hands in her lap and listened to it.

On the second morning Doris brought her bread and honey and said, "The lady says you are to come down to the garden."

"Why?"

"The air."

Leda went down to the garden.

It was a small garden, walled, with a fig tree and a bed of herbs and a bench and a statue of a satyr with his arm broken off. She sat on the bench in the sun, and she had been there perhaps a quarter of an hour when Caesia came out of the house with a book.

"May I sit?"

"It is your garden."

Caesia sat down at the other end of the bench and put the book on her knees and did not open it.

"My grandmother says you are to go to Surrentum as soon as the ship sails," she said. "She says it is arranged. She says your mother has been written to."

"Yes."

"Are you glad?"

Leda looked at the fig tree.

"I do not know," she said. "I have wanted it for ten years. I have thought about it every night. I have made up what my mother's face looks like and what the house looks like and what my brother will say when he sees me." She paused. "And now it is going to happen, and I find that I am frightened of it."

"Why?"

"Because I am not the girl who was taken from that beach," Leda said. "I am twenty-one years old and I have sung in a brothel for six years and I have stood in a basilica in front of six hundred men and said what was done to me, and the woman who is going to Surrentum is not the daughter my mother has been looking for. My mother has been petitioning governors for ten years for a girl of eleven." She looked at her hands. "What will she do with me?"

Caesia was quiet for a moment.

"My brother is in love with you," she said.

"I know."

"He is in his room. He has been in his room since the trial. My grandmother has a man at the door. He has not eaten for two days, and yesterday he broke the shutter, and they had to take the shutters off the window." She turned the book over in her hands. "They are going to send him away. To the army, in the autumn, to a legion in Syria, and my grandmother says that by the time he comes back you will be married in Surrentum and he will have forgotten."

"He will not forget."

"No," said Caesia. "He will not." She looked up. "I am sorry. I do not know why I am telling you this. There is nobody else in this house who tells the truth, and I have discovered this week that I am not very good at being lied to."

Leda almost laughed.

"Neither am I," she said. "I have been lied to by everyone who was ever kind to me. My mistress lied to me about my papers and told herself it was for my good. The consul lied to me in his study

and told himself it was for the city. The steward took me out of my house in a litter and told me it was for my protection." She looked at the wall of the garden. "And the only person who ever told me the truth was a boy of twelve who is dead."

Caesia sat with her for a while.

Then she said, "I will come and see you tomorrow," and went back into the house, and Leda sat in the garden until the sun went off the wall.

On the third afternoon she went down to the tablinum and asked to see him.

The slave at the door said that his master was not receiving. Leda said that she would wait, and sat down on the bench in the corridor, and after a quarter of an hour the door opened and Corvus stood in it.

"You should be in your room."

"I have been in my room for three days." She stood up. "I am to go to Surrentum on a ship the day after tomorrow, and I am to be given a purse and a letter and a woman of the household to see me onto it, and I have been told all of this by your mother, and not one word of it by you." She looked at him. "You are the man who put me in that villa. You are the man who is going to stand up in the Senate in the spring. I have given my evidence. I would like to be told the truth about my own life by the person who has arranged it."

Corvus looked at her for a moment. Then he stepped back from the door.

"Come in."

The tablinum was a room full of paper. There were tablets in racks and rolls in baskets and a table with three inkstands and a lamp, and a strongbox under the table, and a bust of Augustus with a chipped ear, and the shutters were closed.

"Sit down."

She sat.

"You are going to Surrentum," Corvus said. "The ship sails on the day after tomorrow from Ostia. There will be a woman with you, and a purse of four thousand sesterces, and a letter to your mother in which I have said that you were recovered through the courts and that the family of Corvus regrets the delay and the distress." He folded his hands. "It is not enough. I know it is not enough. It is what I can do."

"Why are you doing it?"

"Because it is the right thing to do."

Leda looked at him.

"That is not the reason," she said. "A man like you does not do a thing because it is right; he does it because he has worked out that it is cheaper than the alternative." She sat back. "What is the alternative?"

Corvus's mouth tightened.

"The alternative," he said, "is that you remain in Rome, and my son remains in Rome, and the two of you do something foolish in the autumn, and I have to decide whether to disown him or have you removed from the city. The ship is cheaper." He looked at her. "You are a very direct young woman."

"I have been sold twice," Leda said. "It teaches you to ask the price."

The room was quiet. In the garden a bird was making a noise.

"May I ask you something?" she said.

"You may."

"Did you know what your father was?"

Corvus did not move.

"That is not a question for this room."

"It is the only room in this house where it can be asked." She leaned forward. "I have heard the servants. I have heard the story that goes round the kitchen when the family is not there: that there was a girl in this house before I was born, and that the old consul hurt her,

and that she killed him, and that the son sent her away. I have heard it four times in three days from four different people, and it is always the same story, and every one of them stops when I come into the kitchen." She looked at him. "I stood in a basilica and told six hundred men what a man did to me in a passage. I would like to hear one true thing from somebody in this house."

Corvus sat with his hands on the table.

"Yes," he said. "I knew."

"Did you stop him?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because I was twenty-four years old," Corvus said, "and because he was my father, and because I had spent my whole life learning not to be the thing that stopped him, and because I stood in the doorway for three heartbeats and I did not move." He looked at the table. "I have not said that sentence out loud in seventeen years. I have thought it every day."

Leda was silent for a moment.

"Then you know," she said, "what it is to stand in a doorway and not move."

"Yes."

"And you did it again, this year, when a boy was killed in her house."

Corvus's head came up.

"I did not know about the boy."

"No," Leda said. "That is what everyone says. *I did not know.* The cook did not know what was in the packet. The steward did not know what the money was for. You did not know about the boy. Everybody in this city is standing in a doorway saying that they did not know, and the boy is dead, and the girl fell, and a woman is going into exile." She stood up. "I am not going to forgive you. I want you to know that. I am going to get on the ship and I am going to Surren-

tum and I am going to have a life, and I am not going to think about this house again, and the reason I am not going to think about it is not that I have forgiven anybody. It is that I have decided not to carry it."

Corvus stood up.

"That is wise," he said.

"No," said Leda. "It is the only thing left."

She went to the door.

"Leda."

She stopped.

"When you see your mother," Corvus said, "tell her—" He stopped, and looked at the table, and then at the shuttered window. "There is nothing to tell her. I am sorry. That is all. Tell her that a man in Rome is sorry, and that it is worth nothing, and that I know it is worth nothing."

Leda looked at him for a moment.

"I will tell her," she said, "that her daughter was in a house where a man was sorry, and that it was not enough, and that she should not expect anything from Rome."

She went out.

Marcus came to her at the second hour of the night.

She was awake; she had not been sleeping. There was a scratch at the door, and then the door opened, and he came in with a lamp shaded by his hand, and shut it behind him, and stood there looking at her.

He had a bruise on his cheek that had gone yellow at the edges, and his lip was healing badly, and he was thinner than he had been by the river.

"You should not be here," she said.

"I know."

"If they find you here—"

"I know." He set the lamp down on the chest. "I have three minutes. There is a man at the stair who is a client of my father's and who owes me a favour, and he will cough twice when my grandmother's door opens." He sat down on the floor with his back against the bed, exactly as he had in her room at the Myrtle, and it was such a familiar thing that she had to look away. "I have been going out of my mind in that room."

"Your sister told me."

"Did she?"

"She told me about Syria."

Marcus was quiet for a moment.

"There is no Syria," he said. "There is only my grandmother, and she has decided, and my father does nothing, because my father is finished. Did you know? He went to the prefect's office at the second hour and he was there until the evening, and when he came back he went into his study and he has not come out. The clerks are saying that the emperor will be written to. The consulship will be withdrawn. He will be expelled from the Senate, or he will be allowed to resign, and either way it is finished." He looked up at her. "He has not spoken to me since the trial. He stood up in that basilica and told six hundred men that a girl had been sent away from his father's house with a purse, and then he came home and shut the door, and I have not been able to ask him why."

"Because he is ashamed."

"Because he is a coward," Marcus said. "You told me that at the river and I did not believe you. I have believed it for a week."

Leda looked at him.

"There is a thing I have to tell you," she said, "and I would rather tell it to you now, in this room, than in a letter."

"Don't."

"I am going to Surrentum."

"I know."

"I am going to Surrentum, and I am going to find my mother, and I am going to be a woman in a town by the sea with a name and a mother and a brother, and I am going to be respectable." She said the word as though it were a stone in her mouth. "And I am not going to be the woman who ran away with a Claudius."

Marcus looked at the floor.

"That is not what I asked you," he said.

"It is what you asked me in the portico of Portunus, and it is what you asked me in my room at the Myrtle, and I have said yes to you twice, and both times I was lying." She sat up. "I was not lying because I did not want you. I was lying because I did want you, and because a woman in my position will say anything to a boy who is kind to her, because kindness is the only thing she has ever been given for nothing, and she does not know what to do with it." She reached out and took his hand, and held it hard. "I am not going to spend the rest of my life being the woman who ruined Marcus Claudius Corvus. I have been a thing that men did things to since I was eleven. I am not going to be that for you."

"Then I will come to Surrentum."

"You will not."

"I will come. In the spring, when the legion goes east, I will not go with it. I will sell the horse and I will come to Surrentum and I will stand in the market and I will ask for the house of Vibia Prima, and if your mother turns me out of the door I will sleep in the street."

Leda looked at him for a long moment.

"You are twenty years old," she said.

"Yes."

"And you have never in your life had to do anything you did not want to do, except the army, and you did that because your father's name was on the commission." She let go of his hand. "You will come to Surrentum in the spring, and there will be a letter from your grandmother waiting at the inn, and you will read it, and you will go

back. Or you will come, and you will stay a month, and then the money will run out, and you will write to your father, and he will send it, and you will go back."

"Leda—"

"I am not saying it to hurt you. I am saying it because I have been poor since I was eleven years old and I know what money does to a man who has never been without it." She looked at him. "Go to Syria. Be a soldier. Be a consul. Marry Vinicia Sabina and be kind to her and have sons and grow old, and in twenty years, when you are in the Senate and there is a debate about something, you will remember a night in a portico by a river and you will be sad for an hour, and then you will go home to dinner."

Marcus stood up.

"How dare you," he said.

"I am telling you the truth."

"You are telling me the truth the way my father tells the truth." He was shaking. "You are telling me what is good for me. You are telling me what the world is. You are telling me to go away and be respectable, and you are doing it out of kindness, and it is the worst thing anyone has ever done to me."

Leda stood up.

"Then it is the last thing I will ever do to you," she said. "Go to your room, Marcus. And when they put you on the ship in the autumn, do not write to me. I will not answer."

He looked at her.

There was a scratching at the door, and then two soft coughs.

Marcus picked up his lamp and went out, and the door closed, and Leda stood in the middle of the room in the dark with her hands over her face.

She lay on the bed for a long time with her eyes open.

The house made its noises: a door, a chain, a slave's feet in the corridor, the water in the impluvium, the wind in the fig tree. Some-

where below, a man was laughing, and then he stopped, and the house was quiet.

She thought about Antonia Cassia in the courtyard with her sleeves rolled up, washing the fountain herself because she could not sit still. She thought about Prisca on the kerb in the street with her face in her hands. She thought about the boy in the yard behind the bakery and his eleven sesterces in a rag and the fact that she had never told him that she knew about the money, and that he had never told her about the bakery, and that they had both been keeping a small secret from each other in a house where everything else was known.

She thought: *if I had gone to the gate at the Nones I would be on a boat now.*

And then she thought: *no. I would be in a villa at Ficulea with a man at the gate, or I would be dead in a ditch on the road to Ostia, and Marcus would be in a cell, and there would be nobody to say the mark in the basilica.*

She got up and went to the chest and took out the shell and held it in her fist.

Tomorrow I will ask the old woman for the money for the passage and I will go to Ostia by myself, she thought. *I will walk if I have to. I have walked further than this.*

She did not sleep.

At the fourth hour of the night she got up and put on her shawl and went out onto the upper gallery.

It was a Roman house of the old kind, built around a small atrium with a roof open to the sky, and there was a gallery on the upper floor that ran around three sides of it with a wooden rail, and she stood at the rail and looked down into the dark of the atrium.

The house was quiet. Somewhere a slave was coughing in his sleep. The water in the impluvium caught the moonlight in a small square, and the painted gods in the shrine were black shapes in the

corner, and the whole of the house of the Claudii Corvi lay below her like a thing asleep.

She thought about the room at the Myrtle with the window the size of a bread board, and the fountain with the bronze myrtle in it, and the women sleeping around the brazier at the Saturnalia, and Calybe singing in Bithynian.

She thought about the beach at Surrentum and her brother getting smaller.

She thought: *I will go tomorrow. I will ask the old woman for the money for the passage and I will go to Ostia in the morning and I will be a woman in a town by the sea.*

And then she thought: *I am twenty-one years old and I have no money and no papers and no trade but singing, and my mother has been looking for a girl of eleven for ten years, and when she sees me she will be disappointed.*

The gallery creaked.

She turned.

Claudia Junia stood at the top of the stairs in a dark mantle with a lamp in her hand.

"I thought it was the girl," she said.

"It is the girl."

"You are not asleep."

"No."

The old woman came along the gallery. She was small and straight and she moved without any noise at all, and the lamp in her hand made the shadows of the pillars go up the wall.

"You have been crying," she said.

"Yes."

"At your age one cries at night and is ashamed in the morning." She stopped three feet away. "I have come to tell you what will happen. There is a ship at Ostia on the day after tomorrow; it goes to Puteoli and then to Surrentum, and there will be a woman from my

household on it with you, and a purse, and a letter to your mother. You will leave this house at dawn on the day after tomorrow, and you will not see my grandson again, and in a year you will be married, and in ten years you will be a wife in a town by the sea and this will be a thing that happened to you when you were young."

"I know."

"Good."

Leda looked at her.

"Why did you keep the letter?" she said. "The one she sent you. The one from my mistress, eleven years ago."

The old woman was silent.

"I read it," Leda said. "It was in the box in your room, and the box was on the bench in the atrium, and I have been in this house for two days and no one has told me anything, so I read it." She was not sorry. "It says that she has not spoken and will not speak and does not want anything from you, and that she is writing because she wants you to know that she is alive."

"I know what it says."

"Then why did you keep it?"

Claudia Junia looked at her for a long moment.

"Because she was twenty-three years old," she said, "and she had killed my husband, and she wrote to me and did not beg. I have been in this city for sixty-three years and I have been surrounded all my life by people who wanted something. My husband wanted my dowry. My son wanted my approval. My daughter wanted a husband. The priests wanted a donation. The clients wanted a loan. And once, in seventeen years, a woman wrote to me and said: *I want nothing from you.*" She held the lamp very steady. "I have kept the letter because it is the only thing in this house that was ever given to me for nothing."

Leda stared at her.

"You could have answered it," she said.

"Yes."

"You could have helped her."

"Yes."

"Why did you not?"

"Because she was a whore," said Claudia Junia, "and because if I had answered it she would have been in my life, and my son would have been in hers, and the whole thing would have come up out of the ground, and the family would have fallen. And because I am a woman who has spent her life keeping a house standing, and I have made a great many choices in sixty-three years, and that was one of them, and I have not been sorry about it for a single day." Her voice did not change. "I am not sorry now. I am telling you the truth because you are a girl of twenty-one who is going to a town by the sea and will never see me again, and because there is no one else in this house I can tell it to."

The gallery creaked again.

Leda put her hand on the rail.

"I am not going to Surrentum," she said.

The old woman's face did not move.

"You are going the day after tomorrow."

"No." Leda shook her head. "I have been sent from one place to another since I was eleven years old. I was sold at Puteoli and bought at Puteoli and taken to a house on the Vicus Tuscus, and then I was taken out of that house in a litter and brought here, and now I am to be put on a ship and sent to a mother I do not remember, and every one of those things was decided by a person who was being kind to me." She looked at the old woman. "I am not going. I will go to Surrentum when I choose and I will go by myself, and if I have to walk, I will walk."

"Then you will walk out of this house tonight," Claudia Junia said, "with no money and no papers, and you will be a free woman in Rome with nothing, which is the worst thing in the world to be."

"I would rather be that than be sent."

The old woman reached out and took her by the wrist.

It was not a hard grip. She was sixty-three years old and her hand was thin and dry and not strong, and she took Leda's wrist the way a woman takes the wrist of a child who is going toward a fire.

"Come away from the rail," she said.

Leda pulled her arm back.

It was not a violent thing either. She pulled her arm back and stepped away, one step, and her heel caught the hem of her shawl, and she put her hand out and it found the rail.

The rail was old.

That was what the carpenter said afterward, when they sent for him: that the rail was original to the house, that it was four hundred years old, and that the pegs had rotted in the mortice, and that a man leaning on it in the daylight would have felt it give. He said it in the way that a man says a thing when he has been asked by a great house to explain how a girl came to fall, and he said it more than once, and it was true.

The rail went.

Leda fell backward and the rail went with her, and she did not scream; she made a sound like a woman who has been surprised, and she put out both hands, and the old woman's hand closed on the air where her wrist had been.

It was two and a half times the height of a man from the gallery to the floor of the atrium, and she hit the edge of the impluvium.

She did not die.

That was the thing that everyone said afterward, in the house and in the street and in the Forum: that she did not die. She lay on the floor of the atrium of the house of the Claudii Corvi with her legs at an angle that a leg should not be at, and her eyes open, and she was breathing.

Claudia Junia stood at the rail with the lamp in her hand and looked down.

Then she began to scream for the slaves.

What happened next happened in a house that was already awake.

The slaves came from the kitchen and the corridor and the back stairs, and somebody brought a lamp, and somebody brought water in a jug, and a woman began to pray in a language that nobody in the house understood. Marcus came down the stairs three at a time and knelt in the water and put his hands under her head.

"Get the physician," he said.

"He has gone to the village."

"Then get a horse and go to the village and bring him back, and if he will not come, put him on the horse."

Two of the men went out.

Claudia Junia came down the stairs with a lamp in her hand and stood at the bottom and looked at the girl on the floor and the rail hanging loose above her and the broken pieces of wood on the stone, and her face in the lamplight was the face of a woman adding up a column of figures and getting a number she did not like.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Antonia

◆

She was in Tibur when the messenger came.

She had been in Tibur two days, sleeping in the shed behind the smithy on a bench with her cloak over her, because she had not slept in a bed since the cells, and because the boy's papers had to be entered with the duumvirs of the town and the clerk was a slow man with a great deal of business. She had washed her face in the trough in the yard at dawn and had sat on the wall with the boy while the town woke up, and she had begun, in a slow and patient way, to teach him the letters of his own name.

R, she said, and drew it in the dust with a stick.

The boy drew it.

U.

He drew it.

They had got as far as the F when a man came up the road from Rome on a mule, and the man was one of the bearers from the house, and he was covered in dust, and he had ridden the mule into the ground.

"Domina," he said. "You must come."

Antonia stood up.

"What is it?"

"The girl. She has fallen. In the house on the Palatine, from the gallery, in the night, and she is alive, and the physician says she will not last the day." He wiped his face. "She is asking for you. The old woman sent me. She said to tell you that the girl is asking for you and that there is not much time."

Antonia looked at the boy on the wall.

"I have to go," she said.

"I know."

"I will come back."

The boy looked at her with the flat, patient, unsurprised look of a slave who has learned that people who say they will come back do not.

"All right," he said.

She took the mule.

She rode it hard down the Via Nomentana with the dust coming up around her and the sun going higher, and she came into the city by the Nomentan gate at the fourth hour and went up the Clivus Victoriae with the mule stumbling under her, and the streets were full and the people in them turned to look at a woman in a dusty stola on a blown mule.

She rode through the Nomentan gate at the fourth hour and up the Viminal and along the ridge of the Esquiline, and the city came up around her the way it always did: the smell first, then the noise, then the sheer press of people who had nothing to do with any of it.

There was a crowd outside the house on the Palatine.

Not a crowd of the kind that had burned the Myrtle; a smaller, quieter, better-dressed crowd, standing in the street and looking at the door. There were four litters at the corner and a group of young men in good cloaks who had plainly come up from the Forum to see whether there was anything to see.

A woman in the crowd said, "That is her. That is the one from the trial."

Antonia got down off the mule.

She went up the street with the dust on her and her hair coming down, and the crowd made way for her, and she heard them saying it as she passed: *that is the one, that is Antonia Cassia, she is the one who told the story about the consul, she is not permitted in Rome, look at her, she is not permitted in Rome and there she is.*

The door of the house of the Claudii Corvi was open.

There were people in the atrium.

The impluvium had been emptied and scrubbed, and there was still a dark stain in the seam of the marble that no one had got to, and a bucket and a cloth standing beside it, and a slave woman sitting on the bench by the shrine with her face in her hands.

Doris took her up the stairs.

The room was the best room, with the window that looked over the garden, and the bed with the carved footboard, and the good wool coverlet. They had put her in the bed and propped her up with cushions and there was a physician standing at the foot with his hands behind his back and his bag on the floor, and there was a woman in the corner with a bowl of water and cloths.

And Marcus was on his knees by the bed with his face against the coverlet.

Leda was lying with her head on the pillows and her eyes open.

Her face was unmarked. That was the first thing Antonia saw, and it was the thing she would remember: that Leda's face was unmarked and beautiful and entirely herself, and that the rest of her was a ruin. There was a splint on her left leg and a bandage around her middle, and blood had come through it in a small red flower, and her hands lay on the coverlet and they were the only part of her that moved.

"Domina," she said.

Antonia went to the bed and sat on the edge of it and took her hand.

"I am here," she said.

"You are dusty."

"I rode from Tibur."

"On a mule?"

"On a mule."

Leda laughed, and then stopped, and her face went white, and the woman in the corner came forward with a cloth, and Leda waved her away.

"It hurts," she said. "It hurts all the time and then it goes away and I think it has stopped, and then it comes back. The physician says my back is broken and that there is blood inside me and that it will not stop. He says I will sleep soon and not wake up. He says it in front of me, as though I were a piece of furniture. I would have liked him to lie to me. I have been lied to by better men."

"Leda—"

"I am not frightened," Leda said. "That is the strange thing. I have been frightened since I was eleven years old and now I am not frightened at all, and I do not know whether it is because I am dying or because I have finally stopped being a thing that things happen to." She turned her head on the pillow. "Marcus. Get up."

Marcus did not get up.

"Marcus."

He raised his head. His face was a wreck; his eyes were swollen and his nose was running and he looked, for the first time since Antonia had met him, like a boy of twenty.

"Get up," Leda said, "and go and stand by the window, and do not turn around until I tell you."

He got up and went to the window.

Leda looked at Antonia.

"I have three things to ask you," she said, "and then I will sleep."

"Ask."

"The first is my mother." Her voice was very low. "She is at Surrentum. There is a house in the wine quarter by the gate and her name is Vibia Prima and she has been petitioning governors for ten years. You will go to her, and you will tell her what happened to me, and you will not make it beautiful. You will tell her that I was sold and bought and that I sang in a house on the Vicus Tuscus, and that I was not a virgin when I died, and that I was loved by a boy of a good family who was not able to help me, and that I died in a great house on the Palatine because a rail was rotten." She stopped and breathed. "And you will tell her that I remembered the wasp song. Tell her that. She will know what it means. Tell her that I could not remember the words but that I remembered the tune, and that I sang it in a yard at Puteoli when a woman came to look at me, and that it was the only thing I had left of her."

"I will tell her."

"The second is the shell." Leda moved her hand on the coverlet. "It is in the chest, in the room. It is a cowrie, pink and white, and it has a worn place where my thumb goes. My brother gave it to me on the beach the morning the men came. Put it in my hand when they burn me. Not on my eyes; the coin is for the ferryman. In my hand."

"I will put it in your hand."

"And my brother," Leda said. "Gaius. He is two years older than me and he has a mark on his chin from a fall off a wall, and he was on the beach when they took me, and he ran." She stopped. "I have thought about it for ten years. I have thought: why did he run? And then I have thought: he was thirteen years old and there were four men in a boat, and what else was he going to do?" She turned her head. "Tell him I do not blame him. Tell him I have never blamed him. Tell him that I remembered the shell and not his face, and that when I remembered his face again it was the best day of the six years."

"I will tell him."

"And tell him not to be sorry." Her voice was going. "Everybody in this city is sorry. The consul is sorry. The steward is sorry. My mistress is sorry. There is a whole city of people who are sorry and a boy in a yard and a girl on a floor, and it has not helped either of them." She closed her eyes. "Tell him to be glad. Tell him that I was in a house with a fountain and I learned to sing and I was loved by a boy, and that there was one afternoon when I was ten and we swam out to the rock and he held my hand in the water, and tell him to be glad about that and not sorry about the rest."

"The third is this." Leda looked up at the ceiling. "I want you to burn the box."

"What box?"

"The box you keep the letter in. The myrtle box with the letter from him and the pen he gave you, the one you have been carrying from house to house for seventeen years. I have seen you look at it. I have seen you put your hand on it when you thought nobody was watching, the way a woman puts her hand on a door." She turned her head. "Burn it. Not for me. For you. It is a stone in your chest and you have been carrying it since you were twenty-three and it will kill you the way it killed him, sitting in a room with it."

Antonia looked at her.

"I will burn it," she said.

"Say it as though you mean it."

"I will burn it," Antonia said, "and I will put the shell in your hand, and I will go to Surrentum and tell your mother about the wasp song."

Leda closed her eyes.

"Good," she said.

"Tell me about the house," Leda said.

Antonia looked at her.

"The house is closed," she said. "The court has taken it. The women are in the Subura, in the house of a fuller's widow, and they are well."

"And the cook?"

"Calybe is alive. She is in the cells and she will be brought to the basilica and she will be freed."

"And Tiro?"

Antonia did not answer.

Leda turned her head on the pillow.

"You are a bad liar," she said. "You have always been a bad liar. It is the only thing about you that is any good."

"The house burned," Antonia said. "The night after the first day of the trial. A crowd came up from the Forum and put a torch to the door and the roof went. The women got out. Tiro went back in for the strongbox and came out with the papers and the floor went, and he died in the street."

Leda closed her eyes.

"Did he suffer?"

"Yes."

"Was he afraid?"

"I do not know. The woman who was with him said he asked for me and said the box was out." Antonia's voice was steady. "And then he said something about a boy at Tibur."

Leda was quiet for a while.

"He was going to buy his son," she said.

"Yes."

"Did he?"

"Yes."

"Good," Leda said. "That is good. That is one thing."

She shifted on the pillow and her face went white, and Antonia took her hand and held it until it passed.

"There is a thing I have been thinking about," Leda said, when she could speak. "In the basilica. When I said the mark, and the whole hall went quiet, and I thought: they believe me. Six hundred men and they believe me. And it was the first time in my life that anyone had believed a thing I said without being paid to." She opened her eyes. "I am not sorry I did it. I want you to know that. Whatever happens to me, I am not sorry."

"I know."

"And I am not sorry about Marcus." Her voice was very faint. "I am sorry for what it will do to him. But I am not sorry. He was the only person who ever asked me what I wanted and then waited for the answer."

"I know."

"Tell him that."

"I will tell him."

The physician came forward and said something about the hour, and Antonia said, "Get out," and he looked at her and then at the woman in the corner and then went out, and the woman went with him.

Marcus stood at the window with his back to the room.

She slept for a while in the afternoon, and woke, and asked for water, and could not keep it down.

The physician came back at the ninth hour with a bag of instruments and stood at the foot of the bed and said, in the flat voice of a man who has decided that honesty is a form of professional integrity, that the blood inside her had not stopped, that there was nothing to be done that would not make the last hours worse, and that she might live until morning or might not.

"Get out," Antonia said.

"Domina, I have a duty—"

"You have a duty to a fee and you have been paid, and the fee was for the diagnosis and not for standing at the foot of the bed telling a girl she is going to die in the third person. Get out."

He went out.

Marcus had not moved from the window.

"Marcus."

He turned.

"Come and sit with her," Antonia said. "Not at the window. Here. Take her hand and sit on the floor if you cannot sit on the bed, and do not say anything clever, and do not tell her that it is going to be all right, because she knows and she has known since the fourth hour and she is not afraid." She stood up. "I am going to find the woman and get a clean cloth and I am going to be in the corridor. I will be back in a quarter of an hour. Do not leave her alone."

She went out and stood in the corridor with her back against the wall and her eyes shut.

Twenty-one, she thought. *Twelve and twenty-one. A boy and a girl. That is what this year has cost, and it is not the end of it, and I am forty years old and I have nothing, and I do not know how a person goes on from this.*

She went back in after a while.

The afternoon went on. The light came through the window and moved across the floor and up the wall. Somewhere in the house a door closed and a woman began to cry and was told to be quiet. Outside, the city made its noise: the carts, the hammers, a man calling a price, a dog.

Leda slept for a while.

When she woke her voice was weaker and her hands were cold.

"Tell me a thing," she said. "Tell me a true thing. Not a kind one."

"What do you want to know?"

"Was it worth it?" Leda's eyes were on her. "The house. The fountain. The dinners. Seventeen years of counting and being careful and not trusting anyone. Was it worth it?"

Antonia sat with her hand in both of hers.

"No," she said.

"No?"

"I built a house and filled it with women and made myself rich enough that senators came to my door, and I told myself that it was freedom, and it was not freedom. It was a room with a lock on the inside of the door and no windows. I was afraid every day for seventeen years. I was afraid of the prefect and the Senate and the man on the Palatine with the pen in his box, and I was afraid of the women in my own house, and I was afraid of you." She looked at the girl's hand in hers. "I bought you. I told myself I had saved you, and I bought you, and you sang for men for six years and I took the money, and I told myself that you were not being given to men, and it was true and it was a lie at the same time, and I have known it every night."

Leda was quiet for a moment.

"Then why did you do it?"

"Because I was fourteen when they sold me," Antonia said, "and nobody built a house for me. And because I found that a woman alone in this city has two choices: she can be a thing that men do things to, or she can be the woman who owns the house, and I chose, and I chose every day for seventeen years, and I chose it over and over again, and each time I chose it I lost something, and I did not notice what I was losing until a boy of twelve was strangled in a yard for carrying a lamp." She looked up. "It was not worth it. But I did not know that until it was too late to do anything but try to be a better woman with what was left."

Leda smiled.

"That is a true thing," she said.

"It is."

"Then I will tell you a true thing." Her voice was very faint now. "I loved you. Not the way I loved Marcus, and not the way I loved my mother, who I do not remember. I loved you the way a person loves the door of a house that is not on fire. You were the first person in six years who did not want to put their hand on me, and I would have died for you, and I have spent the last month finding out that you were not worth dying for, and I am glad. Do you understand? I am glad. Because if you had been worth it I would have died for you, and I would never have found out what it was like to be a woman who chose."

Antonia could not speak.

"Marcus," Leda said.

He came from the window and knelt by the bed.

"I am sorry," he said. "I am sorry, I am sorry—"

"Stop." She got her hand out from under the covers and put it on his head. "You did nothing wrong. You are the only person in this whole city who did nothing wrong, and you will spend the rest of your life thinking that you should have done something, and I am telling you now, while I can still tell you, that there was nothing you could have done." She stroked his hair. "Go to Syria. Do not come back for me. Do not be sad for too long. Be a good man, and be kind to your wife, and when you are old and somebody asks you about your life, tell them about a night in a portico by a river and a girl who was free for a month."

He put his face in the coverlet and wept.

Leda looked past him at the ceiling.

"Tell me the wasp song," she said.

"I do not know it."

"Neither do I." Her eyes were closing. "I only know the tune. Sing it. It does not matter if the words are wrong."

Antonia sang.

She did not know the tune either. She hummed something, a low thing with no shape to it, and after a while she began to make words up, about a girl on a shore and a ship and a summer, and it was a bad song and she sang it badly, and the light went off the wall and the room got grey.

At the end, Leda's hand went slack.

Antonia sat with her until the woman came back with the cloths and the bowl, and then she stood up, and her legs were not steady, and she stood in the middle of the room of the house of the Claudii Corvi and looked at the girl in the bed.

Marcus was on the floor with his back against the wall.

"She is dead," he said.

"Yes."

"She was twenty-one."

"Yes."

"I am going to kill my grandmother."

"No," Antonia said. "You are not."

"I am going to—"

"No." She turned to him. "You are twenty years old and you are the last man of the Claudii Corvi, and if you do that you will be tried and executed and the house will end, and she will have won. Do you understand me? She will have won. She has spent her whole life keeping that name standing, and you are the name now, and the only thing you can do that will hurt her is to live and be a better man than she is." She looked at him. "And because the girl asked you not to be sad for too long, and because she was right about everything except your grandmother."

Marcus looked up at her.

"You are going," he said.

"Yes."

"Where?"

"To Surrentum," Antonia said, "with a shell and a story."

They washed her in the room, because the house was in an uproar and there was nobody to tell them not to.

Doris brought the water and the cloths, and Antonia did it herself, with Doris on the other side of the bed, and they did it the way the women had washed the boy in the atrium on the Vicus Tuscus: the face first, and then the hands, and then the rest, with the door shut.

There was a great deal of blood. It had pooled inside her and it came away on the cloths, and there was a bruise on her hip the size of a man's hand where she had hit the edge of the impluvium, and the leg with the splint on it was not straight.

Antonia washed her and did not say anything.

There is a way of doing this, she thought. *There is a way of doing this that the women of this city have known for a thousand years, and it is not to weep while you are doing it, because the dead are not helped by tears and the living have work to do.*

Doris put a coin on each eye and closed them with her thumb.

"She should have a wreath," she said.

"There is myrtle in the garden."

"I will get it."

Antonia was alone with her for a moment.

She took the shell out of her sleeve. It was a small pink-and-white cowrie with a worn place where a thumb had gone, and she had carried it from the chest in the room to here, and she put it into Leda's right hand and closed the fingers over it, one at a time, the way you close the fingers of a child on a coin.

"Here," she said. "This is yours. It was always yours."

Doris came back with the myrtle and they put it on her head, and it was too big, the way the wreath on the boy had been too big, and it kept slipping sideways, and Antonia took it off and put it lower, on the brow, and it stayed.

Then she stood at the foot of the bed and looked at what was left of a girl of twenty-one who had been taken off a beach when she was eleven and had sung in a house on the Vicus Tuscus for six years, and who had stood in a basilica in front of six hundred men and said what she saw, and who was, in the whole of that city, the only person who had told the truth from beginning to end.

There was a knock at the door.

It was Caesia.

She came in with her hands behind her back and stood at the end of the bed, and she looked at Leda for a long time, and then she said, "I am sorry."

"Yes," Antonia said.

"I did not do anything. I want you to know that. I have been in this house all my life and I have never done anything, and now there is a girl dead in the best room and a woman going into exile, and I am going to be married in the spring to a man called Vinicius, and I will have a house, and I will be able to do things in it." She looked up. "What should I do?"

Antonia looked at her.

"When you have your house," she said, "and there is a girl in it who is frightened, do not ask her whether she is well. Ask her what she wants. And then find out who is preventing her from having it, and stop them." She turned away. "It is not a great deal. It is more than anybody in this house did for her."

Caesia nodded slowly.

"I will remember," she said.

She went out.

Antonia went down the stairs into the atrium, where Claudia Junia was standing by the shrine with her hands folded.

The old woman was very pale, and she was standing straight, and she had put on a clean stola, and she looked at Antonia the way she had looked at her the first time, thirty years before, in that same

room, when Antonia was seventeen and had been brought in from the kitchen with her hands still wet.

"Where is she?" Antonia said.

"Gone," Claudia Junia said. "The slaves have taken her to be washed."

Antonia hit her.

It was not a slap. It was a closed fist, and it caught the old woman on the side of the face and knocked her against the shrine, and the little painted figures went over and one of them broke on the floor.

Claudia Junia put her hand to her cheek and looked at the blood on it, and then she looked up, and her eyes were the same pale colour as her son's.

"Are you satisfied?" she said.

"No," Antonia said. "I have been hitting people for a month and it has not satisfied me once."

"It was an accident."

"I know it was an accident. The carpenter has been to see the rail and he has told everyone in the street that the rail was rotten, and he is telling the truth, and it will not help either of us." Antonia stood over her. "You reached out and took her by the wrist and she pulled away. That is what happened. I have it from the girl, and from the rail, and from the fact that you are standing in this room at all, because a woman who pushes another woman over a rail does not stay in the house to be looked at."

Claudia Junia was silent.

"You will not be tried," Antonia said. "There will be no trial. A free woman fell in a great house and broke her back, and the carpenter will say the rail was rotten, and the prefect will not want another scandal in the same month, and the whole thing will be an accident in the record. I know this city. I know how it works. I have spent my whole life being crushed by it and I know exactly how much it costs to make a thing an accident."

"What do you want?"

"I want you to live," Antonia said, "in this house, with the rail, and the shrine, and the broken god on the floor, and your son, and your grandson. I want you to have exactly what you have been fighting for." She turned to go. "And when you die, and you will die in that bed upstairs, I want you to remember that the only thing you ever gave to anybody for nothing was a letter you did not answer."

She went out into the street.

The sun was going down over the roof of the temple of Apollo, and the whole of the Palatine was gold, and the city below was beginning to light its lamps.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Corvus

The Senate met on the fourth day after the girl died, and Corvus stood up in the body of the house and read out his own resignation in a voice that he did not recognize.

He had written it in the night, at his father's table, in the study with the shutters closed. It was four sentences long. It said that he had been honoured beyond his deserts; that circumstances had arisen which made it impossible for him to take up the office without injury to the dignity of the Senate; that he begged leave to withdraw his name; and that he thanked the house for its forbearance. He had read it over three times and had changed nothing, because there was nothing in it that was not true and nothing in it that was not a lie.

The house listened in silence.

When he had finished, the presiding consul said, "The Senate has heard the resignation of Gaius Claudius Corvus, and accepts it, and records its thanks for his long service." And then he said the other thing, the thing that had been agreed in the antechambers before the session, in the way that such things are agreed: "The Senate will also consider, at its next sitting, the question of the conduct of Gaius

Claudius Corvus in the matter of the death of his father, Lucius Claudius Corvus, consul, seventeen years ago."

One man rose.

He was old, and he had been consul in the reign of Domitian, and he had a great name and a bad temper and no money, and Corvus had known him for twenty years and had never liked him.

"Fathers," the old man said. "I did not know Lucius Claudius Corvus well, and what I knew I did not like. He was a hard man in a hard time and he did very well out of it. But I know his son, and I have watched him in this house for nineteen years, and I have never once seen him take a bribe, or protect a friend at the expense of the state, or say a thing he did not believe." He looked around the chamber. "If every man in this room were to be judged on the worst hour of his life, there would be nobody left to vote."

There was a murmur.

Another man rose, and he was young, and he had been praetor the year before, and he had ambitions.

"The house is grateful to the consular for his sentiments," he said, "but the question before us is not whether a man may be judged on the worst hour of his life. The question is whether a man who was present at the death of a consul, and who concealed it for seventeen years, and who is now to be consul himself; whether such a man may be permitted to take the seat without the house having considered the matter." He paused. "I say that he may not. I say that the house must consider it, and that it must consider it in public, and that if it does not, the city will consider it for us, in the street, with torches."

Corvus stood in the middle of the floor and listened to them both, and it occurred to him that he had spent nineteen years in that room and had never once heard a man say a thing that was entirely true, including himself.

There was no debate. There was no vote. There was a murmur of assent, which is what the Senate does instead of a vote when it wishes to be able to say afterward that nothing was decided.

Corvus went out through the doors of the Curia into the light.

The building works were going on as they always went on. A crane was swinging a block of marble through the air, and the dust was coming down over everything, and a foreman was shouting at a man in Greek. Corvus stood at the top of the steps and looked at it for a while.

Men came past him and did not stop. That was the thing he had not expected: that it would be so quick. In nineteen years he had never walked through the Forum without being stopped four or five times. He walked the whole length of the Sacred Way and up the hill and no one spoke to him at all. Two men looked at him and then looked away. One, a knight who had been a client of his father's, crossed the street.

The house was quiet when he came in.

The slaves had begun to leave. He had expected that; a great house runs on the expectation of favour, and when the favour goes the household goes with it, quietly, a few at a time, taking what they can carry. Three of the bearers had gone in the night. The cook had gone. The boy who carried the water was still there, because he was eleven and did not understand, and because nobody had told him to go.

His mother was in the atrium with her cheek still bruised, spinning.

"Marcus is gone," she said.

Corvus stopped.

"Gone where?"

"To Ostia. He went this morning, on the horse, with a bag. He came to me before he went and he stood in that doorway and he said: *I am going to Syria, and I will not write, and when I come back I will*

not live in this house." She turned the spindle. "He said it very quietly. He has your way of saying things quietly."

"Did you try to stop him?"

"No."

"Why not?"

Claudia Junia looked up.

"Because he looked at me," she said, "the way his grandfather used to look at me, when he had decided something and was waiting to see whether I would be foolish enough to argue." She set the spindle down. "I have lost the argument, Gaius. I lost it in the basilica when you stood up and told six hundred men that a girl had been sent away with a purse, and I lost it on the gallery when the rail went. There is nothing left to argue about."

Corvus stood in the atrium of his father's house.

"I have resigned the consulship," he said.

"I know. It was in the street by the second hour."

"The Senate will consider my conduct at its next sitting."

"I know that too." She picked up the wool again, and her hands were steady, and her voice was the voice she used for discussing the price of oil. "They will not try you. They will pass a resolution expressing concern, and they will ask the emperor's opinion, and the emperor will write a letter in the spring saying that the matter is best forgotten, and it will be forgotten, because there is a war coming in the east and nobody in Rome cares about a consul who died seventeen years ago." She wound the wool. "You will not be expelled. You will not be tried. You will simply be a man who was consul-designate and is not, and who lives in a house on the Palatine with his mother, and in ten years nobody will remember why."

"That is worse."

"Yes," said his mother. "That is what I have been trying to tell you for thirty years. There are worse things than disgrace. Disgrace is

at least a thing that happens to a man. This is a thing that happens to a name."

She went on spinning.

He wrote three letters that afternoon and burned all three.

The first was to the emperor, and it was four paragraphs long, and it explained that the consul-designate had been present at the death of his father seventeen years before and had concealed it, and it asked for the emperor's judgment on whether such a man should hold the office. He read it over and found that it was true and that it was also a performance, and he burned it.

The second was to Marcus, at the legion in Syria, and it was one line long. He could not think of a second line. He burned it.

The third was to Antonia Cassia, at the house of the fuller's widow in the Subura, and he wrote it in the clear careful hand of a man who has been writing official letters for twenty years, and it said: *I have resigned the consulship and the Senate will consider my conduct. I am not writing to ask you for anything. I am writing because you said in the shrine that I had never once said what I meant, and I find that I would like to try, once, before I die.*

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he burned it, and went down to the kitchen and asked the boy for water, and the boy gave it to him and did not look at him, and Corvus stood in the kitchen of his father's house and drank a cup of water and thought about the fact that he had never in his life made himself a meal or swept a floor or filled a lamp.

He went to see Faustus.

The prefect had forbidden it, which meant that it cost money, and Corvus had money for another month or two. He went at the second hour of the night through the back of the basilica with a clerk who did not give his name, and down the corridor that smelled of wet stone, and the man in the third cell was no longer singing.

Faustus was in the last cell.

He was sitting on the bench with his back against the wall and his hands in his lap, and he had been beaten; there was a bruise across his face and his lip was split, and one of his eyes was closed. He looked up when the lamp came, and then he looked away.

"Dominus."

"Faustus."

"You should not be here."

"I know."

"They will say you came to silence me."

"Then they will say it." Corvus stood at the bars. "I have come to ask you a question and then I will go, and you will answer it honestly, because there is nothing left that I can do to you."

Faustus laughed, and then coughed, and the cough went on for a while.

"Ask."

"Why did you do it?"

"I told them in the basilica. I was paid."

"That is not why."

Faustus looked at him with his one open eye.

"No," he said. "That is not why." He shifted on the bench. "Do you remember the winter I came to the house? I was eleven. Your father bought me at Puteoli with a boy called Nicias and a girl whose name I never knew, and he had us brought up to the house in a cart, and it was raining, and we stood in the yard and he came out and looked at us the way a man looks at a new pair of boots." He was quiet for a moment. "He gave me to the tablinum. I was quick with figures. By the time I was twenty I was keeping the accounts of the estate, and by the time I was thirty I was running the house, and he never once said a word to me that was not an instruction or a criticism. Not once, in twenty years." He looked up. "And then one night when I was twenty-four he had me stand at the foot of his couch while he ate, and he threw the bones on the floor and told his

guests that I would pick them up, and I picked them up, because I was a slave, and the guests laughed."

Corvus stood at the bars.

"I did not know that," he said.

"No," said Faustus. "You were in Germany."

"I would have—"

"You would have done nothing. You were nineteen years old and you were in Germany and your father was the consul." Faustus's voice was quiet. "I am not telling you this to make you sorry. I am telling you because you asked, and because I have been in this cell for nine days and there is nobody else to tell." He put his head back against the wall. "When Publius Vettius came to me with the money, I did not think about the old man at all. That is the thing I want you to understand. I thought about the house. I thought: if the old man dies and the son is finished, the estate comes to you, and you will be consul, and the house will go on, and everything I have done for twenty years will have been for something." He closed his eye. "And then I thought about the bones on the floor. Both things at once. That is what a man is, dominus. He is two things at once, and he tells himself the good one."

"Why did you use my household's man?"

"Because I had no one else. A steward cannot walk into a strange house and put something in a cup. I needed a man who could go into a great house and be overlooked, and Callistus was in the kitchen and he was in debt and he was stupid." Faustus opened his eye. "I told him it was a purge for an old man's stomach. That is what I told him. He did not know it was poison. He thought he was playing a trick on a guest for money, and he was proud of it, and I let him think it, and he is dead in the Tiber, and that is on me as well."

"And the boy?"

Faustus was silent for a long time.

"I did not order it," he said. "I want you to know that. I did not order it. The man I sent to watch the house was a man called Verus, who had been in the vigiles, and Verus had a partner, and the partner was a stupid violent man who had been in the army, and when the boy followed me to the Caelian and was seen at the fountain asking questions, the partner did what such men do." He looked at the floor. "I did not order it. I have been telling myself that for nine days. It is true and it is worth nothing."

Corvus put his hand on the bar.

"What do you want?" he said.

"Nothing."

"Faustus—"

"I want you to go away," said Faustus, "and be consul, or not be consul, and live in that house with your mother until you die, and I want to be sent to the mines and to die there in the first year, which I will, because I am forty-five and I have never done a day's labour in my life." He shifted on the bench. "Do not come again. Do not send money. Do not put my name on anything. I have been your father's man and your man for thirty-four years and I am finished, and the only thing I have left is that I did it for the house and not for myself, and I would like to keep that, even though it is a lie."

Corvus stood at the bars for a moment.

"I am sorry," he said.

"Yes," said Faustus. "So am I."

He turned his face to the wall, and Corvus took the lamp and went back up the corridor past the empty cells, and the clerk took him out through the back of the basilica into the street.

Corvus went up to his study and sat down at his father's table.

He stayed there for two days.

He did not eat. The boy brought him bread and water and he did not touch it. He sat at the table with the strongbox open in front of

him and the stylus in his hand, and he looked at the wall, and he thought about his life.

He thought about being twelve years old and standing in the shrine while his father explained the family's ancestry to him, name by name, and the one who had thrown himself on his sword in the latrine at Ephesus, whose name was never to be spoken in the atrium. He thought about being twenty-four and standing in a doorway with a cup in his hand for three heartbeats. He thought about the girl on her knees, and the face of a woman doing sums. He thought about the letter he had written that night, in this room, at this table, with a pen that was not his father's.

Take the purse and go. Say nothing, and you will never see my face again. Say one word, and I will see you dead.

He had written it because he had been afraid. He had been twenty-four years old and his father was dead on the floor of the shrine and there was a slave girl with her back open standing over him, and he had not known what to do, and so he had done the thing that men in his family did: he had made an arrangement, and paid for it, and told himself afterward that it had been mercy.

He had told himself that for seventeen years.

He had told himself that he had saved her. He had given her a purse and her freedom and a letter of warning, and he had let her go, and he had never gone near her, and he had never claimed a sesterce of her fortune, and he had told himself that this was the conduct of a decent man in an impossible situation, and he had believed it, more or less, for seventeen years, in the way that a man believes a thing he has never examined.

And then she had built a house on the Vicus Tuscus and become rich, and the city had begun to talk about her, and he had heard her name in the Senate and had felt the cold thing turn over in his chest, and he had understood that he had not saved her at all. He had bought her silence with a purse and left her to make her own way in a

city that eats women, and the fact that she had succeeded did not make it a kindness. It made it worse. It meant that she had done, alone and with nothing, what four hundred years of his family had not been able to do with everything.

He put the stylus down.

On the third morning a slave came to the door and said that there was a woman below who had come for the body of the girl.

Corvus went down.

She was standing in the atrium in a grey stola with her hair covered, and she looked older than she had in the basilica, and thinner, and she had the look of a woman who has been sleeping in sheds and washing in troughs.

"You are not permitted in Rome," he said.

"I am aware."

"There is a hundred-mile limit."

"There is," said Antonia Cassia, "and I am standing in your atrium, and you may inform the prefect if you wish, and he will fine me a sum I do not have and send me out again, and it will be the third time this month and I think by now he is as tired of it as I am." She looked at him. "I have come for the body. She is to be burned at Surrentum. Her mother has been written to and has sent word that she will take the ashes."

"The body is in the mortuary."

"I know. I have been to the mortuary. They will not release it to me, because I am not kin and because I am under sentence." She said it without expression. "They will release it to you. You are the head of the house in which she died."

Corvus looked at her.

"You want me to give you the body of the girl who died in my house."

"Yes."

"Why would I do that?"

"Because you have a box in your study with a pen in it," Antonia said, "and because there is a rail in your gallery that a carpenter has said was rotten, and because you are a man who has spent his life arranging things so that nothing is ever said out loud, and if you refuse me I will stand in the Forum and say it out loud until someone listens." She came toward him. "Or because you are not entirely a monster, and because you know what your mother did, and because you have not slept in three days."

The atrium was very quiet.

"Come with me," Corvus said.

He took her down through the passage behind the tablinum and into the little room at the back of the house, and the shrine was there, dark with soot, the painted gods scratched out, the altar broken at one corner, and the floor swept clean, because his mother had swept it herself seventeen years before and had never let a slave touch it since.

Antonia stood in the doorway and looked at it.

"I have not been in this room since the night," she said.

"I know."

"How many times have you?"

"Twice a year," Corvus said. "Sometimes three."

She went in and stood in front of the altar.

"Give me the pen," she said.

He took it out of his sleeve. He had carried it down from the study; he did not remember deciding to. It was wrapped in the soft leather, and he unwrapped it, and it lay in his hand, four and a half inches of bronze with a flat end and a point, and a dark stain in the groove that no amount of polishing had ever got out.

Antonia took it and turned it over.

"It is smaller than I remember," she said.

"Everything is."

She held it for a moment. Then she put it down on the broken altar.

"You kept it," she said. "I have thought about that for seventeen years. I thought you kept it as a threat, or as evidence, or because you were afraid. And then I stood in a basilica and looked at you and I understood." She turned. "You kept it because it was the only honest thing in your life."

Corvus looked at the floor.

"Yes," he said.

"Everything else in this house is a lie. The name, the ancestry, the four hundred years, the painted gods, the pit in the atrium, the way you stand and the way you speak and the way you have never once in your life said what you actually meant. It is all a story that the Claudii Corvi tell to keep the walls standing." She picked the stylus up again. "And in this room, on one night, seventeen years ago, a man died because he was a monster, and a girl killed him, and a boy stood in the doorway and did nothing, and all three of those things were true, and none of them was a story. That is why you kept it. It was the only thing you had that was real."

Corvus sat down on the edge of the altar.

"I am going to die," he said.

She did not say anything.

"I have been thinking about it for three days," he said, "and I find that the thinking is not the difficult part. The difficult part is that there is no one to tell. My son has gone to Syria and will not write. My mother is in the atrium with her wool. Faustus is in a cell under the basilica, and he will be sent to the mines, and he will die there, and he did it for me, and I cannot even go and see him because the prefect has forbidden it." He looked up. "And then you came to the door and asked for the body of a girl, and I found that there was someone to tell after all."

"Tell me, then."

He told her.

He told her about the twelve-year-old boy and the names of the consuls of the line, and about the one in Ephesus whose name was never to be spoken; and about the German war, and about the night at Zeugma; and about the fact that he had never loved his wife, who had been a good woman, and had died in childbirth with a child that would have been a daughter; and about Marcus, and the fact that he had never been able to say a single true thing to his own son; and about the consulship, which he had wanted since he was fourteen years old, and which he had wanted, he now understood, only because his father had wanted it, and because a man who has been told all his life that he is the last of a line does not have a self; he has a position.

Antonia listened.

She did not sit down and she did not interrupt and she did not comfort him, and when he had finished she said, "Is that all?"

"Yes."

"Then I will tell you something, and then I will go." She put the stylus in her sleeve. "You have spent your whole life believing that you were the last of the Claudii Corvi and that everything depended on you. It is not true. You are not the last of anything. The name will go on or it will not; your son will marry or he will not; the house will stand or it will fall; and in a hundred years there will be a man in a street in Rome who does not know that any of us existed. That is not a tragedy. It is the only mercy in the world." She looked at him. "The tragedy is that you had forty-one years and a name and a fortune and a son, and you spent them being afraid of a dead man in a room."

Corvus stood up.

"I know," he said.

"Then die if you must," said Antonia Cassia. "I am not going to talk you out of it, and I am not going to hold your hand. I have buried a boy of twelve and I am going to bury a girl of twenty-one,

and I have no more comfort in me; it has all been spent." She went to the door. "Give the order for the body and I will go."

"Stay."

She stopped.

"Stay," Corvus said. "Not for me. There is no one else, and I find that I cannot do it alone. I have done everything alone for forty-one years and I am tired, and I have no right to ask you, and I am asking."

Antonia stood in the doorway for a long moment.

Then she came back into the room and sat down on the bench against the wall, and put her hands in her lap.

"Very well," she said.

He went out and came back with a cup and a small jar, and he set them on the altar, and he looked at them for a while.

"It is hemlock," he said. "I bought it in the Subura. The woman who sold it to me did not know who I was; she was old and half blind and she thought I was a gardener, and I told her it was for the moles." He laughed, once. "That is what Faustus's man told her, too. I heard it in the basilica and I thought: we are all buying poison in the Subura and telling old women it is for the moles."

"Drink it," Antonia said, "or do not. I am not going to watch you make a speech about it."

He looked at her.

"You are the hardest woman I have ever known," he said.

"I am the only woman you have ever known," said Antonia. "That is the whole of it. You have lived among the statues and the names, and I am the one real thing that ever happened to you, and you were afraid of me, and you kept a pen in a box."

Corvus poured the hemlock into the cup.

He drank it.

It was quick, or it was not; she had no way of knowing, because she did not look at him for the first part of it, and when she did look

he was sitting on the floor with his back against the altar and his hands loose in his lap, and his face had gone the colour of paper.

"It is cold," he said.

"Yes."

"I did not think it would be cold."

He turned his head against the marble and looked at her.

"Antonia."

"I am here."

"I am sorry," he said. "Not for all of it. For the doorway. I am sorry that I stood in the doorway."

She looked at him for a long moment.

"I know," she said. "I have known for seventeen years."

He died a little after that, sitting against the altar of his father's house, in the room where his father had died, with the broken god on the floor and the scratched-out paintings on the wall.

Antonia sat on the bench and watched him.

She did not weep. She had wept that morning, in the mortuary, over a girl with a shell in her hand, and there was nothing left.

When it was over she got up and straightened his legs, because a man should not be found sitting, and she put his hands at his sides, and she closed his eyes with her thumb the way the women had closed the boy's eyes on the Vicus Tuscus.

Then she went up the stairs and through the house and out into the street, and she told the slave at the door that his master was dead in the shrine, and she walked down the Clivus Victoriae with the stylus in her sleeve and the sun on her face, and she did not look back.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Antonia

They buried Gaius Claudius Corvus on the third day, in the family tomb on the Via Appia, and nobody came.

That was the thing the city talked about for a week. Not the death; the death was expected, or at least it was the sort of thing that men had begun to expect, and the story of the hemlock in the shrine went round the Forum in an afternoon and was improved in the telling. It was the funeral. A man who had been consul-designate in the spring was carried out of his house on the Via Appia with his mother and his daughter and the household slaves behind the bier, and not one senator walked in the procession.

There had been a debate about it in the antechambers. Some men had wanted to go, out of decency or out of calculation; some had argued that to attend the funeral of a man whose conduct was before the Senate was to prejudge the question. In the end the Senate had done what it always did, which was nothing, and the nothing had been understood by every man in Rome as a message.

Antonia watched from the other side of the road, at the top of the steps of a wine shop, with her hood up.

She had no business being in Rome. The prefect had given her until the end of the month to be gone, and she had stayed, because there was a girl's body to be carried to Surrentum and a ship that did not sail until the Nones of August, and because she had found that a woman who has lost everything is no longer afraid of a fine.

The procession came out of the gate of the house at the fourth hour.

The bier was good. The family had not stinted on it; it was the same ivory and bronze couch that had carried his father, with a new cover, and the eight bearers were the household slaves, and behind it came Claudia Junia in black, walking alone, and Caesia, and then the household, which was eleven people now, and then nothing.

The wax masks of the Claudii Corvi went in front, nine of them, in their little cupboards, carried by hired men.

That was the thing that got into Antonia's chest and stayed there. The masks went first: the consul of the German war, the praetor of the Spanish command, the tribune who had died at Numantia, the one who had thrown himself on his sword in the latrine at Ephesus and whose name was never to be spoken in the atrium. Nine dead men in wax, with the paint flaking off their noses, carried through the streets of Rome by four hirelings at four sesterces apiece, in front of a bier that nobody was following.

She watched them go down the hill and turn toward the Appian gate.

Then she went to the house.

Claudia Junia received her in the atrium, in black, with her hair down, and she looked a hundred years old. She was sitting on the bench by the shrine with her hands in her lap and she did not get up.

"You have come for the will," she said.

"I have come for the letter."

The old woman looked at her.

"The letter you wrote me," Antonia said. "The one you have kept for eleven years. I want it."

"Why?"

"Because I am leaving Italy and I do not want it in this house."

Claudia Junia sat for a moment. Then she said, "In the box on the table by my bed. The key is under the lamp."

Antonia went up.

The room was the room of an old woman: a narrow bed, a stool, a chest, a shrine in the corner with a lamp, a wool basket with the spindle in it. There was a box on the table by the bed, and the key was under the lamp, and inside it there were papers: a marriage contract, a birth record, a bundle of letters in a hand that Antonia did not know, and one letter, folded twice, in her own.

She read it standing by the window.

Claudia Junia. I have not spoken and I will not speak. I do not want anything from you or from your son. I am writing because I want you to know that I am alive, and because I have bought a house, and because it has a fountain in the courtyard with a bronze myrtle tree in the middle of it, and because I chose the myrtle myself. You will think that I am writing to frighten you. I am not. I am writing because there is no one else in the world who knows what happened in that room, and because a thing that is known by only one person is not a thing at all, it is a dream. A.C.

She folded it and put it in her sleeve.

There was a second paper in the box, and it was not a letter; it was a codicil, in a clerk's hand, dated six days before the death, and it said that Gaius Claudius Corvus, being of sound mind, left to Antonia Cassia, freedwoman, the bronze stylus which was in the strongbox in his study, and to the guild of the bakers of the fourth region the sum of eleven thousand sesterces in the name of a boy called Felix, slave, deceased, and to his steward Faustus, freedman, nothing at all.

Antonia read it twice.

"Did you know about this?" she asked, when she came down.

"I know everything that happens in this house," said Claudia Junia. "I read it when the clerk brought it. It is not valid; a codicil made six days before death, when a man is known to have been shut in his study and not eating, will be contested by the heir, and the heir is a boy of twenty who is on a ship to Syria and does not care." She looked up. "But he made it. He sat at that table and he dictated it to a clerk, and he left a pen to a woman and eleven thousand sesterces to a dead boy and nothing at all to the man who went to the mines for him. That is the last thing my son did in the world."

"It is not nothing."

"It is a gesture," Claudia Junia said. "He was always good at gestures. It is what a man does instead of the thing itself."

Antonia stood in the atrium of the house of the Claudii Corvi and looked at the old woman on the bench.

"Your son was a coward," she said, "and he was cruel in the way that men are cruel who have never had to be anything else, and he stood in a doorway for three heartbeats when he was twenty-four years old and he never forgave himself for it, and he spent the rest of his life trying to be a good man in a family that did not believe in good men." She put the letter in her sleeve. "I hated him for seventeen years. I have stopped. It is not forgiveness; it is arithmetic. He is dead and I am alive and I have a girl's ashes to carry to her mother, and there is no time left for hating a man who is not here."

"And me?" said Claudia Junia. "Have you stopped hating me?"

"No," Antonia said. "You are still here."

Claudia Junia looked at her for a long moment.

"Will you write to me?" she said. "Once a year. One line. That you are alive."

Antonia stood in the door of the house of the Claudii Corvi.

"I will think about it," she said.

"That is not a no."

"No," said Antonia. "It is not a no. It is the most I have."

She went out.

She went out through the gate into the street.

Caesia was in the street.

She was standing by the cart with her hands folded, in a plain stola with no jewellery, and she had come out without a slave and without telling anyone, and when Antonia came through the gate she said, "I have four minutes. If my grandmother finds out I am here she will lock me in my room until the wedding."

"What do you want?"

"To give you this." She held out a small purse. "It is sixty sesterces. It is not much. It is what I have that is mine."

Antonia looked at the purse.

"Keep it."

"I am not giving it to you," Caesia said. "It is for the boy. The one from Tibur. He will need shoes and a cloak before the winter, and you will be buying wine and paying rent, and I know how a household eats money in the first year because I have watched my grandmother do the accounts since I was nine." She put the purse in Antonia's hand and closed her fingers on it. "I am not being kind. I am being practical. There is a difference and it is the only thing I have learned this year that is worth anything."

Antonia looked at her.

"You are going to be a dangerous woman," she said.

"I hope so." Caesia stepped back. "I am going to marry Vinicius in the spring and I am going to have a house and I am going to do what I said I would do. I am going to write to you. Not once a year; four times. And you will write back and tell me the truth about what it is like to be a woman with a shop in a town by the sea, because I have a suspicion that it is either much worse or much better than this house and I would like to know which."

"It is both," Antonia said.

"That is what I thought."

Caesia looked at the cart, at the women, at the boy asleep on the bundles.

"Did she suffer?" she asked.

"Yes."

"I thought so. I have been hoping she did not." She wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist, quickly, and straightened. "Goodbye, Antonia Cassia. You are the most interesting person who has ever been in this house, and my grandmother is right about you, and she is wrong about everything else."

They sold the contents at auction in the Forum, in the portico of the basilica, on a market day, and Antonia went to watch.

She did not know why she went. She had told herself that she would not; that a woman who has lost a house does not stand in a crowd and watch a man sell her tables. But she woke on the morning of the auction and found that she could not sit in the room above the fuller's shop, and she put on her shawl and walked down through the Subura and across the Forum and stood at the back of the crowd with the porters and the small dealers and the women who come to auctions to look.

The auctioneer was a small man with a good voice and a stick, and he stood on a box with the goods laid out on a trestle behind him.

"Lot eleven," he called. "Three couches, citron wood, bronze feet, the property of a lady of the fourth region. Nine thousand to start. Eight. Seven. Six and a half. Six. Do I hear five?"

They went for four thousand two hundred to a man in a green tunic who dealt in furniture on the Argiletum and would have them re-covered and sold in the autumn for nine.

"Lot twelve. One table, marble, with a lion's head. Two hundred. One fifty. One hundred. Sold."

"Lot seventeen. Eleven lamps, bronze. Forty sesterces the lot."

"Lot twenty-two. One silver service, sixteen pieces, the property of a lady of the fourth region. Twenty-two thousand to start."

The silver went for nineteen thousand to a freedman of the imperial household who had come with two slaves and a purse and who did not look at the pieces, only at the weight.

Antonia stood at the back with her shawl over her head and watched her life go across a trestle and be sold in an afternoon.

The fountain went for three thousand. The curtains went for six hundred. The mirror from her own room, the bronze one with the handle in the shape of a girl, went for ninety sesterces to a woman who was buying for a brothel in the Subura, and Antonia saw her hand it to a slave and say, "There. That will do for the upstairs room."

At the end, when the crowd had thinned and the auctioneer was drinking from a cup, she went up to him.

"The box," she said. "The wooden box with the tablets. Lot forty-one."

"That went an hour ago." He looked at his list. "To a man from the prefecture's office. Papers, deeds, tablets, contents unexamined, four sesterces."

"Who bought it?"

"A clerk. He said it was for the file." The auctioneer looked at her, and then at the shawl, and his face changed. "You are her."

"Yes."

"I am sorry, domina. It is the law. I am paid by the court."

"I know." She looked at the trestle, at the empty place where the goods had been. "There was a small bronze myrtle tree, from the fountain. Leaves on a stem. It was not in any lot."

The auctioneer looked at his list.

"It was listed with the fountain," he said. "It went with the basin. The man in the green tunic took the whole thing."

Antonia nodded.

"Thank you," she said, and went out through the portico into the Forum.

The house was sold at the end of the month.

It went for less than it was worth, because a house in which a consul has died twice is not a house that fetches a price, and because the buyer knew that the family had no choice. The buyer was a freedman of the imperial household who intended to pull down the old atrium and put up a block of flats, and Antonia heard this in the street from a man who had heard it from a mason, and she stood in the Vicus Tuscus and laughed until she had to hold on to a wall.

On the last night before she left, she burned the letter.

She did it in the yard behind the house of a fuller in the Subura, where the surviving women had been living since the fire: Prisca, Meroe, Junilla, the washerwoman, and the boy from Tibur, who had come down from the smithy with his chest on his back and had been given the corner by the oven.

There was a brazier in the yard and they had lit it for the evening meal, and Antonia took out the letter and the box of myrtle wood and put them both in the fire.

The box burned slowly, because myrtle is a hard wood, and it gave off a smell that she would remember for the rest of her life. The letter went up at once.

"What is it?" Prisca asked.

"A letter," Antonia said. "And a promise I made to a girl."

She watched it burn, and then she went inside and ate bread and onions with the women, and Meroe told a story about Alexandria that Antonia had heard four times, and the boy from Tibur fell asleep with his head on the table, and Junilla carried him to the corner and put a blanket over him.

The night before they left, the women sat up in the fuller's yard and argued about the future.

It was a warm night and they had brought the bench out and a lamp, and Marcella the laundress had given them a jug of her own wine, which was bad, and they drank it anyway. The boy from Tibur was asleep in the corner with his mouth open. The washerwoman had gone home. It was Prisca and Meroe and Junilla and Antonia, and a bowl of olives, and the smoke of the vats coming over the wall.

"There is a thing we have not decided," Prisca said.

"We have decided everything. We have decided the boat and the town and the house."

"We have not decided what we are going to do when we get there." Prisca put her cup down. "We have four hundred sesterces and five women and a boy. In Surrentum, that is a month, perhaps two. And then?"

"I will find work," Meroe said.

"At what?"

"I can dance."

"You can dance in Alexandria and in Rome, where there are eight hundred thousand people and a man will pay to watch a woman dance. In a town of six thousand on a bay, you will dance at the festival once a year and the rest of the time you will be a woman with a reputation." Prisca was not unkind; she was tired and practical. "We have all been in a house of women, and now we are going to a town where everyone will know it within a week, and there is no market for what we have been selling except the one we are trying to leave."

"So what do we sell?" Junilla said.

"We sell wine," Antonia said.

They looked at her.

"There is a widow in the town who has a yard and a son who runs a shop and a quarrel with the man who has four ships. There is no wine shop between the harbour and the gate, and the fishermen drink at the tavern by the mole, and the tavern is owned by a cousin

of the man with four ships." She turned her cup. "I can buy wine. I have bought wine for seventeen years and I know what it costs and what it is worth and I know when a man is lying about a vintage. I can keep a shop. I can keep accounts. I have been keeping accounts since I was twenty-three."

"You can keep a house," Prisca said.

"I can keep a shop," Antonia said. "A shop opens in the morning and shuts at night and sells a thing that people need and does not require anyone to be charming after the second hour. I am forty years old and I have spent my whole life being charming and I am finished."

"And what are we?" Meroe said.

"You are free women with papers." Antonia looked at her. "That is not a small thing. It is a smaller thing than it should be, and it is more than either of us had a year ago. Prisca will keep the accounts, because she is better at it than I am and she enjoys it. Junilla will keep the door, because she is the only one of us who can look at a man and make him decide to go home. You will teach the daughters of the harbour families to dance, if their mothers will let you, and if they will not, you will learn to make the bread, because Calybe's bread was the best in Rome and she is not here and somebody in this town will pay for it."

"And you?" said Prisca.

Antonia looked into her cup.

"I am going to teach a boy to read," she said, "and I am going to put a stone on a hill, and I am going to find out what a woman is when she is not being watched."

The lamp guttered.

"That is not a living," said Prisca.

"No," Antonia said. "But it is a life, and I have discovered this year that they are not the same, and that I have spent forty years confusing them."

Meroe laughed, and then the others did, and Junilla said something about the wine being so bad that it made a person philosophical, and they sat in the yard until the lamp went out.

On the last day before they left, she went out to the potters' field on the Esquiline.

She went alone, in the morning, with a bunch of myrtle from a woman in the market, and she walked out through the Esquiline gate and along the road and turned off at the wall, and the man at the gate of the field took two sesterces and showed her the row.

There were a great many stones. That was the thing about the potters' field: it was full. There were stones the size of a hand and stones the size of a door, and some of them had names and some of them had only a number, and the grass was cut short between the rows by a goat that was tied to a post at the far end and looked at her without interest.

She found the stone.

FELIX SLAVE OF ANTONIA CASSIA TWELVE YEARS HE WAS QUICK

She had paid for it in the month of his death, out of the money in the house, and she had not been back since the burning. Somebody had been putting flowers there; there was a bunch of dried lavender tied with a string, three weeks old at least, and a small clay cup.

Antonia knelt down and put the myrtle beside the lavender.

"I am going," she said.

The goat pulled at its tether and tore at the grass.

"I am going to Surrentum with a jar of ashes and five women and a boy, and I am going to keep a shop and sell wine and teach him to read, and in the spring I am going to put a vine over the door." She looked at the stone. "I do not know whether that is a good life. It is a life. I have found that it is more than most people in this city get."

She sat back on her heels.

"I am sorry," she said. "That is all. I have been sorry for a month and I expect I will be sorry for the rest of my life, and it will not do you any good, and I am saying it anyway because it is the only thing I have that is not for sale."

The goat came to the end of its tether and looked at her.

"You wanted a bakery," she said. "I would have bought you a bakery. If you had asked me, I would have said no, because a woman like me says no to a boy who asks for a bakery; she says, *wait until you are older, we will see, we will talk about it in a year*. And then in a year you would have been thirteen and I would have said the same thing, and in four years you would have been sixteen and I would have bought it, because by then you would have been worth it." Her voice caught. "You were worth it at twelve. I did not know. I am telling you now, and you cannot hear me, and that is the whole of it."

She got up.

At the gate of the field she stopped and looked back at the rows and the stones and the goat and the small grey stone with four lines on it.

"His name was Felix," she said to the man at the gate. "If anyone comes and asks, in a year, or in ten years, his name was Felix and he was twelve years old and he wanted to own a bakery."

The man looked at her.

"I will remember," he said.

In the morning they went to Ostia.

Eutychus came to the gate to see them off.

He came in a hired chair with one slave and a basket, and the basket had figs in it, and he stood in the road outside the Ostian gate with the dust of the cart traffic going past him and held it out.

"The third crop," he said. "The best of the year. I said the first was best because it was early, and I was lying; it is the third."

Antonia took the basket.

"You kept your word," she said.

"I am a practical man." He looked at the cart, at the women, at the boy asleep in the back among the bundles. "The papers are lodged with the prefect's office. Every one of them free, with a copy for each, and a note that any magistrate who questions them is to write to me. Nobody will question them." He put his hands behind his back. "The building is mine. I have had the masons in. We are putting in a furnace and a cold pool and a room for the women at the back, and there will be a small garden where the dining room was, and a myrtle tree in the middle of it, because there was one there before and it seems a pity to lose it."

Antonia looked at him.

"You are a strange man," she said.

"I am a man who has spent his life in accounts," said Eutychus, "and I have discovered at fifty-five that there is no line in any account for the thing I have been feeling since the basilica, and it is uncomfortable, and I would like it to stop." He held out his hand. "Domina. If you write to me from Surrentum I will answer, and if you need money I will send it, and if any man in that town troubles you, you will send me his name and I will have him audited."

She laughed.

"I will write," she said.

"See that you do." He looked at the cart. "You have four hundred sesterces and a jar of ashes and five women and a boy who cannot read, and you are going to a town where you know nobody except a widow who has been waiting ten years for a daughter who is dead. It is not a promising position."

"No," Antonia said. "It is the first honest one I have ever been in."

She got up on the cart.

They went out through the Ostian gate in the early morning with the dust coming up and the road full of carts and the Tiber on

the left, and the city fell away behind them, and the women were quiet, and the boy woke up and looked at the river.

At the ninth hour they came to Ostia and the sea.

Antonia had not seen the sea since she was fourteen years old. She stood on the quay with the wind in her face and the smell of it, salt and tar and rotten weed and fish, and she looked at the water going out to the horizon, and she found that she was shaking.

"Domina," Prisca said. "Are you well?"

"I am well."

"You are crying."

"I know." Antonia wiped her face with the back of her hand. "I have not seen the sea since I was a girl. I had forgotten that it was so large."

The ship was a grain freighter called the *Providentia*, and the master was a small brown man with one ear who took passengers because they paid in advance and did not complain about the rats. They were given a place in the stern under an awning, with a chest for a table and a bundle for a pillow, and the women arranged themselves and their belongings and their food, and the boy sat at the rail and looked at the water.

They sailed on the evening tide.

Antonia sat in the stern with the jar in her lap.

It was a plain jar, of good clay, sealed with wax, and it had a label on it in her own hand: *LEDA, CALLED VIBIA RUFA, OF SURRENTUM, AGED TWENTY-ONE.* It was not the custom to put a name on a jar of ashes. The custom was to put them in the tomb and let the stone do the work. But the stone would be at Surrentum, and the journey was four days, and she had found that she could not put the jar in a chest with the bundles.

The ship went out past the lighthouse and turned south, and the shore went by, and the wind came off the land, warm and smelling of pine and dust and something else that she could not name.

Meroe came and sat down beside her.

"Tell me about the town," she said.

"It is on a bay," Antonia said. "There is a cliff above it and a temple on the cliff, and the town comes down to the water in steps. There is a wine quarter by the gate, where the barrels are, and a fish market, and a beach at the bottom of the hill with black sand. The water is very blue. In the summer the rich people come from Rome and put up awnings and complain about the heat."

"You were born there?"

"No. I was born in the Subura, in a room above a bakery, and my father was a grain factor, and he hanged himself in his shop when I was eleven." She looked at the water. "I have never been to Surrentum in my life."

Meroe was quiet for a moment.

"Then why are we going?"

"Because she is," Antonia said, "and because there is a woman there who has been waiting ten years, and because a town on a bay is as good a place as any for a woman with four hundred sesterces and a bad reputation to begin again." She looked at the jar in her lap. "And because I made a promise to a girl in a bed in a house on the Palatine, and I have kept very few promises in my life, and I intend to keep this one."

The wind came off the land, and the ship went south, and the sun went down behind the water, and the sky over the bay turned the colour of a peach and then of a bruise and then of nothing at all.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Antonia

They came into Surrentum on the fourth day, in the afternoon, with the sun on the water and the town coming down the hill in steps of white and ochre and the temple on the cliff above it.

Antonia stood at the bow with the jar in her arms.

She had expected to feel something. She had prepared herself for it on the last night, lying under the awning with the ship moving under her and the women asleep, and she had thought about the town and the beach and the black sand and the boat coming in with men in it who spoke Greek, and she had thought: *this is where it began.*

What she felt, when she saw it, was nothing at all. It was a town. It had a harbour and a fish market and a lot of steps and a smell of nets and lemons. There were gulls.

They came in on the tide and the master put them off at the quay with their bundles, and they stood in the sun on the stones with the whole of the town going up in front of them.

"Where now?" said Prisca.

"The wine quarter," Antonia said. "By the gate."

They found it in an hour. It was at the top of the town, where the road came in from the north, and it was not a quarter so much as

a street: a row of yards behind walls, with vines over the gates and amphorae stacked in rows, and a smell of must and wasps. There was a shrine at the corner with a worn step and a lamp in the niche that somebody still kept filled.

The house at the end of the street had a wall of rough stone and a vine over the gate, and the gate was open.

Antonia stood in front of it for a long time.

"Domina," Prisca said.

"Wait here."

She went in.

The yard was small and paved with cobbles and there were amphorae stacked against the wall in rows, with the painted marks on their shoulders, and a vine over the gate, and in the corner a table with a jug and a knife and a heap of something drying in the sun. A woman was sitting on a stool by the table with a basket of beans in her lap, shelling them.

She was fifty or so, and brown, and thin, with grey coming into her hair and a face that had been worked on by the sun. She looked up when Antonia came in, and her hands went on shelling the beans.

"The yard is not for sale," she said. "If you want the wine, go to the shop at the corner; my son keeps it now."

"I do not want the wine."

"Then what do you want?"

Antonia stood in the middle of the yard with the jar in her arms.

"My name is Antonia Cassia," she said. "I have come from Rome."

The woman's hands stopped.

She looked at the jar.

She was very still for a long moment. Then she put the basket down on the ground, carefully, so that the beans did not spill, and she wiped her hands on her apron, and she stood up.

"You wrote to me," she said.

"I wrote to you in the spring. I told you that I was coming and that I had news of your daughter." Antonia's voice was steady. "The news is not good."

"I know. I knew when the letter came. A woman does not write a letter like that with good news in it." She looked at the jar again. "Is that her?"

"Yes."

Vibia Prima put her hand on the table.

"Sit down," she said. "Sit down before you fall down, you are grey as a fish. Sit on the stool." She pushed the basket aside. "Have you eaten? You have not eaten. There is bread and there is cheese and there is wine, and I will get it, and then you will tell me, and you will tell me all of it, and you will not leave anything out because I am a woman and it is not proper."

Antonia sat down on the stool.

The bread was good and the cheese was better and the wine was the wine of the yard and it was thin and cold and it tasted of the ground. Antonia ate and drank, and the woman sat opposite her with her hands in her lap, and then Antonia told her.

She told her all of it.

She had thought about how to do it, on the boat. She had thought about softening it, and about the words she would use, and about whether a mother should be told the whole of what a slave dealer's yard is. In the end she told it plainly, in the order it happened, because she had been a liar all her life and had found that the truth was cheaper and lasted longer.

She told her about the men in the boat and the yard at Puteoli and the block and the dealer whose name was Nymphodorus. She told her about the house on the Vicus Tuscus and the singing and the promise and the men who put their hands on the girl's wrist as she went by with the lyre. She told her about the dinner and the cup and the basilica, and about a room on the Palatine with a window

that looked over a garden, and a rail that was four hundred years old and had rotted at the mortice, and a girl who lay in a bed and asked for three things.

Vibia Prima listened.

She did not weep. Her hands stayed in her lap and she did not interrupt, and when Antonia had finished she sat for a while and looked at the beans on the ground where she had put the basket down.

"The wasp song," she said.

"Yes."

"I made it up. When the children were small. There were wasps in the yard in the summer and they were frightened of them, and I made up a song, and it was a stupid song, it had no tune to speak of." She looked up. "She remembered it."

"She remembered the tune. She could not remember the words."

"No," said Vibia Prima. "Neither could I, by the end."

She got up and went to the other side of the yard and stood with her back to Antonia, with her hand on the wall.

"You bought her," she said.

"Yes."

"For eleven thousand sesterces."

"Yes."

"And you kept her six years and you took the money she earned and you did not write to me."

"No."

Vibia Prima turned around.

"I have been to three governors," she said. "I have written letters to the prefect's office in Rome and to the legate of the province and to a man I once knew in Puteoli who had a cousin in the household of the governor, and I have stood outside the basilica in Naples for four days in the rain, and in ten years nobody has told me anything, and now a woman comes into my yard with my daughter in a jar and

tells me she bought her." Her voice was shaking. "What am I to do with that? What am I to do with you?"

"Nothing," Antonia said. "There is nothing you can do with me. I am not here to be forgiven; I am here because I promised her I would come, and because she asked me to tell you about the wasp song, and because you have a right to know what happened to your daughter." She stood up. "I have four hundred sesterces and a jar and five women and a boy in the street outside your gate, and I do not want anything from you, and I will go and find a room and I will come back tomorrow to ask what you wish to be done about the ashes."

Vibia Prima looked at her.

"You are a hard woman," she said.

"Yes."

"You will not last a month in this town."

"I have been told that before," Antonia said, "by a woman in a cell in Rome, and she was wrong, and she is dead."

She went to the gate.

"Wait."

Antonia stopped.

Vibia Prima came across the yard. She was a small woman with grey in her hair and beans on her apron, and she stopped in front of Antonia and looked at her for a long moment.

"Did she have a good voice?" she asked.

"Yes."

"Was she beautiful?"

"Yes."

"Did she have anyone who was kind to her?"

Antonia thought about it.

"Yes," she said. "A boy. He was young and foolish and he loved her, and he tried to take her away, and he could not, and he will be a senator one day and he will be sad about her for the rest of his life."

"That is not nothing," said Vibia Prima.

"No," Antonia said. "It is not nothing."

They buried the ashes on the third day, in the ground outside the town, on the hill above the sea, in a small plot that Vibia Prima had bought eleven years before with money she did not have, on the day after the girl was taken, because she had known even then that her daughter was dead and had wanted somewhere to put her.

There was no stone yet. The stonecutter in the town was slow and expensive and had asked what she wanted it to say, and Antonia had said, "Put her name and her age and the fact that she was loved," and the man had said, "Is that all?", and Antonia had said, "It is more than most women get."

The brother was there.

His name was Gaius and he was twenty-three years old and he had a mark on his chin from a fall off a wall, and he was a broad, brown, silent young man who ran the wine shop at the corner and had a wife and a child. He had been on the beach the morning his sister was taken. He had run.

He did not speak to Antonia at the funeral. He stood at the edge of the plot with his hands at his sides and his face set, and when it was over he went to the wall and stood with his back to them all and his shoulders shaking.

His mother went to him.

Antonia stood by the small grave with the jar in it and the sea below the hill and the gulls turning over the water, and Meroe and Prisca and Junilla stood behind her, and the boy from Tibur stood at the end of the row with his hands folded, because he had asked to come and she had let him.

She did not say anything. There was nothing to say that would not have been a performance.

Afterward she walked down the hill alone and stood on the beach.

It was black sand, as she had said it would be, and the water was very blue, and there were fishing boats drawn up in a row, and a man was mending a net on the stones. She took off her sandals and walked to the edge of the water and let it come over her feet.

This was where it had begun. Not for her; for a girl of eleven who had been asked a question by a stranger and had answered it. Somewhere along this shore, ten years ago, a boat had come in and a boy had run and a girl had not, and everything that followed had followed from that one moment of good manners.

She stood in the water for a long time.

Then she went up the beach and put on her sandals and went back to the town.

They took a house.

It was not a good house. It was two rooms and a yard above a fishmonger's on the street that went down to the harbour, and the roof leaked at the corner and the stairs were steep, and the rent was thirty sesterces a month, and Antonia paid the first month out of the four hundred and looked at the yard and thought: *a table there, and a bench, and a vine over the door in the spring, and a sign.*

She did not have a sign made.

That was the thing she had to learn, and it took her a year. She had spent her whole life building a thing that men came to, and she found that in Surrentum she did not want a door that men came to. She wanted a shop. She wanted a thing that was open in the morning and shut at night, that sold something people needed, and that did not require her to be charming after the second hour.

So she sold wine.

It was not a great wine; it was the wine of the yards on the hill, and she bought it from Vibia Prima's son at a fair price and sold it at a fair price and did not water it, and in the first month she sold eleven jars and in the fourth month she sold sixty.

The winter in Surrentum was not the winter of Rome.

It rained. It rained for eleven days in November and then stopped, and the town smelled of wet stone and woodsmoke and fish, and the sea was the colour of a knife, and the wind came down off the hill at night and got into the shutters and made a noise like a man breathing.

They were cold. That was the thing none of them had expected: they had spent their lives in a city where a brazier and a blanket were enough, and they had come to a town where the wind came off the water and found every crack in a wall.

Antonia bought a second brazier and a load of charcoal and a bolt of good wool, and they sat in the back room in the evenings with the shutters closed and the lamp lit and the four of them sewing and the boy reading out loud.

He read badly. He read the way a person reads who has learned late: slowly, with his finger, and he lost his place and went back, and every so often he would come to a word he knew and say it with enormous triumph.

"*The — ship — was — in — the — har — harbour.*"

"Good."

"*And — the — men — were — in — the — ship.*"

"Good."

"*And — there — was — a — storm.*" He stopped. "Is there a storm?"

"There is always a storm," said Prisca, from her sewing. "It is the second chapter."

The trouble came in the winter.

It came in the shape of a man called Aulus Vibidius, who was one of the two duumvirs of the town and the owner of four ships and the largest yard in the harbour, and who sent a slave to her door on a wet morning in December with a summons.

"You are to appear before the duumvirs at the third hour," the slave said. "On a complaint."

"Whose complaint?"

The slave looked at the ground.

"His," he said.

Antonia went at the third hour, in her good stola, with Prisca behind her.

The basilica of Surrentum was a small building with a tiled floor and a statue of Augustus that had lost its hand, and it smelled of wet wool and the sea. There were perhaps forty people in it, which in a town of that size was a crowd. The two duumvirs sat on a raised bench at the end, and Vibidius stood in front of them with his thumbs in his belt.

"The complaint," said the senior duumvir, who was old and tired and read from a tablet, "is that the woman Antonia Cassia, a foreigner resident in this town, has been selling wine without being enrolled in the guild of the wine sellers, and that her house is a house of ill repute, and that she harbours women of bad character, and that the peace of the town is disturbed."

Antonia looked at Vibidius.

"May I speak?"

"You may answer the complaint."

"Then I will answer it." She turned so that the forty people in the basilica could hear her. "I have sold wine in this town for five months. I have bought it from the yards on the hill, including the yard of Vibia Prima, and I have paid the market toll every market day, and I have the receipts, and my steward has them here. I have not watered the wine. I have not raised the price in the festival week when everyone else raised it. I have sold to fishermen and to the wives of fishermen and to two of the men in this room, and if any man here says he was cheated, let him stand up and say it."

Nobody stood up.

"As for the house," she said, "there are five women living in it and one boy, and we are all free, and the papers are lodged with the

prefect's office in Rome, and the man who signed them is the secretary of accounts to the emperor, whose name is Tiberius Claudius Eutychus, and if the duumvirs wish to write to him, they may, and he will answer, and he will answer in a bad temper, because he is a busy man and he does not like to be troubled about a wine shop."

The old duumvir looked at the tablet.

"Have you anything to say to the complaint of ill repute?"

"I have this to say," Antonia said. "I kept a house of women in Rome for seventeen years. That is true. I am not going to stand in this basilica and pretend to be a widow from Naples. The town knows what I was; the town knew it in the first week, because a town this size knows everything in the first week." She looked at the forty faces. "I came here with four hundred sesterces and a jar of ashes and five women, and I have kept a shop and paid my debts and not asked anything of anyone. If that is not enough for the duumvirs, then they must tell me what would be, and I will consider it, and I will probably not do it."

There was a sound from the back of the basilica that was not quite laughter.

Old Vibidius turned around and looked at it, and then at her.

"You are a bold woman," he said.

"I am a woman who has been in a basilica before," Antonia said. "In Rome. In front of six hundred men. There was a consul-designate in the third row and a murderer in the aisle and a girl on the floor, and I am still here, and the consul-designate is dead and the murderer is on an island and the girl is on a hill above this town." She let that sit. "You have forty people in a wet room and a complaint about a wine shop. Do what you like."

The old duumvir put the tablet down.

"The complaint is dismissed," he said. "The wine seller will enrol in the guild and pay the fee, which is four sesterces, and the town will

consider the matter closed." He looked at Vibidius. "Aulus, I have known you thirty years and you are a fool in a good coat. Go home."

Vibidius went out.

Antonia paid her four sesterces to the clerk and enrolled in the guild of the wine sellers of Surrentum, and the clerk wrote her name in a book, and that was the first time her name had been written in a public book since the prefecture of Rome had written it in a list of the condemned.

Outside, in the rain, Vibia Prima was waiting with a basket.

"You did well," she said.

"I have had practice."

"You have." The older woman turned and walked beside her up the hill. "He will not trouble you again. He is a coward and he has been laughed at in his own basilica, which in a town this size is worse than a fine." She shifted the basket to her other arm. "Come to supper on the Kalends. My son's wife is a good cook and there is a cousin of mine coming from Naples who is dull but has a boat."

Antonia stopped in the rain.

"Are you asking me to supper?"

"I am asking you to supper."

"Last year you would not let me in your yard."

"Last year you had my daughter in a jar," said Vibia Prima, and then, after a moment, "and now she is on the hill and I go up on the Nones with flowers, and you go up on the anniversary, and there is nobody else in this town who does." She started walking again. "I am not your friend. I want to be clear about that; you bought my daughter and I will not forget it, and there are days when I see you in the street and I have to go into a shop. But you kept your word to her, and you came to my yard and told me the truth, and you have been decent to my son, and in a town this size that is a kind of relation."

They walked up the hill in the rain.

"I will come to supper," Antonia said.

The shop opened on the Kalends of October, at the sixth hour, with a jug of the new wine and a bowl of olives and a broom.

There was no sign, but Prisca had painted the word VINUM on the plaster beside the door in red letters a foot high, and Meroe had hung a bunch of dried vine over the lintel, and the boy had swept the step three times.

The first customer was a fisherman called Sabinus who came in because he had been told there was a woman from Rome selling wine at a fair price, and who stood in the doorway and looked around the room and said, "Is this it?"

"This is it," Antonia said.

"Where are the tables?"

"There are no tables. There is a bench outside and a jug and a cup and a price on the wall."

The fisherman looked at the wall.

"That is a fair price," he said, surprised.

"It is a fair price for the wine. If you want to be cheated, the tavern by the mole will oblige you."

He laughed, and bought a cup, and drank it standing in the doorway, and then bought a second and sat on the bench outside, and by the ninth hour there were four men on the bench and a woman with a jug and a boy who had been sent for a quart and told to hurry.

At the eleventh hour a man came in who had been at the tavern by the mole and had heard, and who was drunk and wanted to make a point.

"They say you were a whore in Rome," he said.

The room went quiet. There were three men on the bench outside and the woman with the jug and Sabinus, who had not gone home.

Antonia put down the jug.

"I was," she said. "And now I sell wine in Surrentum, and I do not water it, and I do not cheat fishermen, and I am not going to be

spoken to in my own shop by a man who has had four cups at the mole and cannot hold them." She took a cup from the shelf and set it on the counter. "That is two sesterces. If you want to drink it and be civil, sit down. If you want to say something else, say it in the street, where I do not have to listen."

The man looked at her.

Sabinus stood up from the bench.

"Come on, Gnaeus," he said. "You have had enough. I will walk you home."

They went out.

Antonia stood behind the counter with her hands flat on the wood and her heart going, and Sabinus came back in and put two sesterces on the counter and said, "That was well done."

"I have had practice," she said.

"You keep saying that." He picked up his cup. "What does it mean?"

"It means I have been in a great many rooms where a man said something and everybody waited to see what the woman would do." She put the coins in the box. "It is a thing you learn, and then you cannot unlearn it, and it is worth about as much as it costs."

Sabinus drank his wine.

"My wife died four years ago," he said. "I have a boat and a boy of nine and a house with a leaking roof, and I am not proposing anything, because I have heard what happened to the last man who proposed something to a woman from Rome." He put the cup down. "But if you ever want a boat to take you along the coast, or a man to stand on a bench in your shop when a drunk comes in and says something, I am on the mole at the fourth hour every morning."

Antonia looked at him.

"Thank you," she said.

He went out.

Prisca came out from the back room where she had been pretending to do the accounts.

"That was well done," she said.

"Everybody keeps saying that."

"Because it is true." Prisca looked at the box. "Eleven cups and a jug. Nine sesterces, less the four we paid for the wine, less the rent, less the toll." She did the sum on her fingers. "We have made a profit of one sesterce and a half and a bunch of dried vine."

Antonia laughed.

"We will do better tomorrow," she said.

They did.

Prisca kept the accounts, which she did very well and enjoyed. Meroe taught dancing to the daughters of the harbour families, which caused a scandal and then a waiting list. Junilla ran the door and, in the evenings, the room. The boy from Tibur learned his letters in a year and could read the wine lists and then the letters, and at fifteen he could write a fair hand, and Antonia taught him the way she had been taught: sitting beside him at the table with a lamp and a wax tablet, guiding his fingers.

She wrote to Eutychus and he answered, four times a year, in a hand like a clerk's, with news of Rome.

The baths had opened in the autumn. He had put a myrtle tree in the garden. He had been audited by the prefect's office and had come out of it with a commendation. Maro had been given a command on the Danube and had been killed in the second year by a falling tree, which Eutychus reported without comment and which Antonia read three times.

Faustus had died in the mines at the end of the first year.

Publius Vettius had been exiled to an island and had written a book about his father.

And Claudius Corvus's daughter had married, in the spring, a young man of an equestrian family, and the wedding had been small.

Marcus wrote once.

The letter came in the third year, in the winter, from a fort on the Euphrates, and it was four lines long. It said that he was well, that he had been made a prefect of a cohort, that he had heard she was at Surrentum and that there was a stone on the hill above the sea. It said: *I have not forgotten the portico by the river. I do not think I will. If you are ever in need of anything, write to me at this address, and I will send it, and I will not ask for anything in return.*

Antonia read it twice and put it in the box on the shelf.

She answered it in the spring, and she wrote about the wine and the weather and the boy who could now read, and at the end she wrote: *She asked me to tell you not to be sad for too long. I am telling you now because I promised her I would, and because I have found that a promise kept is a rare thing and I intend to keep the ones I have left.*

She did not write again, and he did not.

On the first anniversary of the burial she went up the hill alone at dusk.

The stone was set by then. It was small and grey and it said:

LEDA CALLED VIBIA RUFA OF THIS TOWN AGED TWENTY-ONE SHE WAS LOVED

She sat on the ground beside it with her back against the wall and looked out at the sea, and the light went off the water, and the gulls came in to the cliff, and the lamps began to be lit in the town below, one and then another and then a great many.

She thought about the boy in the yard behind the bakery.

She thought about Tiro in the rain, saying *I look like a man who can keep anything.*

She thought about a man sitting against an altar with his hands in his lap, saying *I am sorry that I stood in the doorway.*

She thought about a girl in a bed on the Palatine, singing a song that nobody knew the words to.

She thought: *In Rome, everything is sold. I have spent my life learning the price of things, and I have paid, and other people have paid, and the accounts have never balanced and they never will.*

And then she thought: *but a woman may keep a shop, and sell wine that is not watered, and teach a boy to read, and put a stone on a hill, and that is not nothing. It is very little. It is almost nothing. And it is mine.*

She got up.

The wind came off the sea, cold and salt, and the last of the light was on the cliff, and below her in the town the women were closing the shutters and the men were coming up from the boats, and somewhere a door opened and a voice called somebody in to supper.

Antonia Cassia went down the hill.